

BEN BOSWELL

A HOTWIFE

MURDER MYSTERY

KILLING THE PAST

A woman with blonde hair and dark eye makeup is shown in profile, looking down and to the left. She has a small black lip ring in her lower lip. Her hand is visible, resting near her chest. The background is a dark, textured wall. Two horizontal yellow lines are positioned above and below the subtitle text.

Killing the Past

Ben Boswell

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Foreword by Kenny Wright

When Ben first broached the idea of writing a mashup of hotwife erotica and psychological thriller, I'll admit that I was a little skeptical. Murder can be a real mood killer. Some would argue that plot in erotica is also a mood killer (not me). But this is Ben Boswell, one of a small selection of authors that could pull something like this off.

Boy, did he pull this one off. *Two Sides to Terri* will always have a special place in my heart, but honestly, this book is Ben's best. He's matured as a writer over these last five years—the sharp dialog is still there; the smart, sexy wife character; and at its heart, this is a story that revolves around Olivia and Dex's relationship. There's a sexy past (always a favorite trope of mine) and boundary pushing. But this book also delivers where most other books don't even try—a driving plot.

Plot in erotica is a tricky thing. It's a completely written medium. The excitement is one crafted from background and setup and scenario, not just a graphic description of sex. But too much of that setup can distract from the primary intent of erotica: to titillate.

Ben nails this balance with *Killing the Past*. When I started reading it, I couldn't put it down. I kept turning pages not only because I wanted to know who the killer was, but to know how the characters would get in and out of the sexual situations that the plot forced them into. I was fascinated by the craft of the storytelling. It's truly masterful.

It also got me thinking about what other kinds of genre mashups are possible out there. It's rare to find something truly new, especially as well trodden as hotwife erotica. This book proves that it's possible—that *anything* is possible. I'm already thinking of other things I could write. Other what-ifs...

So in short, as a skeptic of the book's premise, I'm now a true convert. Step aside, Terri, I think I have a new Boswell favorite.

Kenny Wright

Killing the Past

Prologue

He made his way along the darkened path bordering a small moonlit stream. His eyes darted from side to side. He was anxious, and excited. He'd never cheated on his wife before. Never been interested in it, and honestly, it had never seemed worth the hassle. But that gorgeous blonde had definitely been into him. He could feel it. It might have been part of a creepy game with her hubby, but he could sense it. She wanted it. Wanted him. No one was that good an actor. And now she wanted to meet.

It was late. He knew it might be a setup. He'd left his phone and most of his cash and cards in the car just in case. At worst, he'd be out a few bucks and an old wallet. At best.... He shivered excitedly.

The footsteps came in a rush. He didn't even have time to turn before he felt the cold metal of a gun against the back of his neck. He sighed and went limp, willing to cooperate. A hand reached around and forced a ball gag into his mouth. He was too surprised to resist, and when he realized what was happening, it was too late.

Much too late.

Chapter One: The Ex

I couldn't stop looking at his hands. They were large and covered with dark hair on the back. He wore one of those oversized diving watches, but it looked appropriate for his thick wrists. His wedding band seemed large enough to serve as a napkin ring. I wasn't even thinking about the old adage, big hands, big... I didn't need to. The hands were enough.

The hands were attached to Mitch, who seemed like a perfectly delightful man, and one much in love with his wife Denise, who sat beside him. They had that easy, old-married person rapport, that mix of affectionate gazes and gentle ribbing that seems a hallmark of a solid couple.

I like to think that Olivia and I have the same sort of bond. We've been married twelve years and have two kiddies, seven and nine, staying with Olivia's mom for the night. I glanced at my wife. She was luminous, the way she often got after a couple of drinks and some socializing. Her cheeks had a slight blush, and her blue eyes crinkled as she laughed. She seemed to glow a little brighter when she made eye contact with Mitch, who reciprocated her shimmering gaze with a small, sly smile. Her red painted fingernails trailed across her cheek and flipped her blonde hair from her face. His head tilted slightly in response.

Or maybe I was just imagining the whole thing. I was primed that way.

Olivia and Mitch had dated back in the day. But that was a long time ago, twenty years, in fact, since we were at their twentieth high school reunion. Or maybe they hadn't dated. They'd been friends, that was for sure. And they had been intimate at some point; my wife had warned me on that point before we arrived. But everything else was unclear, and I didn't press for more details because that felt weird.

I glanced around the room, a staid hotel ballroom, though nicely spruced up with balloons celebrating twenty years since graduation, poster boards covered with pictures of the kids from

back in the day. They were the class of 2000, and that, of course, loomed large in the decor. Remember when the year 2000 seemed like a big deal? Or maybe that was just to those of us in our late teens and early twenties at the time?

The graduates had held up pretty nicely, though maybe there was a self-selection bias going on. The men had put on a few pounds and lost some hair. But most of the women were looking pretty good, although as I scanned the room, I noted with a slightly absurd pride that Olivia, despite having two kids, had probably held up the best. She was still slender, and though compared with her HS pictures she'd obviously filled out a bit, that seemed to have concentrated in rounding out her ass and adding a cup size to her top. So, a good thing all around.

Mitch, too, had held up well. Tall, broad shouldered, his thick, curly hair was chestnut brown, though with just a light speckling of salt to add to his gravitas. He had a deep voice, and his face had a few crags, particularly around his hazel eyes, that gave him an outdoorsy vibe.

And there were the hands.

From the moment he'd greeted me with a grin and firm handshake, I'd been thinking about them. About his palms cupping my wife's ass. His thumbs teasing her nipples. His thick digits sliding in and out of her tight, wet, pussy. I didn't even need to think about what his cock was like. It was enough to imagine him fondling her, and Olivia shuddering with pleasure as his fingers churned inside her, curling up to press against her g-spot, sliding out slowly across her clit.

I forced myself to focus on the present. I heard some laughter, and noticed it was coming mostly from Mitch and Olivia. I caught Denise's glance. She forced a chuckle, and then she smiled at me, while giving me a slight eye-roll that I interpreted as: *Get a load of those two. If we weren't here they'd be jumping each other's bones.* Or maybe that was just what I was thinking.

Denise was a stunner herself with a sultry mediterranean look, dark hair in waves, nearly black eyes, full lips. Her green, silk blouse was unbuttoned enough to give a generous tease of cleavage. Her

fingernails were long, painted, and she had a half-dozen bracelets on her wrists. She oozed confidence. For a moment I wondered if she'd be up for a swing. Not that Olivia and I had ever done that or even talked about it. But it definitely felt like given the still-roaring attraction between my wife and her former paramour, it wouldn't take much to make it happen... assuming that Denise was up for it... and that I was.

I wasn't. I glanced at his hands again. I didn't need that kind of competition. Or maybe rather that kind of contrast. I was lanky and brainy, or at least that's how I liked to think of myself. Brainy, I mean. The lanky part is just a fact of life. I'd always expected to fill out at some point, but whenever I tried to gain weight it just went to my belly. So I stopped. And at 6'2" and 155 lbs, lanky it is. And pale too, sadly. My two possible shades are white and violet. Think a turnip. Swedish genes for ya. Olivia says I'm handsome. I'm apparently a ringer for Logan. Though sadly that's a reference to Michael York in Logan's Run rather than a buffed up Hugh Jackman as Wolverine.

Lost in thought, I missed another joke. I forced a catchup laugh, and hoped it wasn't at my expense somehow.

Denise mercifully ended it. She placed a bejeweled hand on Mitch's forearm.

"It's getting late, Baby. Need to relieve the sitter."

He checked his watch, sighed, and nodded. They had a long drive home from Denver to Colorado Springs. We exchanged hugs. Mine with Denise was perfunctory. So much for the foursome. Mitch's and Olivia's hug lasted just a smidge longer than appropriate, which Denise also noticed, given her twisted little smirk. I had a feeling Mitch would get a talking to on the way home.

Since we were staying at the hotel, we lingered a bit longer. Olivia walked me around the posters. Olivia in the newspaper office. Olivia as a midfielder on the soccer squad. Olivia as Sandy in the senior year production of Grease. And yes, Mitch was in it too, though as Kenickie, not Danny. Thank God for small favors.

We finally retired upstairs to our room. I put my jacket over the back of the chair, and sat on the bed loosening my tie, watching Olivia as she removed her jewelry and makeup in front of the mirror.

She was such a sexy woman, yet the moment lacked any real excitement. She was as hot and confident as Denise, but.... Even when you're lucky enough to be still in love and attracted to your spouse, it's, like, you've seen it all before. She unbuttoned her blouse and wriggled out of her skirt. I admired her ass—all those Body Pump classes definitely worked—but I felt about the same urgency about it as I might anything else of beauty. And she felt the same way. She wasn't teasing me with what was, in effect, a slow strip. It was just her getting-ready-for-bed routine. Only, it wasn't quite. There was something off. She doffed her bra and slipped into an oversized tee-shirt. I caught a flash of boob, but nothing more. And then I realized it. Normally she'd be chattering away, reviewing the evening, maybe even narrating her preparations for bed, something. But she wasn't tonight. Instead, she was quiet. Lost in thought.

Mitch.

She was thinking about him. I knew it in an instant. And I knew that if he were here instead of me, she wouldn't be brushing her teeth in her panties and t-shirt. No. She'd be all over him. Perched in his lap. Feeling his hardness beneath her. Kissing him passionately, his face cupped between her palms, as his big hands cupped her ass and mauled her breasts. Her breath coming in gasps as he yanked down her bra and sucked her plump nipples into her mouth, her arms wrapped desperately around his head. Then that frantically urgent struggle to unclasp his belt and yank down his pants, not completely, just enough to free his big, hard prick, so that, pulling her panties aside, she could sink down onto his shaft with a shuddering, contented sigh.

"Are you coming to bed?" she asked.

She'd finished brushing and had crawled into her side. I was still sitting half dressed on the bed, with a pulsing hardon. I calmed myself, and with careful positioning, managed to avoid embarrassment as I folded my pants and brushed my teeth as well. She had turned off the lights, so I climbed into bed in the dark.

She snuggled up against me face to face. "I may have had too much to drink to fool around," she admitted. Not that she was drunk.

It is just that a few drinks makes her sleepy. "On the other hand, it does seem a waste to not take advantage of a night away and a hotel room."

"Always practical," I replied.

"Did you have fun? Or at least, was it not miserable?"

I chuckled. "I had fun."

She snorted.

"What?"

"Well, you barely said a word."

"I didn't want to interrupt you and Mitch catching up."

"Ah ha!" she chirped. "You're jealous."

"Am not."

"Hmmm."

As my eyes adjusted, I could see that she was regarding me with cool amusement.

"Hmmm?"

She shrugged silently.

"So... how long *did* you date?" I asked.

She chortled and rolled onto her back. "Nope. Not jealous. Not even one little bit."

"Were you jealous of Denise?" I asked.

She turned her head to me and gave me a crooked smile. "Of course I was.... Not."

"Hmmm." I said.

"What's that mean?"

"Oh, so you're allowed to 'Hmmm' at me, but I can't 'hmmm' at you?"

She laughed. "Oh God, Dex, this has to be the literally stupidest fight anyone has ever had."

"We're not fighting."

She turned back to me. "Oh good."

I gave her a quick kiss.

"Do you ever think of him?"

A quick shrug. "I don't know. I see his feed on Facebook, I guess."

"No.... I mean.... You know."

"I don't know."

"Now you're just playing dumb."

"Are you sure we're not fighting?" she asked.

"No, just talking."

"I don't know what we're talking about, Honey. We've been married a long time, but I still can't read your mind."

I hesitated a moment before biting the bullet. "Like... I mean, when we fool around."

"You mean tonight?"

"No, I mean in general. Do you ever think of other people? And Mitch in particular."

"Do you? Well, not Mitch in particular. Or... I guess that would be okay. Are you coming out to me, Sweetie?"

"Ha ha. So, so far, you've played dumb, answered a question with a question, and then made a joke. So I'm going to take that as a yes."

"Are we fighting now?"

"Still no."

"Hmmmmmm. You didn't answer my question."

"Do I ever think of other women when we're making love? Sure. I guess. But not anyone real. Like movie stars."

"Or porn stars?"

"That too," I admitted. "But honestly, I haven't been with that many women in my life, and none of them were really memorable."

"Except for me."

"Except for you." She remained quiet, so I prompted her, "O?"

"Why are you asking?"

I rolled my eyes. "It really isn't that hard a question. I'm just curious. And... frankly, it is pretty obvious that you and Mitch have some chemistry still."

"Oh Dex, I'm sorry if—"

"It's okay. He is pretty hunky."

She giggled.

"It's okay," I repeated.

She sighed softly. "Me and Mitch.... It's complicated. We were just friends in high school. I had a secret crush on him."

“And he had a secret crush on you. Except everyone knew it and wondered why you two didn’t just hook up already.”

“Something like that. Or there was another girl in the mix or another boy. Or timing just wasn’t right. And anyway, we didn’t hook up until a couple years later. We were both home for winter break. And there was this party. I can’t remember where, but it was a ways away, and we had both had something to drink, and we’d been flirting all night, and maybe even getting a little handsy and kissing.”

I was tempted to make a joke about young love, red solo cups and pawing in the corner of a party, but I didn’t want to interrupt her flow.

“And anyway, it got late. And some people paired off, and we ended up deciding to share one of the few free beds.”

I chuckled.

“It wasn’t like that.... Or I don’t know. Maybe it was. Honestly, I didn’t really expect anything to happen. We’d... you know... like kissed a little before. But it never amounted to anything. And this was another weird, temporary interlude. We were both going back to school in a few days, and....”

“And?”

“Erm.... I guess I should mention that I was seeing someone else at the time. So I wasn’t really *available*.”

“Uh huh.”

“Anyway, we hooked up. Then went back to school. And that was that.”

“Hmmp. Yeah, no, that’s not quite right. No way the Mitch and Olivia I saw tonight just had a single, little awkward, drunk hook up.”

“It was just.... Oh Dex, I’m sorry if you think we were inappropriate tonight. I really don’t want a fight.”

“O.... I’m not upset. I.... To be honest. I’m a little turned on.”

“By me and Mitch?”

I nodded.

“I don’t understand.”

“I don’t either. Not really. But I know what I saw. And what I’m wondering is what was behind it. What were you both remembering that had you so... glowing.”

“I wasn’t glowing. I—”

“It was a long time ago. I’m not angry and not jealous. I’m just curious.”

“And a little turned on,” she added.

“Yup.” I craned my neck and gave her a quick kiss.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. And then another. And then she began speaking.

“It really wasn’t obvious what was going to happen. We’d had this off/on flirtation for years. And so, I didn’t really know. We stripped down a little and climbed into bed.”

“Stripped down?”

“It was winter. We were in jeans and sweaters. So, yeah took those off. Then we sort of lay there, you know, all awkward like. Then after what seemed like forever, I felt his hand edging against mine. And it was like a spark, just that little touch, and suddenly we were kissing really hard and sloppy. His hands went under my top, and he touched my breasts for the first time. I wrapped my arms around his neck. And then I started to get cold feet, I guess. I thought about Brad, and—”

“Brad? You’ve never mentioned him.”

“That was my boyfriend back at school. It wasn’t really serious. I mean, it was, and it wasn’t. Whatever, hard to explain.”

“It was serious enough that you were sleeping with him, but not so serious as to keep you out of bed with Mitch.”

“Something like that, but it was enough. You know, I was a good girl. This was wrong. So I pushed Mitch away. I was all like, ‘I’m sorry. I can’t do this. I have a boyfriend.’ All that kind of stuff. And even as I was saying it, I sort of knew it was bullshit. I could have been convinced. But Mitch was a friend, and he backed down. He sighed. He grumbled a good night, and then turned away. And right away I started having regrets. I told him I was cold and asked him to cuddle me.”

“Ooof.”

“Yeah, right. The worst kind of mixed-message bullshit. But I was young. I didn’t know what I wanted. What I was even allowed to want.” She paused. “You sure you want to hear this?”

I nodded.

Instead of resuming the story, she rolled over and turned her back to me, seemingly putting an end to it.

“O?”

“Cuddle me.”

I didn’t quite know what was going on, but I slid over and spooned her. I wrapped my arm around her and rested my palm just below her breasts. She pressed back against me, molding her body to mine.

“And then I started doing this,” she said.

I felt her ass begin to make slow circles, grinding against my crotch. My dick began to stiffen.

“He was so hard, and I was being such a tease.”

I imagined Mitch in bed with Olivia. Young, horny, a sexy little thing like my wife squirming against him. He must have been—

“He was sooo hard. Just like you are now.”

“I....”

She thrust back against me, obviously excited.

“He tried to be a gentleman. He tried to move away from my butt.”

She remained silent and I realized that she wanted me to reenact his part in this. So I edged back, and she followed, her ass again pressed against my crotch.

Olivia giggled. “Do you see what a horrible, little tease I was?”

I grunted.

“Finally, he tried to stop me. He put his hand on my hip and scooted back. ‘You have to stop,’ he said.”

She ground against me, pressing back hard, until she had my hard cock wedged between her cheeks. It was so sexy that I almost forgot my role.

“You have to stop,” I said finally.

She turned to face me. Her hand slipped between us and she trailed her fingers across my belly. She reached into my boxers and firmly gripped my hardon.

“Oh did I do this?” she asked.

I grunted affirmatively. She slowly stroked me up and down. Her face moved closer to mine, and I felt her hot breath against my cheek. She palmed the head of my cock, and used the precome to lube her hand for another series of slow, sultry strokes.

“God, you’re so hard. And your cock feels so big and hot.”

I wasn’t sure if she was talking to me or him. Then she gave me a wicked grin. “I’m sorry. I’ll let you sleep,” she said.

I groaned in frustration as she released my cock and rolled over. I felt a surge of emotion. Anger. Vexation. Lust. I didn’t know if I’d have been able to remain in control when I was twenty, and at forty, it was only just.

“Olivia?”

“Hmmm?”

“What happened with Mitch?”

She spun around quickly and pushed me onto my back. She threw a leg over my body and rolled on top of me. I felt her hot breath on my neck, and her heat and wetness against my crotch.

“He didn’t have quite your level of self-control,” she said as she nibbled my neck. “He grunted and grabbed me. I rolled onto my stomach, and he climbed on top of me. I could feel him, Baby, feel his hard cock against my ass.” She reached down and yanked my boxers down just enough to free my cock. “I told him no. I couldn’t. I had a boyfriend. He didn’t listen. His hand was between my legs. And I was so, so, so wet.” She was. Her panties were soaked. “I begged him, ‘please don’t.’ He covered my mouth with his big strong hand while his other hand ripped my panties off. I screamed into his hand as his big, hard cock pressed between my legs.” She pulled her panties aside, and rubbed her snatch up and down my shaft. “Then suddenly, he was inside me.” At the same moment, I was inside her. She began bouncing her hips up and down, fucking me hard.

I wouldn’t last long with her like this. “Slow down,” I groaned.

“He didn’t.” And she didn’t. “He fucked me hard. I screamed. I screamed so loud. Right into his palm.”

I imagined Mitch pounding his big cock into my wife. Dominating her. Her tight, little pussy stretched by his prick. She

kissed me hard. I was close. She was ahead of me. Her cunt spasmed on my cock. I grunted and came inside her.

“Oh God,” I moaned.

She chuckled and rolled off me. We were both sweaty.

“Were you scared?” I asked after a while.

“No. I knew I could trust him.”

“Even though he’d just... um.... It all sounds a little rapey, no?”

She chuckled. “Yeah, that wasn’t fair of me, was it? He was beside himself... well, after he finally came. He rolled off me and he kept saying he was sorry, so sorry. And I didn’t know what to say, how to explain things. I was too embarrassed to really say what I thought. So I did the one thing I really wanted to do.”

I waited for her to explain, but instead she ducked down under the covers and took my cock deep into her mouth.

“Uhhh,” I sighed as she enveloped my prick in her hot, wet mouth.

It would normally take me at least a few minutes to get hard again, but between Olivia slurping on my pole, and my mind working overtime to conjure up lurid images, I was ready again almost right away. I kept picturing them in bed. A strapping Mitch nearly smothering my slim wife. Her eyes wild as she screamed into his palm. His huge prick driving her into the bed.

She eased down my boxers, and I removed my t-shirt. She’d managed to slip out of her underwear as well. She trailed wet kisses up my belly, my chin. She kissed me wetly. Her tongue carried with it a hint of musk and salt, and for a confused moment, I wasn’t sure if I was tasting myself or Mitch.

Olivia rolled over and pulled me on top of her. My cock slid into her hot, gooey hole. I imagined that I was having Mitch’s sloppy seconds.

“What are you thinking?” she asked.

I was too embarrassed to answer honestly. “What happened after?”

“This,” she said as I slowly fucked her. “And then more. All night. The next day. The day after.”

“How many times?”

She chuckled. "As many times as two horny twenty-year-olds can manage. The fact that he wanted me so badly was such a turn-on."

I groaned excitedly at the thought of Mitch wearing my wife as a second skin, his huge prick plunging into her eager pussy every time it got hard.

"He's big," I said.

"Is that a question?"

I nodded.

"He's not actually the biggest man I've ever been with. But yes, big... and thick." She licked her lips as she said it.

"And after? Did you two stay together?"

She shook her head. "No, I went back to school. To Brad, although we did break up a few weeks later anyway. And then we hooked up a couple of times later on, but it was always complicated. Different cities, boyfriends, girlfriends, you know, messy."

"You cheated on guys with him?"

"Yes. Three in total."

I felt lightheaded. She'd cuckolded three men. Was I one of them?

"Am.... Am I one of three?"

She smirked at my question, especially since it was paired with my excitement rising. I felt my heart pounding. That slow fucking was also past. I was plunging into her sloppy pussy hard.

"Would you like to be?"

"No," I said. I wasn't in denial. I knew I was lying. She knew it too, and she played with that knowledge by remaining quiet, letting the silence do her work for her. My mind again was racing. I ran through every work trip she and I had ever been on, my weekends visiting old college friends, any time that we were apart. Had she fucked Mitch then? Once? More than once? Had he been in my house? In my bed?

"Ah, ah, oh God, Dex, you're so hard thinking about him fucking me. You're imagining when it might have happened. Thinking you're one of the three."

"Am I?"

She shook her head. "No...ah, ah, ah... not yet."

I groaned. "What would have happened had Denise and I not been here tonight?"

She paused. She didn't give me a flippant answer or even a sexy, teasing one. She was thinking about it. About whether she'd have fucked Mitch if I were not around.

"He'd be inside me. Making me come again and again."

"Oh God," I gasped as I suddenly lurched past the point of no return.

She chuckled as I rolled off her.

"You know I'd never cheat on you, right?" she said.

"Of course, Honey," I replied gasping for breath. "And I wouldn't want you to."

We were both lying, and we both knew the other was lying.

Chapter Two: Taking Stock

We returned home having made good use of a night away from the kids in a hotel. We even snuck in some morning sex before checking out, which I don't think we've done since our honeymoon. We were both pretty charged up, and I think I might have been able to pull off getting road head if I'd pushed it. But I didn't, and once home we immediately seemed to settle back into our routine, focused around kids and work, and with little room for a long night of sex.

It didn't help that we both had demanding jobs. I had recently gone out on my own. Well, with a few people, of course, but I was a founder and an owner for the first time in my life. We barely had enough business to just get by, but we'd been bidding on contracts, and had recently made the short-list on a monster that would keep us busy for years, and more importantly make the founding partners, if not filthy rich, then certainly in possession of "fuck you" money. Olivia, in the meantime, was actually bringing in most of the family income working as a lawyer. She was coming up for Partner, but the goalposts kept moving. And did I mention we have two kids, with all the practices, lessons, and "playdates" that entailed.

So yeah, sexytime was a bit of a rarity.

"So, you get any this weekend?"

That was Trip. Bobby Triplett. One of my business partners. Trip and I met in college and have been friends ever since. It was his idea to go out on our own. We'd worked in other places before, and a couple of jobs ago he'd just missed out on a pretty decent buyout because he switched firms before the offer came through. So he was looking to catch up.

"Well, good morning to you too."

He sprang into my office. He was a sparkplug of a man, on the shorter side and stocky, with dark hair, and shining eyes behind

tortoise shell glasses. He always had, as they say, a bounce in his step.

“Tracey and I did it twice this weekend.” He held up two fingers and added a happy nod.

“Um, congrats.”

He sat down across from my desk and cracked his knuckles. “Yup, she can’t keep her hands off me.”

“Isn’t she trying to get knocked up again?”

“Yes, there is that. I’m not sure why we need a fifth kid... but you know, happy wife happy life.”

He didn’t always seem quite as happy as that makes it sound. He missed out on the buyout because Tracey had pushed him to switch jobs to increase his salary. Since she didn’t work outside the home, and with four kids, she couldn’t be as patient as Olivia was about the whole start-up game.

“And you get a little nookie in as a result.”

“I’ve been wearing briefs. Hopefully that’ll cook the swimmers enough that I can have the best of both worlds.”

I laughed, though it felt pretty passive aggressive.

“You?”

“We had fun at her reunion.”

“Hmmm, I bet. Was Olivia the hottest woman there?”

I shrugged modestly, as if her attractiveness was my doing. “Of the class, probably. Though the ones who came held up pretty well.” I thought also of Denise. “There was this one other guest who was in the same league.”

“And?”

“What?”

“Buns? Nookie. Banging Timbs?”

“Don’t you think it is a little inappropriate to be talking about our wives like we used to talk about girls we picked up frat parties?”

He nodded sympathetically. “So no. Sorry dude. I was sort of hoping for you that being around her old crushes would get her going.”

“I’ll have you know that we did it three times.” I held up three fingers. “On Saturday night alone.”

He whistled. "You know she was thinking about other dudes, right?"

He was closer to the truth than I was willing to acknowledge. "Just like Trace is probably thinking about me when she's with you."

He gave me the middle finger and laughed. He changed the topic, "Hey, Markson is still nosing around. He thinks if we team on the proposal, we'll be a shoo-in."

"Markson is a dick. Fuck him."

Markson was Trevor Markson. Over the years, Trip, Markson, and I had worked together and competed on numerous projects.

"He is a dick," Trip admitted. "But he's got good connections and a good eye for numbers."

"Dude, last time we worked with him, he threw us under the bus."

"Well, in fairness, we did botch the roll-out. He just wasn't willing to be a good teammate and take the fall along with us. And yeah, he was maybe a little more gleeful about it than we'd have liked."

"I don't want to work with him."

Trip nodded. "Just consider it. Plenty of feed in the trough for all of us. But we need to get invited to chow."

"Yeah, yeah. But I still think we're better off without him."

He gave me three quick nods and virtually leaped out of the chair before bounding out in the hallway.

I pulled up the proposal and reviewed it for what seemed like the 100th time. It was as good as it was going to get, but I couldn't help tinkering. It was just something to do. I was pretty sure we'd get past the screening, but that's when the politics start. It isn't like Markson would make a difference in our favor, but the danger was him working against us. Maybe it was better to have him in the tent pissing out than outside pissing in.

"No," I muttered to myself. "He's a snake. He's the kind of guy who'd praise your marriage and seduce your wife."

I jolted. That was a strange thought. Though yes, Markson had never tried to disguise the fact that he thought Olivia was sexy. Somehow, he managed to work in a discussion of her workout

routine every time they met. But after the weekend's events, I wondered where my mind was going with this. Was I turned on by the idea of Olivia and Markson?

Trevor Markson was tall and broad shouldered. Olive skin and dark eyes. A thick shock of black hair. He could have played the heavy in an old mob movie. He was vain and a bit of a drunk. Probably a narcissist, but that gave him an infectious confidence that can have its own appeal. When we first met him, at a conference, he seemed charismatic and in-control. It took a couple of years of working together to realize that was all an act. But the young, insecure girls he seduced didn't have the advantage of time. By the time they realized, he'd moved on to another target. Markson was a cocksman, with an endless series of notches on his belt.

Trip and I found this out on a project we worked on with him, three jobs back, when we were all in the same company. We were bidding to be subs on a contract, but we weren't sure whether to prioritize price or deadline on the proposal. Just a stupid, little, technical detail, but the difference between success and failure. Trip wanted to provide multiple options, but I was worried that violated the terms of the RFP. I figured we should flip a coin. Markson had a better solution.

He knew a girl working for the prime. Sharon was a short, pale-skinned, strawberry blonde, with a pretty face, but a few extra pounds, which, honestly, probably made more of a difference for her than anyone else.

So, he seduced her. They met at a happy hour, and ended the night with her blowing him in a bathroom and swallowing his come. This was a fact he told us gleefully the next morning. He didn't skimp on the details. She had a fat ass that turned crimson when he spanked her. She let him come on her face. She was completely shaved. We received a picture to confirm that. She came really hard when he put a finger in her ass, but cried when he fucked her anally, not that this stopped him from coming in her ass. And when she had given him everything she had, and it still wasn't enough for him, she also gave us the internal project rubric. He kept her around long enough to have her eat his ass, and then he dumped her.

It was good money. The contract we won was at least in part because of Markson's subterfuge. The bonus we received helped provide seed money for Trip and me going out on our own. But it came at a price, which was having to look myself in the mirror knowing about Sharon. He was an abusive shit. So why was I even thinking about him and Olivia?

Chapter Three: Dreaming

I call them, somewhat melodramatically, the Lost Hours. Somehow the hours between 6pm, when you get home, and 10pm, when the kids are in bed, pass in seconds. Blink and they are gone. Then it's late. You stagger into the bedroom. There is time for sex, but honestly watching a little TV seems more appealing, although halfway through a show, you realize you're already drifting off.

Olivia and I were both half catatonic as we climbed into bed.

"How was your day?" I asked.

She tore her attention away from yet another true crime book. Her shoulders slumped. "I don't know."

That perked me up. "Everything okay?"

She sighed. "No, not really."

I'm not sure if she moved toward me or me toward her. It just sort of happened, and I had my arms wrapped around her.

"Charlie?"

She nodded. "I can't tell whether he's in my corner or not."

Charlie Shreve was the head of Olivia's practice area. He was in his early-60s, with thinning grey hair, and glasses. His vote would be crucial to her becoming a partner.

"He says he is," I noted.

"Yeah, but then he cuts my hours, which looks bad. Pushes down realization rate. Affects the bottom line."

"I don't know," I replied, not quite knowing what to say. Olivia is very conscientious. Maybe even a little too much sometimes. I could imagine her spending more hours than strictly necessary on a project.

She sighed. "He hired me. He trained me. If he didn't think I should become a partner, he should have said so long ago."

"I'm sure he'll support you."

Olivia rolled her eyes. "We'll see."

"What? I mean, other than cutting your hours, what has he done?"

"It's more.... It's more what he hasn't done. I... I mean, I've fucked stuff up sometimes."

"Yeah, haven't we all?" I said with a chuckle. "That's the point of training young people, right?"

"Right, but, like, he's always been supportive."

"So, that's a good thing."

"I don't know. Is it? Or is it just that he never had the heart to tell me I wasn't doing a good job."

"Oh, Honey, that's just in your head."

"Remember that case, with the guy and the cows and the cropduster? Tams and I really blew that one, right? But only she got *counseled*. Why do you think that is?"

"She was senior to you."

"By one year. No, I mean, seriously, Dex, why do you think?"

I sighed. "Because Charlie likes you and thinks you're a good lawyer?"

"Or because Tammy is fat and Charlie likes my ass in a pencil skirt."

"Does he still? I mean, obviously he does. He's a man. But does he ever say anything anymore?"

"No. And that was a long time ago. Before you and I even met, I think."

"So?"

"I mean, it's nothing overt. Just that hopeful, puppy dog gaze guys give you when they want to get in your pants but don't have the confidence to say so."

"Ouch." Olivia had, indeed, made the first move in talking to me.

"You were an exceptionally earnest puppy dog. And handsome."

I chuckled. "Yup. Me and George Clooney. Have to beat you girls off with a stick."

She looked up at me. "I deserve this, right? It's not just that Charlie would like to get me into bed."

I kissed her. "You're a star. They would make you partner even if you looked like a horse."

Noise from downstairs woke me. I glanced at the alarm clock, but it wasn't on my nightstand, but it was late. Still dark outside. Olivia wasn't in bed. Her side was made up. Had I gone to sleep before her?

I rose and went through the doorway and toward the stairs. The lights were on in the family room, casting swirling shadows on the lower half of the staircase. The steps were slippery and soft, as if covered in mud, though looking down, I could see they weren't. It was just that the carpeting was wet and moldy. I had to brace myself against the wall to make it through that swampy morass.

The family room was sunken and spacious. Olivia had apparently renovated. And then I remembered, it was part of connecting our house to our neighbor's. The construction continued into the darkness beyond the patio door.

Olivia was sitting on the sofa with her back to me. Beside her was a man. They were talking and laughing. Their words were muddled, but the meaning seemed clear, as if I had the benefit of a simultaneous translation to provide meaning. *He'll never know. Who cares if he does.* Giggles... at my expense.

I moved closer and found myself on the other side of the sofa. I called Olivia's name. She didn't respond. Didn't seem to notice me. I was in the kitchen now, with a good view of them through the plexiglass partition.

Olivia was naked. Had she been already? I banged on the glass, but they didn't seem to notice. Too busy. The man was dark-haired and hirsute, back and chest covered in thick, black curls. He was sucking one plump tit, but the reason for Olivia's moaning was something else. His hand was between her legs, two thick fingers stretching her pussy. I couldn't see his face, but it was someone I knew, though I didn't know who it was. There was a sense of familiarity rather than identity.

My wife moaned louder and louder, until the man took his fingers from her juicy cunt and fed them into her mouth. She gagged

on his thick digits, but writhed on the sofa sensuously. There was another man, in the shadows, watching. He was closer than me. Much closer. Almost looming over them, craning his neck to better see the man molesting my wife.

I was standing over them. She moaned around his fingers. He was naked and she was stroking a huge, veiny prick. *Should I fuck her?* He asked. I tried to ignore the question. I knew if I tried to speak, the dream would end. I knew it was a dream now. The point in the nightmare where you realize what it is and try to will and shout yourself awake, but instead of fighting it, I just hoped it would continue. Her cunt was wet, pulsing, and swollen. It needed to be fucked. Hard. By a huge, veiny prick. I needed to see it.

“Dex... Dex... wake up... you’re having a nightmare.”

“Huh, what?”

I was in bed with Olivia. She looked me over, concerned.

“You okay? That was a heck of a nightmare.”

I nodded, still not quite sure which reality was real.

“What were you dreaming about?”

“Nothing.”

“Nothing as in you can’t remember? Or nothing as in you don’t want to tell me?”

“I... don’t remember. Something about a monster.”

She accepted my deflection without comment, and instead leaned over and gave me a kiss.

“Goodnight Monster Boy.”

I rolled over and tried to get back to sleep, hoping to be able to continue the dream, but knowing it wouldn’t happen.

The dream stayed with me the next day, though not so much in its details that seemed increasingly murky as time passed. What remained was crystallized in that image... well, less a specific image than an impression of something... of need, of desire. Mine, hers, the strange man’s. Who was he? I wasn’t sure, and it didn’t matter. But all three of us had one shared wish. Like three separate flashlights combining at one key spot, illuminating all the details, while leaving the rest in shadows. Her wet cunt. His huge prick. And

then even that faded, but it left behind an afterimage, a retinal burn, and when I closed my eyes, I saw it still, in negative, but still clearly.

Chapter Four: Sapphos

I dragged myself into the house on Friday evening, stressed and exhausted from work. The RFP we were working on was due in two weeks, and we'd just received a new template for the out-year costing model. Trip was taking a first cut, but I'd need to work on it over the weekend as well. I kicked off my shoes and walked toward the kitchen.

Olivia heard me and called out. "Val is coming over for dinner. Is that okay?"

We were in the kitchen, and Olivia was cutting up a cantaloupe for the kids to snack on in front of the TV.

"Awww, darn it, I have a work thing... just can't get out of it. I was just here to pick up a change of clothes."

"Ha ha. A thing, eh? Anyway, we haven't seen her in weeks."

"Has it been that long? It seems, um, much more recent than that."

She rolled her eyes at me. "Be nice."

"You should tell her that."

"Oh, please, you give as good as you get."

Val and I had something of a contentious relationship. They were college friends, and Val always acted as if she knew Olivia better than I did. And maybe she did. Trip, after all, knew plenty about me that Olivia didn't.

"Sounds great," I replied. "Just as long as the booze holds out."

"I bought extra."

The doorbell rang. Olivia gestured at the melon. "Finish up?"

"Sure."

She scurried to the door. Shrieks, hugs, air kisses, giggles. They burst back into the kitchen arm in arm.

"I see you finally got him to do a little work around the house," Val said as she saw me filling bowls with fruit.

"Nice to see you too, Val."

She blew me a kiss.

"I'll have a glass of wine, please," I said.

Olivia was already pouring three glasses of Merlot. She handed me one, and the girls clinked theirs. I brought the cantaloupe to the kids, who were somehow juggling a video game, bouncing through Youtube videos, and frantically reviewing and liking Insta posts all at the same time.

I returned to the kitchen. Olivia was heating oil on the stove, while she chopped up a bowl of pico de gallo. She'd changed out of her work clothes, but instead of her usual weekend sweats, she'd put on a cute, summery, flowered dress. Her hair was braided into a ponytail, cute and wholesome. Val was in her usual skin-tight jeans, leather boots, and sleeveless top. She was tall, nearly 5'10", slender, with her dark hair cut in a fade above the ears, rising to a pompadour. Her left ear was filled with rings, and a tattoo of a snake curled up her right arm and across her shoulders.

They were standing close, chatting animatedly. Val had a big smile on her face, and I noticed her giving Olivia the once over. Which wasn't surprising, given Val's orientation, but I'd never quite noticed before how she devoured my wife with her eyes. Hearing about Mitch seemed to have put a new filter over my eyes.

Olivia threw the marinated meat into a cast iron skillet. It seared in a loud, smokey whoosh. I quickly set the table.

Val refilled our glasses as we sat down. Olivia pulled warm tortillas out of the oven.

"So how was the reunion?" Val asked.

Olivia shrugged. "Fine. They had all these old pictures. I can't believe how young we looked."

Val chuckled. "Oh, Sweetie, you can still pass for twenty-five." Then she looked over at me. "Did they ask you why you'd brought your dad?"

"Ha ha," I said, as cut myself a piece of steak. "Did you know Olivia was Sandy in Grease?"

"Of course," Val replied. "She brought the costume with her to school."

I laughed. "Really?"

Olivia nodded. "I thought maybe I'd wear it at a party or something."

“But she was too chicken,” Val said. “I was always trying to get her to wear those leather pants out in public.”

“Leather pants are not all that comfortable, actually,” Olivia noted.

“But they are sexy,” I replied, noting that Val was nodding along. “Do you still have them?”

She snorted. “Oh God, they’re probably in my parent’s house somewhere. But there is no way I could get my fat ass into them now.”

“But I bet Dex would love to see you try,” Val said, speaking probably as much for herself as for me.

I relaxed thanks to the wine and the light sexual banter. I finished my glass and rose to open another bottle. “Oh, and I got to meet Mitch. I guess he’s the one that got away. Maybe she wore those pants for him?”

I turned to see Olivia shaking her head slightly and Val looking down at her plate. There was a chill in the air.

“I... erm.... Would anyone like more wine?” I asked, filling their glasses without waiting for an answer.

“We had a good trip,” Olivia said. “Nice to not have to make up the bed after you leave. Right Honey?”

I nodded. “Yeah, and they even put mints on our pillows.”

Val lifted her head and gave Olivia a small smile. “This is great. You totally need to give me this recipe.”

“So, what was that about?” I asked as Olivia climbed into bed.

“Erm, what?”

I lowered my eyes and peered at her. “Um, Mitch? When I said his name, it was like all the air left the room.”

“Yes.”

“Olivia? ‘Yes’ isn’t actually an answer.”

“Right.”

“Ol—”

"I'm thinking."

"About what you want to tell me?"

She sighed. "Or at least how much."

"You can't refuse now," I said with a smile.

"I know."

"So just start at—"

"Remember when I said I'd cheated on three guys with Mitch?"

Well, maybe it was more like two guys and a girl?"

My eyes went wide. Comically so, given Olivia's guffaw.

"Oh, come on, Dex, you must have suspected that Val and I... you know."

"Suspected... no. Fantasized... yes."

"Typical."

"Oh God, Olivia. I need details. Was this just like, you know, like hand holding and cuddling, or...."

"You don't *need* details. You just *want* them."

I laughed. "I may actually *need* them this time."

"Pervert."

"Yes. You're just a squeaky clean, good girl. I think you were just about to tell me about your experience with sapphic delights."

"What is there to tell? We were hanging out, drunk, sitting under a blanket in my dorm room. She was giving me goosebumps by gently tracing a fingertip across my forearm. Her lips were full and looked so kissable. And... it just happened."

"Just that one time?" I asked.

"No. I mean, if you're going to experiment, you might as well, you know... experiment."

"Did you like it?"

"What isn't there to like? Soft lips on your nipples. A tongue flicking on your clit. Lesbians are really, really good with their hands. And making a woman come is... different and exciting. And Val is very dominant, which is always hot, and was even sexier somehow with a woman."

"So what happened?"

She reached into my pants and stroked my hard cock.

"Sometimes a girl just needs a cock."

“And then any cock will do?”

Olivia chuckled. “When you’re desperate enough, I guess. But in this case, it wasn’t just *any* cock.”

“No, it was Mitch’s big cock.”

“Big, hard, thick,” she teased.

“Oh Olivia,” I sighed as she used my precome to lube my shaft. “I want you.”

I started to roll on top of her, but she redirected me beneath the covers. “I’m not sure I’m ready for just *any* cock.”

My vision blurred as my blood pressure soared. If Mitch were here, he could have her. She’d spread wide for him. But I had to earn it. Olivia was playing a game with me, but I also knew the tease reflected an underlying reality. Mitch could always have her. She guided my head down between her legs.

“Take off my panties,” she ordered.

I did as I was told, sensing her heat, wetness, and excitement as I did.

“Is that from thinking about Val, Mitch, or me?”

She chuckled. “Don’t worry about that.” She grabbed a handful of my hair and pressed my face to her juicy, shaved snatch.

She was so wet that my cheeks were quickly covered with her juices. I licked at her swollen clit. She moaned softly. Her trimmed blonde muff was soaked as well. I slipped a finger inside her, and then drew it out slowly, pressing against her clit the entire time. She shuddered.

“Oh, you’re almost as good at that as Val,” she said with a small chuckle.

She was yanking my chain, but it was another blow. Carefully struck. I already knew I didn’t fuck her as well as Mitch. Now, she was letting me know I couldn’t eat her out as well as Val. I redoubled my efforts. I sucked her juicy lips into my mouth, I flicked her bean with my tongue, I made slow circles on her clit with the pad of my thumb. She moaned louder and began thrusting her crotch against my face.

“That’s it, Baby, drink my come,” she gasped.

I mouthed her pussy and sucked hard. She pressed down on the back of my head. Her hips rolled in passion. I felt her pussy get hotter and wetter, and then felt her spasms through my lips.

I kissed my way up her body. My prick was so hard it ached. I needed to bury it in her sloppy, wet hole. But she slipped out from beneath me and put her hand on my chest. Her other hand reached into my boxers and stroked my cock.

"Why does this turn you on?" she asked.

"I... I don't know."

"But you do like it. I've never quite seen you like this. Is it knowing I'm not a good girl. Knowing I like it hard and dirty. That I'm a cheater."

"Yes."

"Should I fuck Val? I do so miss eating pussy."

"Yes," I groaned. "I want to be inside you."

She laughed. "How about Mitch? Should I fuck him too?"

"Yes."

"And what about his wife? Should I let them both seduce me? Would you like to watch me eating Denise's pussy while Mitch fucks me from behind?"

"Oh God," I grunted, spurting all over her hand and my boxers.

She laughed. "You are such a pervert."

"Oh God," I gasped, trying to catch my breath. "You should talk."

Chapter Five: Work Woes

I didn't stay in the handjob zone for long. Less than ten minutes, in fact. Just long enough for me to get hard again. Then we went ahead and proved that the marital bed can be just as hot as a hotel room. That is, if you have the right motivation.

Olivia and Val were lovers for almost a year. Young lesbians, apparently, have the same sex drive as young men. Or at least they did. Val was a kinky, demanding lover. She liked to go out dancing and fondle Olivia on the dance floor, fingering her to orgasm. And she liked to make Olivia kneel before her and lick her clit.

And then Mitch came to visit. He was completely accepting, and said he was happy that Olivia had discovered her true self. He managed to disarm Val's suspicions, at least until she walked in on Olivia exuberantly riding Mitch's cock.

Olivia doled these memories out slowly, a new one every time my ardor seemed to be flagging. It was glorious.

"Oof, rough weekend," Trip exclaimed after he bound into my office and commandeered a chair. "Tired Friday, headache Saturday, work stress Sunday. Or she said. I think it is just that her ovulation tracker said it was not an auspicious time. Not that I am sure the damn thing works. One time it told us to fire away, and it ended up that she was just starting her period. Anyway, I had to whack it. What's the point of being married if you still have to whack it?"

"Love?" I offered. "Companionship? Family?"

He laughed. "Oh good, you didn't score either."

I tried to shrug noncommittally, but my attempt at equivocation was like chum in the water.

"Oh, another good week, huh? She's still thinking about her old boyfriends. Well, whatever gets the engine running, am I right?"

Was he right? Because that was something I was worried about. I didn't want our sex life to be about other people. But... on

the other hand, how often does your wife of over a decade ride you like a rodeo star while massaging your balls with the gooey mix of arousal and come leaking from her pussy?

“Trip? So... how weird is this?”

I explained the situation to him. Mitch. The chemistry between them. Her history of cheating on lovers to be with him. And the coup de grace, the fact that one of those lovers was a woman.

“Oh, fuck, oh fuck,” he groaned. “Val is that sexy brunette, right? Great ass and the boots? They went down on each other. Fuck, that’s hot. Did they ever 69?”

I turned my palms up. “Jeez, I don’t know. I guess, right?”

“Imagine being a dude walking in on that, man. I bet that boy Mitch had ‘em both. Did O tell you that?”

“Um, no.”

“But you know it happened, right? Or at least it should have.”

“Why do I get the sense you’re not going to get any work done today?”

He shook his head. “Damn. You think Trace has ever gotten up to anything like that? Fuck, I’d kill to have that kind of story from her.”

“You should ask.”

“Ha. Hey, Honey, just apropos of nothing, do you have any lesbian orgies or big-dicked exes in your background.”

I chuckled. “I said nothing about orgies. Or big dicks.”

He laughed. “Yup, I’m sure ol’ Mitchy is packing a micro phallus. Totally explains why Olivia kept cheating on other people with him. Think he could have her still? Like, if you hadn’t been at the reunion.”

“It was a long time ago, and not any real serious relationships. So... no.”

“Whatever gets you through the day,” he said with a chuckle.

“Well, having now provided you titillation for the week, I need to get back to work.”

“Yes,” he said loudly. “Work! So... Markson.”

“Ugh, what about him?”

“Look, he wants to go out. Have a few drinks. Clear the air.”

“Pass.”

"Why do you hate him so much? It can't just be the thing with the girl."

"That would be enough, honestly. But look, you can't trust the guy. And I don't want to be his partner."

"Okay, so that's progress."

"How so?"

"Well, you don't want to be his partner, so no equity. And he can't seduce consenting adults either as part of the capture process. Any other red lines?"

I shook my head. "Dude.... Fine. Whatever. He's not going to accept that deal anyway. He wants a piece of the pie, not just a salary."

"Well, we'll see, won't we?" Trip said, already bolting toward the door. Just before leaving, though, he stopped short. "Hey, wanna go shooting this weekend?"

Once we started having kids and being away for 6 hours on a weekend was no longer maritally viable, we'd switched from golf to skeet and target.

"What are you thinking?"

"I'd say target, but it's been so long that I doubt I could hit a target at five paces. So skeet."

"Done."

When he finally left my office, my cell rang. Olivia.

"Hey, Honey, what's up?" I said.

"Charlie just invited us to dinner with him and Ellie for this weekend. Any objections."

"No, of course not. You think this is a harbinger of good news?"

"I'm hoping. I don't think he'd invite us out to tell us that I wasn't going to make partner. So at least, it probably isn't bad news. Okay, I'll get a sitter lined up."

I hung up and went to work, which meant calling up the proposal I'd already reviewed 100 times and just crossing those T's and dotting those I's one last time.

Trip showed up for work late the next day, and missing the usual spring in his step.

"Oh God, you look like shit," I noted.

"Knew I could count on your support," he replied, easing himself into the chair in my office.

"Um, late night? Or right, Markson. Was that last night? You don't waste time."

He smirked. "Yup. And I hired us a new capture manager."

"Oh God, no. I told you I didn't want to partner."

"No partner. Straight fee for service."

"What else did you promise him?"

"Seriously, Dex, nothing. He was, um, a motivated seller."

I really didn't want to get dragged into Markson's gossip, but Trip knew how to string me along too well for me to resist. I sighed. "All right, I'll bite. What happened?"

He smirked and put his fingertips together, and then peered at me through the diamond they made.

"You're still drunk," I said.

"You should see the other guy."

"Trip, seriously, I—"

"Markson is getting divorced."

I laughed. "I didn't realize the fucker was married."

"Yeah, well, he apparently didn't much realize it either. Lots of drama. He managed to get himself caught *in flagrante*, and now Anna is taking him to the cleaners. Which is why you get a prenup."

"You have a prenup with Trace?"

He nodded. "She'd do okay if we split up. But yeah, there's a cap. Honestly, you should have an agreement too. Do you know how many companies have blown up because one of the founders had to give away his voting shares?"

"Yeah, well, not sure Olivia's gonna go for that," I replied. "Anyway, Markson is a dick, and thinks with his dick. So it serves him right that Anna is making him pay. I'm surprised she took it for so long. I mean, she had to know, right?"

"Maybe she liked what he was giving her enough to look the other way."

I groaned. “Yeah, ha ha, I get the point. If she could take it, then why am I being so prissy.”

He shrugged as if the thought had never occurred to him. “Yeah, well, he’s in a holding pattern. He doesn’t want to add any assets to the marital pile until the divorce is settled. So we get him for a song.”

“He’s going to want equity on the backend.”

Trip shrugged. “And yeah, if we’ve fallen in love with him by then, we can always—”

“No. No dude. No backdoor promises.”

Trip held his hands up. “No promises at all. I’m just saying, the future is the future. We’ll worry about it then. In the meantime, he’s going to help out at a quite reasonable hourly.”

“I don’t like this.”

“Yeah. I don’t mind, honestly. Especially given the terms. He is good.”

“Yeah,” I grumbled. “He is.”

I was still conflicted as I drove home. Markson showed his talents quickly. After an initial review of our submission, he noticed an overly conservative NPV estimate, and with a small adjustment in the project management model that improved the bid while also improving front end cash flow. Annoyingly, he’d already earned most of what we planned to pay him, and that was just in his first half-day.

“How was work?” Olivia asked when I got home.

I rolled my eyes. “Great. I guess. We definitely improved the proposal this afternoon.”

“So why, ‘I guess’?”

“Trip hired Markson to consult and it was his change.”

Olivia chuckled. “You hired Markson? I thought you hated the guy.”

“Hate is a strong word.”

She looked at me skeptically.

“But,” I continued, “probably appropriate in this case.”

She laughed. "Wine?"

I nodded and she poured me a glass of Sauvignon Blanc.

It was surprisingly quiet in the house. "Kids?" I asked.

"Pizza party at Claude and Grace's pool. They'll get a ride home after."

I took a deep draught of wine. "Wow. Lucky us." It was so rare to have some Lost Hours to ourselves. "Anyway, I didn't hire him. Trip did."

She opened the oven and checked inside. The aroma of garlic, sundried tomato, olive oil, and shrimp flatbread filled the room. She closed the door and turned on the broiler.

"I thought you were the big cheese. Co-Founder and CEO," she said portentously.

I laughed. "And he's Co-Founder and President and we have three VPs and no staff, so, you know, our business processes are still evolving."

"And you hate him, because he mistreated some girl?"

"Yeah. I mean, he used her."

Olivia shrugged. "It won't win him any humanitarian awards, but as long as she was willing, there isn't much to gain by prying into people's private lives."

"He made us his accomplices. I mean, he even showed us nudes he had of her."

"Oh, I didn't realize he tied you two boys down and inflicted this on you."

"Ha ha. You know what I mean."

She reached into the oven and pulled out the flatbreads that now had a perfect little sear on them. She put one onto each plate and brought them over to the table. I refilled our glasses. She took a sip.

"Actually, no. What do you mean?"

"Oh, I don't know. I mean, you're right. At the time, I didn't mind the prurient details. It's only after, when he dumped her."

"Guys have sex with women and then dump them all the time. And women with have sex with guys and dump them too."

"He was married at the time," I noted.

She lifted up her flatbread and took a bite, drawing out a gooey string of Mozzarella, which she proceeded to slurp up noisily. She grinned at my vaguely horrified expression.

“Amusing how you’d get all bent out of shape about cheating when you can’t seem to hear enough about me being unfaithful.”

I felt a need to fan my face.

“That’s not the same. You were not married to Val or Brad.”

“Who knows what their marriage understanding was? There are some casual relationships that have stricter guidelines than some marriages.”

“She’s divorcing him.”

“That could easily be more about him never putting his coffee mug in the dishwasher than marital extra-curriculars.”

I spotted my mug from this morning sitting on the counter. “Ha ha,” I said, while also quickly rising and spiriting the mug into the dishwasher. “I’m not sure why you’re defending the guy.”

“I’m not defending him. I mean, not particularly. I’m just saying, I think the story you’ve constructed about Markson and the girl being the straw that broke the camel’s back is pretextual.”

“Oh, so I have a hidden motive?”

She shrugged.

“Out with it.”

“Oh, Dex, this is silly.”

“We’re not fighting. I swear. Just, what are you saying?”

She took another bite of flatbread. Chewed slowly. Dabbed her lips. Drank another sip of wine. All before answering me.

“Trevor Markson is a very handsome man.”

“I don’t th—”

“He exudes a sort of dangerous sensuality.”

“I.... uh.....”

“It is... very... hard... to resist a man like that.”

I was hard too. “Did you and Mar....?”

“Did we what?”

“You know. Make—”

“Love? I don’t think Trevor does that. No, I think, he... fucks.”

“Oh God,” I groaned.

“So is that what you want to know? You want to know whether I’ve ever fucked Trev? Whether I’ve ever spread my legs wide and taken his huge, pulsing cock in my tight, married pussy?”

“Yes.”

She laughed. “It almost sounds like you’d want me to.” She took a swig of wine. “I seem to be saying that a lot recently. Would you want me to?”

“No. He’s an asshole.”

“That’s the problem, Dex. Assholes often fuck sooo good.”

My mind was reeling. I glanced at my wine. I felt drunker than I should on a glass and a half. My heart was pounding, my hands shaking.

“Olivia... did you and Markson?”

She ran her hand down across her chest and down between her legs. She gave me a crooked smile. I didn’t need the answer. I had it. Markson had fucked my wife. All those stories about Sharon I immediately recast with Olivia. Drinking his come. Getting her ass spanked red. Licking his ass.

Her answer was even more painful when it actually came.

“No. I haven’t. But. I totally would, even if I had to give him my ass and my boss’s business secrets to get that dick.”

I wasn’t drunk, but it was something of a blackout. I remember tackling Olivia to the floor, and her managing to twist away. I caught her on the stairs and tore off her panties. I was so hard and almost inside her when she managed to escape my grip, her laughter taunting me as she ran bare-assed to the second floor. And then in bed. A confused combat, until finally, she squeezed my chin in her hand and sank down on my painfully throbbing prick.

Olivia was in a good mood when she joined me for breakfast. So I knew nothing too disconcerting had happened last night, even though my memories of it were intermittent. I offered her a cup of coffee. She took it with a smile.

“I just woke the kids,” she said.

“So the time bomb is ticking.” Somewhere between 7 and 9 minutes after waking, they’d be downstairs clamoring for attention.

“Are we okay?” she said.

“I am if you are.”

“Are you? Because I’m having fun with this, but it gets you really intense.... Which is... hot. Especially now.” She glanced at the ceiling from where the kids jumping could be heard. “But, you know it is a game. I’m not really—”

“I know. And... I’m having fun too.”

She grinned and scanned the room conspiratorially. “I think you come even harder thinking of me with Markson than you do with Mitch.... I... do... too.”

So, yeah, things were a little crazy.

The crazy, though, was packaged in distinct bursts. Most of the time, the vast majority of the time, things were normal. No one looking at us from the outside would have any sense that Olivia and I were exploring... what? Fantasies? Desires? Fears? All of them at once?

The week passed quickly. Markson made a number of useful recommendations to the pitch, and based on the expenses he was filing, he was having drinks with half the members of the selection committee.

I woke up early on Saturday morning, and went to the gun safe. Then back to my office to track down the combination since I opened it so rarely. I unlocked it and glanced inside. On the bottom was my Sig Sauer P320, its case now covered with a fine layer of dust. I thought about taking it out, but I knew that would be depressing. I hadn’t shot it in a couple of years, and it needed to be cleaned and oiled before I could use it. Instead, I grabbed the Browning 725 and a box of shells.

I met up with Trip at the range. He’d already gotten the station set up, and we got started. Trip was great on the single shots, but had trouble with the doubles, but neither of us were quite good

enough to make the shooter's option on twenty-five meaningful. There were always a few stupid misses beforehand.

"You were right," I admitted. "Markson is good at this."

He waved me off. "He is an asshole."

"What does Tracey think of him?"

"Barely knows him, I guess. I asked her, and she said she wasn't sure she could pick him out of a lineup."

That gave me pause. When had Olivia seen him that Tracey hadn't?

"Haven't we been to, like, a bunch of events and parties together?"

Trip shrugged. "I dunno. I guess he never made an impression on her. Why?"

"Just curious." I took my shots. Hit the high, missed the low. We moved over to the next station. "How goes the baby-making?"

He rolled his eyes. "We're apparently not in optimal insemination time, so I'm supposed to stockpile."

"How's that going?"

"I jerked off to a Chive Things That Bounce Thursday gallery."

"Ha. It's always great to hear about a marriage where the couple shares the same values."

"So how's Mitch? Olivia keeping up with him?"

I gave him the evil eye. He laughed.

"Glass houses, Baby. Glass houses."

I beat Trip, as I usually do. At home, I locked away the shotgun, and took a shower.

"Are you ready to go?" Olivia asked when I came down the stairs.

"Are you nervous?"

"Fuck yeah."

I chuckled. "It'll be good news."

When we arrived at Pavia's, Charlie and Ellie were already seated. He had a Martini. She had a Cosmo. We joined them and ordered a couple of glasses of Pinot Grigio. Pavia's was an old-school Italian place. Waiters in tuxedos, plush seating, and bland food.

"It's so great to see you both," he enthused. "We should do this more often."

He raised his glass and we toasted.

"Have you been here before?" he asked.

I had once. Olivia hadn't. That gave him an opportunity to monologue a bit about the Roman-style artichoke appetizer and the Osso Bucco main course. Since he seemed to be paying, I took his recommendations and also ordered a bottle of Barolo. I might even have the Tiramisu for dessert.

We bantered through the appetizers, but once the main course arrived, Charlie seemed to lose patience. "So, I have an announcement."

I caught Olivia's eye and gave her a supportive nod. She replied to Charlie, "Oh, I hope it's good news."

He paused for a moment to let the anticipation build. "It is. For all of us. I'm... going to start my own firm. And, Olivia, I'd like you to come with me."

My wife's face froze and then dropped. "But... I'm... up for partner."

"And you'll be a partner at my new firm."

I could see her mind racing. Being a partner in a two-person startup is quite different from being a partner in a 500 lawyer, multi-city law firm. But what choice did she have? Once Charlie left, there was no way the firm would promote his long-time protege, especially since most of their work came from clients he would surely take with him. I could tell from her expression that she'd come to the same conclusion.

Charlie continued. "We'll grow it together. You have to see the space I picked out. It's in Five Points. All kinds of fun bars and restaurants around. Your office has the most amazing views of the

mountains. It's empty now, but you can decorate it however you like. We'll bring Margery over and hire a paralegal. With the legal market as it is, we'll have our pick of young associates to add as we expand our book of business. And when I retire, it's all yours."

"I... I need to use the restroom," Olivia said, as she rose and fled the table.

"Should I check on....?" Ellie asked.

Charlie nodded and his wife followed after mine.

He looked at me. "I... I don't understand. This is good—"

"For you maybe," I snapped. "But she's almost forty and she's been working to make partner since—"

"But she'll be a partner."

"Of a two-person shop. She'll be your assistant."

"I'm sorry, Dex, I don't think you understand, this—"

"Just delay your departure until after the partnership vote. I mean, that's the least you can do."

"The least I can do? I've trained her. I've helped her get her network up and running. I protected her position through two maternity leaves. The least I can do?"

"You need to delay this until her partnership vote, and you better make sure she gets it."

He squinted at me. "Or what? I'm being the good guy here. I didn't need to take her along."

"Weren't you already married when you made a pass at her?"

He was initially shocked, but quickly regained his composure. "I don't know what you're talking about."

"I think you do."

Olivia and Ellie interrupted our standoff when they returned. We finished dinner in near silence. I did not have the Tiramisu.

Chapter Six: Send Nudes

Olivia stared sullenly out the window as we drove home.

“O?”

She shook her head. “I... I don’t know that I’m ready to talk about it.”

“It’ll be all right. You know, things have—”

“Oh for fuck’s sake, Dex, you’re not really going to tell me that things have a way of working out and that every dark cloud has a fucking silver lining?”

“I’m just trying to be help—”

“Helpful? I know. But platitudes won’t help.”

“So what would help?”

She shook her head as if to say nothing would help, but then she changed her mind. “A drink. Let’s stop for a drink. The sitter is paid until midnight.”

Though we live in a residential area, there is a small shopping center less than a half mile from our home, and tucked inside is a small Southwest restaurant, El Pecado, that stays open late as a bar. It was mildly crowded. Most of the seats at the bar were occupied, but we settled into one of the many empty booths. There was no waitress, so I went up and ordered a couple of beers and brought them back to the table.

Olivia took hers without really looking and took a swig. She shook her head slowly, as if still trying to process her disbelief about the evening’s events.

“O?”

“So, there are two explanations, and they both suck,” she said finally. “Number one, he wasn’t thinking about me at all. Even though we’ve worked together for fourteen years, he didn’t give me and my career even a second thought. Number two, he was thinking about me, and this is his way of keeping me under his thumb.”

“Or maybe, he really does think this is a great opportunity for you, and when he retires in a decade or whatever, you’ll be able to take over all of his clients.”

She sighed and gave me a crooked smile. "Do you think that's it?"

"I don't know," I replied with a shrug. "Honestly no. But maybe that's how he rationalized it to himself, and he may believe that."

"What is with you men? Why is it so hard to see a woman as a colleague rather than, I don't know, a help maid?"

"Men?"

"Yes. You know, the people with the dangly bits between their legs."

"I—"

"You don't think he'd have done this if I were a man, do you?"

"I don't know. Self-involved people will, you know, self involve."

She took another swig and stared blankly in the direction of the bar.

"Olivia. This sucks. And you're probably right that whether deliberate or not, he wouldn't have done this to a man."

She turned to face me. "Or who knows, maybe you are right, and he's just... whatever."

I chuckled. "Can't even bring yourself to finish out that thought?"

"Nope." She finished her beer. "I need another. And get a couple of Tequila shots."

"Um, okay."

"What's the matter, Dex, can't keep up with a little, ol' woman?"

I laughed. "I'm not carrying you home."

"Someone will."

"What's that mean?"

She grinned. "Maybe I need a little strange to cheer me up."

And that's the problem with dress pants. You can hide an erection in jeans, but suit pants? Not so much. At the bar, I scanned the room. It was dark, and I couldn't see into the booths on the other side of the bar, but I didn't see a lot of options for Olivia, or at least not of the type of "strange" I thought she might be looking for. No tall, dark, and vaguely dangerous strangers.

My erection eased slightly, and I managed to return with the drinks without making a spectacle of myself. Olivia smiled at the

Tequila board, with indentations to hold the shot glasses, salt, and limes. She dribbled some salt on the back of her hand and raised her glass.

“Prost!” she exclaimed, as she went salt, drink, lime before slamming the shot glass back on the table.

I matched her.

“I think that’s the first time I’ve seen you do a shot,” I said.

She laughed. “You should have known me in my wild youth.”

“I’d have liked to.”

“I’m not sure you would. But that’s the problem. It doesn’t help that I’m a woman, but it’s also that Charlie has known me since I was twenty-three. At some level, I’ll always be that first year he interviewed all those years ago. The one who did more stupid shit than I can remember. I should have moved on years ago.”

I shrugged. “You can’t redo the past. And anyway, would you do things differently, really?”

She sipped at her beer. “I don’t know. Doesn’t really matter. I mean, I made the choices I made. Charlie has always been a bit....” She paused. “I’ve never really thought about this. Maybe I should have. I mean, I have thought about it. But it’s complicated. He’s paternalistic, but also protective. He’s possessive, but it also means that unlike a lot of associates, I haven’t been slammed with competing demands and projects. He’s provided a secure situation and a reliable salary, which certainly has helped as you’ve bounced from job to job.”

“It is sort of the nature of what I do.”

“I know. I’m not being critical. But there have been some years when my salary was basically our only income.”

“Yeah, but that’s not Charlie’s doing. That’s yours. You earned your salary. There were plenty of late nights, and there still are. It isn’t charity for which you owe him.”

She waved her hand in front of her. “No, I’m not saying that. I don’t know what I’m saying. I’m annoyed and disappointed. Ugh, whatever. Get another round and let’s find something else to talk about.”

“Another round?” I gestured at both the beers and the Tequila board.

“Man up.”

I laughed. “Okay. It’s your hangover.”

Of course, it would be mine too. I went to the bar and got our drinks. Then returned to the table.

“So what are we going to talk about?” she asked.

“I was getting the drinks. I figured you’d be working on that part. Kids?”

She stuck out her tongue. “Meh. Not sure that is appropriate for a drunken night out.”

We gulped the Tequilas. My head spun a little. She smiled at me goofily, definitely buzzed.

“I think there was more alcohol in these ones,” she said. “So, topic?”

My tongue loosened by booze, I asked the question I’d been thinking about for the last couple of weeks. “So, who is number three?”

“Huh?”

“You said you cheated with Mitch on three people. Brad, Val, and...?”

“Has this been keeping you up at night?”

“No, but it’s like hanging out there.”

“Are you hoping I lied and that you’re really number three?”

“No, of course not. I just—”

“Would it be worse if I’d done it before or after our wedding?”

“Huh? I... I guess after. Why?”

“So it really wouldn’t be so bad if I’d done it before, even if it was right before?”

I stared at her open-mouthed.

“Like, the night before?” She said cringing.

“Olivia, did you real—”

“Walk down the aisle with my pussy still throbbing from his big, fat cock? His come dripping down my leg?” She burst out laughing.

“Oh, God, if you could see your face. I think you really do want me to cheat on you.”

"I don't. It's just... I can't explain. The fantasy is hot."

"How do you know the reality wouldn't be? Let's say I walked over to," she scanned the bar and settled her gaze on a burly, middle-aged guy, with a shaved head, and a goatee, "him and started a conversation."

"You find him attractive?"

"Meh. He's fine. And alone. And it looks like he fucks hard. I'm not looking for romance. I'm just looking for a guy to take me out back, press me up against a wall, and give me what I... we... need."

My heart raced, but I realized she was just playing with me. "You don't have the guts."

"You think he has a big dick?" she asked.

"I... I don't know."

"Well, of course not. But what's your guess?"

"He's probably all right."

"I hope he's thick. That's what I'm craving tonight. Something big and fat to really stretch me out."

I stared wordlessly, my mouth too dry to speak.

"I'm going to find out." She picked up her empty shot glass and licked around the outside. "And I got all the guts I need from this." She rose, half-empty beer in one hand, shot glass in the other, and walked over to the man, taking the seat beside him.

He watched her sit down, and then quickly glanced at me. He'd apparently checked her out earlier, and also noticed she was with someone. Olivia placed her hand on his shoulder and looked right at me so I could read her lips, said, "Don't worry about him. Buy me a drink?" She waved the shot glass in his direction.

He shook his head. I imagined him saying something, like, *I don't want any trouble.*

Her hand curled around his thick neck and caressed below his ear. She leaned in and whispered something to him. He jolted, and then looked at me again. He shook his head, this time with an amused grin, before returning his attention to my wife.

My face burned as I imagined what she might have said to him. *Don't worry about my husband. He likes to watch me with other men.* Or maybe something harsher. *He's a sissy. I need a real man.*

Whatever it was, he bought her that drink, and they downed a shot together.

My heart was pounding again, and my hand shook as I tried to drink my beer. This was bad, bad, bad. She was upset about dinner with Charlie, more than a little tipsy now, and seemingly intent on teaching me some sort of lesson. She was teasing this stranger, and it was hard to imagine this ending well, which she surely knew, because drunk or not, Olivia could read a room. And if that was true, then she wasn't leading him on. She'd decided that getting roughly fucked by a stranger was just what she needed.

They finished their beers and ordered another round, though thankfully no more shots. I seemed to be a major topic of conversation, since they both kept looking in my direction, with grins and smirks. She made slow circles with her fingernail on the back of his neck. His hand drifted down and rested on her knee, and instead of pushing him away, she parted her legs slightly to encourage him. They both leaned forward, talking excitedly. His hand slid up her thigh, her's began to massage his shoulder and beefy arms. I took out my phone and, as surreptitiously as possible, took a series of pictures of them directly and through the mirror behind the bar to capture their faces.

When their beers arrived, they separated for a moment to take a swig. Foreplay was apparently thirsty work. She said something, and he chuckled, and then he reached out and hooked a finger inside the V of her dress and peered down in her cleavage. She swatted him away with a giggle, but it was definitely *no harm, no foul* as they continued their conversation, and his hand remained on her thigh, gently caressing her sensitive skin. More talk, more laughter, more bedroom eyes. I'd finished my beer, and my throat was parched, but I didn't dare rise to order another drink for fear of provoking something and... because I was hard as a rock.

Olivia slipped off her barstool, and pressed up close to him. His hand seemed to be obscenely far under her dress. She wrapped her arm around his neck and their foreheads were nearly touching as they spoke.

Oh my God, I thought, here we go.

Then she backed away from him and walked in my direction... and then right past me and toward the bathroom with nothing more than a small grin on her face. I could feel his eyes on me, but I didn't look in his direction. As exciting as this all was, I couldn't bear the thought of making eye contact with the man who seemed likely to be fucking my wife before the night was out.

My phone buzzed in my pocket.

<Olivia>: Are you having fun? I am.

<Dexter>: I don't know. Where is this going?

<Olivia>: That's entirely up to you. Either way, I'm going to get fucked hard. Will it be by you or Denny? That's his name, btw, and I'm getting good vibes about what's in his pants.

<Dexter>: Seems like you've already made up your mind.

<Olivia>: LOL. If that's the idea you need to give yourself permission, then sure....

I stared at the phone, not quite sure what she meant or how to respond. She texted again.

<Olivia>: I won't be needing this.

Attached were a series of pictures taken in the bathroom. Olivia smiling for the camera. Olivia pulling her dress off her shoulders. Olivia removing her bra, and then holding it aloft, Olivia grinning for the camera as her now braless nipples poked through the fabric of her dress.

<Olivia>: Or this.

Another series of images. This time starting with her legs. Then her thighs as she raised the hem of her dress. Then her panties, first in place, then eased down to mid-thigh, then pooled around her ankles. Finally, a picture of her smiling for the camera with her bra and panties in her hand.

<Olivia>: Still there Dex?

My hands were shaking so much that it was difficult to respond. But I finally pecked out an answer.

<Dexter>: Yes. What now?

<Olivia>: I am going to send you three pictures. I want you to forward them to Denny. His number is 720-555-2129.

<Dexter>: Why?

<Olivia>: I want them to come from your phone.

I had no idea what was going on. My mind was racing and getting precisely nowhere.

The first picture came through. It was a mirror selfie. Olivia with her dress peeled down to her hips, showing off her beautiful, firm breasts and rock-hard nipples. She was sucking her thumb in a way that screamed blowjob.

I gasped. I couldn't send that to Denny.

Then the next picture came through. This time she had one foot on the ground, another on the sink. Her dress was hiked up high, and the camera was centered on her juicy, shaved pussy, cleaved open with excitement.

I was paralyzed.

The third picture was lewder still. Another mirror shot, this time over her shoulder. She was facing away from the camera, bent at the waist. Her dress was up over her ass, and with her legs spread, and one hand spreading her cheeks, her little, puckered asshole was clearly visible.

For a moment I forgot how to breathe. Sweat ran down my face.

<Dexter>: I can't send these.

<Olivia>: You have to. I told him that if he played in our little game, he could see my tits, my pussy, and my ass. So either you send them, or I bring him back here and show him in person. Your call.

It was a bluff, but a terrifying one. Or maybe it wasn't. I couldn't be sure. And in a way, I almost wanted to find out quite how far she'd go.

<Olivia>: Dex, Baby, so did you send them? Or should I invite him to join me? I probably should warn you... I'm very, very horny right now.

Even if she wasn't, I was pretty sure being locked in a bathroom with a guy she'd been teasing mercilessly for the past 45 minutes would result in more than a "look, don't touch" situation. Feeling like a complete simp, I sent the nude images of my wife to this stranger.

<Dexter>: I sent them. Now what?

<Olivia>: Now I go back and sit with Denny and he and I talk about which of my holes he wants to fuck first.

Would now be a good time to mention that I've never had anal sex with my wife, and that as far as I knew, she was an anal virgin?

<Dexter>: I thought the deal was if I sent them, you wouldn't show them to him yourself.

<Olivia>: The deal was that if you didn't send them, he'd get a personal, intimate show. We didn't discuss what would happen if you did.

Never argue with a lawyer.

I started to type a response, but then heard footsteps behind me. It was Olivia looking very flush. One thing that was obvious was that she was, indeed, very turned on by this. She wasn't doing it just to either punish me or excite me. She slowed as she passed my table and placed her bra and very damp panties in my palm. Then she continued on to Denny, who was watching the two of us with a big smile. He had his phone out in front of him, proudly displaying the pictures I'd sent.

She sat down beside him again, her arm again circling his neck, his hand returning to its place on her thigh. He'd ordered another round of shots and beer. He prompted her to drink the Tequila, and she made as-if to do it, but I noticed she surreptitiously managed to pour most of it out onto the bar's spill channel. She sipped her beer as the two of them carefully perused the images I had sent.

My drunk and horny wife was sitting with a strange man, looking at obscene pictures of her, and discussing which of her pretty little holes he'd like to penetrate first. It was mind boggling. I didn't know this slutty, dirty woman, and yet there she was, inhabiting the body of my wife and the mother of my children.

That thought also served to remind me how close we were to home. I'd never seen this guy before, but it was quite possible that he lived nearby. It was possible we'd run into him at Little League games. At the grocery store. That didn't even consider the other patrons or the bartender. I glanced around and with relief noted that I

didn't recognize anyone, but that didn't mean that a neighbor wouldn't walk in any second, or that someone had already spotted us and I'd been too distracted to notice. Ever since she'd sat down beside him, I'd had tunnel vision. Even if they didn't notice Olivia sharing pictures of her asshole with a stranger, they would certainly notice her fingers caressing his neck and his hands on her thigh, and they might also see me sitting by idly.

All of those thoughts raised my internal temperature, scrambling my brain. Hearing about Olivia's sexy past was undeniably exciting, and visualizing her with another man was even more arousing. The risk of being seen, caught, heightened things even more. The humiliation of sending obscene nudes of my wife to another man scalded. Imagining the discussion they were having as they reviewed the pics left me almost delirious. I didn't know if I could survive seeing her go off with him. I didn't know if I even wanted it, but it felt as if I'd explode if she did. The more they talked, the more the lurid images filled my mind. Olivia kneeling before him, slobbering on his big cock. Perched on a bathroom sink getting railed hard.

<Olivia>: He says he'd like my ass first. Big surprise, right?

I looked up and she was smiling at me. They both were. My face burned. She typed into her phone.

<Olivia>: Are you okay, Sweetie? You seem a little wound up. So should I let Denny sodomize me? Or will you be taking me home?

I had to read the text three times to understand it. My eyesight was blurry, and my brain seemed on the verge of grinding to a complete halt.

I remember the next few minutes episodically as if through a strobe light effect. I don't remember rising, but I do recall throwing a stack of twenties on the table in the hope of covering our tab. I don't remember walking over to them, but I do remember the queasy feeling as I shook Denny's hand. I don't think I replied to his offer of a drink. Regardless, I have an image of leading Olivia outside.

The fresh air jolted me back to the present. I squeezed her hand tight and started to walk in the direction of our home, but she

yanked me instead into a darkened alley leading to the loading zone behind the shops. She stopped just a few paces in, just enough to be out of sight to a casual passerby, but close enough to the bar's entrance that we'd be easily seen by anyone curious enough to take a closer look. She pressed her forearm against the wall and leaned forward. With her other hand, she lifted up her dress, exposing her bare ass.

"Are you going to do this, or should I go back inside and get Denny?"

I didn't know if she was offering me her ass or her pussy. I fumbled with my zipper. I somehow managed to free my cock and slide behind her. She reached back and guided my raging erection into her steaming cunt. She was so wet that it almost felt as if she'd already been fucked, and with my mind so foggy, I suddenly wasn't sure she hadn't. Had Denny followed her into the bathroom and I'd just missed it? No, that was surely impossible, but I'd never felt her like this, so wet, almost sloppy.

I fucked her hard. She moaned louder and louder, as if determined to draw attention to us.

"Shhhh," I said.

"Fuck me. Fuck me. Fuck meeee!" she replied, her volume and pitch increasing.

I had to shut her up. I covered her mouth with my hand. She growled excitedly into my palm and began twerking on my dick. This was how Mitch had fucked her that first time. Mitch with his big hands and big dick. Was that what she was thinking about? Or was she imaging being taken like this by Denny?

She came hard, her pussy spasming in time with her hips thrusting back against me. I came as well, filling her with what seemed like a gallon of jism. We were both gasping and leaning against the wall for support.

"Oh God," I groaned.

"Now that is how you turn an evening around," she replied with a chuckle.

The bar door opened and we heard some voices.

"We need to get out of here," I said.

I took her hand and we continued toward the parking lot in back, and then went through the gate that led back into our neighborhood. Walking hand in hand, we seemed like a normal suburban couple again. But we were not, and my mind raced.

“Would you really have gone with him?” I asked.

“I’d have gone with pretty much anyone by the end there. You would have liked to see me with him.”

“No.”

She laughed. “I wasn’t asking.”

I didn’t respond. Maybe she was right. “Would you have had anal sex?”

“It wouldn’t be the first time.”

I turned to look at her and she was already looking at me with a grin. She shrugged. *Oops, did I never mention that before?*

“Mitch?”

She shook her head. “No. Someone else.”

“Who?”

She chuckled ruefully. “We’re almost home.”
And indeed, we were.

Chapter Seven: The Next Level

“She’s late,” Trip said once we were away from the girls. We’d been sent out to check on the grill.

“Oh, um, congrats?”

“Beer me.”

I nodded to the cooler. “Get me one too.”

I poked around at the coals for a bit. They were getting there. Trip returned with two open bottles of Narragansetts. We clicked the necks.

“You seem glum,” I said.

“I was just hoping it would take a little longer to happen. But Tracey’s nothing if not fecund. Apparently, we got it right two weeks ago.”

That wasn’t much of a surprise. They already had four. And Tracey seemed predestined for it. Sexy, curvy, little thing, all tits and ass, a body that seemed to scream its child-bearing potential. Put her in a bikini and every man within 100 yards developed whiplash from twisting to look at her. Even her current look of mom shorts, t-shirt, and dark hair in a practical pixie cut, she still exuded a powerful sex appeal.

“Five fucking kids,” he sighed. “There are guys our age, man, they’ve sold a start-up, they’re sitting on a yacht with twenty-four-year-old sluts who are perfectly happy to drain their balls all day long as long as the party doesn’t stop.”

“And fuck the muscular deckhands when you’re not looking.”

He shrugged. “Whatever. As long as I get mine.”

“Some women get extra horny when they’re pregnant,” I noted.

“Did Olivia?”

“Nope.”

“Yeah, Tracey neither. I think that’s a myth. Created by women to make men think getting them knocked up is a good idea.” He drained his beer. “Want another?”

“I just started this one.”

“Pussy.”

He fetched himself another beer and we went back inside. Olivia was drinking a glass of white wine, Tracey a sparkling water. Trip caught my gaze and rolled his eyes. Poor guy.

"So, you hired Trevor Markson," Olivia said to Trip.

He shrugged. "Can always use an extra set of eyes, and he came cheap."

It was Tracey's turn to roll her eyes. "Bobby just likes to live vicariously through him. What was the latest? He picked up some married woman on a trip to Vegas?"

"Yup," Trip chuckled, "while hubby was losing money at the tables, she was making some fun of her own."

Olivia laughed. "It was a set-up, I bet. Some guys in the lifestyle like their wives to step out on them." She shot me a quick, wicked grin. I looked at my feet.

"I doubt Trevor needed a set-up to make it happen," Tracey replied. "All tall, dark, and handsome like that. Rawr."

"He's a slut," I said.

"So much the better," she replied. "At least he knows what he's doing."

Trip rolled his eyes.

"Oh, Honey," his wife said. "You know what you're doing too. It's just, you know, if he lets drop any tips...."

Olivia chuckled. That seemed to catch Tracey's attention.

"O, you think he's dreamy too, right?" Tracey asked.

Olivia demurred, waving her hand airily.

"Oh come on," Tracey teased. "Not with Dex around, of course. But let's say you were suddenly a widow."

"Whoa, that's dark," I said.

Tracey continued, "Like, Dex gets hit by a bus. And suddenly you're a single mom, with a lot of stress. You're sad. But you have needs. No way Trevor gets a shot?"

"I would never hook up with Trevor if Dex were dead," she said, giving me a quick wink. *But if he were alive and watching...?*

"Can we stop imagining my death? It's creepy," I said.

"Sorry, sorry," Tracey replied. "It's just that Trip won't stop talking about his new buddy and his crazy stories. Like I say, old

married man, living vicariously through his slutty, single buddy.”

“I’m not old,” Trip replied.

“The old modifies married in this case, not man,” Olivia replied. “As in, stuck in a rut, rather than decrepit.”

“Gee, thanks, Miss Sunshine.” He shook his empty beer. “Anyone need another?”

I gulped mine and waved it at him. He disappeared into the backyard.

“I think he’s dealing well with maybe being a father again,” Tracey said. “Don’t you?”

“Oh, yeah, great,” Olivia said, laughing.

I grilled some steaks and pepper strips. We ate outside. It was a lovely afternoon and evening. Afterward, the girls went back into the house, to chat and chase our kids to bed. Trip and I remained on the patio working our way through the beers.

“The one good thing is that I have a designated driver for the next year,” he said.

“You really don’t want another kid?”

He shrugged. “Want? Naw. But it’s fine. You love them all the same. Some sort of chemical reaction, right. Just not super excited about it, you know? But when the little fucker pops out, I’ll be immediately in love. Ready to give my fucking life for it.”

I nodded. We sat in silence for a while.

“I didn’t realize you were so chummy with Markson,” I said.

“I’ve always liked the guy. He’s a dick, but he’s entertaining. Trace is right. I do sort of like to live vicariously through him. Taste of a life I’ll never get to live. Though you’re getting to be in the same boat. Any more fun with talking about the old boyfriend?”

“Mitch? No. He hasn’t come up recently....” I sort of trailed off.

Trip picked on it. “But....”

I looked around to make sure we were alone. “Okay, but, you can’t tell anyone, not even Tracey.”

He crossed himself. “Scout’s Honor.”

"That's the sign of the cross, and you were never a scout."

He chuckled. "So sue me. Spill it."

I hesitated. "So, we went to this bar..."

"Yeah, yeah," he interjected.

"Jesus, Trip, calm down." He leaned back and took a sip of beer. "So, we're at this bar, and we're just talking, and she sees this guy at the bar, and she's, like, should I go over and talk to him?"

"Yeah? Did she?"

"So, she goes over. And they start talking. And doing shots."

"Oh shit, man. Where were you?"

"Right there. He knew I was there. So he knew it was a game, but what kind of game, right? Because some people play that game to completion, you know?"

"Was he making the moves on her, or what?"

"Yeah, and Olivia was totally egging him on. She was massaging his shoulder, and he had his hand on her knee. And she told me later they'd been talking about sex most of the time."

"Man, I don't know if I could handle that with Tracey."

"Yeah, it's hard to explain. Like, you want it to stop. Every time she laughs or her fingertips tickle his neck, it's like you're about to have an aneurysm. But it's hot."

"Was he good looking?" Trip asked.

"I mean, middle-aged guy, you know." I took out my phone and showed him a couple of pictures I took of Olivia and Denny.

"Meh. I'm better looking than him. Think you could handle it if it was a really hot guy, someone you knew she really wanted to bang?"

"I don't know that'd have made much difference. Women get turned on differently. And it wasn't just a game. I mean, she was raring."

"After you got her home?"

"We... um... didn't quite make it home."

"Oooh, you dirty dog. In the car?"

"Alley behind the bar."

He hooted. "Oh fuck, dude, that's hot. Shit, you are living the life, aren't you? You might be more entertaining than Markson."

I shrugged modestly.

“Oh, speaking of that prick,” he continued. “Have you heard anything about Phase II on the project?”

I shook my head. “Nothing serious. Just the usual, if this works and can scale, then....”

“Markson says there’s already some interest in going global. Not clear who, but he says there’s already some pre-commits on this.”

“There’s pre-commits on everything. Even Pets.com had global partners lined up once they locked down the U.S. market. Then they went belly-up.”

“This is different. Real money already locked up.”

“How does Markson know this?” I asked.

He shrugged. “Who knows? He’ll tell you every last detail about his sexual conquests, but his business sources are top secret. That said, he’s the ultimate schmoozer. Knows everyone. What’s he call himself, an economic intelligence agent?”

I snorted. “He’s a dipshit, not a spy. Well, whatever. Doesn’t change what we do.”

“Right, right, but it does mean what we do might get even bigger than we’d hoped.”

“If we get the contract.”

He nodded. “Yup.”

We sat in silence for another few minutes. The girls were giggling inside, and I wondered whether Olivia was telling Tracey about our bar adventure as well. Their laughter seemed to raise the same question for Trip.

“You think she’d go through with it?” he asked.

“Huh?”

“Olivia. Like, if you were into it, think she’d have gone out back with him instead of you?”

My heart was in my throat. Olivia had told me outright that she would have. Though I wasn’t sure she would have, I could picture it. I had been picturing it. Olivia up against the brick wall, her ass exposed, and instead of me there, Denny with a thick hardon pressing into her non-virgin asshole.

I forced a laugh. “Naw. Don’t be silly. It’s just a game.”

He grinned, raised an eyebrow, and drained his beer. "All right time for one more before we go."

Olivia and I stood arm in arm on the stoop watching Trip weave his way to their car. Tracey paused for a moment and rolled her eyes at Olivia. *Men, am I right?* They drove off.

"You think they're doing okay?" my wife asked.

"As well as anyone," I replied with a shrug, though my assessment was actually darker. I hadn't seen Trip this morose in a long time.

We went back inside and worked together to clean up the dishes and glasses.

"You guys went through a case?"

"It was already started, and anyway, Trip drank most of those."

"Throwing your buddy under the bus isn't a good look."

I grabbed a kitchen towel and began wiping down the counter.

"Oh please, I gave up covering for Trip back in sophomore year."

"He's not happy about the baby, is he?"

"No, he's fine. Not his preference, but he's reconciled. I think. You know, we're guys. We never quite tell each other the truth. Anyway, it's not a baby. It's... a late period."

"Tracey's clockwork, Babe. And she's too young for *The Change*. So it's number five for them."

"Do you want more?"

"Fuck no," she said with a laugh. "Aren't we on to a new stage in our lives?"

"What stage is that?"

"Well that is still to be determined, isn't it? Honestly, I'd been assuming it was a quiet transition to middle age, getting kids ready for college, maybe buy a vacation home, travel... but now I'm not so sure. You seem to want more."

"Me? I'm the easy-going one in the relationship."

She laughed. "Yeah, that's what everyone thinks. I play along. But we both know that's not true."

Trip had had more beers than me, but I was still more than a little buzzed. "I'm not sure I follow."

"Oh Dex, sure you do. We've always lived life according to your desires, haven't we?"

"Have we?"

"Baby, I'm not looking for a fight," she said. "I just don't want us to get in a thing where I'm the bad guy, forcing shit on you. I mean, this whole thing with Trip pretending he's just having another kid because Tracey wants it is... bullshit."

"He—"

"Is full of shit," she interrupted. She took a sip of wine, and I noticed the bottle was empty. Since Tracey wasn't drinking it meant Olivia was more than half in the bag.

"I... I honestly don't know."

"Exactly."

"I'm sorry, Honey, I'm a little drunk. What are we talking about?"

"We're talking about men making women into the bad guy. Like we're dark conjurers who cast spells with our pussies, when in reality, most of us would be happy with a much more prosaic life."

"Hmmm. Oh, I see. So this is all me. You didn't want to fuck Mitch."

"Oh, Sweetie, I would *love* to fuck Mitch again. But I'd never do it, or even think about it, unless you encouraged me. Fucking Mitch would be amazing. It *always* was. But right now, I'd do it mostly because it turned you on. And yeah, I'd enjoy the motherfucking shit out of it. Pleasing your man does not mean you can't like it too."

"If it's so fucking amazing, why aren't you with him?"

She laughed. "Oh please. Because while we are often in thrall to our pussies, it isn't close to the kind of control your cocks have."

"Do you know how sexist that is?" I asked.

"Whatevs. You know it's true."

"I don't know any such thing."

"We need to have a conversation about boundaries," she said, taking a seat at the kitchen table.

“Now?”

She gestured to the chair next to her. “Yup. Our tongues are just loose enough that we’ll actually be honest.”

“I wouldn’t lie.”

“Neither would I, but we might pull our punches normally. So, according to people in the lifestyle—”

“Wait, you did research?”

“Sure,” she said with a shrug. “Why not? You know, this is actually a really common thing. It’s mostly men, but some women are into it too, and the tamest version is just asking about your partner’s sexual past. Then there’s reliving or retelling past sexual adventures. Then there is fantasizing about other people in the present. Actually watching your spouse flirt with other people.” She paused. “See, we’re already quite a ways down this path. But there are a lot more steps.”

My mouth was dry, and I found myself at a loss for words.

“Then, of course, we get the really fraught options. Some men get turned on by their wives actually fooling around with someone else. And there are all sorts of boundaries there to negotiate. Is it just making out? Fondling? Over clothes or under? Above the waist or below? Some men just want their wives to service another man. I hope that’s not your thing. I probably wouldn’t want to just blow a guy even if it turned you on. For some guys, it is everything but fucking. For others, fucking is okay, just no kissing. Some men apparently get off on their wife doing things for her lover that she won’t or doesn’t do for her husband. Are you still with me?”

I nodded. “Yes. But doesn’t this all depend on what the woman is willing to do?”

“Sure. I have boundaries, too. But I want to understand yours first. And also, I can tell from the way you keep adjusting yourself that you like hearing me talk like this. So, um, where was I? Oh right, sex acts.... Does she, or maybe I should say, do I suck cock? Swallow? P in V? Anal? Where is he allowed to come? Inside me? Or my face? Tits? So many options. You need to think about that. You don’t want me coming home having swallowed three loads of

my lover's come when what you really wanted was to see my gooey pussy."

"Oh God, Olivia," I sighed.

She plowed ahead, "What about public sex? Or bondage? Or group sex? Would you want me to have a threesome with another couple? Or maybe with two men fucking me at the same time? Three? Four? Some men want to see their wife get gangbanged. Actually, that's also a question. Would you want to watch? Or just hear about it? Or, and this is a weirdly kinky one, would you want to know I was fucking another man while I withheld all the details. You'd just see me getting all dressed up for my date, and then several hours later, I'd come home well-fucked, and you'd get no details other than what you might be able to glean by examining my body."

I didn't want any of it. None of it. But then why was my heart racing and my cock throbbing.

"And then, there is the big issue," she said.

My head was reeling. "Big issue?"

"Well, yeah, who the other man is. Is it a random stranger we meet in a bar? Is it a one-off, or would you want me to have a regular lover? Would you rather it be someone we know? A neighbor or even a friend, someone you see often, and every time you see him you'd get that surge of excitement knowing he'd seen me naked, that I'd sucked his cock, that I'd spread my legs wide and let him pound me. Should it be someone I'm really attracted to? Some men really get off on the danger of losing their wife. Or does he just need to have a big cock? That seems like the one constant. Men like to fantasize about their wife getting really stretched out by a fat dick. Then there are some men who get off on the humiliation of their woman being taken by a rival or even a hated enemy. The bully. The overbearing boss who makes the man work overtime while he's in the man's bed, fucking his wife with his big dick."

"Jesus, Olivia, you've given this a lot of thought."

She bit her lip. "I don't think you quite realize how much your excitement turns me on, Dex. When I was flirting with Denny, and he was looking at my nudes, and massaging my thigh, all I could think about was what you'd do to me later. Seeing you get that worked up

is addictive, and I need boundaries otherwise I'll just keep upping the ante until you're ready to burst."

She rose suddenly and climbed into my lap and ground against my erection. I could feel her heat and wetness through the layers of clothes. She kissed my sweaty forehead.

"God, Dex, you're so hard, and your skin is burning. I've never seen you like this. I like it. I like it a lot."

Her breath was coming in hot, moist gasps, her lips parted slightly, her tongue swirling in her mouth. I palmed her breasts. Her nipples were rigid nubs. We were ostensibly talking about boundaries, but with her writhing in my lap, all I knew was I wanted more.

"I... oh God, O, this is intense."

"Mmmm. What's next? Do you really want me to... fuck... another man?"

"O... oh my God."

"Get your dick out," she growled.

"What about the kids?" I asked, though I also began to work on my pants.

"We'll hear them."

We wouldn't. Not if we were fucking and talking dirty. But booze and arousal had made us reckless. She hiked up her dress and pulled her panties aside.

"I'm not sure this is a good—"

"Oh God," I sighed as she impaled herself on my cock.

"You were saying?"

She was sloppy wet and steaming hot. She rolled her hips deliciously, conveying a barely contained passion. She nibbled on my neck and moaned in my ear.

"Who am I fucking, Dear?"

"I... I don't know."

"Mmmm, he's big... and hard..." she cooed. "Is it Mitch? No. That's too easy. Too safe. Maybe that guy from the bar. Denny. Have you been thinking about what would have happened if I took *him* out back instead of you?"

"Yes," I moaned.

“Tell me. Tell me what you imagined.”

“I... I don't know. Just that... he's big. And you're bent over and reaching back, spreading yourself for him.”

As I spoke, she arched her back and cupped her cheeks. “Like this, Baby?”

She settled onto me, and I felt a cool breeze on my balls. Anyone walking in on us would see Olivia completely exposed, balls deep on my cock, and with her little, pink asshole on display.

“Then, what?” She gasped.

“He fucks you.”

“How?”

“Hard... rough...”

She moaned. “Where, Baby, where does he fuck me?”

“In... in....”

She grabbed my hand and pressed it between her cheeks. I felt the tender skin of her anus. It seemed to pulse at my touch.

“Say it,” she hissed.

“In... in your bottom.”

“Say it. Say it really. Like you mean it.”

“He fucks you up the ass.”

“Ohhh, Baby,” she gasped. “That's sooo nasty. You want a complete stranger to ram his big, fat cock in my tight, little asshole. Your wife getting buttfucked in a dirty alley. You should have told me. I'd have done it for you.”

I shook my head. “I can't.”

She began grinding harder against me.

“You can't say it, but you want it, don't you?”

She was so hot and juicy. I'd do anything to get her like this. I circled her puckered anus with my fingertips.

“That's it, Dex, tease my asshole. Get me ready for another man's cock. That's what you want. That's what you come thinking about. A big dick in your wife's ass.”

“Uhhhh,” I came in spasms.

“Ahhhh, yeah Dex, oh God, that's good,” she moaned as she came as well.

We were drenched in sweat and breathing hard. She smiled. "You're a sexy man," she said. "I like that you have fantasies about me."

"You're amazing."

"The only thing that would make me better is if I was sitting on another man's dick."

I blushed. Between embarrassment and the sex I was probably a lovely, eggplant purple.

"I...."

She put her finger to my lips. "Shhh, Baby, you don't have to say it out loud, But I have to know. Would you really want this? If I found the right time, the right place, and the right cock, and I could make it sexy for you, would you want me to be with another man?"

It was such a hot idea, and yet, at the moment, still abstract enough that I wasn't quite sure what I was committing to. Without looking at her, I gave her a quick nod.

"Is that a yes?" She cradled my chin and forced me to look in her eyes.

Her excitement was palpable. And so was mine. Still inside her gooey cunt, my prick began to twitch back to life.

"Yes," I said softly.

She grinned. "I'm going to cuckold you, Sweetie. You won't know when or where. But anytime we're apart, I... just... might... be... sucking... cock."

"Oh God."

"You better bring me upstairs and fuck me right, unless you'd like me to go out hunting tonight."

I hesitated. I was inside her already, and yet, the idea of pulling out and letting her "hunt" was enough to give me pause. She noticed, and I felt her pussy pulse on my cock.

"No. Not tonight. Tonight you're mine."

It was frenetic and dark and insanely exciting. Every time I seemed to be flagging, she threw out more lurid plans and ideas. She told me about how she used to lick Mitch like an icecream cone. She jerked me off on her tits. She described Val using a strap-on with her. The hours blurred together. My legs cramped. My cock

ached. But even though I was exhausted and raw, I was still as hard as I've been in my life when I was fucking her from behind, staring at her tight asshole winking at me, and listening to her tell me that her ass was off-limits to me, and only available to her lovers.

I woke up the next morning. The sun was high and I wasn't in our bed. I was sore all over and my throat was dry. It took me a few disorientated moments to realize I was in the guest room. It was nearly noon. Last night was a haze. Had I dreamed it all? And why was I not in the master bedroom? My thoughts spiraled out of control. Had I dreamed about fucking her while she was... fucking another man in our bed? Had I come on her chest, or had I watched it? Had I grabbed a handful of her sweaty hair and fucked her doggy style, or had she invited another man into our house?

I was naked. My dick was stuck to the sheets. Had I just been jerking off alone while I listened to Olivia and her lover fuck half the night away?

I rose shakily and yanked the top sheet off the bed to wrap around my waist. I peeked into the hallway, and seeing the coast was clear, I slipped into our bedroom. The bed was made. Had she tossed the sheets from her night of passion into the wash? I half-expected to see another man's shoes beside the dresser and his pants draped over the back of a chair. But there was none of that.

I showered and dressed quickly. I went downstairs, still feeling more than a little discombobulated. I came down into the kitchen to find Olivia making lunch for the kids.

"Morning, sleepyhead," she said.

Oscar, our oldest, eyed me skeptically. "Did Daddy get drunk last night?"

"No, Sweetie, Daddy has been working really hard recently and just needed to catch up on his sleep." She gave me a quick wink. "Anyway, I told you he'd be up to drive you two to camp pickup."

"Of course," I replied, as if I hadn't completely forgotten the kids were going off to camp for three weeks today. "Is there any more

packing?”

“Nope. All done. Well, except, could you roll up the sleeping bags again. I never get them quite right.”

“Of course. That’s a man’s job.”

Olivia rolled her eyes. Gracey, our youngest, laughed. “Daddy is silly.”

The kids ate and we finished up collecting their camp gear. Then we drove them to the bus that would take them to camp. There were all the usual hugs and tears. And while I tried to remain in the moment, I couldn’t help but consider that the maturation of Olivia’s lusty plans happened to coincide with a period when that sort of shenanigans would be easier to accomplish.

Back in the car after the buses drove off, I confronted her.

“Of course,” she said with a laugh. “Why waste three weeks when we’re empty nesters? Unless, you’re having second thoughts?”

Of course, I was having second thoughts. Only a sociopath wouldn’t.

“Were you serious last night?” I asked.

“Mmmm, yes. I know this breaks the fantasy a little, but last night was some of the best sex I’ve ever had. I’m willing to make some sacrifices for that.”

“Some of the best?”

She laughed. “See where your mind goes? I tell you I had a great time last night, and you immediately start wondering with whom I had better sex.”

“I’m just trying to get a sense of where I rank.”

“Last night was definitely top... five.”

I groaned as I began to imagine those other sexual encounters.

“Mitch?”

“Yup. That first time, definitely.”

“Val?”

She shook her head. “No. Val was fun. She taught me a lot and I have no regrets, but in the final analysis, I need dick.”

“Brad?”

She chuckled. “Naw. He was nice. Nothing more.”

“So who?”

“Though one thing about Brad... when we first got together, we each had roommates, so we couldn’t always find a place to fool around. But he had a car, so sometimes, we’d just drive around and I’d suck his cock.”

I shivered. “That’s very giving of you.”

“Pleasing a man is my favorite foreplay. I like having my pussy eaten as much as the next gal, but sucking cock is what really gets me going. Sometimes he’d come in my mouth two or three times before I’d get so horny that I’d make him pull over and fuck me in the backseat. You never come in my mouth.”

“It... feels disrespectful.”

“It is. But it’s also hot.” She slipped beneath her chest strap and leaned toward me. “I want you to come in my mouth.”

“We’re almost home.”

“Then you better be quick.” She unzipped me and pulled out my cock. “Just think about the fact that I’ll be doing this to another man soon.”

“Oh God,” I sighed as she swallowed me whole.

I finished just as we pulled into our driveway. Then we went inside and fucked away the rest of the afternoon.

Trip showed up in my office, as usual, first thing Monday morning.

“You know what?” he snarled. “Fuck you.”

“Did I... do something wrong?”

He shook his head sadly. “You’re a cocksucker, you know?”

“Actually, I don’t know. What the fuck has gotten into you?”

“I’m pushing forty. Too old to have a favorite porn star. But here I am.”

“What’s her name?”

“Mia Melano. There’s talk she’ll do her first on-screen anal soon.”

“You must be all aflutter.”

“Fuck you, Dex. Fuck you and your horny ass, getting jiggy with his in-her-sexual-prime wife.”

“Whoa, Dude, that is uncalled for.”

“What is uncalled for is that I haven’t gotten my dick wet in almost three weeks. And your wife starts dishing to my wife about how your sex life is off the charts.”

I felt a surge of anxiety. I wasn’t sure I could handle other people knowing too much about our game. I tried to play it cool. “Maybe Olivia was trying to inspire Tracey.”

“Well, it didn’t work. She’s preggo and doesn’t have any more use for my cock. Anyway, you know how Trace sometimes gets about you guys. Don’t need to rub it in.”

In a previous venture, Trip had sold out before me to pursue another opportunity. As a result, he missed out on a pretty solid payday. It wasn’t so much that Tracey resented it, but she was a little jealous sometimes that we were, at the moment, better off.

“I’m sorry, Dude. I really am.”

“Anyway, give me the secret. Honestly, I don’t even need Trace to get into some new prime. I just want that slutty, little whore I had when we were first dating.”

“So... Trip, just so we’re clear. It’s 2020. Calling a woman ‘a slutty, little whore’ is frowned upon. Even if she is your wife.”

He waved it off. “You know Tracey was more into me than I was into her.”

“Yeah, you were a fucking idiot. You didn’t like her hair or something.”

“Whatever. Where I grew up only dykes had short hair.”

“You’ve been spending too much time with Markson. You’re turning into an asshole.”

He chuckled. “Maybe. But, whatever, she won me over. By draining my dick every way imaginable.”

“A true modern love story.”

He waved his hands airily. “Whatever. It is what it is, right?”

“Trip, honestly, I don’t know what to say. Sorry my fucking marriage is working out? Is there anything else I can do for you?”

“Oooh, Dex is too important to talk shit. Fine. Remember we have a status update Wednesday, and then Friday is bidders’ call.”

“Yup. Already on my calendar.”

“And your BBQ is Saturday. Get extra beers.”

I laughed. “Will do. Remember to tell the sitter to stay late.”

As he left my office, I couldn’t help but wonder what, exactly, Olivia had told Tracey, and what Tracey might have conveyed to Trip. For the sake of my sanity, I convinced myself she’d been discreet about our plans. It was one thing to admit getting turned on by Olivia flirting with another man, quite another to acknowledge we were thinking of moving to the next step.

It was a surreal week. Not in the metaphorical, but rather in the literal sense. I found I was having difficulty distinguishing between reality and fantasy. Olivia had a particular ability to get under my skin.

She prepared me by suggesting that anytime we were apart she might be with another man. Not that every time we were apart she was cheating on me, but that she could be any time. And maybe her texts were innocuous, but I couldn’t read them that way.

Monday:

<Olivia>: Hey Baby, let’s pass on the steaks tonight. I had enough meat inside me at lunch.

Tuesday:

<Olivia>: Oh, feel so relaxed. Max gave me a great stretch at the gym today.

Wednesday:

<Olivia>: BIG project today. Need to work LATE.

Thursday:

<Olivia>: Fuck, Charlie is still talking about a new firm before I make partner. Think there is ANYTHING I could do to convince him otherwise?

Friday:

<Olivia>: Day drinking is okay if the firm provides the booze, right? Meet me at Happy Hour tonight. But don't be late... or I might be gone.

The call for companies bidding on the contract ended at 4:00pm. Trip and Markson were all for calling it a day and enjoying the long weekend. I insisted on a meeting. I could have been there at 5:00pm when Olivia's Happy Hour started. Instead, I showed up at 7:00pm when it was ending.

When I walked into the bar, it was obviously transitioning from the work crowd into the evening local set. Four seats in at the bar was Tammy, Olivia's work friend, the one who got tossed off the partnership track while Olivia had been spared. She acknowledged my arrival with a relieved nod and immediately hoisted her purse on her shoulder and departed.

It took me only a moment to see why. In that transition between happy hour and the later crowd, the dance floor was empty, except for Olivia and.... I had no idea who he was. He was young; I'd have carded him if I'd been working the door. He was slender, with muscular arms, and long pale hair. He was me, twenty years ago, except more buff, more confident, and with a thicker beard.

They were slow dancing, even though the DJ was playing a party beat. Her arms were wrapped around his neck. His were draped low over her waist, his hands cupping her ass. Olivia had eschewed the casual Friday option and was wearing a tight, grey pencil skirt and white blouse. Her skirt was short. Short enough that as her dance partner squeezed her ass, her skirt rode up, high enough to expose a flash of stocking tops and garter. I noticed her heels. Four inches and open toes, painted red. Fuck Me Pumps.

I scanned the room, and was relieved that I didn't recognize anyone. Somehow the idea of people knowing was worse than the possibility that my wife would fuck another man. Because, yes, it was obvious Olivia would fuck this young stud if I didn't intervene. That

wasn't just me. Olivia and I made eye contact, she gave me a quick wink and then began to nibble on her new friend's ear.

I sat at the bar and ordered a beer from Todd, assuming that was his name and he hadn't just swiped someone else's nametag. He was gossiping with Brent, who was wiping down glasses. And naturally the topic of conversation was Olivia and Zach, yes, that's what the barkeeps called him. They were the only two on the dance floor. I was staring at the TV, but really just to the side so I could watch Olivia through the mirror. Todd and Brent were a few paces aside, talking softly, though not so quietly that I couldn't hear.

"Man, the cougars don't usually come out until later at night," Todd said.

"Cougars need the help of beer goggles to capture their prey, but this one would do well even in sunlight. She's more MILF than cougar," Brent replied.

"Married MILF, too," Todd said.

"She's just slumming. Getting juiced up. Probably meeting hubby right after and just getting her heart pumping a little."

It was a reminder that what Olivia and I had been doing was hardly unique. Though obviously bartenders see a lot of bizarre behavior.

"I dunno. She's dressed all hotsy-totsy. And she's old enough to know that if you start nibbling on a guy's ear and let him grab your ass, he's going to expect something."

"All Zach's gonna get is blue balls," Brent joked.

"I'll bet he at least gets his dick sucked."

"Bet. Fifty bucks."

They shook hands. That was a scenario Olivia hadn't teased, but it was shockingly exciting to hear strange men talking about my wife like that. Betting on whether she'd suck a stranger's dick.

Todd's chuckle clued me into the fact that Zach and Olivia were making their way over to the bar. They took the two open seats immediately to the right of me, with Zach in the closer seat and Olivia able to look at both me and Zach as she spoke.

"What can I get you? Todd asked, slapping the bar jauntily.

“IPA for me,” Zach replied. His voice was deeper than I expected. “Olivia?”

There was another boundary we didn’t discuss. Real names or fake. I’d have probably said the latter, but the cat was out of the bag in this case, and also I hadn’t realized quite how exciting and intimate it would be to hear Olivia’s potential lover using her real name.

“Water for me,” she said.

“Aww, night is still young,” Zach replied.

“All the more reason to hydrate properly. Last guy I was with got leg cramps right in the middle.” She smirked at me through the mirror.

Todd laughed and got their beverages.

“Was that last guy your husband?” Zach asked, fingering her wedding band.

“You caught me,” she laughed. “Does it bother you that I’m married?”

“Bother? No. I just don’t want to end up looking down a gun barrel.”

“Don’t worry, you won’t be. My husband isn’t like that.”

“Oh, is he more the *understanding* type or the *clueless* type?”

She laughed. “What he doesn’t know won’t hurt him.”

“Just the equivalent of a little white lie,” he replied.

“Well, you are white, but hopefully not too little,” Olivia joked. He nearly choked on his beer. She patted him on the back, laughing as he coughed. “Take it easy, Baby, you’re no use to me dead.”

Once he’d recovered, he said, “Maybe we should go somewhere more private, where I could be of *big* use to you.”

“Mmmm, that is tempting. But I’d hate to make such a *big* decision without consulting anyone. Boys? Got a sec?” she called out to Todd and Brent. They shuffled over. “So, my new friend here wants to take me somewhere more private. What do you think?”

They shared a grin. “Well, that’s a tough question. Lot of—”

“You can’t ask them,” I interrupted. “They have a bet riding on this.”

Zach wheeled on me. “Really none of your business, Dude.”

Olivia quieted him with a hand on his shoulder. "Have you been eavesdropping?" she asked.

"Hard to avoid. You're sitting right next to me."

"Fair enough," she said, and then she turned back toward the bartenders. "Which one of you bet what?"

Brent grinned. "I bet that you're just a tease. Todd thinks you're going to suck Zach's cock."

Zach threw his hands up in the air. "I barely know these guys," he said.

She ignored him and focused instead on Todd. "Why do you think that?"

He shrugged. "Over the years, you pick up things. Like, look at the way you're dressed. All your friends were in casual Friday clothes, and look at you, all dressed to impress. Those heels. Those thigh-highs you keep showing off. You got dressed like that this morning, so you've been thinking about it all day, about meeting a man after work. So I bet you're pretty invested in this. Not sure if you're doing this as part of a game with your husband, or whether you're looking for some fun on the side, but either path leads to Zach's pants."

Olivia laughed. "You're like the Sherlock Holmes of cheating wives."

"So, am I right?" asked Todd as Zach looked on hopefully.

She smiled and opened her mouth as if to answer, but then suddenly turned toward me. "Hey, eavesdropping married dude, what do you think I should do?"

Zach looked toward me, his face a mask of pleading, asking me to be a bro and to hook him up.

"None of my business."

"That didn't stop you from getting involved about the bet," my wife replied.

"I just didn't want you to think you were getting an unbiased perspective."

"Aw, you're so sweet. But you're in the mix whether you like it or not."

Zach, Brent, and Todd glanced back and forth as if at a tennis match.

She continued, "So, do I suck his cock or not?"

"Is that all that's on the table?" I asked.

"Well, once dicks get into mouths, calculation does sort of get thrown out the window. Sucking cock does get me very horny."

"So if I come down on the side of going with him, you might end up having sex?"

She nodded. "Sometimes sucking a dick is just so good that you have to sit on it. So is Zach getting lucky tonight?"

Our three onlookers were obviously getting turned on. I noticed a couple of drinks getting low at the end of the bar, but neither of the bartenders seemed much interested in rectifying that. I hoped the prurient interest was worth the reduced tips they'd be likely to see. Zach, for his part, was absentmindedly stroking his erection through his pants and beginning to rock back and forth like a caricature of a mental patient.

"I feel like we need to take the husband's equities into consideration. So which is he, clueless or cuckold?"

"She's her own woman," Zach interjected. "She doesn't need his permission." He beamed at my wife.

"Oh, Sweetie, any feminist cred you might have gotten out of that statement is lost because it is just in service of shooting your load down my throat."

He opened his mouth to answer, but I cut him off before he could fuck up his case even more. Truth be told, Zach didn't seem real bright.

"So you swallow?" I asked.

She nodded.

"Even with your husband?"

Olivia laughed. I wasn't sure how this would end up, but I was tickled by how much fun she seemed to be having. "Sometimes. Not often, honestly. That's more a trick for a new lover."

Todd and Brent chuckled. Brent added, "Yeah, Jessie stopped doing that once I put a ring on it."

“Stopped doing it for *you*,” Olivia chimed. Then back to me. “Come on Mister. Give us your judgment. Poor Zach needs to know if he’s going to get any or if he should go whack it in the men’s room.”

“You never answered my question. Clueless or cuckold?”

“He knows I’m looking.”

“What does he get out of this?” I asked.

“You’d have to ask him,” she replied. “But part of it is probably how excited it gets me. When we talk about it, I get so wet that my thighs get slick, and I just can’t get enough of him.”

Todd and Brent were also having trouble hiding their erections. Zach was turning a slightly alarming shade of scarlet. But all three were rapt.

“So you’ve done this before?”

She shook her head. “Just fantasized about it.”

“And you think hubby can handle the real thing?”

“He can handle anything, I think. He knows it’s just a game. And whatever I do to Zach’s cock, I’m still going home to him... hot, wet, and ready for action.”

We locked eyes and I wondered if any of our audience were fooled by this ridiculous pantomime. But then again, they were dealing with reduced blood flow to the brain, and they evidenced zero skepticism.

“Well,” I said, placing my palms on the bar as if bracing myself for the weighty decision I was about to issue. “I think Zach here should take this pretty lady back home to her husband. And if, while on the scenic route, she decides to pass the time by slobbering his knob, then it is winners all around.... Except for you Brent. You’re going to be out fifty.”

Brent grimaced and Todd laughed. Zach seemed a little confused, but I was sure Olivia would explain it to him.

I rose. “Well, all this talk has me wanting to go home and give the wife the business.”

Olivia grinned. “Sounds like a great plan. Give it to her hard. Who knows where she’s been.” Then back to Todd. “Slobbering a knob is thirsty work. Let’s do another round and then we’ll go.”

I clapped Zach on the shoulder. "Have fun, Buddy. Treat her right."

I left the bar, resisting the urge to look back, and also trying to ignore the tent in my pants.

Chapter Eight: Back at Home

I rushed home to be sure to be there when she arrived. I needn't have hurried. It was still daylight out when I got home, and I sat in the kitchen watching the sun set over the Rockies. More time passed, and I started thinking. Another drink, fine, ten minutes. Scenic route home, okay add twenty minutes to the usual trip to Cherry Creek. She should have been home soon after dark. I glanced at my watch. 9:20pm. Almost two hours since I'd left the bar. I thought she'd be twenty minutes behind me.

I wasn't really worried about her. As dopey as Zach might be, he surely knew that between me and the bartenders as witnesses, any harm that came to Olivia would be placed quickly on his head. And anyway, I had the sense that she could more than handle him if he, somehow, got out of line.

So, in my mind, it wasn't concern that filled my mind as much as.... I wasn't sure what emotion I was feeling.

She was sucking his dick. That I knew. Her road head story about Brad left me little doubt about that.

And that was weirdly and painfully hot. I'd asked what her husband got out of it in part in the hopes of understanding it myself. I didn't. Not really. All I knew was that the idea of my hot wife driving around and blowing a complete stranger was wildly exciting. It was dirty and wrong and out of character, but as I visualized her bobbing up and down on Zach's big cock—and I couldn't help but imagine it as a thick, veiny, angry monster; she was right about that, whatever else I might fantasize about, it was her being driven mad by a massive prick that set me off—I felt a surge of excitement that manifested in hot flashes, heart palpitation, and a hardon that throbbed painfully. I thought about relieving myself, but I couldn't bear risking getting it all out of myself. After she'd sucked and fucked a huge, new cock, I couldn't let her come home to a drippy, flaccid member. That's, I guess, part of the appeal for the woman. Aside from whatever quality dicking she gets, it encourages her man to step up his game.

Time passed. Olivia was in another man's car. She'd sucked him off at least a couple of times. Unless she'd really dragged it out, they'd left the bar at least two hours earlier. Zach was young. Early twenties. I remembered a Saturday, before I met Olivia, but after college. I was single and horny. I started day drinking around noon, and watching porn soon after. I jerked off seven times before passing out around 2:00am. So, he was surely capable of giving her material to work with for many hours, but would she be willing to suck cock and drink come again and again until he could no longer get it up?

I was beginning to understand the peculiar and transgressive nature of our game. I'd given her permission to give another man oral, and I'd even tacitly acknowledged that it might lead to more. His cock might be so irresistible that she had to "sit on it." But as time passed, I had to consider that she'd done more than just succumb to a sudden overwhelming desire, and had instead chosen to explore her yearnings more fully.

Olivia, worked up beyond words, suddenly ordering Zach to pull over, pulling her sopping-wet panties aside and sinking down on his monster prick was a wild, dark, tantalizing image. Her going to his place, stripping naked, lying on his bed, spreading her legs, and inviting him to take her was, somehow, scary and challenging, still oddly hot, but also disturbing. It was the difference between *our* game and her cheating.

I tried to busy myself. Tomorrow was our annual 4th of July pool party/BBQ. I'd been so busy with work that I'd let Olivia make most of the preparations. I checked our fridges, and found a generous supply of beer, ribs, hamburgers, and sausages. Our friends would bring the side dishes.

I checked the time after my diligent inspection. I had only burned ten minutes.

I arrived at the bar around 7:00pm and got pulled into Olivia's "will she or won't she" conversation a few minutes later. I left around 7:30pm and was home by 8:00pm. I changed, settled in, and watched the sunset around 8:30pm. And then waited an hour. And then another.

She was at his place. His cock had wowed her. She couldn't resist. She agreed to go back to his place. She was in his bed, naked, and desperate to please her new man. I was forgotten, or when remembered, just the target of a joke.

My phone buzzed with an incoming text. Finally, she was letting me know what was happening. I checked the number and didn't recognize it. Opening the chat window, I saw why. It wasn't from my wife. It was from the man in the bar from last Friday.

<Denny>: Hey, Man. This is Denny. We met last week?

If I needed any reminders of who he was, I could just glance at the previous messages in the chat, including the three pictures I'd sent him of Olivia's three inputs. He didn't wait for me to reply before plowing on.

<Denny>: I can't stop thinking about your wife. Wanted to see if you guys wanted to meet up and pick up where we left off last week. I'm at El Pecado for a while. Bartender says he sees you around sometimes, so maybe you're locals. I'm up the road a bit in Aurora, so can get together whenever you want.

I blocked his number. I might unblock it later, but for now, Olivia's two-hour "car ride" was all I could think about.

I couldn't bring myself to text her. Hot wife waters were full of dangerous shoals. I was trying to navigate, in real time, the knife edge that divided sexy couple play from pathetic, loser cuckdom. I had nothing to hold against her. Not really. I'm not sure she could have solicited more consent from me unless I'd been there the whole time, literally approving every lick and kiss. I'd sent them on the scenic route, so who was I to complain they were taking their time? And sending a note asking when she might be home felt piteous. *Hey Honey, don't want to interrupt your boning, but could I get an ETA on you coming home?* I could, too easily, imagine her showing him that sort of message, and them laughing as his fat prick slid into her slutty pussy.

I heard a car pull into the driveway. If I knew Olivia, she'd take this moment as a way to ratchet things up. They'd park and just make enough noise to rouse my interest. When I looked through a window or opened the door, the light inside the car would come on

just in time for me to see her dip her head into his lap. Then I would watch as her blond head bobbed up and down hypnotically. I took a deep breath and approached the bay windows in the dining room.

But I guess I didn't know my wife. Instead, I heard the car go into reverse, and a moment later, Olivia walked through the front door. She noticed me standing by the window.

She grinned. "Have you been staring at cars for long?"

"Where've you been?"

She slowly sauntered into our darkened kitchen.

"Didn't you tell us to take the scenic route?"

"I didn't expect you to take so long."

She shrugged. "Give me a curfew next time."

"What did you do with him?"

Her smile broadened, as if I asked exactly what she'd hoped I'd ask.

"You like mysteries, right, Dex?"

"I... huh?"

"Mystery. Like Agatha Christie or like all those absurd David Baldacci stories you read."

I nodded. "I still don't—"

She silenced me by yanking her white blouse out from her skirt and beginning to unbutton it. I stared rapt as she doffed her top. She was wearing a sexy, white lace, demi-cup. It was for show rather than function. Even after two kids, Olivia doesn't need a bra. She has the perky tits of a twenty-something, which she proceeded to show off by deftly removing her bra.

"Olivia?"

She reached behind her and unzipped her tight skirt. With a sexy shimmy, it slid off her hips and pooled at her feet. She was naked save for high heels and thigh high stockings. Illuminated by the rippling light from the pool, she stood with her legs shoulder-width apart, which drew my attention to her blonde triangle and shaved pussy hidden in the shadowed cleft between her legs.

She drew her hand slowly across her body. "Go ahead, Dex. Play detective. Examine my body. Figure out what I did or didn't do with Zach."

As I approached, she reached behind her and flipped on the bank of overhead LED lights. She was suddenly illuminated as if on stage. I glanced back toward the dining room. She was pretty well hidden from the street, though anyone walking their dog slowly past our front yard would be able to make her out. But through the French Doors leading to the pool deck, I could see our neighbors' houses clearly, which meant they could see her as well.

"Olivia, I—"

"You're going to need the light for your examination." To tempt me further, she cupped her breasts and presented them to me.

Her areolas seemed swollen, her nipples dark red. Approaching closer, I could see her breasts had been roughly handled.

"He hurt you."

She laughed softly. "No, not really. We all get a little crazy in the grips of passion, don't we?"

I circled around her. She followed me with her eyes. The marks on her ass were even clearer, a complete handprint on one cheek, red streaks on her hips.

"You fucked him," I said.

"You knew that might happen, but are you sure? Have you completed your investigation?"

I hesitated. She turned to face me. "How do you know I let him do anything more than fondle me roughly?"

I traced her lips. They seemed puffy. "You sucked his cock."

"Maybe we just kissed hard. How would you know?"

"I don't—"

She grabbed me by the back of my neck and kissed me suddenly. Her tongue thrust deep into my mouth. I palmed her sensitive tits. She hissed in my mouth and continued to kiss me passionately.

"Can you taste him, Dex?"

I trembled. Anger, jealousy, lust rushing chemicals through my veins. Had I tasted a hint of musk or salt that might be him? I wasn't sure, and I couldn't admit it anyway.

"No," I said tightly.

“Funny. And I haven’t even brushed my teeth. I could be sucking dick all day long every day and you’d never know, I guess.” I flinched as she leaned in to kiss me again, and she gave me just a little peck and a grin. “If we’re going to do this, you can’t get squeamish at even a hint of another man’s come. Next time I’ll be a little less diligent about swallowing to make sure you have a taste.”

I shook my head. “No.”

“Oh, so I can swallow four loads of come, but you’re afraid of a little aftertaste?”

“Did you?”

“Yes.” She seemed to enjoy how shaky that response left me. “What else did we do?”

“I don’t kn—”

“Investigate,” she said as she pointedly ran a fingertip through her pale pubes.

I hesitated. Her smirk was galling. I knew what she wanted me to do. She wanted me to kneel before her and examine her pussy. Even standing, I could tell her labia seemed more prominent than usual, swollen. She literally wanted to rub her freshly fucked cunt in my face. The problem was, I wanted it too.

I dropped to my knees. She let out a little, excited yelp, and then arched her back and thrust her crotch at me. Up close I could see that her pussy wasn’t just a little puffy. He’d wrecked her. Her labia were bloated and stretched, dark red and very wet, and she gaped slightly.

“He fucked you.”

“Why don’t you taste to be sure.”

“No. I’m not licking another man’s come out of your cheating twat.”

“I swallowed all of his loads, so you’ve already come as close to that as you will tonight. Go ahead, give it a little taste.”

“No.”

She chuckled. “Okay, suit yourself.”

I started to rise, but she pressed down on my shoulder. “You haven’t finished your inspection.”

I glared up at her. She glanced downward over her shoulder.

“You didn’t.”

“Didn’t what, Sweetie?”

“Give him your....”

“My ass? You might want to check that.”

I spun her around and pulled her butt cheeks apart. I stared at her tight, puckered asshole. I didn’t notice anything different, but I really didn’t have much to compare it to. I’d, at most, caught fleeting glimpses in the past; the picture I sent to Denny, and which I’d reviewed as well several times, was the closest thing I had to a “before” image of her anus. But regardless, compared to her battered pussy, it was clear her ass hadn’t been used as hard or as long.

“I... I don’t think so,” I said.

She encouraged me to my feet. “So, what’s your bad girl been up to?”

“You sucked him off. And swallowed his come at least once. He fucked you hard. He may have come inside you. I don’t know. He smacked your ass, and...” I lightly touched her darkened nipples. She shivered. “...he pinched your nipple. You didn’t have anal with him.”

“Close, close, Dex. I did suck his cock and swallowed, but I’d given you that. He didn’t fuck me.” I regarded her skeptically. “But he did finger bang me hard. He got rougher as it went on. After a couple of orgasms, my mouth wasn’t enough, and he needed a little extra excitement, so he spanked and slapped and jammed three fingers inside me and called me a ‘dirty whore.’ Of course, part of that was for show.”

“Show?”

“For the driver.”

“Driver?”

“Oh, did I not mention we were in an Uber?”

It was exactly like blowing a gasket. A sudden rush of steam that fogged my vision and scrambled my brain. There is a moment when everything clicks suddenly. And there it was, clear as day. Olivia up on all fours in the backseat of the Uber, her head in Zach’s lap, slobbering on his prick. Her blouse unbuttoned and bra pushed

down to expose her breasts as he mauled her sensitive nipples. Her yelps and mewls vibrating up and down his spit-covered shaft. Her skirt up over her ass, getting spanked hard. Then adjusting herself to give the driver a view of half his fist stretching her cunt. Her pained and sultry cries. The sound of a cock plunging into her throat. The wet squish of his fingers churning inside of her. The smells of sweat, come, and her wet snatch filling the enclosed space of the car.

She palmed my crotch.

“I can feel your hardness and heat through your pants. So, do you want to drop a fifth load of the evening in my mouth, or would you rather drop the first one in my pussy?”

I don't remember answering. I may just have made a Frankenstein-style grunt. But then, there she was, on her hands and knees in our brightly lit kitchen, waving her ass, and her wet, stretched cunt in my face. I thrust into her. She was wet and loose, and it was difficult to remember that it had just been his hands and not his dick inside her. And anyway, could I really believe her on that point? Did I even want to? God, she was so wet that it had to be sloppy seconds... or was that just what I wished had happened.

I came as multiple visions surged across my consciousness. It didn't sate me. I was in a frenzy. After I climaxed, she rose, and giggling ran toward the stairs. I caught her and we fucked in the middle steps. And then again in bed. Then, she said it was her turn. As I fondled and teased her overheated body, she told me how much she missed new cock, and how she was planning to make up for ten years of monogamy by gorging now. She told me there'd be days when she was too sore from fucking her lovers to fuck me. That she couldn't wait to have a really big one again. That I'd soon have all the practice I needed to read her body. She came again and again, obviously as much from the lurid ideas she was expressing as from my massaging her clit.

I woke up. It was nearly noon. I was on the basement sofa this time. I was not quite sure how I'd gotten there.

And then I remembered. After she'd worn me out and I couldn't get it up, another man had joined us.

Since you can't finish the job, I got some help, she taunted.

He seemed familiar, but I couldn't quite place him. He was dark haired and muscular and naked. I had the sense he'd been at the house the whole time watching us.

Give us a little privacy, she said.

But they couldn't wait even for me to leave the room. He was huge and she rode him. And although I couldn't get it up before, I was jerking my hardon as I glided out of the room.

Or.... no... was that just a story she told me.... or a dream?

"Hey, sleepy head, decided to help me?" she said as I came up the basement stairs. She poured me a cup of coffee and placed it on the kitchen table.

I was groggy, disoriented. The dream had messed with my mind, and I wasn't sure what, if anything, I remembered from yesterday was real.

I shuffled across the floor and took a seat. The coffee was hot and strong, and I sipped it slowly. Olivia was wearing a bathrobe and slicing carrots and celery.

"Why was I in the basement?"

She shrugged. "Honestly, I don't know. I dozed off and I woke up just in time to see you walking out the door mumbling. I figured you'd be back soon, but then I fell back asleep. I had a long night, after all." She winked at me.

The coffee began to kick in, and things began to clarify. But there was still a surreal aspect to it all. Had she really gone driving around in the back of an Uber for two hours blowing another man? And why would that have gotten me so excited when in the cold light of day, the whole thing seemed more than a little tawdry and disgusting?

"Dex? You okay there?"

"Huh? Yeah, I...."

"You sort of zoned out. Thousand-yard stare. A little creepy, Babe."

"I'm sorry. I know. It's just. This whole situation is weird."

She picked up her own cup of coffee and sat down opposite me. Her robe was a bit loose, and I pervily peeked down between her breasts. She laughed. "Eyes up here."

I looked up and she cupped my hand in hers. "Are you okay? We're still on the same page, right?"

I nodded. "Yes...."

"But?" she said. "I could almost hear it trying to escape."

"This isn't a game anymore," I noted.

"It is still a game, but it is more complicated now that it involves other people and not just fantasies."

"No, I mean...." I paused. She was right. The other people was the issue. "Yeah, but that has two meanings. What we owe to them and, well, what we owe to each other."

She nodded. "Right. And honestly, that's a constraint. If we involve other people, we can't leave them worse off. It can't be a bad experience for them. That would be wrong. To just use people like that. But I don't think ol' Zach has much to complain about, do you?"

At the mention of his name I felt that crazy surge of adrenalin... or serotonin... or maybe dopamine, I could never keep those straight... that jumbled everything. Whereas a moment ago, the image of Olivia getting fingered and swallowing load after load of come was repulsive, it now had an undeniably erotic component.

"But," she continued, "at the same time, this has to be about what we want... and need. So, are we balancing all of that?"

"I don't know. Honestly, this was easier when it was just talk," I said.

"Would that be enough for you?"

"I don't know.... Probably not," I admitted. "Having real people in the mix is...."

"Intense. Crazy a little," she enthused. "Sex is like that. It scrambles the brain. We do things when we're high on sex that we wouldn't do otherwise. And it's hard to distinguish what we want from what we think will please others."

“Yeah, so, last night...?”

She nodded. “Did I spend two hours sucking dick and getting molested just to please you? I don’t know. You sent us out, and I knew you wanted a good story. And I did think about what that would mean. I asked myself if you’d be disappointed if I just gave him a quick hummer or even a handjob and just came home. That was my original plan. But then we were in that Uber, and the driver was watching us, and then I started playing with and sucking Zach’s cock, and that was super exciting. So, it was easy to convince myself that staying away longer, playing harder, would please you. Did it? You sure seemed pleased when I got home.”

“Yes, though, maybe an hour would have been enough?”

“I can’t promise you that. I can work within general boundaries, but there is a flow, and in the moment I really get off on pleasing a man. And I know this won’t really make sense to you, but feeling a man shiver when you take him deep, hearing his moans, and feeling the urgency in his touch as he gets close... it is hard to resist. There is something about pleasuring a man....”

I couldn’t fully understand her perspective. Straight men, in general, don’t quite get what a woman gets out of, say, blowing a guy. We like it, but don’t get its visceral appeal. But Olivia’s enthusiasm was palpable and very sexy.

“Did he make you come?” I asked.

“No. Not really. No,” she shrugged. “Some of what he did felt good, but really it was more pleasing him, and showing off for the driver, and thinking of you that got me hot. But I can’t promise I won’t come with other men if we continue this.”

She squeezed my hand and looked me in the eyes. “Are we okay? Are we still doing this?” she asked.

I remembered the dream I had. Remembered her moans as she rode that stranger’s big cock in my own bed. I remembered the way my fucked-out cock was immediately hard again. I thought about last night, about what would have happened if Olivia had really lost control, and had fucked Zach, and then the driver, and then Zach again, moaning and coming on their big dicks. The sense of tawdriness and revulsion was gone, replaced by excitement.

I nodded. "Yes," I said softly.

She smiled. "Good." Then she rose. "I want to show you something."

She pulled her robe open, and I feasted my eyes on her lovely, naked body. She was almost completely unblemished, only a small bruise on her breast hinting at her ravishment. My eyes drifted downward. She'd shaved off her triangle and was completely bare. Her pussy was a smooth mound, bisected with a thin line, that struck me as both lewd and chaste at the same time.

"Good as new, right, Dex?"

I reached out toward her hairless mound. She slapped at my hand.

"No, Sweetie. I think you should wait until someone's had a chance to get it a little messy first, don't you?" She dropped to her knees between my legs. "But that doesn't mean I can't suck you off, does it? I mean, just to get my throat warmed up in case something even bigger comes along."

She didn't wait for me to answer. Instead, she fished my already raging erection out of my boxers. She swallowed me whole, massaging my balls, and humming vibrations up and down my shaft. Her tongue swirled on my shaft. I thought of her pretty, tight, little pussy... and then I thought about it getting shredded by a huge cock, turning her inside out, leaving her gasping in passion, and then gaping as his come leaked out of her battered hole. I shuddered and came in her mouth, and she swallowed it like a pro.

She wiped her mouth clean and gave me a smirk. "Well, that was quick. Now, would you mind putting out the tables and chairs? People will be coming by before we know it. Oh, and by the way," she said, pausing before heading upstairs, "if you ever can't find me today, I might be up to no good."

Chapter Nine: The Party

Trip and Tracey came by a bit early to help with the set up. I was still a little shaky. I went back and forth between feeling like a stud with a sexed-up wife and a confident, carefree, progressive attitude toward sex and moments where it seemed like I was a weird, pathetic dupe, whose wife was screwing around with other men. That's the nature of what, I guess, is the "Divine Agony" of the whole cuckold fantasy.

Trip finally broke into my thoughts. "Okay, Bro, out with it. You're either bummed out about something or preparing to gloat. I can't tell which."

"I have no idea what you mean."

We were carrying a heavy folding table out to the lawn beyond the pool.

"You keep going between a weird, lunatic smirk and this equally weird, lunatic haunted look. If I didn't know better, I'd think you were about to go postal."

"Is that even a term anymore?"

"Yeah, probably not, that was like a 1990s thing, right?"

"Along with grunge."

"You never really outgrow high school, you know?" he said.

We set the table down and walked back toward the garage to start setting out the booze. Trip brought several bags of ice, and we filled coolers with a mix of beers and wine and set them out around the yard. Inside the house, Tracey and Olivia were talking and laughing as they prepared the various bowls of chips, dip, and veggies.

"How come they get to stay inside chilling in the kitchen, and we're out here hauling tables and coolers?" Trip asked.

I rolled my eyes. "You have to ask?"

"Yup, women have half the wealth and all of the pussy," he said.

"Jesus, you are spending too much time with Markson."

"Yeah, yeah, I mean, we do have actually more than half the wealth and basically all of the political power, but I mean, in terms of just normal, interpersonal relations, wives rule the roost, don't they? It's a paradox. Society is patriarchal, but at least among the people I know, that whole *happy wife, happy life* thing seems to define the relationship."

"Wow, that's deep."

"Yeah, it...." He finally caught my smirk. "You know what? Fuck you."

I laughed. "There we go. That's the Trip I know."

"So, if you hate Markson so much, then why did you invite him today?"

"I... um...."

He laughed. "Oh, you didn't. That was O, huh?"

"I didn't say that."

"Didn't need to. Well, well, well. Now that is interesting."

"Dude, we work with the guy thanks to you. She probably just figured it was what I'd want."

"The girls think he's hot."

"By, 'the girls,' do you mean our wives?" I asked.

He rolled his eyes and then plowed ahead: "I get it. I know this isn't politically correct, but chicks... By which I mean, intelligent and independent women in touch with their own sexuality... dig assholes. There is that fine line between confidence and assholery that doesn't quite manifest until after they've done the nasty."

"You think Olivia invited him because she thinks he's hot?" I asked.

"She doesn't?"

I winced. I'd walked right into that. And again, I wondered what, exactly, Olivia might have told Tracey who might have passed it along to Trip. Though, in fairness, I'd pass along plenty to Trip myself.

"Yes. She thinks he's hot. Like Tracey does.... Like every other broad this side of the Rockies."

"Tsk, ts, ts. Broads? That's a very Marksonian term."

"It's irony. Look it up."

Trip reached into one of the coolers, sat in a lounge chair and cracked open a beer. "I'm just messing with you," he said. "I know he gets under your skin."

I grabbed a beer as well and took a swig. "It's okay. It's just, Olivia and I are like in a weird space. A good space. But complicated."

"She hit on another guy in a bar?"

Even though Trip was a good friend, I didn't want to expose myself quite as much as answering that honestly would entail. When I told the story about Denny, I dropped the detail about sending him the naked selfies. Similarly, I couldn't imagine admitting that my wife had actually messed around with another man. So I told him a highly edited version of last night, including the fact that the bartenders and I had been called in to consult on whether she ought to go on a date with Zach, though I ultimately had us counseling her not to.

Trip chuckled. "You guys are crazy." Then more seriously, "You think she'd have actually gone out with him if you'd encouraged it. I mean, it was just a date, but still."

I wondered if he intuited that there was more to my story than I'd let on. "Probably."

"You never know how a *date* will end up. Feels like playing with fire."

"Fire is hot," I noted. "But yeah, you can get burned."

"I joke about Tracey, but I just don't think I could handle anything more than light flirtation. Even that would probably fuck me up."

"I can't explain it."

"Boys?" Olivia called from inside. "Have you started the grill?"

"Yes!" we both called back as if answering our mom. And then we stood and got the grill warmed up.

Inviting Markson was not my only surprise. In addition to the usual friends and neighbors, Olivia had also invited Mitch and his

wife Denise. I raised an eyebrow at Olivia when he arrived, and she winked at me.

The way Olivia was dressed was also a wink of sorts. It was a pool party, so everyone was in some sort of swimwear. My wife had chosen a skimpy gold bikini, with strings holding together the four small triangles that composed the top and bottom. The triangle covering her butt was particularly small and narrow, not quite a thong, but not far off, leaving most of her cheeks exposed. Her effort at modesty consisted of a transparent, patterned, golden-brown wrap. Her hair was pulled into a thick ponytail, and she was wearing high-heeled cork sandals. Around her left ankle was a thin gold chain with a little gold pendant.

And, of course, she'd explicitly told me of her plan to get a little messy. It was hard to imagine she'd do anything at our own pool party, in our house, with so many friends and neighbors around. But then again, much of where we'd gone over the past few weeks would have been hard to imagine until just recently.

Although her attire was among the skimpiest, Olivia wasn't the only woman dressed sexily. Denise would have been alluring even in a sackcloth, but happily she wasn't wearing that. She instead was sporting a black bandeau bikini, her hair in loose waves past her shoulders, and oversized, gold-framed sunglasses. Tracey was also looking good. Though not showing yet, the tittie-fairy seemed to have come early, adding to her already voluptuous frame and making her otherwise relatively modest pink booty short and crop top outfit look outright provocative.

We'd always agreed to make it a kid-free event, so it was just a bunch of adults, in swimwear, day drinking and periodically cooling off in the pool. We started mid-afternoon and ran into the evening. It's always been a good time, and sexy, but never quite like this, at least for me. Now every time I noticed my wife's ass, I wondered who else was checking her out, and what they might be thinking about doing to her. And similarly, I looked at the other couples differently, wondering what kind of shenanigans *they* might be up to in their bedrooms. It's a stereotype that swingers think every other couple is either swinging already or potentially into it, but I

understood that now. Once you start playing, it shifts your perceptions not just of yourself and your partner, but also everyone else.

Olivia ran her playlist through the speakers by the pool, and the rhythmic beat along with the booze and the sun had everyone loosening up pretty well. Trip and Tracey were dancing, her ass jiggling deliciously, a fact noticed by many of the men, not least of whom was Markson, who seemed vaguely mesmerized by it. He noticed me looking at him, and tipped his beer in my direction, giving me a nod and a leer that wordlessly conveyed he'd tap that ass if given half a chance. Not that that was much of a surprise. He was such a poonhound that a wedding ring was probably an aphrodisiac to him. I'd need to warn Trip to keep his eyes on his wife.

I was on my third beer, and despite Markson's presence, I was feeling happy. At least until I ran into Charlie, Olivia's boss. I didn't know she was planning on inviting him. Our dinner out had ended awkwardly, and it was, in part, to forget about that evening that our game had taken the leap of including other people. In some way I should have been thanking him for that given how much fun we'd had. But I couldn't think generously about a man who seemed determined to ruin my wife's career even though it seemed like it was a matter of obliviousness rather than maliciousness.

"Charlie," I said with a nod.

"Dex," he reciprocated curtly.

"So... have you given any thought to the timing of your move?"

"Dex, maybe this isn't the best time. I'll discuss this again with Olivia, okay?"

"That's not fair, man. You have this power differential with her, and she can't afford to cross you."

"We've been working together for a long time. I think actually longer than you've known her. I understand you're protective of your wife, but she doesn't need your help. She and I communicate well."

"Not that well," I replied. "You blindsided her with your plan to leave the firm."

"I told her, and you, basically as soon as I knew anything concrete. Do you consult with your subordinates about your career

plans?”

“I don’t call my colleagues subordinates, even if I am their boss or supervisor. But then again, I also have never used my position for... um... self-gratification.”

His eyes flashed. “Dex, you’re on really thin ice.”

“Me? I’d think you were the one at risk of falling through. You wouldn’t really want to air all this out.”

“That’s the second time you’ve threatened me. I wouldn’t do it a third.”

“You can’t bully me.”

“Same here, Buddy. Same here.”

I put my hands up to calm things. “All I’m asking is that you adjust the timing so as to not screw her over on the partnership vote.”

“I know what you’re asking. And I know what you’re suggesting will happen if I don’t. Which, honestly, is none of your fucking business. It was before your time, and I doubt Olivia wants to review that period of her life either. So, butt out.”

Ellie’s arrival ended our discussion. I welcomed her to our house, made a little small talk and walked away, Charlie staring daggers at me. That was fine with me. He could hate me all he wanted as long as he at least considered Olivia’s interests.

I grabbed another beer and stood in the shade to cool down both literally and figuratively. I noticed Olivia’s lesbian former paramour talking intently to Mitch’s beautiful wife, Denise. Val was in board shorts and a tank top, looking super fit and athletic. She was taller than Denise and sort of hovered over her. Denise peered at Val over the top of her glasses, nodding enthusiastically to whatever Val was saying. Val punctuated her discourse by touching Denise, first on the forearm, then on the shoulder, and having gotten her used to being touched, Val began making small circles with her fingertip on the back of Denise’s neck. Val spoke again, and Denise’s eyes went wide for a moment. She giggled and shook her head, but didn’t break eye contact with the taller woman.

I shook my head and chuckled. Val was good. Really good. I didn’t know if she’d actually get anywhere with Denise, but she was

clearly a talented seductress. She and Markson should trade tips.

One of the neighbors had taken over the grill for me, so I went over and relieved him. People were eating slowly and steadily. I threw on a few more brats and checked on the brisket in the smoker. It was coming along nicely, and would be ready in an hour or so, for those who kept their appetite.

A few minutes later, Markson came over, and since I had just resumed grilling duties I didn't have a graceful way to slip away.

"Hey Dex, thanks for inviting me."

I forced a smile. "Great that you could make it Trev."

"I was a little surprised. I know I rub you the wrong way."

"Naw, man. We all have our own styles; it's all cool."

"I think we're in good shape on the bid," he said. "I'm hearing good buzz on where we are compared to the competitors."

"Well, you're the capture manager, so I trust your judgment. Though I'm always leery of buzz. Too many competing agendas and people trying to muddy the waters."

"I trust my source."

I rolled my eyes. "Another poor girl?"

"Naw, man, I'm not a one-trick pony. No, this one I worked with the good, old fashioned trio of booze, strippers, and drugs."

"Please keep me out of this. I always think working with you it's likely that someone will end up in jail."

He laughed. "Look, let's leave that aside then. I want to talk more about the future. So, assuming we get the contract and don't end up in jail," he gave me a winning grin. "What's next? I mean, for me?"

"You know, I think it might be better if you work all this out with Trip."

"You'll go along with whatever we come up with?"

"I... I can't promise that."

"You know, I can still queer this deal if I feel like it. My source is not just a source to get info, but I can also inject information into the process."

"Well, now, you're really bringing me around." I could see him getting angry. "Look, let's just play it one step at a time. Let's see if

we get the contract and what the final terms are. Odds are we'll be expanding pretty dramatically if it ends up anything like expected, and then we'll all be in a better position to make a decision."

He nodded, not quite placated, but also realizing he didn't have much to gain by getting into it with me.

"So, who's the tall dyke?" he said, nodding in the direction of Val.

"Val. Friend of Olivia's. And I'm not sure we're supposed to use that word."

He shrugged. "What kind of friend?"

"Friend friend. They went to college together."

"I wouldn't have pictured Olivia for a LUG. You know, Lesbian Until Graduation."

"I know what it means."

"Anyway, Olivia's always struck me as a woman who loves men. She's subtle, classy, but you can tell. You can see it in their eyes. Knowing she's got at least a little bi in her makes her even sexier."

"That's my wife you're talking about."

He laughed. "No need to brag about it. Anyway, I'll talk to Trip, but keep an open mind about me." I nodded, more to get rid of him than anything else. He clapped me on the shoulder. "I think I'm gonna see if I can't get somewhere with Val. She looks like she might be a gold star, and there's nothing I like better than ruining that."

I groaned as he walked away. He was infuriating, pretty much always, but his insinuating comments that he had particular insight into my wife really pushed my buttons. Why had Olivia invited him? Probably, I reflected, precisely in the hopes of provoking that kind of conversation.

And speaking about Olivia, where was she? I glanced around the yard and pool, and couldn't find her. And Mitch, where was he? I'd been so distracted by Charlie, and then watching Val put the moves on Denise, and finally by Markson that I lost track of her... them. I scanned in the direction of the house. There! Was that movement in our bedroom? My imagination went from zero to sixty

in 2 seconds flat. My dream came back to me. Olivia riding a big-dicked stud, her hands on his chest and she rose up and down on his thick shaft. His hands roaming over her body, her tits, her ass, pressing his thumb in her willing mouth. Him crunching upward to kiss her, his face coming into focus. Mitch. And Olivia gasping excitedly into his mouth as she creamed all over his cock.

“Is there supposed to be so much flame?”

I startled and noticed one of my brats was on fire.

“Probably not,” I replied as I rolled it until it stopped combusting.

Olivia laughed. “Having fun?”

“I can’t believe you invited Markson.”

“Oh, and the two of you were chatting it up like old buddies just a minute ago.” She glanced at him trying to make conversation with a skeptical, but amused Val. “He’s certainly not a man who avoids challenges. You have to give him that.”

“He’s on the prowl. He was checking out Tracey’s ass earlier.”

“Ha. She’ll be tickled pink.”

“Yeah?”

She nodded. “Yeah. She has a little crush on him. The whole bad boy thing.”

I rolled my eyes. “I thought you gals outgrew that once you were out of your twenties.”

“We outgrow acting on it... well, at least most of the time.” She winked at me and slapped my bottom. “Okay, grill man, I’m going to mingle.”

It didn’t occur to me until after she left that Trip seemed to think his wife couldn’t even pick Markson out of a lineup. Though I guess that’s the sort of white lie people tell their spouses about their crushes.

As the afternoon turned into evening, I served the brisket and shut down the grills. Some of our guests had left—Charlie and his wife were long gone—but most remained. After dark we’d have a nice

view of the town fireworks. In the meantime, people were drinking and lounging in or around the pool or had pulled chairs together into loose clusters to chat and catch up. We lit Citronella tiki torches once the sun dipped below the mountains, and they flickered, dare I say, romantically.

I noticed that Olivia was sitting in a small group with Mitch, Denise, and Tracey. His shorts showed off his muscular legs, and when he laughed, his eyes crinkled fetchingly. The guy was a total stud, and I was grateful that he and Olivia hadn't had the guts to act on their attraction when they were both single. And I could also see why she might cheat on her lovers with him when things either got boring or were going badly.

I decided to join their little circle. Mitch was in the middle of a story that involved rescuing a baby deer he'd come across while hiking. It had been wounded by a bear, but somehow managed to get away, but it wouldn't last the night. So, in addition to being fit, handsome, and outdoorsy, he was a lover of animals.

"Anyway, I carried her back down to the ranger station, and they were able to get her to the vet."

"Weren't you worried about the bear coming back for its meal?" Tracey asked, enthralled.

"A little." He shrugged modestly. "But I couldn't just leave it there."

So, brave as well. Fucker.

Denise chuckled. "I was wondering when the deer story would come out," she teased.

"It's my best story," he replied.

"Somehow it always comes up when women are around," she noted.

"You and Val seemed engrossed earlier," he said, changing the subject.

Denise blushed and looked down for a second, but she quickly recovered. "She does *not* like you. What'd you do to her?"

He rolled his eyes. "That was a long time ago."

Olivia jumped in, "Yeah, that's my fault. Val and I were... involved. And...."

"You cheated on her with my husband," Denise said with a laugh.

Olivia blushed. "Yeah, something like that. Of course, he wasn't your husband at the time."

Denise waved it off. "I know. It's just funny. I figured it was something like that."

"Wait, wait, wait," Tracey jumped in. "You and Val?" she said to my wife.

"It was in college," Olivia said. "Oh, like, you never kissed a girl."

"Well, of course," Tracey said. "We've all done that." I noticed Denise nod in agreement. "But that's not the same as being *involved*. A little drunken kissy-kissy on the dance floor is *de rigueur*. Put us girls in a nightclub and we'd probably be smooching by the end of the night, especially if there was a guy we were trying to impress."

"I'd pay to see that," I joked. Mitch nodded slightly.

Tracey ignored me. "But this sounds like more."

"Val can be very sexy," Olivia said, and I noticed a small smile on Denise's lips. "And it was very exciting for a while."

Tracey persevered, "It sounds like—"

"Yes Trace," Olivia interjected. "I went full lesbo. Dining at the Y. The whole nine yards."

Tracey went wide-eyed as Denise and Mitch laughed. Trace turned toward me to gauge my reaction. I shrugged. "I think it's hot."

She laughed. "You men are crazy."

Olivia rose. "Well, now that we've dissected my sexual orientation, I'm going to get a refill." She waved her solo cup in the air. "Anyone want anything?"

"I'll go with you," Tracey said.

"Me too," Denise added, rising. "You boys stay out of trouble."

That left me alone with Mitch. Given what Olivia and I had been up to recently, that should have been unproblematic. Maybe it was just me, but it still felt awkward. Do other men have that issue? He'd had my woman. She'd gone down on him. He'd had his big dick inside her, and I knew it was big because she'd told me so explicitly.

“Love your home,” he said amiably. “The pool is great.”

“Yeah, we got lucky finding this place. Everything just came together.” The real luck was staying put long enough a couple of jobs ago to be part of a generous buy-out.

“Denise and I are thinking of moving up here. Colorado Springs is lovely, but if you’re not Air Force or an evangelical, you can sometimes feel like an outsider.”

“How did you choose to live there?”

“Wanted to be close to Denise’s family. She’s an Air Force brat, and they retired there. But I’m thinking Denver would be close enough, you know?”

I nodded. “I’d think so. Depends a little on how much they help with child care. Having Olivia’s mom around has been a lifesaver sometimes.”

“Maggie is great. Is she still doing well?” he asked.

Maggie is Olivia’s mom, and his question was a reminder that he knew Olivia from way before I did.

“Yeah, you know, getting older. But she’s still really active.”

He nodded. “That’s good to hear. She was always really supportive back in high school. Even when I couldn’t talk to my parents about something, she was always there.”

He had a bit of a wistful air about him as he spoke, and I couldn’t help but wonder if Olivia didn’t represent something of the one who got away, a little like how she felt about him. I needed to change the subject.

“Did Olivia give you a tour when you arrived?”

“No. We came right back out here.”

“Let me show you around.”

I gave him a quick tour of the house, which allowed me to focus on things like our new stove, the entertainment center in the basement, and our new windows instead of his and Olivia’s past. After he returned to the backyard to find his wife; I grabbed another beer and downed half of it in one swig.

I spent some time circulating among the guests, tossing away some of the trash to ease the cleanup later. As the sky darkened and the fireworks were about to begin, I went looking for Olivia to watch the show with my wife. I figured she'd be on the pool deck, but she wasn't. I looped through the backyard, checking the various clusters, which was slow, since everyone wanted to chat for a bit. When I finally finished my loop, I could hear the national anthem playing at the high school, which signaled the imminent start of the fireworks show. I hadn't found Olivia... nor, I noticed, was Mitch around.

I felt a hard knot form in the pit of my stomach. A parade of images flashed through my mind. His big hands and broad smile. His muscles and twinkling eyes. And the progression of our game. The wild sex, the images I sent to Denny. What she'd done with Zach, and what he'd done to her, her mauled tits, her pussy swollen and messy from his hands. I thought about her naked body from this morning, and her shaved, perfectly smooth mound. And I remembered her words from the night of the reunion, when I asked her what would have happened had Denise and I not been there: *He'd be inside me. Making me come like no one else can.*

I hustled back inside. The first explosions began outside, filling the house with bright flashes of color. I tried to quiet my breathing enough to listen for any activity. I didn't want to just be stomping around the house all higgledy-piggledy. The fireworks show started off slowly, allowing for small gaps between the explosions and the resultant oohs and aahs. And then I heard it. It took a few moments for my ears to isolate the sound, but yes, unmistakable, and coming from the basement, feminine moans of passions.

I slipped off my shoes and slid in my socks to the stairs. The lights were off except for the colored LED light strips along the ceiling that the kids had talked us into. I couldn't be sure where they were, but I could definitely hear her, louder now, moans mixed with gasps, and beneath it all the wet, slurping sound of a pussy being penetrated again and again. I eased down the stairs, hoping they weren't right there, and weren't facing in my direction. I wanted to see them before they saw me.

Every step closer made her moans clearer, and more high-pitched than usual, more urgent. No matter how excited she was with me, he could fuck her like no one else could, his big cock stretching her and reaching deeper than I could hope to. It was a dark and painful thought, but also one that caused my mind to begin to fog with excitement. The explosions began again, faster, flashing colorfully in the basement through the small casement windows.

At the bottom of the steps, I let my eyes adjust to the dim light and surveyed the room: the bar, the sectional in front of the TV, then finally, there, in the corner behind the pool table. Two bodies, writhing together. A firework burst confirmed what had just been a vague impression. There were two people there, but neither was Olivia nor Mitch.

Instead, I was greeted by a wholly unexpected, and wildly erotic scene. It was Denise and Val. Denise was stripped nearly naked. Her bikini bottoms were completely gone, and her bandeau was up around her neck like a collar, with the extra fabric wrapped around Val's fist. Val's other hand was down between Denise's legs, her fingers thumping her clit like a bass player. Denise squirmed, moaned, and gasped as her hands clutched at Val's muscular arms. Denise shuddered, her big, beautiful breasts swaying deliciously. Then again, more violently, her moans constricting in a high squeak.

Denise's body seemed almost to melt. Val wrapped up the smaller woman and pulled her into a passionate embrace. They kissed wetly, open mouthed. Val pulled back on the bandeau wrapped around Denise's neck. Denise moaned in frustration, craning forward, hungry for Val's lips. Val teased her with small pecks all over her face. She ran her hand up Denise's luscious, writhing body, from her juicy pussy, between her full breasts, to her lips. Val pressed her fingers into Denise's willing mouth. Denise cupped Val's hand and seductively sucked her own pussy juices from Val's digits.

Val smiled a self-satisfied grin. Tightening her grip on the bandeau, she eased Denise down to her knees. Mitch's wife stared up submissively. Val nodded, and Denise grabbed Val's board shorts at the hips and pulled them down. Val had a nearly full bush, just

trimmed slightly for neatness. She pulled Denise closer. Denise grabbed Val's firm ass and buried her face in Val's snatch, licking and sucking eagerly. Val swayed slightly, gilding Denise's head confidently.

A quick succession of explosions caught my attention. As erotic as it was to watch Denise and Val, I didn't want to get caught watching, and anyway, I still hadn't found Olivia. With some reluctance, I retreated up the stairs, but not before trying to consciously imprint the scene in my memory. This was something I wouldn't want to forget.

I crossed the kitchen and went into the foyer. I paused and stared up the stairs. I didn't know if Denise going with Val was some sort of deal between Mitch and his wife, but I was absolutely certain what I would find if I went upstairs. I just wasn't sure if I was ready to see it. To see my wife fucking another man, in our bed, and not just any man, but rather her big-dick ex, who she'd been low-key pining for since high school.

I took a deep breath and climbed the stairs. The double doors to our bedroom were cracked open as if to invite me in. I widened the opening and peered inside. The lights were out, but they were clearly visible from the light streaming in from outside. The French doors to our balcony were thrown open, and with each explosion from outside, I could hear the cheers from our friends and neighbors in the yard below.

They weren't fucking. That might have been easier. Instead, they were making love. In the lull before the finale outside, I could hear their soft moans, the sound of their passionate kisses, the sweet nothings they whispered in each other's ears, unintelligible from my distance, but also unmistakable in their tenderness and passion.

She was on her back, legs in the air, knees bent and toes pointed toward the foot of the bed. Her arms were wrapped around his neck, holding him tight. Between her legs, his muscular ass rose and fell rhythmically, giving her long, deep, slow strokes of his huge prick.

There was a burst of light from outside. Then another and another. The explosions began to come in rapid succession, the booms louder and louder. He fucked her harder and faster in time with the fireworks. Her legs straightened and rose to the ceiling.

“Oh... oh... oh fuck, Mitch. Oh fuck... oh God... oh God... oh God!”

She closed her eyes, arched her back, and threw her head back, offering him her neck. He kissed her chin, her throat, and then rose up on his powerful arms and began to really pound into her.

The fireworks were firing in rapid succession, strobe-lighting the room. Her breasts jiggled wildly, topped by her rock hard, stiff nipples. Her eyelids fluttered.

“Ah... ah... ah...” she cried. “Oh Mitch... Oh Mitch... oh God!”

Her body shuddered in ecstasy. He thrust in hard and shivered as he filled my wife with his come. From outside, a wave of cheers greeted the end of the fireworks, but it could just as easily have been in response to Mitch’s performance.

Olivia pulled her lover into an embrace. They kissed and rubbed noses and whispered and giggled together. I backed away, and zombie-like, returned to our guests outside. I grabbed a beer on the way and took a swig, and hoped that no one would notice how pale and shaky I surely was.

With the fireworks over, the party quickly broke up. People helped with the plates and bottles, so that all that was left out were the tables and chairs that I could deal with tomorrow.

Olivia was still inside as I started to bid farewell to our guests, and I couldn’t help but wonder if people noticed. Had they, maybe, seen her going into the house with Mitch? Had they observed the two of them making plans earlier? Had anyone overheard Olivia crying out his name in passion? It didn’t help that I suspected they were doing it again. Those kisses and tender murmurs after they each climaxed didn’t feel like a coda, but rather like a transition to a second (or third?) round. That vision of Olivia riding a big cock returned, and I thought I could almost hear them back at it, though surely it was my imagination. Right?

Markson came by to say goodbye. "Thanks for the invite. Fun party," he said.

"Good to see you, Trevor. See you at work on Monday."

"Where's that pretty little wife of yours? I'd like to say goodbye to her, too," he said pointedly.

I couldn't tell what he was insinuating. Was it just that he wanted to check her out again in her skimpy outfit? Or did he know she was inside getting her cunt stretched by another man? We shook hands and he left.

Trip and Tracey showed up next. He was trailing a bit behind her, and I thought I could sense a frostiness between them.

Tracey gave me a big hug. "Great party as always."

She didn't ask about Olivia, which I took to mean she knew that my wife was... um... indisposed. Luckily, she moved on before the full horror of embarrassment hit.

I shook Trip's hand. He looked glum.

"Everything okay?" I asked.

"I'll talk to you Monday," he replied.

He followed his wife to their car, still a few paces behind her.

"What's up with them?" Olivia asked.

I jolted at her sudden appearance. She was back in her bikini and wrap. Her hair was loose and she was glowing post-orgasmically.

"I thought you might know."

"Me?" she mouthed, pointing a finger at her chest and smirking.

I didn't get a chance to follow-up before more people came up to say their goodbyes. After a couple of neighbors left, Val walked up. She was grinning like the proverbial Cheshire Cat, although actually said cat does not appear in any proverb I know.

She gave Olivia a big hug.

"Did you have fun?" my wife asked.

Val grinned. "Yummy, yummy, little doe. High LP. The three of us can have a lot of fun if you ever come back to the light."

Olivia laughed. "God, you're the worst."

"Mmm, well, the pussy wants what the pussy wants." She turned toward me. "Right Dex?"

"I... um...."

"Stop it you nasty bitch," Olivia teased.

Val laughed. "Nasty bitch. I like that. Might get that as a tat. Join me?"

Olivia laughed. "Go away."

Val smirked and swaggered away, more the cat that ate the canary than the Cheshire Cat.

"What does she know?" I hissed at my wife.

"Just about everything." *Ev-ery-thing*, all three syllables drawn out.

Before I could continue my questioning, Mitch and Denise approached. He stuck out his hand and I shook it instinctively, only to immediately receive an emotional jolt as I thought about how less than twenty minutes earlier that very hand had been roaming my wife's body.

"Thanks for the party," he said. "It was unexpectedly revelatory." He glanced down at his wife, who blushed.

"Come on, Mitch, let's go." She gave me a quick nod, which seemed to convey some sort of affinity. And I noticed she didn't acknowledge Olivia at all.

It took what seemed like an interminable additional quarter hour before we managed to shoo everyone out, including a small clutch of neighbors who'd set up shop in our family room. Finally, I closed the front door behind the last guest and found Olivia in the kitchen.

She gestured toward a rocks glass, filled almost a third of the way with Maker's Mark. "You look like you need that," she said.

I did. I was wrung out physically and my mind was churning. I sat at the kitchen table and took a sip.

"Olivia, we—"

"I need to show you something," she interrupted.

She approached me, untying her wrap and letting it fall on the floor behind her. She was just in her bikini. She took my hands and placed them on her hips.

"Take off my bottoms," she said.

Pressing down on my hands, she got me started. I took over and slowly eased her bikini off, as she rocked slowly back and forth.

Lower until I exposed her shaved mons, and her swollen, wet cunt. It wasn't as battered as it had been when she returned from her adventure with Zach, but she was obviously freshly fucked. If I'd had any doubts, the string of jism leaking into the puddle in the liner of her bikini made it unambiguous.

"Do you want a taste? Some men do."

I shook my head. "No. Not me."

"Pity," she said. "A tongue would feel so nice right about now." She paused for a moment to let me reconsider. When I didn't, she eased her panties off the rest of the way. I stared mutely at her sloppy hole.

"Take off your shorts," she said.

"No, Olivia, we need to talk."

"Take off your fucking shorts, Dex."

Her peremptory tone combined with the sight of another man's jism dripping from her pussy hit me with surprising power. It was an irresistible command. I shook my head, but at the same time I lifted up from the chair and slipped off my shorts. She ran her fingernail gently up my stiff shaft and gave me a self-satisfied smile.

I finally found my voice, "Just because I'm hard doesn't mean I'm not angry."

She placed her hands on my shoulders, straddled my legs, and dropped down into my lap, impaling her sloppy pussy on my prick. Face to face, she held my gaze.

"I won't move. And if you can hold out even thirty seconds, you get to remain angry with me."

"Olivia, no, I—"

"How does my cunt feel?" she asked.

"Olivia, this isn't fair, I—"

"Dex, tell me what it feels like to be inside my freshly-fucked cunt."

"I... I..." The sensation of it, and her tone, and her gaze reduced me to incoherence. "Wet," I finally gasped.

She smiled. "Mmm," she sighed. "Mitch comes more than any man I've ever been with. When he comes in my mouth, it always ends up dripping down my chin, no matter how fast I try to swallow."

And when he comes in my pussy, it feels like he's leaking out of me for days."

I groaned as I imagined his thick ropes shooting into my wife.

She continued, "You should see what it looks like when he comes on my face."

I shuddered.

"Dex, what else? What else are you feeling?"

"You're loose."

Her smile turned wicked. "I always forget how good it feels to be pounded by a big... thick... cock."

I gasped and came.

She hadn't moved. Just the sensation of her sloppy pussy, lewd words, and brazen attitude were enough to set me off.

A wave of shame swept over me. "Okay," I whined, "you proved your point. I'm a pathetic, whipped loser, now... get off me."

She kissed me passionately. "No Dex, you're just wired this way. And I just wish we'd communicated about this sooner. We wasted a decade of you fantasizing about me being with other men while I was fantasizing about the same thing."

"It was just a fantasy," I replied.

"For me too. But sometimes fantasies are fun to fulfill."

She reached over and picked up the Bourbon. She took a sip, and handed it to me. I finished it and replaced it on the table.

"We need to communicate," I said. "You can't just do things... and you can't conspire with others."

"Now, Dex, be fair. I floated it past you this morning, didn't I? I mean, part of the fantasy is that I'm a wanton woman who can't quite control her urges, isn't it? That anytime we're apart, I might succumb to another man's charms."

I nodded. "I guess. But, this took time to put together and—"

She laughed. "You think I pre-planned all of this?"

"You've never invited Mitch to one of these parties before."

"We hadn't just seen him a couple of weeks before either, had we?"

"I... I don't know."

“Dex. When I showed you my pussy this morning, I was thinking of seducing another man. But it wasn’t Mitch. It was Markson.”

I groaned and felt my cock swell. She felt it as well and grinned.

“No planning necessary. It would have been easy to just lure him away from the group. He’d have been more than eager to cuckold you.”

“I bet. So... what happened?”

“I saw Val putting the moves on Denise, and I recognized Denise’s bicurious body language, so my dirty little mind started scheming. It was easy. I got Denise alone, and worked the conversation to Val. I told her that Val was an amazing lover, with the best hands I’d ever experienced. And I told her she should go for it. She said she was worried about how Mitch would react, and I told her that if she was okay with it, I could take care of that problem.”

“And she said okay?”

“Mitch and Denise are, um, open-minded that way. Denise mentioned my anklet, and said she’d like to have another party where all the women were wearing them. Do you think it would be fun to swing with them? Would you like to play with her big titties and enjoy her juicy pussy while Mitch and I fucked right next to you?”

My dick was rock hard again, and Olivia began to ride me up and down. A mix of my come, Mitch’s, and Olivia’s juices leaked onto my scrotum.

“The most difficult part was actually Val.”

I thought about the way Val had handled Denise, confident and in command and without the slightest hesitation.

“I find that hard to believe.”

Olivia chuckled. “She’s mad at you. She thinks you’re the puppet master. That I fucked Mitch’s big, beautiful cock just to fulfill your fantasy.”

“Well, you did.”

“Mmmm, yes, of course. All for you, Baby.”

She smirked wickedly and ground her hips against me.

“Are you still angry?”

“I don’t know,” I admitted. “I can’t see through the lust.”

She pressed her forehead to mine. "None of it matters, Baby. Dicks, pussies, come. It's all just a game."

"It makes me nuts."

"Mmmm, me too. I came so fucking hard knowing you were watching us."

"You knew I was there?"

"Of course. We put on a good show, didn't we, Dex? Timed it just right. Climax during the climax. And he fucked me so damn hard."

She rolled her hips vigorously. I couldn't tell if she was thinking about him or me. She yanked off her top.

"Suck my titties," she demanded.

I switched back and forth between her hard nubs. The harder I sucked, the faster she rode me, and when I lightly bit down on her nipple, she hissed excitedly, and her pussy spasmed on my cock. I gasped and came as well.

She rose up off me. Her pussy was even messier than before, and sexier still. She dropped to her knees between my legs and slurped my slimy prick deep into her mouth. She looked up at me submissively as her tongue bathed my cock, and her contented moans ensured I didn't get completely soft. She worked me patiently, coaxing another erection, and then using her tongue, hands, mouth and tits, expertly, she made me come again.

I woke with a start. It was still dark, not even a hint of dawn outside. Olivia was beside me, naked, snoring softly.

My heart was pounding. My skin was slick with damp sweat. My breath came in ragged gasps. I felt as if I were ready to jump out of my skin. My hands shook. I had to get up, do something. I splashed water on my face. My pallor was grey. A vein throbbed on my forehead. Pain in my chest.

I grabbed my robe and went downstairs. I paced in the kitchen. My heart seemed to race faster. I was having a heart attack. I needed to get to the hospital, but there was no time to explain this to

Olivia, no time for an ambulance. I knew I'd be dead if I delayed even a moment. I grabbed the car keys and got behind the wheel of my car. I pulled out of the driveway.

Focusing on the road seemed to calm me. I was barely out of the neighborhood, driving west on Parker toward downtown, when I realized I was behaving ridiculously. The panic broke. And I was suddenly dead tired. I pulled over and shut off the engine, and passed out.

Chapter Ten: The Body

The sunrise woke me, glaring in through the windshield. I managed to make it back to the house before Olivia woke up. Still out of sorts, I decided breakfast and coffee would help. She found me digging into a stack of pancakes.

"I guess being married to a slut makes a man hungry," she teased.

"You want some?" I replied with a full mouth.

She laughed, but quickly turned serious. "Everything okay, Dex? Did you take the car somewhere last night?"

"No," I lied. "Where would I go?"

She shrugged. "Maybe you have another woman, though I'd have thought you wouldn't have much left to give."

"Maybe I'm just more virile than the men you're used to."

Olivia squeezed between me and the table and sat in my lap. "You are definitely that." She reached into my robe and tweaked my nipple. She giggled when I shivered. "So, are we good, Dex?"

She'd made me come seven times. We'd fucked in the shower. She'd hinted I could have her ass, though I demurred.

"Yeah, we are," I said

She smiled. "Good." Then she rose and poured herself a cup of coffee.

"Are you... do you... have any other plans?"

"Oh Dex, that wouldn't be any fun, would it? Isn't it more exciting not to know when I might, just by chance, run into a handsome stranger? It could happen at any time. At the grocery store, at work, just out and about, and the first you'd know about it would be when you discover my smeared lipstick, or swollen tits, or messy cunt."

I swallowed hard. She chuckled.

"Well, Dex, you stay out of trouble. I have my personal trainer this morning, and last time Max was so very upset with me for not getting my cardio done. I don't know what he's going to do to me today."

She flounced out of the kitchen, lifting up her robe at the last moment to give me a flash of ass for good measure.

I went back to bed after she left, though my nap was disturbed by dreams that flirted with being nightmares, just on the borderline between weird and terrifying. The last had me stuck in a strange house that I couldn't leave. Doors just led to more doors. Corridors that seemed to loop back on themselves. I had a sense that Olivia was there somewhere, but I couldn't find her. My anxiety rose, beginning to approach that sense of frustration, where you begin to lash out and try to force yourself awake, but at some point, the realization of being in a dream forms, but I never quite got there. Instead I woke up feeling even more tired than before.

"Jesus, Dex, come here!" Olivia demanded.

She was sitting at the kitchen table, looking at her open laptop.

"What's the matter? Taylor have a new boyfriend?" For some reason, Olivia was a little obsessed with Taylor Swift. *There is something weird about her. Like she's an alien in human form.*

"Isn't this the guy?" she asked.

She had her browser open to the Denver Post main page. The lead story, top left, was a picture of a man who looked a lot like Denny, the man she'd flirted with in the bar. Below his picture was the headline: "Aurora Man Murdered in 'Execution Style' Killing."

She clicked on the link to the full story.

Dennis Jennings, 57, was found dead in the parking lot of the Walmart near Town Center. He had been shot twice in the head, and police report that his body bore evidence of having been tortured. Mr. Jennings's wife, Muriel Jennings, told police that her husband had gone out in the early morning hours saying he had a crisis at work. When he did not respond to calls, Ms. Jennings tracked his cell phone to the Walmart parking lot. She found her husband in a

pool of blood, and immediately called the authorities. Police are asking that anyone with information about this killing should call the Aurora police at....

"Jesus," I groaned. "That's the guy."

"Tortured," Olivia said. "What the heck was he mixed up in? Fuck. Imagine if I'd gone outside with him, and...."

I wrapped my arms around her. "He was mixed up in something weird, probably. Seemed like a normal guy, but still water runs deep. I'm guessing it was some sort of money issue. Maybe he owes it... or maybe he tried to collect on something."

"Or maybe there's a serial killer on the loose," Olivia replied. "And this is his first, signature case."

I chuckled. "Yeah, then you'll get interviewed on the podcast about the case. The mysterious woman who was seen flirting with the doomed man in a local bar. Who is she and what does she know? I wonder if we can lock down the rights to this."

"Ha ha, Dex. But this is serious. I mean, he's dead."

"I know, but it is just a weird coincidence. Every day we walk and drive past thousands of people. And statistically, there is at least one person every day that we walk by who dies in the next twenty-four hours. It just happens the one guy in this case was someone you flirted with. And his death was gruesome rather than, like, a car accident."

She tilted her head. "I'm not sure your math is right there, Mr. Wizard."

So, romantics that we are, we did the math, actuarial tables and everything. There is still some disagreement about who won this debate.

We made love that night. There was no one else and no acrobatics. Just the two of us.

Trip was skulking around my office when I arrived at work Monday.

"You waiting for me?" I asked.

"We need to talk."

I ushered him inside and closed the door behind us.

"You seem stressed," I said.

He shook his head. "Dude, I think Trace is stepping out."

"No you don't."

"It's your fault."

My chest tightened. "Um, what are you talking about?"

"I, um, mentioned the game you and Olivia play—"

"Jesus," I groaned. Soon there would be literally no one who didn't know. "You said it was just between us."

"Wives don't count, do they? When you tell a married man something, you have to assume he's going to tell his wife."

"Noted. So, Trace...?"

"She said it was hot that you guys were spicing things up. Then at the party... did you see her eyeing up Markson?"

I shook my head. Keeping track of one hot wife is hard enough.

"I asked her what she was doing," Trip continued. "And she told me since she was already pregnant, well, you get it..."

I grinned. "She's just yanking your chain. And since you're talking about it two days later, it seemed to work."

"Yeah, I guess. Maybe, I'm just getting desperate. I haven't gotten my dick wet in weeks. I swear, if we get this contract, things are going to change. In the meantime, I kept imagining her getting fucked by Markson's big dick. You know he's huge. No one is that much of an asshole unless he's packing."

"Or overcompensating. I bet he's a microphallus."

Trip chuckled. "No you don't. Anyway, speaking of Markson, he says the screening committee has their final meeting today. He thinks we're moving on to the next stage."

I shrugged. "That's just a compliance issue. We knew we'd get that far."

"Yeah, but still nice to hear. Anyway, Markson says they are fast-tracking Phase I because they want to start moving on to Phase II."

"I thought Phase II was still theoretical and would only happen if P1 was successful."

"I guess they're confident enough that they want to lock-in first-mover. Upshot is that the P1 decision is going to be made by the end of this week. We should move on some hires."

"Like big-dick Markson?"

"Wouldn't hurt."

"Let's hold off," I said. "That's what he wants. So this whole story is super convenient. And if we go to him trying to keep him past P1, he'll want a big commitment, signing bonus, equity... the works."

"Okay, okay," he relented. "But it is just going to cost us more later."

"Unless we decide we can do without him... and Trip? We can do without him."

He nodded skeptically.

"I don't know how you can stand that your wife is horny just because she's thinking about another man," he said.

"It's not so bad," I replied. "In the end, it's your dick that gets the benefit. And about now, how nice would that be?"

"I dunno. I'm already anxious enough when she goes out to her book club at night and shit like that."

I shrugged. Trip was going to have to negotiate that part by himself if they went down this path.

I arrived home before Olivia, so I started to get dinner ready. I cut up some onions, splashed a little olive oil in the pan, and started browning them over a low heat. I opened a bottle of Sauvignon Blanc and poured myself a glass, and I cut the chicken breasts into narrow strips. Setting those aside, I picked out an assortment of peppers, and began to julien them as well.

The doorbell rang, which meant that either Olivia had forgotten her keys or someone was trying to sell me something. I hurried over, but not before the chimes sounded again.

I jolted at the sight of two men in suits.

"Dexter Mullins?" asked a dapper, Hispanic man.

I nodded.

"I'm detective Torres. This is my partner, detective Land."

"Oh Jesus, is Olivia okay?"

Torres responded. "Your wife is fine as far as we know. We're actually here to see if we could ask you a few questions about some texts we discovered on a deceased man's phone?"

My heart rose into my throat as I put two and two together. Denny. The explicit selfies. "Oh God. I can explain, it is totally ridiculous and—"

Torres interrupted me. "Actually, Sir, we'd prefer to bring you down to the station and chat there."

"Um, do I need a lawyer?"

He smiled. "I don't know, do you?"

"It's not... it's...."

"We're not looking to embarrass anyone. We'd rather just clarify things in a low key manner. Once you get the lawyers involved...." He turned his palms up. "It's out of our control. Everything gets on the record."

"I have dinner on the stove."

"Why don't you turn that off, and let's get this taken care of. It shouldn't take long."

"Okay, okay," I replied. "Do you mind if I text my wife?"

"Detective Land will remain here until she arrives. We'd like to speak to her as well. And it'll be easier to explain everything in person. There are enough ambiguous texts floating around already, aren't there?"

I blushed and nodded. "Okay, give me a few seconds."

"Mind if we wait inside?" he asked.

I nodded and they slipped in past me. Land awkwardly gave me a small smile that didn't quite reach his cold, blue eyes.

I hurried to put away the half-made dinner, and then returned to find them poking around the family room.

"Uh, I'm ready," I said.

Torres gestured toward the door and followed me. Land remained behind. In addition to Torres's black Impala, there was a cruiser in our driveway. That would surely get the rumors going, I thought grimly.

Torres directed me to the back seat. “Regs,” he said by way of explanation, which didn’t quite ease the impression that I was being arrested.

He didn’t speak during the short ride to the station, and once there he ushered me into an interrogation room, with a simple wooden table with a bottle of water, three chairs, and a TV protected behind plexiglass.

“I’ll just be a few minutes,” he said.

The door shut behind him. And I thought I heard it lock. I resisted the urge to check. I didn’t want to seem like I was anxious, and I was pretty sure someone was watching me. Instead, I settled down at the table and took a sip of water. And I waited.

And waited. And waited.

I knew this was a mind game cops like to play, but it was frustrating because this was an easy situation to clear up. I finally gave in to my temptation, I checked the door. As expected, it was locked. I sat back down in the chair.

Unexpectedly, the TV came to life. And to my horror, the screen was covered with the three pictures I’d sent to Denny: Olivia with her tits and tongue out, exposing her pussy, and looking over her shoulder with a naughty grin as she offered up her asshole.

“Oh God,” I groaned.

The door opened, and Torres and Land entered. They sat down opposite me, each with a pad of paper.

“Can we take that down?” I said, gesturing at the screen.

Land smirked, and Torres ignored me.

“So, Dexter,” Torres began, “I presume you heard about the recent murder in Aurora of Mr. Dennis Jennings?”

I nodded. “It was all over the news.”

“Yes. And, so, you might understand our interest in nailing down what is going on with these texts.”

“Yes, of course. It’s... it’s silly really, so—”

Torres put his hand up. “If you don’t mind, I’d like to ask questions in order to keep everything straight in my mind.”

“There’s nothing to keep straight, it—”

“Dexter. Dex? Do you go by Dex?”

I nodded.

"Dex, how did you know Mr. Jennings?"

"I didn't *know* him. We just. Ugh. We just ran into him in a bar."

"Which bar was that?"

"El Pecado. Southwest place on Evans. Near Monaco."

"Do you go there often?"

I shrugged. "Every once in a while. It's convenient."

"And so you knew Mr. Jennings from El Pecado."

"No. I mean, we didn't *know* him. We met him, just that one time."

Land raised an eyebrow as Torres continued the questioning.

"Can you recall the date?"

"It was the week before the 4th. A Friday. So, like the 25th? 26th?"

He nodded. "And so, you met up with Mr. Jennings in the bar."

"No, we didn't meet up. We were there. He was there. And that's how we met him."

Torres put his pen down. "Dex, how long has your wife been having an affair with Mr. Jennings?"

"She's not. Listen, she and I play this game. I have this fantasy of her being with another man, and this was just part of that game. He was just in the right place at the right time."

"Unlike two nights ago," Torres noted.

"I don't know."

"So, you're saying you had never met Mr. Jennings before that night?"

"No."

This time Land snorted. I glared at him.

Torres put a hand out to calm me. "You can see why we're having trouble with this, right, Dex? These are very personal images of your wife. They are of your wife, right?"

I nodded.

"Very personal," he repeated. He turned toward his partner. "Your wife let you take pictures like this, Dan?" Land shook his head. "Yeah, me neither," Torres continued. "Even when we were first

dating, I'm pretty sure if I asked her for a high def shot of her butt, she'd have shown me the door."

I sighed. "Look, I know this is fucked up, but—"

"How many men have you or your wife sent this sort of picture to?"

"None. Just this one guy."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes.... well, I don't know for sure, I guess. I haven't. She may have. I... she took those pictures in the bathroom and sent them to me first, and asked me to forward them to him."

"I don't understand. How did you have his number?"

"She had it."

"So, you're sitting there with Jennings. She goes into the bathroom, takes some selfies, sends them to you, and, what, you show them to him? How'd they get on his phone?"

"No. I was sitting by myself. She had gone over to him. She flirted with him for a while, and then took the pics. She sent them to me and told me to text them to him."

"So, she knew his number?"

"I guess he gave it to her."

"At the bar?"

"Yes.... well, I think. I don't really know."

"Is it possible your wife has been having an affair without you knowing?"

"I... I don't know. I don't think so. I.... Look, I know this sounds crazy, but it is just this game we play, you know, to get each other worked up."

"So your wife hasn't had sex with another man during your marriage?"

I looked down at the table in the vain hope of hiding my embarrassment, but I'm certain my skin tone gave it away.

"We'll come back to that. So why send him pictures? And why these three?"

"I don't know."

Land chimed in. "It's almost like one of those tourist menus you see when you travel abroad. You know, point at the dish you want."

Torres smirked. "Have you communicated with Mr. Jennings on any other occasions?"

"No. Just that night."

They exchange a quick glance.

"Actually, no," I corrected. "That's not right. He did send me a text Friday."

Torres nodded. "Yup. And then Saturday night late, he was murdered."

They kept at me until nearly midnight, going over the story multiple times. They used the pictures as a cudgel. Whenever they wanted to increase the pressure on me, they returned to Olivia's nudes. They dissected every image. Why had she stuck her tongue out in the first picture? Was she aroused in the second? What was she suggesting when she flashed her asshole? Then it would be back to Denny, and whether we'd known him before, or perhaps Olivia had? By the end, I was almost convinced myself that my wife had been having an affair and that I was a jealous husband. They told me that if I had anything to tell them, I should say it now. Things would only get more difficult later.

Torres and Land drove me home. Olivia was sitting at the kitchen table, drinking a glass of bourbon, looking as wrung out as I felt. Her questioning had been shorter than mine, but surely no less stressful. We made eye contact, but she didn't say a word.

Torres asked me to remain in town, and then, just as he was about to leave, he spun back around.

"Oh, Dex, I almost forgot. I noticed you went through a background check to buy a handgun several years ago. Would you mind if I took a look at that weapon?"

"Um, okay. It's in a safe downstairs. I used to shoot targets, but haven't gone to the range in years."

He followed me into the basement. Olivia trailed behind us. I unlocked the safe.

"I shoot skeet, once in a while," I said, pointing to my shotgun. "But you can see from the dust, I haven't taken out the handgun in a while."

I reached in and grabbed the box. Immediately, I realized it was light. But I was committed. I placed the box on the pool table and opened it. It was empty. I stared at the foam outline of the P320, as if staring hard enough would make it reappear.

"Dex?" he said.

"Sweetie, did you leave it in your locker at the range?" Olivia asked. Then to Torres, "I swear, detective, that man would lose his head if it weren't attached at the neck."

"Yeah, jeez, I must have."

Torres nodded. "Where do you shoot?"

"Tom's in Englewood. But they're closed now."

He smiled wanly. "Tell you what, Dex, how about you drop by there tomorrow and bring the gun down to the station. What do you say?"

"I'll try. But I have a busy day at work. I was planning to get some stuff done this evening, but..."

"Yes, try. The sooner we get all of this cleared up the better for all of us, right?"

We went back upstairs to find Land snooping around my office.

"Maybe you should go now," Olivia said to them both.

Land pointed to our wedding picture on my desk. "You are very photogenic, Mrs. Mullins."

She gazed at him coldly. He smirked and ambled from the room with insolent deliberation. I shut the door behind them. I breathed a sigh of relief, but turned to find Olivia glaring at me.

"Dex, where is your fucking gun?"

"I have no idea."

"Where did you go last night?"

"I told you, I did—"

"Don't lie to me. Jesus, Dex. Did you... did you kill that man?"

"No. What? What the fuck are you talking about?"

“Why didn’t you tell me he’d texted you?”

“I... I didn’t want to make an issue out of it. I blocked him. I thought it was done.”

“Someone sent him a text. From a burner phone. Claimed to be you. That’s what lured him out to the Walmart in the middle of the night. So, where were you?”

“How do you know that?”

“Torres and Land told me. They think I was fucking Denny behind your back. That you flew into a jealous rage and killed him. They said you were dangerous, and that you’d probably kill me too.”

“That’s insane.”

“That’s what I thought. But where is the fucking gun, and where the fuck were you?”

“I don’t know where the gun is. I swear. Look at the box. It is covered in dust. Someone must have stolen it at some point, and I never noticed.”

“You want to go in front of a jury with that story?” she asked.

“I didn’t do anything.”

“Dex, where did you go last night?”

“I had a panic attack, okay, Olivia? This whole fucking game we’re playing is hot as hell, but it ain’t for the faint of heart. I thought I was having a heart attack, and in my half-awake state, I decided the best thing to do was drive myself. Then after a few minutes, I realized I was being crazy. So I pulled over and tried to calm down... and I fell asleep. I woke up when the sun came up.”

“Jesus Christ, Dex. Did you tell them that?”

“No. They didn’t ask. They were fixated on the texts and the pictures.”

“They were treading carefully. They were trying to spook you into some sort of admission without directly accusing you of anything. That way they can say they didn’t need to Mirandize you. It was just informational.”

“I should have asked for a lawyer,” I grumbled. “But I thought I could explain things away. I didn’t do anything.”

“Yeah, well, what’s done is done. I’m a lawyer and I thought the same thing. Honestly, I didn’t quite want to bring another person into

our personal lives.” She sighed and then took my hand. “Dex did you kill that man?”

“How can you ask me that?”

“I need to know.”

“If you think I could be a cold-blooded killer, someone who could lure a victim out at night, and then torture and murder him, what difference does it make what I say?”

“Dex, please. It does... it does look like a crime of passion or something. Someone had a personal beef with that guy.”

I shook my head. “Olivia, I swear, I don’t have anything to do with this.”

She nodded. “Okay. Then I guess we just need to hope they get a break in the case. And when they come back, you ask for a lawyer right away. Don’t talk to them. Not one word, Dex. Not one word.”

I nodded. “I’m fucked, aren’t I? I have means, motive, and opportunity. I have no alibi.”

She sighed. “I don’t know. I’ll make some calls tomorrow. Get a criminal lawyer lined up.”

“That’ll just confirm things for them,” I noted.

“Yup.”

We dragged ourselves upstairs and went to bed. I don’t know that either of us slept a wink. I know I barely did.

In truth, despite my protestations, I wasn’t sure what I had done or not done. Since that first night, I’d been plagued by sleepwalking and semi-lucid dreams. I didn’t know where my gun was, but I knew I always kept the safe locked. And last night... I remembered pulling over and seeing the lights of downtown in front of me, which meant I was parked in a northwesterly direction. But I awoke with the sunrise in my eyes. At some point between when I remembered pulling over and when I woke up, I had driven the car, at least long enough to change its orientation. And if I could do that in my sleep, could I have killed a man as well?

I thought about those pictures Olivia had me send to the now-deceased Denny. How could I not? I’d been stuck in a room with them blown up on a 60-inch TV for three hours. I burned with

embarrassment as I recalled trying to explain them away, trying to pretend there was nothing particular or weird about sending another man pictures of my wife's tits, her juicy pussy, her tight asshole. I remembered Olivia and Denny reviewing the images carefully, so that Denny could decide which hole to defile first. And I remembered Olivia's claim that she would have let Denny sodomize her if I'd wanted. After all, *it wouldn't be the first time* she'd gotten fucked up the ass. I remembered her going off with Zach, and coming home with a finger-blasted pussy and a claim to have swallowed four loads of come. And most of all, I remembered her cries of passion as Mitch fucked her. It was enough to make any man crazy... or even murderous.

And yet... I knew I hadn't done it. Even as my conscious mind accused my unconscious, I knew there was another layer, another barrier. That as crazy as Olivia was making me, I wouldn't kill a man, couldn't kill a man.

I woke up in bed with Olivia. She was already awake and looking at me.

"I'm sorry," she said. "This was all my fault."

"No. What?"

"I...", she let out a soft sob, "I behaved like a stupid schoolgirl at the reunion, mooning over an old crush, a long-ago fling. I..."

"O, no. No, don't say that. You were just being honest with your feelings, and I liked it. I liked the idea that my ol' married wife still had that sort of fire inside her. I still find it hot. It hurts, but God, I've felt more alive over the past couple of weeks than I have in years."

"It should have stayed a fantasy."

I laughed. "Maybe. But until poor Denny got himself killed, I think we were both enjoying the ride. You did enjoy the things you did, didn't you? You didn't just do it for me?"

Tears ran down her cheeks even as she smiled. "Yes."

"I did too. Even if we never do anything like this again, I'll never forget how hot it was to see you come in the reflected glow of the

fireworks. It was... magical.”

She laughed. “Men are strange.”

I gave her a quick kiss. “We are.”

We both called in sick. Olivia made some phone calls to get names of good criminal defense lawyers. In the meantime, I obsessively read every news story and social media post I could find on the Dennis Jennings murder, and when I had exhausted those, I researched the man himself.

He was 57 at the time of his death. He sold vinyl siding. He was married with two grown kids. He had Broncos season tickets, and tailgated before home games with the same group of people for over twenty years. If he had any weird vices, they were invisible to the naked eye. As far as the cops would know, he was living a perfectly normal life until he crossed paths with me and my wife.

I was clicking back on the Post’s website when a breaking news alert appeared: “Body Discovered in Sloan Lake Park.”

An early morning jogger came across the body of a brutally murdered young man concealed in the woods beside the path in Sloan Lake Park. Police have identified the victim as Edgewood resident, Zachary Beauregard, 24. Beauregard had been beaten and was shot at least once at close range. Police are seeking witnesses who might have seen the victim in the early morning hours.

There was no picture, so I Googled the name. And there he was. Zach. Our Zach. The Zach who had blown four loads of come in my wife’s mouth in an Uber.

“Olivia....”

My tone brought her over quickly.

“Oh my God,” she gasped.

“We need to get out of here,” I said. “Right now, they’re wondering about this second weird murder, but in a matter of hours they’ll find out about the Uber ride that dropped you off here.”

“You didn’t go anywhere last night, I’m your alibi.”

“You’re my wife. And,” I said, wincing, “a cheating whore who offers her ass to strangers in bars and blows men in the back of an Uber.”

She nodded. “I don’t sound like a credible witness,” she admitted. “Okay, so lawyer up?”

“Once they learn about the Uber, they won’t even look at other motives or suspects. They’ll just build the case against me. And it is a strong case. No. We need to go underground and figure this shit out.”

“Dex, we don’t know anything about investigating a crime. The closest I came was a criminal law clinic when I was a second year.”

“Right, but what choice do we have? If we don’t shake loose something, no one will.”

“I don’t know. If we run, it is like an admission of....” She stopped talking, but I could tell she was trying to process something.

“What?”

“Dex, this isn’t random. You might not be the killer, but it is connected to us... to me. Two men I was involved with sexually are dead, and....”

“Mitch,” I said. “We have to warn him.”

“Oh God.”

“You call Mitch,” I said. “And that’s it. Then we go. Leave all our electronics behind. No credit cards. Just cash and the clothes on our back. We’ll drive downtown and stash the car in the lowest level of a garage and then move around on foot or by public transport. We need a little time to work this out.”

She nodded. “Okay, okay.”

While Olivia called Mitch, I packed two backpacks with essentials. But what are essentials in a case like this? I settled on a change of clothes, toiletries, flashlights, canteens. I packed a pair of binoculars that Olivia had bought when she tried to get into birding.

As I prepared, I tried to work through the logistics of going underground. In the modern world, we are constantly broadcasting our locations. Cell phones, chips in credit cards and work badges, IP addresses. We could buy food with cash, but that was basically the

one of life's necessities that didn't require some sort of electronic activity. What would we do for shelter?

When I returned, Olivia had changed into jeans and a t-shirt. I tossed her a ballcap, and wore one myself.

"I couldn't reach him," she said.

"Copy out your contacts and take a hardcopy," I said, doing the same with my own phone.

Then we stacked our electronics on the kitchen table along with all our chipped and RFID-enabled credit cards and IDs. The small pile represented a shocking percentage of our engagement with the rest of the world, and leaving all of that behind felt like a leap into the great unknown.

"It's okay," I said. "We'll be back soon."

She nodded, and I wondered if she, like me, was skeptical about that happy talk. There was a killer out there, linked to us somehow. The cops were after me. Ever coming back to my home seemed like a distant third compared to the possibility of ending up either dead or in jail.

"Let's go," I said.

Chapter Eleven: On the Lam

Olivia was quiet as we drove down out of our neighborhood.

"You know," I said, "only I need to go into hiding."

She shook her head. "I'm less concerned about the cops for myself, and more worried about the guy killing people connecting to me."

"Sorry, you're right. Torres and Land got me so rattled that...."

"We need to get unrattled. We need to approach this and think it through clearly."

I nodded but let her continue. I recognized her tone and knew she was hooked on to something.

"Dex, who knew about Denny and Zach?"

"The only person I said anything at all to was Trip."

"And we know that Tracey knew because he told her some, and I confirmed other parts as well. Val knows some of it," she acknowledged, "and so do Mitch and Denise. But... I didn't even know their last names or where they lived or anything. We had Denny's phone number, but even if you showed Trip the pictures—"

"I didn't."

"It's okay if you did, Dex. I mean, it's not *okay* okay to do it without my permission, but I know that's part of the fantasy. *Hey, Bro, check out my hot wife,*" she said the latter in a generic male imitation.

"I didn't. I'd tell you if I did."

"Well, even if you had shown him the pictures, it wouldn't explain how he would know who they were."

"I'm pretty sure I never even said the names Denny and Zach... oh fuck, I did show Trip a picture of you and Denny at the bar. Think that was it?"

She shook her head. "I don't know. Seems far-fetched. But maybe you gave Trip enough to track down Denny, but then what about Zach? And anyway, why would Trip want to kill two men?"

"I don't think this is a motive, but I know he's been jealous of our sex life."

"You've been bragging?"

"Well yeah, of course."

She shook her head and grinned. "That seems like a thin reed. But okay, we have to keep Trip on the list."

"List?"

"Of suspects," she explained.

"Right, right," I said. But the more I thought about it, the more likely it seemed to me that I should be on the top of that list. "It's almost as if someone had been shadowing us and saw you meet those guys. Then, via conservation, or picking up a credit card slip, or whatever, they could identify the men. Like a stalker or something."

"Oh God," she gasped. "Dex, take me to the library. I need to use their computers."

"What, what is it?"

"Just... just do it. I swear I'll explain, but I need to check something. Drop me off and take care of the other things we need."

"Um... okay," I said.

I did as she asked. After she ran inside the public library, I made quick stops at the bank to take out as much cash as the ATM allowed, and the drug store to pick up a half-dozen burner cells that would be our lifeline to the outside world.

By the time I returned, Olivia was standing outside the library clutching several sheets of paper and looking pale and shaky.

"Jesus, O, what's the matter?"

"Just drive."

"What's going on?"

"I'll explain everything, but for now, I need you to concentrate on the road and look out for anyone following us."

"Oh... right."

"Mix things up," she said. "Switch lanes. Drive around a block. Pull into a parking lot. Pull a U-turn and then another a few blocks later. I'll keep an eye out for any cars following us."

"Okay, okay."

We didn't actually have any training in evading surveillance. I knew she was just channeling the innumerable cops shows and spy

novels we'd consumed over the years. It was stressful and slow going, and I was continually conscious of the fact that it was only a matter of time until the cops linked Zach's murder back to us, and then we'd be the subject of a manhunt. The sooner we abandoned our car, the better. But then again, we didn't want to ditch our car only to come face-to-face with a killer who seemed to have some personal gripe with us.

We finally made it downtown. I parked in the lower level of the convention center lot. We sat in the car for a couple of minutes to see if anyone followed us, but it seemed the coast was clear.

"Olivia, what is going on?"

She peered up at me and I saw her eyes were red. "This is all my fault."

"O?"

She took a deep breath.

"I need to tell you about Mac."

"Mac?"

"Sean MacDonald. He was the third man who I cheated on with Mitch, but it's much, much worse than that."

She took another deep breath.

"Second year of law school, I took a criminal law clinic. Basically, we were assigned to a public defender, and we shadowed him or her and did some research and drafting on a couple of cases. I was assigned to work with a guy named Ellis Drews. Ellis was a youngish guy at the time early-thirties, and actually he's someone I think might be a good person to contact once we're ready to go to a lawyer. PDs work an assembly line process. They have, like forty minutes, per client. They only meet most of their clients right before a court date. It is totally fucked up. But part of the idea of the clinic was to give us not just a taste for how the world really works, but also how it ought to work in theory. So, in addition to the conveyor belt, we got to review the upcoming cases and select a couple for more in-depth research.

"So, first day, Ellis hands me a stack of folders and tells me to pick out two or three to focus on. So I go through them. Tons of drug cases, some DWI repeats, a couple of aggravated assaults, a sexual

assault, some burglaries. Anyway, I pick out two. One is this woman who is accused of a weapons charge, and the other is this young guy who was booked on grand theft auto, drug possession, and assaulting a cop. That's Mac. And of course, that was my first lesson. I went through a tall stack of files, filled with black and Hispanic male defendants, and the two who caught my eye were a middle-aged woman and a white man.

"I don't remember what happened with the woman. I think the charges got dropped at some point. So I was left with Mac. The first time we met, it was the three of us, me, Ellis, and Mac. Mac was tall, good looking with a sort of bad boy sneer. He had a scar on his cheek below the ear. Long, straight hair. Tattoos on his forearms. His juvenile record was sealed, but it was obvious from the gaps in his history that he'd been in trouble early and often, and as an adult he had arrests for aggravated assault, which was dropped, and a felony vandalism that might have been related to a botched B&E. That's what caught my eye. Poor kid, tough upbringing, blah blah blah.

"Anyway, Ellis explains the deal. He has a plea offer from the prosecutor in hand. They'll toss the drug charge because, in theory, the drugs might have been in the car before he stole it, and they'll reduce the assault to a resisting arrest. But given his record, he's still looking at a five-year sentence, so maybe thirty-six months assuming he doesn't fuck things up in prison. Or, Ellis tells him, we can go to trial, and he gets charged with the whole nine yards and if convicted is looking at minimally ten years in the can.

"So Mac starts talking. He says he borrowed the car from a friend and the traffic stop that nabbed him was bogus and when the drugs were found, the friend claimed the car was stolen, so the drugs couldn't be tied to him, and the assault was just Mac trying to explain... and you know, these guys are good. They're bullshit artists. But I swear, Dex, it sounded convincing. Like, the whole bit about the prosecution being willing to drop the drug charge. Mac's point was, they'd only offer to drop it if it was bogus, and it would be bogus if his story was true. He says he wants to fight it. So Ellis shrugs and says fine. "My colleague, Ms. Jensen, will be working with you to develop the case." And that's that. We go to arraignment.

He pleads not guilty, and we get a trial date. Ellis gives me a prep sheet to work on.”

Olivia sighed deeply. I could see where this was going now, and I was tempted to stop her, but the demons inside of me also wanted to hear the story. I waited, and she continued.

“I start visiting Mac. And I don’t know if you know what a jail meeting room is like, but basically just a table, some chairs. You can request the prisoner be handcuffed or that you have a no-contact meeting, like with a glass shield, but it’s not like this guy was Hannibal Lecter, and anyway, cons are usually smart enough to know that harassing their lawyer is a super dumb move. And in theory, there’s a window the guards can look through to keep an eye on you, but in general they don’t give a fuck what the inmates are up to.

“So it’s just him and me. And I’m trying to work through Ellis’s sheet—documenting Mac’s story, putting together witness lists—but Mac’s always got a story. Gift of gab. Irish roots and all. I keep having to go back to get everything I need, and in the meantime I get his life’s story... or some version of it. Dad was a no-show. Mom drank. Her boyfriends beat him. White kid in a mostly black neighborhood, so all the shit that goes with that. Shitty circumstances, shitty luck, shitty friends. At one point, he meets a girl. They’re both in a bad place, but they’re working together to make things better, and then she ODs....”

“And...” Olivia took another deep breath. “And, he starts crying. And just instinctively, I gave him a hug. And the hug turned into a kiss. And the kiss... well, before I knew it, I’m up on the table, with my legs spread, and he is just pounding the shit out of me. Like really hard, really fast, and he’s....”

“Big,” I said. “He’s the one guy bigger than Mitch, right?”

She nodded. “Yeah, and it’s really hitting me just right. And the whole situation... it was fucking hot.”

“One of the top five?” I asked, recalling that conversation as well.

“Yup. And again, it wasn’t that it was sooo good. But just the whole thing pushed all sorts of kink buttons. Handsome prisoner. In

jail. The risk of being busted at any moment if a guard happened to peek in. It was quick. Just a few minutes, but I came like five times. I basically ran away immediately after. It was mortifying. Getting out of a jail takes forever. Gates, doors, ID checks. And the whole time I felt like everyone knew what I'd done, and that I'd forever be known as the naive, blonde law student who fucked an inmate. Mortifying, but also unaccountably exciting."

"Sort of like being the guy whose wife picks up strange men in bars."

We shared a moment. A gaze. A smile.

"I told myself I wouldn't go back, that I'd drop the class, just pretend it didn't happen."

"But you did go back."

She nodded again. "It was hot. Addictive. I went back every day. We didn't even pretend to work on the case. I'd put on slutty underwear, or no underwear. I'd get on my knees and blow his big prick, and then we'd fuck. Part of it was that I knew it was just a crazy, temporary thing. He was going to prison for the next few years. You know, two ships passing in the night. But then, a fucking crazy thing happened. The friend, the one whose car Mac stole, got busted with a pound of coke, which both supported Mac's story, and blew up the friend as a witness for the prosecution, and instead, the prosecutors offered to drop the charges on Mac if he testified against his friend. And bam, just like that, he was free."

"Ooof. So much passing in the night," I said.

"It gets worse. He had nowhere to live. So...."

"He moved in with you."

She shook her head as if she still couldn't believe it. "I couldn't say no. He needed help, and I was all into rescuer mode, and the sex was still crazy. So yeah. And it was okay for a while, but you know, he was a fuck up. He didn't have a job, so I supported him on my part-time job and the money my parents sent to help with school. He'd get drunk and get into fights. He never beat me, but he could get scary. Angry, moody. He was always very demanding sexually, and when he was in his moods...."

"He's your anal experience, isn't he?" I asked.

She nodded. "And more. He... uh... sometimes shared me with his friends."

"Oh God, Olivia, why didn't you tell me? I'm so sorry, I'd have never suggested—"

She put her hand on my chest. "No. Don't be. It isn't like you triggered some PTSD. To be honest, it was hot. I'd be blowing one of his friends, and he'd be stroking his big prick. And then they'd take turns with me. It was... fun." She sighed. "Until I realized he wasn't doing it because it turned him on, but rather because he was charging his friends."

"Oh, Olivia."

She laughed darkly. "Yup. I'm sorry Dex. I should have told you sooner."

"You don't need to apologize for the shitty things some asshole did to you."

"Maybe, but you had a right to know you were marrying a literal whore."

"Don't."

She shrugged. "It's true though. And I didn't leave right away when I found out. I kept doing it for a while. I didn't quite know how to get out, who to talk to. And then, one day I ran into Mitch and his girlfriend, at a club. And we exchanged numbers, and, well, the same thing happened that always seems to happen when Mitch and I run into each other."

"You ended up in bed," I said.

"Bed. Back seat of the car. Bar bathroom. We were both living with other people at the time. And of course, Mac found out. And he got really, really angry. Which was fucked up because he was still offering me up to his buddies."

"But not getting his pimp's cut," I said.

"Or a control issue. Whatever. One night, he was hammered, and he told me he'd kill me if I saw Mitch again. That he'd kill Mitch too. The next day, when he was sober, I worked up the courage to confront him. I told him to get out. And after a long standoff, he did. He went to a bar. And got into a fight. He killed a man by beating him to death with a pool cue. And now...."

She handed me a printout of a data table with one row highlighted.

Sean MacDonald. 2nd Degree Murder. WP Release Date: June 12, 2020.

"He just got out," I said.

"Yeah. And he's stalking me and killing men I have sex with."

"But, why didn't he kill me first?" I asked.

"Maybe he likes the idea of making you the fall guy? Who knows? But my murderer ex-boyfriend gets out of prison, and two weeks later people start dying around me. That is a heck of a coincidence, isn't it otherwise?"

"So we go to the cops?"

She shook her head. "We need more. This will just seem like a desperate gamble, and we at least need to see if we can figure out where he's been. But before that, we need to reach Mitch and warn him."

Chapter Twelve: The Hollow

I know it makes me a sick fuck, but her story got me hot. I would have loved to fuck my wife right there in the parking garage, bent over the hood of the car so that as I enjoyed her juicy pussy I could look at her tight, little anus and imagine Mac's huge prick stretching it out.

Olivia's suspicions about Mac, though, left little time for fooling around. Two men were already dead, and for all we knew Mitch was next. I hid the car keys in the well of a support beam. And right before we left I remembered to grab the ExpressPass transmitter. I tossed that into the back of a pickup driving by as we exited the parking garage. If Torres tried to track that it would lead him on a merry chase. We crossed the street and went to Sculpture Park and sat beneath some trees with a view of The Dancers, a weird Slenderman-esque pair, and no less creepy for being light rather than dark.

We got our prepaid phones working, and she tried calling Mitch again.

"Fuck," she grumbled. "Still no."

I'd been doing my own research. "If we hurry, we can catch the next bus down to Colorado Springs. At the very least, that would put some distance between us and Torres and Land. And also we might be able to hide out at their place for the night."

"What about Mac?"

"Well, if we're right, that's where he is as well," I said.

She nodded. We got up and jogged the quarter mile to the bus station and managed to get the CDOT South just as it was about to leave.

With an hour and a half to kill during the drive, we continued to try to fit the pieces together.

"Okay, so he's been thinking of you all these years. And he's obsessed. He gets out and tracks you down."

Olivia picked up the story, "He sees I'm married with kids. Won't be easy to get me back, unless he gets you out of the picture."

"If he kills me, he probably just ends up back in jail. And anyway, he wants to prime you to want him back. Showing up suddenly after your husband is murdered is likely to raise your suspicions."

"Right," she said. "So he's biding his time. He follows us; he does his research. Maybe he's hoping he can catch you screwing around on me. Maybe he's hoping we're already on the rocks."

"So, he's in the bar the night you flirt with Denny. If he's following us, he knows we banged in the alley afterward, so he realizes we're playing some sort of kinky game. He gets the idea that maybe he can frame me for some sort of jealousy-inspired murder. A crime of passion. When he sees you go off with Zach the following week, he knows he can put the plan into motion."

She nodded, and then asked, "Dex, what about the gun?"

"Okay. So... I've been thinking about this. He's stalking you, casing us. He sees the party setup, and he decides this is a perfect opportunity to get inside our house and find something to use as part of his plan. Maybe he's thinking of stealing something of mine and planting it at the scene. For all we know, he did exactly that. Hairs from my comb or whatever. But then as he's searching through our house, he finds the gun safe. And then he remembers he noticed a combination written down in my desk drawer. He carefully opens the safe, making sure not to disturb the dust, and steals my Sig Sauer. Now all he has to do is make sure the gun is found after the murders are done."

"That's a lot of moving parts," she said.

"Well, you said he was a burglar back in the day. It's within his skill set. And there were enough people in and out of the house, that we really might not have noticed one slightly unfamiliar person. Especially since we were both distracted much of the time."

"Jesus, this is like something out of a movie."

"Yeah, but those are inspired by real life, and vise-versa."

She stared out the window toward the mountains to the West.

"What are we going to do if we find him?" she asked.

"Mac?"

She nodded.

"I don't know. We'll need to be careful before we approach him. And we'd better hope he doesn't come to us first. In the meantime, I just want to make sure no one else dies, especially your favorite loverboy, Mitch."

She chuckled. "You did get your wish, Honey. You got added to the list of people I've cheated on with Mitch."

"Yeah, I'm not sure that's such a big deal. I sort of think that anyone who is with you long enough ends up on that list. Speaking of which, try him again. There's a stop coming up at Castle Rock, and if he's safe we might decide to cut the trip short."

She dialed his number again. "Still nothing. He might not be answering a call from a strange number. And the texts I've sent aren't showing up as delivered."

"Try Denise?"

"I don't have her number."

"Facebook?"

"Can they track that if I log into my account?"

"Probably," I said. "But this is still a local murder case. I bet they don't have that kind of resources immediately available."

Our burners weren't exactly the most up-to-date devices, but despite that she managed to log in. She was friends with Mitch, but not Denise, so she had to friend-request Denise first. Luckily Mitch's wife apparently had notifications enabled because she accepted the request quickly. Olivia fired off a Facebook message.

<Olivia>: Hi Denise. Thanks for accepting the friend request. We are trying to get in touch with Mitch, but he's not answering his phone or texts.

<Denise>: God, you are a little slut, aren't you? You're not actually entitled to his dick, you know.

My wife showed me the message and rolled her eyes.

I shrugged, "You can see why she might be skeptical of any emergency you might have."

<Olivia>: I swear it isn't that. We think he might be in danger. And we need to reach him. Could you ask him to call me?

<Denise>: Whatever. He's not answering. He's hiking in Red Rock Canyons. He might have turned off his phone. He likes to

commune with nature sometimes.

"You think she's yanking my chain?" Olivia asked.

"Could be. But at least we know where to go once we arrive. Give Denise your number just in case she needs to reach us."

I could tell that the exchange had made Olivia anxious. "I'm sure he's all right," I said.

She took a deep breath. "I hope so. The last time I saw Mac was when we fought over Mitch. If he spent the last decade obsessing about me, then he was surely doing the same about Mitch. If I don't fuck Mitch, we don't fight. If we don't fight, he doesn't end up in a bar, in a foul mood, and end up killing a guy in a fight. It wouldn't be shocking if he blamed Mitch for everything."

"If that's true, then why not kill Mitch first?"

She shook her head. "I don't know. He might not have known how to find Mitch. He only focused on Denny and Zach because he saw them with me."

"So, why do we think he's tracked down Mitch now?"

"I don't know," she replied. "I... fuck... I wish Mitch would answer his fucking phone. Right now, all I know is that he's somewhere on a secluded hike, out of touch. I don't know if he's safe or in danger, but I know I won't be able to relax until we make contact."

"We will," I said, patting her hand.

She resumed staring out the window, and I glared at the road ahead through the windshield. She was right. We did need to at least warn Mitch, but I couldn't shake an uneasy feeling about her response. He would always have a special place in her heart, and that was more difficult for me to handle than her sexual desire for him. It was just like when they were in our bed. The memory of him pounding the hell out of my wife at the climax of the fireworks show was hot as hell. The memory of their gentle lovemaking, kisses, and tender whispers in the calm before the storm left me feeling queasy.

We arrived at the Tejon Park-n-Ride and took a cab the four miles through the historic town to the entrance to Red Rock Canyon. Despite the name, it was more a city park than anything backwoods. There were large, open, grassy spaces with kids and dogs and young people on blankets drinking wine, though to the west, the park rose into a series of low, but steep hills, crisscrossed with paths. It seemed less menacing than some sort of primeval forest or mountains might have been, but it was also easy to imagine a stalker following his prey unnoticed until the right moment arose.

“Where do we start?” I asked.

Olivia pointed toward the hills. “Let’s see if we can’t get a better view from up there.”

We filled out canteens and took the Sand Canyon Trail out of the parking lot and began a gentle climb until we branched onto the Contemplative Trail that was a little more isolated and wound between two low, red rock ridges.

“We won’t see much from here,” I said.

“Yeah, but she said something about communing with nature. Maybe she meant he liked the Contemplative Trail?”

“I think you’re reaching.”

She shrugged. “I think at this point, we’re operating as much on instinct as anything else, aren’t we?”

“True enough.”

I had the binoculars around my neck, and I used them to try to identify any of the relatively few hikers who had come this way. There were several who could have been Mitch. The same basic look, tall, outdoorsy, fit, but none was our man. Our cell signal was awful, but whenever we managed to get any bars, Olivia tried Mitch’s cell. But still nothing.

We continued to the end of the trail and then followed it onto Roundup, which quickly turned into a series of switchbacks separated by swathes of thick woods. Although not large, the park was deceptively rugged, and I began to realize the folly of two inexperienced searchers finding anyone in particular. It was also hot. First week in July hot. And I’d already gone through about a third of my canteen.

"We'd be better off if we had a helicopter," I noted.

"You're not being helpful," Olivia snapped. "This way," she said pointing in a vaguely southerly direction, deeper still into the park.

I followed. And my anxiety grew. Something was wrong. Something was off. I had a vague sense that we were being watched or followed. Olivia marched on ahead, much more decisively than I felt the situation warranted.

"Um, where are we going?" I asked.

"We're trying to find Mitch."

"I know, but—"

"You want to go sit in the shade while I search, Dex? Go ahead."

I remained with her, but that little nagging doubt in the back of my mind wouldn't remain quiet. What did I really know about this whole Mac story? Only what she'd told me. It was odd that it had never come up before. I understand that it was embarrassing, but we'd been together for nearly twelve years. Doesn't, *hey, I used to date a guy who is locked up for murder*, come up at some point? We'd seen Val many times, and she must have known the story, but I couldn't remember her ever mentioning Mac. The closest thing to corroboration I had was Charlie's cryptic statement about Olivia not wanting to "review that part of her life." She had started working with him soon after the episode with Mac had occurred, so maybe he knew. But then again, would she really have been hired on if the firm knew that she'd been sleeping with a convict she was supposed to be representing?

There were so many coincidences, and all of the changes in our lives had begun with one moment. The night of the reunion. When my wife had laid eyes again on Mitch. Her high school crush. The one man who seemed able to make her betray all other relationships.

Where was she leading me? *My husband was mad with jealousy. He'd already killed two men because he thought I was flirting with them. He dragged me and Mitch to an isolated spot. He meant to kill us. But we were lucky. We surprised him. There was a fight, but Mitch managed to disarm him.*

“Here!” she said.

She scampered down the hill into a low hollow beneath an overhang of rock, surrounded by a copse of tall, spindly, Lodgestone pine.

He was waiting there. I knew it. With my gun. Who else could have realistically stolen it but Olivia? He’d shoot me. Self-defense. It was my gun after all, so I must have been the one who brought it.

I should run, yet I knew I couldn’t. He’d catch me. And I had no intention of dying in flight. If Olivia and her lover were going to kill me, they’d have to look me in the eyes when they did it.

I followed my wife down into the cool, dark creek bed. I hoped they’d at least have the decency to have my body recovered, and not just leave it to scavengers. Twigs cracked beneath my feet. I reached the bottom and found Olivia staring at me, hands on hips, a thin smile on her lips.

“I thought he’d be here,” she said. “We came here once. And for some reason, I thought....”

I scanned my surroundings anxiously.

“Olivia? What are you talking about?”

“I don’t know. Dex.... I just... had this feeling. Mitch and I hiked in this park once. Years ago. It was after Mac went away. After... I had some rough times when the whole thing with Mac blew up. For a while, I felt like I just wanted to run away from everything that had gotten all fucked up. I took a semester off from school. I drank too much. I had bad sex with the wrong men because, honestly, I didn’t think a right man would want to be with me. I felt broken. Mitch reached out. Val did. Charlie did. And I alternated between lashing out, pushing them away, and then pulling them close. Too close sometimes. Mitch took me down here to get away a little. We hiked this part, and other trails. It took me a while to realize he was trying to tell me something difficult. I thought it was like an intervention or something, but it was that he’d met this girl, and he thought she was special, and....”

“Denise?”

She nodded, shaking loose a tear that tracked down her cheek.

“I threw myself at him. I played it off like a lark. You know, a last fling. *Before you settle down with that slut, you need to give me one last taste of that big cock.* He was young. I can be persuasive. Of course, I was hoping that he’d realize I was his true love. We had sex down in this hollow. It was... awful.” She laughed. “The one time being with Mitch was bad. I was trying too hard. Doing porn star shit like gagging on his dick, talking dirty. No connection. And after he was totally bummed out and almost looked ready to cry. And I was all brassy. *Yeah, you’ll be thinking about that on your wedding night.*”

“Olivia... none of this is your fault.”

“I know,” she said airily.

“No, seriously. I don’t know what the heck is going on. I don’t know if Mac is the solution or just a dead end. I don’t know if Mitch is in danger or not. But there is nothing you did that caused any of this. Not anything you did last week. Or a decade ago.”

“How do you know that?”

“Because, it doesn’t matter what you did or didn’t do. Whoever is behind this is fucked up. Deranged. And we’re going to make ourselves crazy if we try to explain it. To make it make sense. To find the things we did, or didn’t do, to make it happen. That doesn’t matter. All that matters is figuring out who is doing this and to try to keep ourselves and other people safe. But to do that, we need to trust each other. Even if that means we will ourselves to do that. Because if we can’t trust each other, then we’re doomed.”

She looked at me pensively. I knew she was still wondering about the gun. Whether I might be harboring a homicidal jealousy beneath my apparent excitement at our game. And I had all of these questions about her and Mitch. But there was nothing to do but to take a leap of faith. We each needed to trust someone, and we were what we had.

“I trust you,” she said.

“I trust you too,” I replied. “Let’s get out of here and find some reception.”

She nodded. I took her hand and we climbed out of the hollow toward the ridgeline above.

As we crested the hills, and could see Colorado Springs laid out ahead of us, Olivia's cell phone rang.

"Hello," she answered. She breathed a deep sigh and her knees nearly buckled in relief. "Oh God, I'm so glad you're okay." She nodded as she listened. "I know. I'm sorry. We were just worried. Where are you?" And then, "Oh, okay, we're here too." She turned toward me and whispered, "He's in the parking lot." Then back to him, "We'll be back in 40 minutes. And Mitch? Don't just wait for us. Get in your car, drive around. We'll call again when we're close. We'll explain everything in person."

She hung up the phone. "He got all of the messages of the call notifications all at once when he turned his phone back on. Denise is apparently furious."

"Yeah, well you can't blame her, I guess."

Chapter Thirteen: Pursuit

We rushed back to the parking lot. It was mostly downhill, which made the going easier, but we were both covered in sweat, breathing hard, and out of water by the time we scooted past the pavilion and heard the dogs barking happily at the dog loop. Olivia called Mitch, and we effected a rapid pick up. Olivia hopped in the front of his Suburban and I stretched out in the back. She scanned the parking lot anxiously and didn't relax until we were on Route 24. I studied the cars behind us to try to see if we were being followed.

"Um, are you two okay?" he asked.

"Did those murders in Denver make the news down here?" she asked.

"Murders? I don't know. Aren't there murders every day up in Denver?"

"You've turned into a provincial down here, Mitch," Olivia teased. She sighed. "Okay, let's start from scratch."

"How far is your home?" I asked.

"Just a few minutes."

"Why don't we wait to explain with Denise?" I suggested. "She needs to hear all of this too."

We drove the remaining couple minutes in awkward silence.

Denise shot us daggers as we followed Mitch inside. Both Olivia and I mumbled apologies. We told her we needed to talk, and she settled the kids with their screens and joined us on their porch. Mitch got some beers and set them out. I took a deep swallow, soon regretting it, as it immediately went to my head. We hadn't eaten since breakfast, and a couple of hours of dehydrating hiking didn't help either. Seeing my reaction, Mitch went back into the kitchen and returned with bottled water and a bowl of trail mix.

"Are we all comfy now?" Denise asked.

"Okay... so here goes," Olivia began.

She'd obviously been working through the details in her head, because she presented a tight recitation of events. She left nothing out. Denise listened disapprovingly as Olivia described her emotions

at spending time with Mitch at the reunion. Denise shot me a quick, *I-told-you-so* gaze. Denise's expression became bemused as Olivia related the encounter with Denny in the bar and detailed her time with Zach. I knew she wanted to make sure they fully understood the situation, but it also felt like an act of penance. Her description of the party was shorter, they had been there after all.

Denise chuckled when Olivia glossed over her time in bed with Mitch, and then teased her husband. "I told you, Honey, you were just a stunt cock."

"Be nice," he replied. "You had your own fun."

Denise noticed my grin and raised a questioning eyebrow at me.

"I'm sorry. I watched you and Val for a while."

"Interesting," she said. "So you're a voyeur and only like to get involved in the messy aftermath?"

I blushed. Mitch came to my defense. "They're new to this. Still figuring it out."

"Well, he's new to it at least," Denise noted. "Your girlfriend's been around the block a few times, right?"

Olivia nodded. "We think my past may have come back to haunt us." She turned to Mitch. "Did you tell her about me and Mac?"

Mitch looked shocked. "No, of course not, and you don't need to—"

"I do need to." She told the story about Mac, although I noticed that here she did go light on the details. Those were apparently still very painful, though she did pointedly admit that she'd "done a lot of things that I'm not proud of."

Denise turned sympathetic. She cupped Olivia's hand. "You were young. And good dick scrambles the brain."

Olivia took a deep breath. "Mac was released from prison three weeks ago. Denny and Zach were murdered over the past 72 hours. Denny on Sunday morning early. Zach was found this morning. They'd been abused and then shot."

Denise tilted her head. "What?" Then to Mitch, "Did you know?"

He shook his head. "Not until I picked them up, and I'm just hearing the details."

Denise yanked back her hand. "And... what, you think this psycho ex of yours is tracking down the guys you've fucked recently?"

Olivia looked down, and I answered for her. "Something like that. We think he might have been stalking Olivia, and—"

"Why did you come here?" Denise shrieked.

"We tried to call. We wanted to make sure Mitch was safe."

"But if this psycho is following you... then... you led him here."

"We didn't know what else to do," Olivia said.

Denise's eyes went wide. "How about the fucking cops?"

"They think I did it," I replied.

"Did you? I mean, that is the obvious conclusion," Denise said.

"I don't think so."

"Think?" She turned on her husband. "Mitch, I swear to God, if this crazy skank and her looney hubby bring any harm to this family, I'll...."

She rose and stormed off in a huff.

Olivia placed her hands over her face. "I'm sorry, Mitch. Fuck. She's right. We need to go."

"We were just trying to...." I trailed off.

Mitch rose and I stood as well. "I don't know what you're mixed up in. But you need to keep us out of it."

Olivia sighed. "Mitch. We think he might have been in the house during the party. He could easily have seen us go off. And, Mitch, he already knows about you. He and I had been fighting the day he killed a man and got sent to prison. We were fighting because he knew I had been to see you. We couldn't just wait and hope that we got through to you on our prepaid phones. We... I... couldn't just sit on my hands and hope you didn't get killed."

"You need to go," he said. "Denise and I will take the kids somewhere safe. Don't try to find us. Don't communicate with us." He paused. "How are you keeping away from the cops?"

"We left all our electronics and credit cards at home. We ditched our car. We're living on cash and... whatever we need to do," I answered.

"Do you have a weapon?" he asked.

“No, we think he may have stolen my gun and is using it to commit the crimes.”

He glanced at Olivia, silently communicating his suspicion that I was the psycho. She shook her head. He considered the situation for a moment.

“Okay,” he sighed. “I’ll be right back. Wait here.”

He disappeared into the basement. I had a sense that he might be calling the police. In truth, that is very likely what I would have done had I been in his shoes. I kept my concerns to myself. He returned after a few minutes with a small bag.

“I know you think this Mac guy knows about me, but do the cops?”

Olivia shook her head. “I don’t think so.”

“Okay, take this credit card. It’s a spare. We only use it if our regular card glitches or something. You’re going to need it to survive. Trying to live on cash, especially you two, nice white bread couple, will look suspicious. Hopefully they don’t connect us all together.” He reached into the bag and pulled out a gun. “Take this. It’s registered to me, so just remember that. If you really came here to protect me, then....” he trailed off.

Olivia gestured toward me. “I’d shoot myself in the foot.”

I took the gun from Mitch. “I’ll only ever use it to protect Olivia.”

He nodded. “I’ll drive you back to the station.”

We didn’t speak on the short drive. He barely stopped and we hopped out. He sped off to be with his family.

“Well, we fucked that up,” Olivia said.

“No. He’s alive, and they’re going into hiding. I don’t know if we’ll catch Mac, but at least we won’t have to worry about Mitch, or his family, being harmed.”

We had some schnitzel and beers at the Edelweiss and then took the late bus back to Denver. We slept the whole way and only woke up when the bus lurched to its final stop.

It was only a little after 9pm, but it had been a long, long day. We decided to chance using Mitch's card and get a room at the Hampton Inn. I stayed outside as Olivia checked us in. If the desk clerk had any questions about the different last names on the card and her ID, she'd just play the "I didn't take my husband's name" gambit and dare him to make a fuss. He didn't. It was a slow Tuesday night, Olivia gave him a big smile, and anyway, he seemed more interested in whomever he was texting than his professional obligations.

In our room, Olivia checked to see if the news had any more coverage of the murders. Two gruesome murders with a roughly similar MO, had created a bit of a frenzy. The police said they were exploring the possibility of a connection, but they were vague otherwise. Behind the scenes, I knew that the fact that Olivia and I had run for it probably served to condemn me, and instead of looking for any other suspects, they were working on connecting the cases. The Uber ride would come up soon, and I knew that our faces would soon be on every newscast. Me as a murder suspect, Olivia as a possible victim of my murderous rage.

"We need to change our appearance," I said.

"I was thinking the same thing. I'll go get some supplies at the Walgreens. The cops probably have an APB out for you already."

"I don't like you being out alone."

"I'll be quick. And I'll keep to busy streets."

"He could have followed us. I didn't see anyone, but we didn't take any evasive measures today. And anyway, once he saw us get on the bus, he could have taken any route he wanted to meet us at our destination."

She gave me a quick kiss. "Don't open the door unless you know it is me. He doesn't want to kill me. You maybe, but if we're right, he wants me alive."

"Okay, you're probably right."

She peeked out the door in the hallway and seeing it was empty scooted toward the stairs.

I took out my phone and called Trip. He didn't pick up at first, but when I dialed a second time he answered.

"What?" he grumbled, apparently expecting a telemarketer.

"It's me."

"Jesus, Dex, where the fuck are you? What is going on? These two cops came by the office looking for you."

"What did you tell them?"

"The truth. That I didn't know where the fuck you were. What do they want? And where are you? Dude, we're in the home stretch on this bid, but you know how it is. Now is when they want to check that every fucking comma is in the right place. We need you here."

"Trip, I have bigger problems."

"Yeah, what is going on?"

"It's...." I hesitated. "It's best you don't know."

"Dex. Are you fucking nuts? I have no idea what you're mixed up in, but the cops are your friends. Whatever it is, get a good lawyer and tell the truth."

"You don't understand." I hesitated again, trying to figure out what I wanted to say. "Look, you're going to hear some weird shit about me. Just... Trip... just trust me. It isn't true. And...."

"What do you want me to tell the cops if they come back?"

"The truth."

"Which is?"

"Just the truth as you know it."

He sighed. "Dex, whatever it is, I can help."

I thought about Mitch and his family. Trip and Tracey had four kids. I couldn't get them mixed up in this.

"No. Just no. Trust me. You don't want to be involved."

"What am I supposed to do about the bid?"

"Looks like Markson is going to get his snout in the trough after all. Bring him in."

"Jesus, you must be in trouble. You sure?"

"Yeah. Honestly after the last couple of days, partnering with Markson is going to seem like a walk in the park."

He didn't speak for a few moments, then finally he said, "Dude, you don't need to do this... whatever it is... alone. You have friends."

"I'm not alone. I have Olivia. I'll be back. Just give me a little while. And get that fucking contract."

He laughed. "Yes sir." Then: "stay safe."
"Thanks man."

Olivia returned after about half an hour, although it felt like much longer. Mac may have wanted her alive, but that covered a lot of eventualities, including having her chained naked to a post in the basement of a crack house.

"Everything okay?" I asked.

"Yeah, come in the bathroom." She jangled a bag of purchases. "I've always wondered what you'd be like with dark hair," she said.

She cut my hair short and dyed it nearly black. My facial hair is fine and light enough that I don't shave every day, so she colored that dark as well. Adding a pair of low power reading glasses, and I looked suddenly a little like a Cuban poetry professor.

"What about you?" I said.

"I think I need to stay as I am."

"Olivia, this isn't—"

"Look, first of all the cops are looking mainly for you. Second, we're not trying to hide from Mac. We don't want him to surprise us, but we do want to find him. That's the only way we're going to gather any evidence on him. And to find him, I need to be that blonde girl he's been obsessing over for the past decade."

"And what if he *does* want that blonde girl dead?"

"He doesn't. We didn't even know he was out there. No, killing Denny and Zach was a means to an end, and if he'd just wanted revenge on me... well, he could have nabbed me at any time, done whatever he wanted, and dumped my body."

"We don't know what he wants."

"Right. But we're not going to get anywhere just trying to hide out. We have to make some assumptions and act on them. Cowering won't help."

"Olivia... maybe we should just go to the police."

"Their evidence is circumstantial, but solid enough to charge you. And if your gun turns up, mysteriously, and is the murder

weapon, then you're done."

"Okay. But look. Okay. So I go to jail. And I know, it's the rest of my life. But I'm alive. And you're alive. And our kids have parents. And...." I stopped before I choked up completely.

"He's a killer," she said. "And you going away to prison isn't going to satisfy him. If we can't bring him down...."

I nodded. She was right.

"We should get some sleep," I said. "It's been a long day. Tomorrow will be longer."

That lasted all of an hour.

"You awake?" she asked.

It was half-past midnight.

"Yup."

"I'm not going to be able to sleep. We should go out scouting for Mac."

"Where would we even start? I thought maybe we could figure out his parole officer and maybe social engineer that or something."

"Yeah, we can do that tomorrow. But for now, we can check out some of his old haunts, if they're still around. He used to hang at some bars around West Colfax, out near Lakewood. He's only been back in town a few weeks. I bet he's gravitating toward something familiar."

"Okay," I said. "Better than just lying here awake."

We got dressed again and headed downstairs. We left most of our stuff in the room, but I had Mitch's gun in my backpack. I took the packaging from all the hair care products and disposed of them down the hall. If we ever got tracked to that hotel room, I didn't want anyone to discover the cosmetic alterations we might have made to ourselves.

That eventuality came to pass sooner than either of us could have anticipated. As we walked out the front door and crossed the street to grab a cab by the Hyatt, a number of police cars with lights flashing, but no sirens, pulled up to our hotel. Detectives Torres and

Land arrived a moment later in an unmarked car. After a quick consultation, a bunch of cops fanned out through the lobby and to the rear door.

Olivia grabbed my hand. "We need to move!"

I let her drag me. I was momentarily numb. Somehow, in the past two or three hours we'd managed to draw interest.

"How'd they find us?" I murmured.

We slipped into the Hyatt and then back out the rear door. We looped around and headed back toward Colfax to find a taxi and get away from the area. We ditched our active phones as a precaution. I had luckily kept the other phones with me in the same backpack in which I carried Mitch's Glock, but all the rest of our stuff was still in the hotel room, and now gone.

Neither of us spoke during the cab ride. Part of it was that we didn't want the driver overhearing anything, but part of it, at least for me, was shock.

"Drop us off here," Olivia said suddenly.

We were still several blocks short of our destination. But I paid and got out with her.

"Why?"

"Dex, we need to get smarter. Did you make a call from that room?"

"Yeah, I called Trip, but how would they have that cell?"

She shrugged. "Who knows? And it might not have been the cell. We shouldn't have used Mitch's card. Just being used in a hotel in Denver might have triggered some algorithm. And, I wasn't careful about cameras when I went to the store. Might have gotten picked up by some facial recognition system."

"That feels paranoid."

"How do you explain the cops?"

"I don't know. Maybe they have some system to send out pictures to hotels and the check-in clerk spotted us."

"Right," she replied. "Or maybe Mac was following us and sent the cops in to grab you. Could be anything. We need to be more careful. Need to really be below the radar. So no need to take a cab

right to our destination. And there is nothing paranoid about this situation. There are dead bodies to prove that.”

“Okay, so what now?”

“We press. We have to realize that we’re on a tighter clock than we had even imagined.”

We stopped at the first bar we came to. It was a newer place, built into an old industrial building, and they’d kept some of the trappings of its previous incarnation, like the heavy girders running across the ceiling. But at ground level, it was modern and sleek, and seemed designed to attract a younger crowd, though late on a Tuesday night, there wasn’t much of a crowd at all. A young woman bartender with an eyebrow piercing was playing with her phone.

Olivia stopped us two steps in. “Not here.”

“What are we looking for?”

“Something that might have been around a decade ago. And with a bartender who wasn’t still in elementary school when Mac was last free.”

“On the other hand, he might want to hang out somewhere where people don’t know him.”

“Yeah, but that could be literally anywhere, so I think we’re better off acting on the assumption that he’s seeking something familiar.”

“Okay, lead on.”

We came to a second bar, tucked in on a smaller road off of Colfax. Iron Bar was written, appropriately enough, in wrought iron above the entrance. Olivia stopped me.

“I think... this was one of the places he used to go. Let me check it out first. If I don’t come out in a couple of minutes, you follow after. Pretend you don’t know me. The more distance we create between the on-the-run couple the cops are looking for, the better.”

I nodded. “Okay.”

Instead of standing on the street, I continued down the block and back, looking for anyone trailing us. I didn’t notice anything, but then again, I hadn’t suspected that we wouldn’t be safe, at least for the night, at the hotel. When Olivia didn’t reappear, I followed her in.

This bar was dingier, with low ceilings, wooden tables that bore the marks of heavy use, and a line of top-shelf liquor bottles with enough dust that it was obvious that rail drinks were the norm. It was also a bit more crowded as well with people who either didn't work early or for whom showing up more than a little hungover was considered if not acceptable, then at least not fireable.

Olivia was at the bar with a shot and beer chatting with the bartender. He was an older guy who seemed to be channeling Willie Nelson, though I wasn't close enough to see if he reeked of pot... though, of course, that is more the norm than the exception in Colorado nowadays

I sat down a few seats away from Olivia, not so close as to seem as if we knew each other, but maybe close enough to slide over if she showed me any interest. Willie glanced at me and then raised an eyebrow while subtly nodding toward Olivia. *Did you see what just walked in?*

She turned toward me. I smiled. She returned her attention to Willie without acknowledging me. I shrugged slightly.

He came over. I ordered a beer, and when he brought it he knocked on the bar. *On the house.* "I always give customers dibs," he said softly. But since I had apparently been unceremoniously been shot down, he was free to make his move. He returned to his spot in front of Olivia, and gave her a smile, which she reciprocated. He poured himself a shot to match hers. They clinked and downed them.

She sipped her chaser. She looked around. "Cool place. I like the vibe."

He chuckled. "It's a dive. Come here on the weekends, though, and then it's a dive with puke in the sinks."

Olivia laughed. "It's a bar. I'm sick of all those places that seem embarrassed about what they are. Like serving avocado toast changes the fact that people come in to get drunk. Selling an illusion, that you're hip or hot or stylish, but ultimately, people come for the booze."

"And to hook up."

"Really? Does that still happen? I thought all of that was on Tinder nowadays."

"You'd probably know better than me. I don't get a lot of swipe rights."

"Oh, I don't believe that," she replied flirtatiously.

"That's a nice ring," he said.

She wiggled her fingers. "My husband is very understanding."

"Is that so? Is that why you're here?"

"Well... maybe... thing is, I'm looking for an old friend. Was wondering if you might know him."

He laughed. "Oh, I knew this was too good to be true."

"Good looking guy."

"Of course."

"Tall. Lots of tats."

He laughed. "So not the kind of guy you usually see at the country club?"

"Do I seem like a country club kind of girl?"

He nodded, and pulled a bottle of Wild Turkey from the well. "Want another?"

She edged her glass in his direction. He refilled hers and his own.

"My friend's name is Sean. Goes by Mac."

Willie stiffened ever so slightly. *Jackpot*. He forced a smile. "I need to offer those rummies last call," he said.

Olivia and I exchanged a quick glance. She'd seen the same thing I had.

Willie returned.

"So... what did you say your name was?" He asked.

"I didn't. But it's Susan."

"Well, Suzie, see, part of the reason people hang out in a bar like this is that they're trying to get away from unwanted attention."

She batted her eyelashes. "Oh, he'll want to see me."

"Yeah, maybe yes, maybe no. Maybe your hubby ain't as understanding as you make it out. Or maybe you got yourself knocked up. Tell you what, you leave a name and number, and if

some guy named 'Sean, goes by Mac' shows up then I can let him know."

She smiled sweetly. "Maybe I can make it worth your while?"

"Yeah? How's that?"

She reached into her pocket and pulled out some twenties.

He laughed. "Oh, Sweetheart, I am not interested in your money."

"What are you interested in?"

"Why don't you give it a little thought and see what you come up with?"

He walked away to close out checks and wipe down tables.

Olivia threw me a questioning glance. I was exhausted and still shaken about the police arriving at the hotel. I couldn't tell if my heart was racing with excitement or anxiety. I wasn't sure if I was thinking with my brain or my dick. I gave her a quick nod.

She shook her head and grinned.

He returned.

"Well, Suzie?"

"How about I take you in the back and suck your dick until you blow your load down my throat?"

He looked around the bar.

She added, "You already served last call and passed out the checks. All you're doing is waiting around until it is time to kick out the drunks and lock the door. Might as well get your rocks off."

"Okay, slutty Suzie, let's do it."

"Mmm. You don't mind if I call my husband, do you? He likes to listen in."

"Not at all."

I took that as my cue to drop a ten on the bar and say goodbye. He didn't acknowledge me, which was fine. I hustled to the front door and took my phone out just as it began to vibrate.

"Hey."

"Frank, Baby, I met a guy. Not *the* guy, but *a* guy. Is that okay?"

I hoped that she had the presence of mind to ensure he couldn't hear my end of the conversation.

"Think this is our best chance to track down Mac?"

“Mmmm, Baby, yeah. I sure hope so. Do you mind?”

“If you’re okay, I’m okay.”

“Sounds good, Baby. Enjoy the sounds.”

I muted myself so that they wouldn’t hear me or the traffic as I walked up and down the block. I probably should have ducked into a doorway, but at 2:00am in a somewhat sketchy part of town, I felt that perhaps it was best to keep moving.

“Interesting marriage you have there,” Willie said.

“Different strokes for different folks,” she replied.

“I’ve got something for you to stroke.”

“Mmmm, I can’t wait.”

I listened to their footsteps, the sound of a door opening, and then shutting. A light switch flickering on.

“Nice digs,” she said.

“I’ve got the feeling this isn’t your first time in a bar storeroom.”

“Now, why would you say that?”

I could almost hear the smirk in his voice. “Tits, please. We don’t have much time. They’re already well-watered, but if we take too long the drunks out there will jump the bar and drink from the taps.”

“They’re not very big.”

“But damn nice,” he replied. “I bet these nips get hard as erasers, don’t they?”

“They will if you keep playing with them like that.”

My mind filled in the details. I imagined the storeroom as cramped, dusty, piled high with boxes, lit by a single bare bulb. My wife, topless, her bra and t-shirt tossed aside, a stranger’s hands tweaking her nipples.

I heard the unmistakable sound of a belt jangling loose.

“Dinner time,” he said.

A slight thump. Olivia dropping to her knees in front of him.

“Uncut, I don’t get to play with those very often.”

“Your hubby really listening in?” he asked.

“Mmmm,” she replied, her mouth full.

“Your woman is sucking on my foreskin,” he commented helpfully. “She’s got great fucking tits.”

I heard more slurping and sucking sounds.

"Fuck man," he groaned. "She's sucking on my balls. You like them grey pubes?"

"Mmmm, yeah," she cooed. "Oh, damn, you're so hard."

The squishing sound that followed must have been her fist pumping up and down his shaft. More kissing and licking followed.

"Oh fuck," he growled. "Yeah, Suzie, you look so hot with my dick in your mouth. Fuck that's hot. She do that to you man? Eye contact and take you to the root? Or is that just for all the other guys she fucks?"

The slurps got louder and faster, as did his moans. She was bobbing up and down on his dick.

"Oh fuck, oh fuck," he moaned. "Oh fuck, I'm gonna nut in your wife's mouth. Oh fuck, you're going to drink it all up, aren't you?"

"Mmmm," she moaned with what seemed like genuine enthusiasm. Though maybe that was just my own.

He grunted and grunted again. I thought I could hear her swallowing, though that might have just been my imagination or wishful thinking.

"Oh man," he sighed. "That was good. But then again, you get a lot of practice, don't you?"

"Maybe I'm just a natural."

"You gonna do that for Mac?"

"Maybe, though he's much too big to take all the way. So, where can I find him?"

He laughed. "Well, you could just stay right where you are, and you'd see him around 10am tomorrow. I hired him as a barback."

I jolted out of my sexual high. For a few moments I'd almost forgotten we were running from the cops and trying to find a killer. And now, suddenly, we were close, very close... maybe too close. Olivia seemed to have the same thought.

"Now, I want this to be a surprise, so you're not gonna tell him I'm looking for him, are you?"

He laughed. "Baby, you're a world-class whore, but I'm not gonna sell out a bro like that."

Fuck. That might send Mac running... or worse, if he realized we were onto him, he might come after us.

"I just want to fuck his brains out," she cooed.

"Then he'll be psyched when I tell him you're looking for him."

I felt in the backpack for the gun. If I rushed back into the bar and into the backroom we could tie him up and just wait for Mac to arrive. But there were still a few patrons in the bar. They'd seen Willie go in the back with Olivia, and at least a couple, regulars, would be waiting around to high-five him when he got back. We couldn't risk him tipping off Mac, which would only take a few moments. A text: *Some crazy blonde bitch is looking for you at the bar*. What does that take to send, 30 seconds? I couldn't rush the bar, and I couldn't just wait for him to come out after he did close up in the hopes he'd be alone because—what if he wasn't?—and anyway, in the time between when he shooed Olivia out and when he came out himself, he could easily tip off our prey. Again, Olivia apparently had the same thoughts.

"Well, maybe I can make it worth your while if you hold your tongue."

"You gonna try those twenties again?" he chuckled.

"I was thinking, maybe I could go back to your place and we see how many times you can come in one night?"

Was she still topless as she said it? Maybe making slow circles of her nipple with a fingertip? Maybe casually trailing her hand between her breasts, down over her belly, hinting at the pleasures that might be his if he agreed.

"You're a handsome man," she continued. "So I know you don't have any problems getting women, but when is the last time you had a woman offer to worship your cock all night long?"

"I'm gonna want more than your mouth."

"Of course, Baby. I hope you like a shaved kitty, because I am completely bare."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah," she cooed. "Of course, we'll need a couple of rules."

He groaned. "Here we go."

“First, we need to lock up your phone. Don’t want you deciding to send an early morning text to our boy. And second, my husband gets to watch.”

He laughed. “How about, no?”

I cringed. She’d gone too far. Preventing a warning to Mac was the only issue that really mattered. Now she’d blown that up.

“Really? You sure it doesn’t turn you on to think about fucking the hell out of me while my husband watches? Making me scream in passion while all he can do is play with his pud? You seemed to like taunting him while I was sucking your cock. Imagine how much fun it’ll be when you’re turning my tight, little, married pussy inside-out.”

“I don’t know.”

“You can set the rules, Baby, as long as he’s in the room. You want him sitting quietly in the corner, then that’s what you get. You want him naked so you can see him get hard when you pound my cunt? You get that. If you want, he’ll even hold my legs apart so you can get in nice and deep.”

I had no idea where Olivia was getting all these ideas. She had apparently been giving all of this a lot more thought than I realized. It was in equal measure exciting and terrifying.

“You’re a kinky slut.”

“You have no idea,” she purred.

There was a muted sound of breaking glass. “Oh fuck, need to get back out there,” he grumbled.

“We have a deal?” I imagined her holding him back.

“Yeah, Slutty Suzie, we have a deal.”

I started back toward the bar. I heard Willie chasing out the last of the patrons and closing down the register.

Olivia whispered in the phone, “Did you get all that?”

“Yeah. I don’t know how involved I want to be in—”

“Don’t worry. Once I get going with him, he’s going to forget all about you.”

“Okay.”

"I may need to do things for him I've never done for you," she warned.

"I know."

"We good?"

"Yes."

"Hey, lend me a couple of dollars?"

I startled as a man came out of a darkened doorway toward me. He was big, or at least the heavy overcoat he wore even though it was July made him look that way. He had one hand out to reach for the money, the other hidden away inside the folds of his coat.

"Who was that?" Olivia asked.

"You talking to someone?" he asked.

He closed the distance toward me quickly.

I had a gun in my backpack, but I wasn't sure I could get it out in time, and the effort would leave me exposed. Instead, I slid the phone in my pocket to free up my hands.

He took two more quick steps. I could smell the sweat and booze on him. His eyes were wild, his sparse, ragged beard hinted at a man young enough to pose a threat and desperate enough to carry out.

It all happened so quickly that I am not even sure my perception of it is correct. He lunged toward me, reaching toward me with his outstretched hand while at the same time his other hand slashed at me. I don't know if I saw the knife. I certainly didn't see a wicked blade flashing at me as I might in a movie, but I instinctively recognized what was happening. I turned sideways, and whipped my backpack around, catching his hand flush. The heft and hardness of the gun inside caught him by surprise and whatever he was holding flew out of his hand and skittered into the street. But his other hand had a hold of my shoulder and I felt him begin to spin me down. I managed to plant my left leg, kicked out, low and hard, with my right. I made solid contact and he howled as his knee buckled. I stumbled as he fell, ending up several paces away from him. He jumped up quickly. His expression was murderous hatred. He took a step toward me, but his injured knee would not hold him. Spitting in my

direction, he wheeled and hobbled away, turning into an alley and disappearing as quickly as he had appeared.

My heart raced, even as my mind dissected what had happened. Had I really pulled off a ninja move of parrying a slashing knife and incapacitating an attacker with a perfectly-aimed kick to the knee? Or had I flailed in a desperate panic and landed a lucky blow? What was I really capable of under the influence of fear and sexual excitement?

I approached the front door of the bar. Willie's laugh stopped me short.

"I shoulda known," he said. "Thought it was weird that Slutty Suzie would offer to suck my dick loud enough for you to hear, but then again, I thought maybe the psycho bitch liked the idea of strangers knowing what a whore she was."

"Don't talk about her like that," I said.

"It's okay," she interjected.

"No, it's not," I snarled.

He laughed. "I just nuttet in your wife's mouth, and she gobbled it all up. And now we're heading back to my place so I can fuck the shit out of her."

"So, be grateful then," I said.

He laughed. "Okay then, Lady Susan, please escort me back to my abode so we can complete our assignation." He laughed again, and then muttered under his breath, "freaks."

He only lived a few blocks away, in a building converted from a warehouse. He was on the second floor, up an industrial metal staircase. His apartment was completely open, with high ceilings, large windows, and exposed brick walls. It was the kind of place that might go for \$3 million in New York, but was considerably less in west Denver. I suspected he owned the bar rather than just working there.

We followed him as he walked into the kitchen area and took three beers out of the fridge. He cracked them open and offered us one each. We took them and took a sip.

"Okay, gracious host duties done. Now, Hubby, go ahead and take off her clothes."

Olivia laughed. "I can strip on my own."

"I want him to do it."

She looked at me. I gave her a quick nod. We took another gulp of our beers and placed them on the counter. She dropped her arms to her sides. I reached for her t-shirt. She trembled slightly at my touch.

"Nice and slow, Hubby. I want to enjoy this."

I nodded and slowly untucked her t-shirt. Standing in front of her, I grabbed her t-shirt by her hips and deliberately lifted it above her head. I tossed it aside. Her eyes shone with excitement, her breathing shallow and rapid. I moved behind her and pulled her bra straps off her shoulders. I unsnapped the clasp and eased her brassier off.

I reached around her and began to unbutton her jeans.

"Probably need to get her shoes off first," he said. "Is this the first time you've stripped your wife for another man?"

I couldn't have answered even if I'd wanted to. My throat was too tight.

"Yes," Olivia responded for me.

"Why me?"

"You have something I want," she purred.

I got down on my knees beside them and began untying the laces on her hiking boots.

"I already gave you that. You know where to find him," he noted. "Why's it so important he not know you're looking for him?"

She moaned. I looked up to see him fondling her breasts, rolling her nipples between his thumbs and forefingers.

"Your wife has some great tits," he said when he noticed me peering up at them. Then back to her, "So, Sl.... Suzie, why the mystery?"

I lifted her foot to remove her right boot, and she placed her hand on my head for balance. He chuckled. I burned with embarrassment even as my dick threatened to tear a hole in my pants.

"I just want it to be a surprise."

"And that's worth all this?" he asked.

She wiggled her toes as I eased off her sock. I went to work on the other foot.

“Giving Mac a treat is worth almost everything to me.”

He chuckled again as she balanced herself on me, though this time, his mirth seemed to be related to his questions. I rose and stood behind my wife, avoiding his effort to make eye contact with me. I was grateful that her body hid my erection.

“He has a horse cock,” she sighed. “And knows how to use it.”

He laughed. “I don’t know if I like the idea of fucking a pussy loose and sloppy enough to handle that.”

“Oh, Sweetie,” she cooed, “that’s not how it works. It’s a muscle. Being able to take a big, fat prick, and enjoy it, just means your pussy has great muscle tone. Which, you’ll see for yourself if my husband ever finishes getting me naked.”

“Yeah, husband, you’re falling down on the job.”

My hands shook and my heart pounded, making it a challenge to unbutton her jeans. I finally got them open and lowered her zipper. I felt the heat emanating from her pussy, making me dizzy. I grabbed her jeans and began to pull down. She wiggled her hips sexily to help. Then one foot and then the other, balancing herself on me each time. Olivia was naked save for a pair of simple, pink panties, which was somehow even sexier than if she’d been wearing some special lingerie.

“Baby,” she said to me. “Finish it. Finish stripping me for another man.”

My heart skipped a beat. I was so excited, and in that moment of lustful madness, she was somehow making this about us. Willie was a tool, a mark, a bit player in our story. Or maybe that’s just what I wanted... what I needed to believe. I eased off her panties and she stepped out of them daintily.

Willie took a step back and removed his shirt. He had the body of a punk rocker, though 40 years past his prime. He was still lean, with tight, corded muscles, but the tats on his chest were faded, and anyway, hidden behind a mat of silver-grey hair.

“Is she ready?” he asked.

I stared at him dully as he sat on his platform bed and removed his shoes.

"Check the oil," he added.

She turned toward me. I looked down at her, looking smaller than usual in her bare feet. She was flush with excitement, her lips curled into a seductive smile. Her nipples were erect, pointing slightly upward as her chest heaved. I slid my hand down between her legs. Her labia were swollen, cleaved open, and very wet.

"She's ready," I sighed.

Holding my gaze she cupped my hand and pressed my finger inside her. Her pussy was drenched and furnace hot. It pulsed on my digit in time with her pounding heart.

"She's so ready," I gasped.

He patted the bed beside him. "So bring her over here."

He was completely naked, his cock rock-hard in his lap. He was average sized, no bigger than me, maybe not even that big, which left me vaguely and slightly shamefully disappointed. Olivia took my hand and we walked over to him.

"So, Hubby," he asked. "How should I fuck her first?"

I turned toward my wife.

"Don't need to ask her." He reached out and casually fondled her snatch. He rubbed his fingers together and grinned. "That is one juicy pussy. She'll like it no matter what."

"Doggy style," I said.

"You heard the man, Baby Doll. Get on up here on all fours." He took her hand and pulled her onto the bed.

She positioned herself perpendicular to me on the bed, but he adjusted her so that her ass pointed at me.

"Now, come on, Baby," he said. "We want to give the man a show, don't we?"

He eased her legs apart. Her lips cleaved open, glistening and pink. He caressed her inner thigh. "Damn, I love a woman who drips down her legs." He pressed two fingers inside her. She moaned and shuddered. "She's gonna come before I even get my dick in her. You too," he said with a chuckle as he spied the tent in my pants crowned with a wet spot.

“Fuck me already,” she growled.

He spanked her ass playfully. “I know you don’t want me to call her a slut, but what’s a man to do when a girl talks like that?”

He palmed her ass cheeks. “Mmmm, nice and firm. I bet you do plenty of squats and stairs to keep your ass nice for all the strange cock you get.” He spread her cheeks and ran his thumb over her anus. “Does she take it up the ass?”

Olivia spared me having to answer. “Sometimes.”

He chuckled. “I never really got that. If you got a juicy cunt and a wet mouth to play with, what’s the point?” He slid two fingers back in her pussy. Olivia’s ass undulated lewdly. “Fuck, that’s a horny slut.”

I didn’t argue this time.

“Fuck her or I will,” I grunted.

He laughed, but also slid in behind her. He withdrew his fingers and began rubbing the head of his cock between her swollen pussy lips. She moaned passionately and began thrusting back to capture his dick, but he kept just the tip inside.

“Last question, Hubby. You want her up on her arms like that so I can pull on that convenient ponytail or down on the bed....”

Olivia answered the question by dropping forward, her chest to the mattress.

“Like that,” I growled.

“Face down, ass up,” he said approvingly. He slapped her ass. “Such a good, dirty, bad girl.”

He thrust in hard, balls deep. She hissed excitedly.

“Oh fuck, that’s a nice cunt,” he sighed.

She’d had enough of the talk and the teasing. Now that he was inside her, she took charge. She thrust back against him hard, her body writhing, both of them grunting and groaning. She reached between her legs and grabbed a hold of his scrotum so he couldn’t escape even if he wanted to. She managed to loosen her ponytail, and as she fucked him, her blonde hair fanned out above her head. She twerked on his dick, her ass a blur, her pussy making obscene, squishing sounds as she impaled herself on him again and again.

He seemed shocked. He'd been around the block a few times, but he'd never been fucked like this. And I'd never seen her like this. I saw now how she could get in the throes of uncontrolled passion, the way she'd been with Mac in the interrogation room back then. And I could only imagine how hot it would be to see her this way with a young, hot, tatted-up convict with the biggest cock she'd ever had in her life.

I gasped as I realized I was spurting in my pants. Thankfully, Olivia and Willie were doing the same thing, him pumping his load into my wife's cunt as she gasped and shuddered from head to toe. I retreated a few paces and settled into an armchair, crossing my legs to hide the spread of jism across my lap.

"Fuck, that was amazing," he gasped. "Damn, Hubby, did you see—"

Olivia wheeled around and wrapped her arm around his neck, spinning him onto his back on the bed.

"Hey!" he exclaimed.

She thrust two fingers into his mouth. "You talk too much, old man. Now, you better get this thing up again, or I'm going to cut the useless lump off." She dove toward his crotch and swallowed his slimy prick into her mouth.

I watched my wife bob up and down on his cock. She had her ass in the air, and as she slurped him back into working order, I could see her wet snatch, pulsing with excitement, and a thin stream of his creamy come leaking out and down her leg.

My cock twitched with excitement, but the rest of my body and mind had other ideas. It had been a long, long day.

I slept in fits and starts. In between I caught snippets of them fucking. Olivia on top, riding him reverse cowgirl. Then later on the back, ankles by her ears as he slammed into her again and again. If I hadn't been so exhausted, I'd have loved to watch more, but I only came to long enough to admire their enthusiasm before nodding back off.

I awoke a little after 7:00am. Light was coming in through the high windows, and it took me a few moments to get my bearings. The bed was a mess, blanket on the floor, sheets twisted into tight coils that looked suspiciously practicable for some impromptu bondage, but Olivia and Willie were not there.

I straightened up stiffly, carefully separated my junk from my crusty boxers. Something clattered to the floor, and when I picked it up, I saw it was Willie's phone along with a post-it note in Olivia's hand, "Take this with you and follow Mac."

I rose and stretched, and then I finally heard the shower running. The bathroom door was cracked open, almost an invitation, and I decided to take a peek. Willie had a large, glass-enclosed shower. He was facing the spray, arms at his side, while my wife knelt behind him, unmistakably eating his ass while giving him a reach-around handjob.

Well, she did say she might have to do for him things she never did for me.

Chapter Fourteen: Closing the Trap

I left his loft quickly. I was a bit of a mess, wrinkled and I bet I smelled like a goat, but at least the come stain on my pants had faded to a barely visible discoloration. I went into a local Starbucks and splashed some water on my face so that I felt almost human. A Venti of deep roast and a morning bun brought me the rest of the way.

I tried to take stock of our situation. From the moment we heard about Zach's murder, we'd be running on panic and adrenaline. It was a miracle we hadn't been caught by the cops, and it was an even bigger miracle that we'd gotten as close to Mac as we had. But I decided to take stock.

I borrowed a pen and sheet of paper from a man who seemed to have an entire home office set up. I started with a timeline.

June 12: Mac released from prison

June 26: Olivia flirts with Denny and I send him dirty pictures.

July 3: Denny texts asking to hook up with Olivia.

July 3: (late) Olivia flirts with Zach. Blows him in the back of an Uber.

July 4: Party. Olivia fucks Mitch.

July 5: (early next morning) Denny is found abused and murdered.

July 5: (afternoon) News story about Dennis Jennings appears

July 6: (after work) Torres and Land come to ask questions

July 7: (morning) Zach found beaten and murdered

July 7: (mid-morning) News story about Zach. Olivia and I run.

July 7: (night) Less than 3 hours after checking into hotel, cops arrive.

It fit together nicely. Mac was obsessed with Olivia. That made even more sense to me now than before. Any man would quickly become obsessed with a woman who fucked like that. And, of course, it was their fight that had triggered his drunken evening that led to a murder conviction. She was also the girl he'd left behind who

had ditched him when he was convicted. It seemed perfectly plausible that his first business upon getting out would be to find her.

So he did. And found she was married. He stalked her. Maybe he even broke into our house. He saw the gun safe in the basement. He's a B&E guy, so maybe he knew people write down their combinations, and he found it in my desk drawer. A germ of a plot formed. He'd use my gun to... something. He continued to stalk her, in the shadows, keeping his distance, but he was there when she began to flirt with Denny. He took note, and when I went home with Olivia (after we fucked in the alley), he followed Denny to his home, so he could easily track him down again. He was in the bar again the night Olivia was messing around with Zach, and saw them go off together.

I paused.

How did he find Zach after that? Did he follow the Uber? Social engineer the information out of the bartenders we'd been talking to that night? Why would they give up their friend to this menacing stranger? I wrote "Tracking Zach?" in the margin. What was his beef with Denny and Zach? He can't be that upset they were fucking Olivia. He used to pimp her out, after all. No, it had to be about setting me up, getting me out of the picture. But how did he know Denny and Zach would be traced back to me? The texts linked me to Denny. The Uber ride to Zach. So for his plot to make sense, he had to know both those things. "Connecting Dex to Denny/Zach?" in the margins.

There were gaps in the logic, but then again, aren't there always at least some ambiguities? On the whole, the pieces fit together pretty well. The more pressing issue was trying to find unassailable evidence of all of this. My gun with his fingerprints on it would be a good start. Some evidence putting him in the right places at the right times would also help. But more than anything, we'd need a confession.

I also took stock of our material situation. The \$500 I took out of the ATM was down to \$220 after buying the phones, the bus tickets to and from Colorado Springs, the hair care products, and the various cab rides. In my backpack, I had Mitch's gun and one more

unopened phone. The loss of Olivia's backpack at the hotel meant we'd also lost our change of clothes, basically clean underwear, which I could have really used at the moment, toiletries and everything else. Aside from the jism in my pants, I had also hiked in these clothes, and slept in them. I looked like a bum, and between my clothes and my smell, I would have trouble operating stealthily as I tracked Mac.

We still had our ATM cards—they had magnetic strips rather than RFID chips—but I was loath to use them. There was just too much risk that the cops would get a notification in near real time, and for us to close the trap on Mac, we needed to be able to get around with at least some freedom of movement. As it was, it felt like we were living on borrowed time.

I looked at my watch. Almost 8:00am. I had two hours before Mac was supposed to appear at the bar, and I needed to reset my situation as quickly as possible. I took a bus back up Colfax to Sullivan Gateway, and then took off at a rapid pace for City Park. Once inside, I crisscrossed the trails until I was sure no one was following me. Then I called Trip.

"Trip, it's me."

"Jesus, Dex, where the fuck are you? What's going on?"

"When the cops came by, did they say anything about monitoring your phone?"

"No. Jesus, is someone listening in?"

"I don't know. I... don't think so. But they might be able to see who is calling you and track my cell. I need to see you in person."

"Okay, but you told me I didn't want to be involved."

"You don't," I admitted. "But I need help. Meet me at Saint Ignatius Loyola. Sit in the pews on the far right. 9:00am. And please bring cash."

"Cash?"

"A few hundred. Whatever you can get from the ATM. I just need a little money for the next couple of days."

"Okay, man, but..."

"Don't worry. I don't expect you to go down with me. Just... do this one thing, okay?"

“Okay.”

I disconnected and tossed the phone into Duck Lake. I hurried out of the park and made my way to the public library on North High Street. I needed to check the news.

The Denver Post didn't have much, which clearly annoyed the reporter assigned to the story. Two brutal murders in the space of 48 hours, no obvious gang connections, and Denny in particular, as a middle-class white guy was an object of curiosity. There was some speculation of a sexual situation, or at least enough for his widow to issue a heated denial. Otherwise, it was a bland collection of “the investigation is on-going,” “citizens are asked to contact authorities if they have any information,” and “we are investigating all avenues.” The one really troubling quote was from an unnamed detective on the case who confirmed, “there is a person of interest, and we will be sharing more information on that soon.” So... tick tock.

I had a few more minutes before I had to leave to meet Trip, and it occurred to me that I didn't even know what Mac looked like, and that seemed like a useful bit of info to have before I tried to tail him.

There are a lot of Sean MacDonald's out there, including a surprising number associated with murder, either as victim or perpetrator. But I finally managed to find the right one, and found his mugshot as well as a story on the crime itself. In the booking picture, he looked like a young Orlando Bloom in his Legolas days, though with somewhat shorter hair, and a smattering of tats peeking out from his orange prison jumpsuit. It didn't seem fair that a guy should get to look like that and also have a huge dick, but life isn't fair, and anyway, where had it gotten him?

The news story was pretty damn gruesome. Mac bashed in the other guy's skull, and one of the witnesses commented on the amount of blood and brain matter on the pool cue after. The victim was a guard at the county jail, and police speculated that the two had beefed when he was being held on drug charges. I shuddered. This was one guy with whom I did not want to be mixed up with, but, of course, that ship had sailed.

I left the library and took a circuitous route to the church to make sure I wasn't being followed. I cut through office buildings, going in the front door and exiting the back. I stopped and backtracked. I made sure to walk against the traffic on one-way streets. I knew Trip was not taking those kinds of precautions, but I just had to hope the police didn't have enough resources to keep a tail on him full time. I'd find out soon enough if that was a good bet.

I arrived at the church and lurked in the high shrubs just outside the entrance, pressed up against the red brick exterior. I kept traffic on 23rd and York under surveillance, but didn't notice anything out of the ordinary. Just the usual commuters on their way to work downtown. I spotted Trip's SUV coming up 23rd. He pulled into the church parking lot, and went inside. There was still no sign of pursuit.

When I picked Saint Ignatius, I had been imagining a European-style cathedral, full of dark nooks and crannies, but sadly the church was just a big, open space, well-lit. I almost ran when I stepped inside, but the ticking in my head was getting louder, and I needed to be back at the Iron Bar by 10:00 to make sure I didn't miss Mac arriving at work.

Trip was sitting in the second pew from the back, looking around anxiously. I slipped in next to him.

"Relax, please," I said.

"Dude, what—"

"Trip, I don't have time to explain everything. Do you—"

"Yeah, here's your money." He handed over a thick envelope.

"You *did not* get this from me."

"Of course not."

"Dex, what's going on? Give me the short version."

I sighed. He was going to learn sooner rather than later anyway. "The cops think I committed a murder. Two actually. They think it is some sort of sexual game gone wrong."

"Oh Jesus," he hissed. I looked around anxiously. Taking the Lord's name in vain is surely an even bigger sin in a church. "Trace was saying you two were going to get into trouble."

"I didn't do it. It's... look... you just need to trust me."

"I do. But... Dex... whether I do or not... that really doesn't matter. You have to go to the cops. You have to—"

"I can't," I interrupted. "Trip, the evidence against me is circumstantial, but, if I didn't know I was innocent, I'd vote to convict me. I just need a little time to get some evidence on my side. Just enough so that the cops are even willing to look at other possibilities."

"Okay, okay," he said, but he shook his head as he said it, which aptly communicated his misgivings. "Dex, what about the bid?"

"I'm sorry, you and Markson will just have to carry the water."

"I know... but... they're in final deliberations right now. The committee has noticed your absence... and what happens if they find out the reason?"

"What are you suggesting?"

"Maybe... we take you off the bid and corporate documents for a bit. You know. A leave while you sort this out."

I shook my head. "That's Markson's idea, isn't it? That fucker would screw a drowning man in the ass."

He took a deep breath. "Actually.... It was Trace who mentioned it—"

"Tracey doesn't know—"

He put up his hand. "And I thought it was something to consider."

I sighed. "Trip.... You need to do what you need to do. Thanks for the *support*," I said, placing the money in my backpack. I stood and began to walk away.

"Dex...."

I waved over my shoulder, but didn't look back. In a way, he was right. The smart thing was to cut ties with me.

I took the bus back down Colfax. Is there a merit badge for crisscrossing your town multiple times in a 24-hour period?

I approached the bar and tried to find a good spot to establish a stakeout. I knew I had to keep my distance. If Mac had been

obsessively stalking us, Olivia's rushed cut and dye job on my hair would not fool him for long, but I also needed to make sure Willie hadn't been playing us. Not that I could really do much about it if he had. I could spitefully smash his phone, but that wouldn't undo the multiple loads of come he'd dropped inside my wife, much less alter the fact that she'd tongued his ass. I wondered for a moment what they were up to. Hopefully, they were getting some sleep after a long night, but new pussy is addictive, and I was pretty sure he'd take advantage as much as possible. I shook that thought out of my head. I had work to do, and fantasizing about Olivia and another man was not a productive use of my time.

Across the street from the bar, about 50 yards down, I found a construction site with no constructing going on. It didn't look abandoned, just temporarily inactive, and it seemed to me that if I acted like I belonged, no one would take much notice of me. Waiting until no one was around, I squeezed through an opening in the fence and then circled the lot as if making an inventory. Three shovels. Yup. A pallet of bricks. Check. I continued until I'd looped back toward the fence, finding a spot beneath a somewhat rickety stack of plywood that afforded a view of the bar, and also cover from curious passersby or residents of the neighboring buildings.

Right at ten o'clock, a tall, well-built man approached from the south. His head was down, in his ears he had inexpensive wired earbuds connected to a device in the front pocket of his green/grey work pants. He was wearing a canvas ball cap, his shoulder-length blonde hair, combed straight and still wet from a recent shower. He wore a vee neck t-shirt, in a pale yellow, and his arms were heavily tattooed. He walked to the bar and drew out a set of keys and went inside. He was punctual if nothing else.

I continued to observe for a while. He left the front door open to air the place out, and I could see him inside, sweeping, and wiping down all the tables and counters. A delivery truck arrived. Mac greeted the driver and reviewed a list as the driver unloaded crates of booze. Standing there in the street, I got a clear look at his face. He was older than in his mugshot, but ten years in prison had not aged him as much as I might have expected.

Maintaining my vigil, I set up my last burner phone and called Olivia. A bit to my surprise she answered immediately. I'd expected her to be tied up, either literally or figuratively, with Willie. Maybe I'd even hoped for it.

"Dex?"

"I found him."

"He found him," she said to Willie.

"Told you," he answered back.

Then to me, "John's angry that we stole his phone." So Willie's name was actually John. Too bad, he was still going to be Willie to me. "But I made it up to him."

I wondered if that was a reference to the rim job and reach around, or whether she'd offered up yet another kinky treat. I decided to let that slide.

"I'm not sure what we do next," I said. "I can't get too close or he'll recognize me. And I can't spy on him from out on the street either. Did I mention I nearly got mugged last night?"

"What? No, what happened?" she said, genuine concern in her voice. Even though she was probably still lounging around naked in another man's apartment, she was worried about me.

"Never mind. I'll tell you later. Last night was crazy. What we really need is to know where he lives. Maybe you get a confession out of him, but finding that gun or whatever other evidence he might be hiding, is going to be the key. Does Wil... I mean, John, know where Mac lives?"

She asked him.

"No," she replied. "Just that he's subletting a place not too far away. Wait, hold on...."

I heard a muffled conversation. Then she came back to the phone.

"Okay, so this is interesting. Mac apparently works through the lunchtime rush, and then gets off around two. He's off for a couple of hours, and then comes back in to set up and support the happy hour crowd and evening business."

"Oh, so what does he do on his break?" I asked.

More conversation in the background.

“So, it depends. Sometimes he just hangs around the bar eating lunch. Other times he goes home or whatever.”

“We need to find out where he lives... and ideally get inside.”

“Leave that to me. But you follow, and if I can arrange it, I’ll let you in. When he goes back to work, you’ll be able to search the place.”

It occurred to me that we’d come a long way very quickly if we could so casually come up with a plan that involved my wife having sex with yet another man.

“Okay,” I said. “I need to buy a change of clothes and more phones. Do you need anything?”

“I’ll join you. There’s a Walmart nearby. Meet there in half an hour? I just need to take care of something that, uh, just came up. Want to listen in?”

I chuckled. “I’ll pass.” I was sure I’d have enough of that later in the day.

I continued to watch Mac for another few minutes. Aside from a brief smoke break outside, he remained hard at work. Just before I left to meet Olivia, one of the bartenders arrived. They fist-bumped and exchanged a smiled greeting. He may be a killer, but no one seemed to be holding that against him.

I walked to the Walmart and waited for Olivia inside. She was a few minutes late, looking both tired and radiant.

“Did you have fun?” I asked.

She grinned. “He was surprisingly energetic for an old goat.”

“Think we’re safe with him not warning Mac?”

A quick shrug. “I think so. I think I convinced him I’m just a nympho out for a good time. Even if he does say something, I don’t know that Mac would put it all together. At this point, short of tying John up, there is not much more we could do. For what it’s worth, he was snoring pretty solidly when I left, and he doesn’t go in until right before happy hour, so....” She sniffed at me. “So yeah, you need a change of clothes.”

“Sorry I didn’t get a chance to shower like you did.”

“Oh, Baby, did you peek in on me being a bad, bad girl?”

I blushed a deep red. Why was I blushing? She was the one who had her tongue up another man’s ass.

“Let’s go,” I said. “I want to get back to my stakeout.”

We separated to do our shopping. We met back up at the register, me with more pre-paid phones, underwear, khaki pants, a couple of polo shirts, and a few toiletries, Olivia with a couple of short skirts, sheer tops, and sexy lingerie. Yes, there is sexy lingerie at Walmart. She also had a small pile of costume jewelry. She even found a pair of heels. We paid for our items and then hopped into the nearby Planet Fitness on a day pass to shower, change, and shave. Well, I didn’t shave, since my new dark facial hair was part of my disguise, but Olivia....

She came out of the locker room looking like a million bucks. She was wearing a grey skirt and pink blouse, and she looked professional. Except the skirt was a little too short, and the blouse a little too sheer. I could see the outlines of her demi-cup bra. She had on a cloth, choker necklace, hoop earrings, divers bracelets on her right wrist, and expensive looking, but actually twenty-five dollars, watch on the other. Her mascara was heavier than usual, her lips redder, and the whole outfit made her look like a younger, somewhat looser version of herself... which was, of course the point.

“Was that the outfit you wore that first time you did it in the interrogation room?”

She grinned. “That might be too on-point, don’t you think? But that was the inspiration, yes.”

As we headed back toward the Iron Bar, I was uncomfortably aware of my odd mix of emotions. I was angry, scared, and hopeful all at the same time, but also excited, exhilarated even. And it was just at the thought of closing the trap on Mac, but also the expectation that doing so would require Olivia to sleep with him.

“Are you excited about this?” I asked.

“About finding Mac, or, um, what will happen after?”

“The latter. If you lure him back to his place, you know he’ll probably want... expect to....”

“Fuck? Are you asking if I’m aroused by that?”

I nodded.

“I could ask you to check the oil like you did last night.” She smiled as I reddened. “But I think you know the answer. Thing is, just the fact of knowing that I’m going to have sex gets me excited. It’s that kind of self-reinforcing dynamic that has gotten me into the worst situations, but there you have it. How about you?”

“I know it’s crazy. He killed two people already. And tried to set me up. I’m terrified that I’ll have to aim the gun at him and shoot him. And that possibility and clearing my name should be all I can focus on, but I can’t help it. I just... is he really that big?”

She smirked and held her hands what seemed like a foot apart.

“I just can’t help thinking,” I continued. “About him fucking you. You taking that whole big thing—”

“Inside me,” she gasped. She took my hand and squeezed it tight. “We’re a couple of sick fucks, you know?”

“Well, you are. I’m just a poor, put-upon husband with a slut for a wife.”

She slapped my shoulder. “Just for that, Dex, I’m going to ask him to fuck me in the ass.”

I had to stop to rearrange my junk.

We stopped for lunch on the way, popping into a bar and grill with high booths for privacy. I was wound up, couldn’t keep my legs still.

“This is it,” I said. “Either we find something, or we’ll need to go to the cops and hope for the best.”

She nodded. “He won’t just monologue a confession. Though I’ll have my phone recording in any case. How long do you think this thing can record?”

I checked my own. “Sixteen gigs of memory, so at least sixteen hours. I think battery life will be the bigger issue.”

“Anyway, I doubt he’ll just come out and incriminate himself.”

“Depends maybe on whether you can convince him you’d be pleased with what he did.”

Our burgers arrived. Olivia took a big bite of hers.

“That’s a big lift. I guess we should have talked about this before. But what exactly is my story?”

“What did you think it would be?”

“Some sort of weird coincidence. *Wow, I didn’t know you were back in town.* Or maybe, *Wow, it is you. My friend was at this bar last week and thought it might be you.*”

“So no mention of me?” She squinted. “I mean, like, something about me being out of the picture soon, or something?”

“Like, *What a coincidence, you’re a murderer and my husband is going away for murder too?* I don’t know how to work that.”

“The question is how remarkable it will be to show up, after he’s been stalking you and then killing people, without mentioning that some weird shit is going down.”

Olivia took another bite, while nodding thoughtfully. “So... ideally we’d wait for him to make contact with me, right? Then it is up to him to explain himself. My guess is that he’s waiting to hear you were arrested, so he can pop up out of the woodwork, all like, *Oh my God, I just saw your husband was arrested for murder. What happened? I’m so sorry. Is there anything I can do to help?*”

I nodded. “Right, right. But we can’t assume he’d reach out immediately. He might wait a little while to put some distance between him and me. Or he might wait for me to be convicted.”

“Right, so back to the basic question. Is it more plausible that I just happened to hear he was back in town and my pussy talked me into visiting him? Or that now that my husband is likely to be out of the way, I decided to rekindle things. The first makes me out to be a cheating slut. The second a cold-hearted bitch.”

“Cheating slut is more plausible. And so, you don’t mention anything about the murders?”

“No. And maybe that’s the way he slips up. If they come up, then he’s connected.”

“At least until my face appears on the news,” I said.

“Right, so I’ll act all cock-addled and hope he slips, and in the meantime try to figure out a way to sneak you into his apartment so you can search it.”

“And we need to do all of this before the cops find me, or go public with my name, or Willie dishes to Mac about last night.”

“That’s about the size of it,” she replied. “Easy-peasy, lemon-squeezy.”

She finished her burger. But me, I was too anxious to eat.

Things were suddenly moving very fast. Mac’s break was from 2:00pm to 4:00pm. Then he’d be back at work until late in the evening. So, if we were going to break things open, we needed to make some real progress in those two hours.

Olivia left the restaurant first. I followed a few minutes after. Before she entered Iron Bar, she called me. I wished her luck, and then muted my end. I heard her enter the bar. 1980s rock on the radio. Def Leppard? Poison? No, Whitesnake. *Here I go again....* Footsteps as she approached the bar. The hum of conversation growing louder, although the place didn’t seem full.

“What’ll you have?” a man asked. Maybe that bartender I’d seen fist bumping Mac earlier.

“White wine and a menu, please,” she said.

“I have Chardonnay and, um, Pinot Grigio.”

“Pinot,” she replied.

I heard her tapping her fingernails on the bar. Singing softly, “And I’ve made up my mind... I ain’t wasting no more time.” Olivia has a surprisingly sweet singing voice. Surprising because she rarely sings. Which, I guess, goes to show that there are all sorts of things out there if you’re just willing to look for them.

She swiveled noisily on her barstool. I imagined her surveying the room. As a barback, Mac was likely either cleaning up or working in the back, but his job would periodically bring him into the main room to change a keg or bus some tables.

“Your wine. Have you decided what you want to eat?” the bartender asked.

“Not yet. Not really hungry. Maybe I’ll just drink lunch.”

“My kind of woman,” he joked. I imagined him walking away, wiping down the bar, wondering if maybe he might be able to talk the boozy hussy into joining him in the back.

“There he is,” she whispered for me. “He’s coming this way.”

“Ol... Olivia?” said a man with a deep voice.

“OMG, Mac. Is that you?” Then a moment later, “Actually, I knew I’d find you here.”

“You were looking for me?” Did he sound skeptical or just surprised?

“Well, sorta. A friend. I think you know her. Val? She was here last week and said there was a cute guy working here who looked just like Mac. So I decided to check it out.”

“Val? I’m surprised she didn’t just tell you to stay away.”

Olivia laughed. “Yes, you two never did get along, did you? You both wanted the same thing out of me.”

“Yeah, um, that was a long time ago,” he said apologetically.

Another laugh. One that placed in my mind the image of her reaching out and touching his forearm reassuringly. “If I had bad memories, I wouldn’t have come.”

The bartender interrupted, “Hey Mac, Miller keg is running out, swap it out.”

“Listen, I need to get back to work. But it was great seeing you.”

“I’d really like to catch up,” she trilled. “When are you off? Maybe we could go someplace more quiet.”

“Um... sure. I’m off at two. I usually go home, but—”

“Home sounds great. I’d love to see where you’re living nowadays.”

“You know, um, I’ve been... away.”

“I do.”

“Mac?” the bartender said.

“Go, work. We’ll catch up in a bit.”

She ordered a second wine a few minutes later. The bartender tried to chat her up a little. A couple of guys who were stretching their lunch hours tried to draw her into a conversation about America’s

Got Talent, playing on her resemblance to Heidi Klum, which yeah, is sort of right. But she didn't bite.

A little past two, Mac returned.

"So, like a coffee?" he asked.

"I'd like to see your place."

"Um, okay," he replied with less enthusiasm than I might have expected from a man who'd been obsessing about fucking my wife for the past decade. But maybe he was playing it cool. After all, her sudden appearance must have thrown him for a loop.

She asked for the check. Bartender replied, "On the house."

"Is that because you want me to come back or because I'm friends with Mac?" she asked.

He chuckled. "Maybe both."

They walked out of the bar. It was a bright afternoon, and Olivia squinted as her eyes adjusted. Mac kept his ball cap low, over his eyes.

"How long have you been out?" she asked.

"Almost a month now. Sorta. It's complicated."

They walked right by the construction site. I waited for them to pass and then followed behind, continuing to listen in on their conversation, although now that they were outdoors, I only caught snippets.

"Was it bad?" she asked.

He shrugged. "No picnic. But I didn't go in with a lot of outside beefs. And there's something about being in for killing a guy that makes the other inmates think twice before fucking with you."

He talked about the food: it sucked. The other convicts: most of them just wanted to do their time. The guards: cocksuckers. Though given the tone, I think he meant that metaphorically rather than literally.

We crossed the river and walked on the bike path on the bank before turning back onto a city street. They reached his building. It was a surprisingly modern construction, probably built in the last decade or so. Key fob to enter the front door. They went in and I continued past the entrance. No front desk at least, but the elevator looked like it might need a key fob as well. Ten stories, give or take. I

got to the end of the block, crossed the street, and looped back. I went into a 7-11 and stood by the front, carefully studying the chip options, while also peering up at Mac's building. They had gone silent, probably interference from the elevator and interior hallways, but the connection didn't drop completely. I breathed a sigh of relief when I heard Olivia's voice.

"Wow, nice place," she said.

"It's not mine. Just... a friend is letting me stay here for a while."

I heard her footsteps as she circled the apartment. I hoped she wasn't just admiring the decor, but rather trying to figure out a way to get me in. Then I spotted her standing at a window. Six stories up. She opened the window and placed her hands on the sill and leaned out to get a better view. Four windows from the north side of the building.

"I bet you get some nice sunrises," Olivia said.

"I'm not really much of a morning person."

"I remember."

She turned and disappeared back inside. I realized we'd gotten trapped by another set of unexamined assumptions. A recently released ex-con, I'd implicitly figured he'd be living in a group house or some run-down building. I'd imagined myself just having to climb through an open window, not having to break into a building with modern security. On the other hand, I now knew where he lived.

I decided on a desperate gambit. While Olivia and Mac made small talk, I took another burner out of my pack, and called the police.

"I'd like to speak to Detective Torres."

I was routed quickly to his office number. The phone rang. I jolted when he picked up.

"Torres."

"This is Dexter Mullins."

"Where are you?"

I ignored the question. "You think I did it, but you have the wrong man. I can tell you where to find the real killer."

“That’s great. Why don’t you come on in, and we’ll talk all about it.”

“Listen, Detective, you need to—”

“No, you listen, Dex. You are in a world of trouble. We know about your wife and the man in the Uber. He’s dead too. Your gun club? No locker there. You’ve already lied and withheld evidence. I’ve been holding off on giving your name and face to every news organization in the state, because I know we’ll get you soon, but I’m out of patience. Turn yourself in, now.”

“Just do this one—”

“I am not negotiating. You have one hour to come in.”

I stared at the phone for a moment longer. “Fuck,” I grumbled as I threw it to the ground and stomped it into pieces.

“Dex... Dex...” Olivia was hissing into the phone.

“Yes, yes, I’m here.”

“Fuck, Dex. Just... did you see me at the window?”

“Yes. Where are you?”

“I’m in his bathroom. I have his key. I’m going to throw it out the window.”

“Olivia—”

“Just listen. Catch it. Make sure the fob doesn’t shatter. Come up to the sixth floor. Apartment B. When he’s distracted I’ll say ‘I missed this.’ You come in then, quietly. There’s a closet in the alcove. Hide in there until we’re gone. Dex, you get all that?”

“Yes.”

“Okay, gotta go.”

I heard her flush and then wash her hands. She rejoined him in the apartment.

“How did you find me?” he asked.

“I told you: Val. Why, do you not want to see me?”

“I’m just surprised. Things between us didn’t end well.”

She paced around the apartment, her heels clicking on the wooden floors.

“We were young. Things got crazy. I needed some space.”

“So you went to your ex,” he said.

She backed up toward the window. I crossed the street.

"It wasn't like that," she said. "I mean, yes... it was. I slept with him, but I didn't go for the sex. I went for the emotional support."

He snorted, and in that moment, I saw a small object fall from the window, black and silver. I cradled my hands. The keys hissed past my face and slapped painfully into my palm.

"I thought about you often," she said.

"You never called or wrote."

"Like you said, things ended badly. And I was scared."

"And you moved on and got married."

"But I never stopped thinking about you. About how things were with us. Intense, crazy. Almost too much. I didn't have the maturity to handle it. But now I do. We both do."

It took a pedestrian eying me crookedly to bring me back to my mission. I wasn't supposed to be staring up a window mesmerized. I was supposed to be using this time to get inside the building.

I scanned the front door open and hurried inside.

"What about your husband?"

I pressed on the elevator button. It opened immediately. I stepped inside and hit six.

"What about him? He's a good—"

The door closed and the connection faded to a low hiss. I hoped we wouldn't disconnect. At six, I got out and quickly moved to his doorway. The audio returned.

"I haven't been with a woman... or anyone... for over ten years."

"It's like riding a bike." I heard rustling. And then a moment later, she said, "Am I like you remembered me?"

"Better," he sighed.

"Boobs are a little bigger, and I have a little more booty."

I pictured her stripping off her bra and panties and spinning for him.

"Now you," she said. Then a moment later, she let out a low whistle. "Even more Ink and muscles. You're going to be fighting them off with a stick." She sucked in through her teeth. "Oh, fuck, that didn't—"

"It's okay," he replied.

“I’m really sorry. Let me apologize properly.”

More clicking footsteps. Naked with heels. Some rustling. A kiss maybe? I was dying to be inside so I could see what was going on. Instead, I remained frozen, pressed up against his apartment door, keys in the lock, waiting for her signal.

“You don’t need to do this,” he said.

She laughed softly. “I don’t need any extra reasons to want to play with this.”

He moaned softly.

“It seems happy to see me.”

I imagined them facing each other, both naked. Her pale, unblemished skin contrasting with his tattoo-covered body. Their eyes locked and shining. Olivia licking her lips as she slowly stroked his massive prick with both hands.

“Can I kiss it?” she asked. “I don’t think I can get it in my mouth anymore. Out of practice.”

I pictured her gracefully dropping to her knees and admiring his prick up close. His thick, veiny shaft. His heavy balls. I imagined her licking up its length.

His low moan seemed to confirm that conjecture. “Oh, Olivia.”

I heard more kissing sounds. Licking. Wet squishing. A small choking gag.

“See, out of practice,” she giggled. “Sit down.”

Bed springs squeaking. I visualized him sitting on the edge of his bed, Olivia rising up and standing between his legs, offering her body up for closer inspection.

“Did you shave for me?” he asked.

“I think you know I’ve been up to no good.”

He didn’t bite. “God, you’re so wet.”

“Mmmm. I’ve been like this from the moment I started thinking about seeing you. Oh... oh... ah....”

I wondered if he was sucking her tits or playing with her pussy. The answer was probably both.

More movement. Bedspring again. She had joined him on the mattress. Kissing. Then from Olivia, a long, slow, hissing sigh.

“Oh, God, I missed this,” she moaned.

More kissing. Heavy breathing.

"I missed this so much," she gasped.

It finally penetrated my lust-fogged mind. I turned the key and quietly entered his apartment. I had them in stereo now. Left ear via the phone, tinny, distance, right ear in person, more throaty, intimate. I ended the call and took out my earbuds. I tried to take stock of my situation, but it was challenging with Olivia's moans drifting from around the corner.

In front of me was the closet in which she thought I could hide. To the left of the door was a side table with a dish of change and miscellaneous keys. I added his keys to the mix. The apartment had parquet floors. To the left, a small, but clean kitchen. To the right, a dining room table with four chairs. Beyond that, I didn't know.

I should have ducked into the closet and hidden away there, but I couldn't resist the temptation to spy on them. It was more than a temptation. Her moans felt more like a compulsion, seeing what was happening, a necessity. A rationalization flitted through my head—I should try to get a better lay of the land before hiding myself away. But that was just an excuse, and I knew it.

Her moans were loud, but a little distant. It didn't seem as if they were immediately around the corner, but nevertheless, my heart pounded as I prepared to peer into the room beyond the dining room table. My wits kicked in just in time and before popping my head out, I used the camera on my cell to peek past the wall. The camera was the weakest part of the burner phone, but enough to do the job. Beyond the alcove was a living room, with sofa, TV, a desk tucked into a corner of the room by the windows, but not Olivia and Mac. There was another room in the apartment, a bedroom, and that's where they were.

I stepped cautiously into the living room. It was a little impersonal, but surprisingly nice for a newly released con, maybe an Airbnb or some other short-term rental. It was hard to imagine that the state was paying for this. I didn't know much about Mac. Maybe he had family money? But if so, why had he been relying on a public defender and law student intern on his earlier drug charges?

Her moans were louder from here, as was the squeaking from the bed. I saw why. The bedroom door was wide open. Actually, it was more than a door. The rooms were connected by a wide opening with a sliding door, so that someone sitting on the sofa in the living room could comfortably watch whatever was happening in the bedroom. I couldn't risk walking that far into the room, however. Instead, I edged forward, working the angle, gradually seeing more into the bedroom. Like the living room, it was tasteful if anodyne. An armchair by the window, the better for reading. A tall house plant, that may have been artificial.

Holding my phone out in front of me, I continued forward until I could see the left foot of the bed. Then even more cautiously, until I finally caught a glimpse of them, his knees and feet pointing toward the living room, her heel-clad feet aiming at the ground. It took me a second to work out the geometry in my mind. He was sitting at the foot of the bed. She was kneeling in his lap, riding him. I crept forward, and confirmed my deduction. I saw her ass, rising and falling, his powerful arms wrapped around her back.

A little closer still. I watched as she lowered herself again, dropping down into his lap, hitting bottom with a sigh and a shudder. I was close enough and angled felicitously so that as she rose again, I could see his cock, huge and glistening with her juices, emerge from her tight hole. An inch, then two, then a fist's worth of prick, thick, hard, her labia clinging to his shaft. She continued to rise up. Still more dick. Another fist's worth. Her pussy seemed to stretch ever wider as the head of his cock threatened to crown, but then she reversed course and began to take him back inside her. I was put in the mind of a medieval Claymore, with its two-handed grip, and bulbous counterweight at the end. Those handles could easily be over a foot long, and while he surely wasn't that big, he couldn't be, it was still shocking that my wife could take all of that inside her.

And not just take it, but love it. She mewled softly as she engulfed him with her cunt. He helpfully cupped her ass and pulled her cheeks apart to give me a better look. She shivered in delight, and her anus pulsed, which reminded me that she hadn't just taken

that monster vaginally, but anally as well. I had to step back and look away lest I come right then and there.

Back in his lap, fully impaled on his cock, she rocked her hips gently. Her body was lithe, swaying sensuously, completely given over to the pleasures of his prick. Seeing the effect he had on her, I finally understood what had seemed like madness on her part. The reckless assignations in a jail meeting room. Her willingness to service his friends. If he hadn't crossed the line by trying to make money off it, things might have gone quite differently.

Olivia kissed his face and his neck. "I want it hard," she moaned.

He rose and effortlessly lifted her in the air. She was still impaled on him as he spun around and deposited her on her back on the bed. That drew me in closer. His head would be facing away from me in this position. Olivia pulled her knees to her chest. She wanted every last inch of that massive cock. His back and legs were also a mass of muscles and tats. He rose up on his powerful arms. She gripped his triceps.

He pulled out almost all the way. He paused for a second, letting her anticipation build. Suddenly, he hammered into her hard, balls deep.

"Oh God, oh God, oh God!" she exclaimed between gulping breaths.

He pulled out again. She lay beneath him, gasping, her chest heaving, nipples hard little nubs. She could have easily seen me if she'd just looked, but she was completely focused on him. Her eyes shined with manic energy. He slammed in again, their bodies coming together was a slap.

"Oh fuck. Oh my God," she cried out, her head flailing from side to side.

He pulled out again. Her body seemed primed to explode. She undulated sensuously, gasping open-mouthed, her hands clawing at his arms. He clenched his muscular ass and thrust in again.

This one left her breathless. She opened her mouth as if to cry out, but nothing emerged. Instead, her body began to shudder

orgasmically, her body heaving as waves of pleasure washed over her.

He slowly pulled out again. She looked at him with what seemed like trepidation, but was something else altogether.

“More,” she gasped.

He seemed happy to oblige. He didn’t mix it up. This was something they had practiced together. Those brutal, super-deep thrusts, affected my wife like nothing I’d ever seen. It wasn’t the tender, scarily loving sex she had with Mitch; it was something more primal, darker, and addictive. How could a woman... how could anyone... resist this sort of pleasure? Why would they want to?

My head spun. Olivia came yet again. And I realized... I was the one who’d walked into a trap. She’d set all this up. She and Mac. She had kept up with him, knew he was getting out. She lured me in by exploiting fantasies she must have intuited by the way I acted when I saw her with other men. I walked right into it. She’s stolen my gun. Given it to Mac. He’d committed the murders, but she’d planned it. She told me to text those pictures to Denny. She ensured the Uber came to our house. So that she could enjoy what she was enjoying right now, except openly, and forever.

In the other room, Olivia was urging him on. She gripped his powerful ass and pulled him into her.

“Uh... uh... uh... that’s it, Baby, fuck me hard. Come inside me. I want to feel your come after all these years.”

A murderous rage came over me. I reached into my backpack and pulled out Mitch’s gun. I’d walk in, shoot him, make her confess, and then shoot her.

Her screams, his grunts, the sight of his massive prick turning her cunt inside-out, it was all too much. I had to end it. Was going to end it.

One last thrust. He stayed inside her. His balls tensed. She moaned as she felt his cock pulse, her toes curling as one last orgasm claimed her.

I was on the threshold to the bedroom. Gun in one hand. Hard cock in the other. I needed release. I’d get it one way or the other.

I sat curled up deep inside his coat closet, though there were no coats, just cleaning supplies. I tried to remain quiet, but I was still breathing hard. In the opposite corner was a pool of my jism.

I heard them talking. It was muffled. I was behind a closed accordion door and they were two rooms away. I heard laughter. More talk. Then footsteps. Coming toward me. I peered through the crack. He arrived in the foyer first, then she.

"You sure you want to hang at the bar? You know I don't get off until ten?" he said.

"I'll need that long to recover."

"Oh, so you don't want me to visit you during my break?"

"I didn't say that. But I may only be up for sucking on your cock. Would you mind?"

He laughed. "I missed you."

"I missed you too. I wish I'd known you were out. I'd have loved to have you come to our July 4th party."

"Yeah, well, that'd be hard. I have to go back in on weekends."

"What?" she said incredulously.

He shrugged. "Yeah, I'm in a work-release program. Monday to Friday. I spend weekends back in lockup. If I stay clean for a year, then I transition into regular parole." He checked his watch. "I need to head back."

"Yeah, yeah, of course," Olivia replied.

As she walked out the door, she cast a quick glance at the closet. I'm not sure she saw me peeking, but I saw her. And I knew we both had the same thought in our mind: *What the fuck?*

Chapter Fifteen: New Vectors

I stumbled out of the closet.

If he was in lockup on Saturday, then he couldn't have killed Denny, and we'd been on the wrong track this whole time. I was staggered by the enormity of it all. Everything we'd done. Everything she'd done. Willie. Eating his ass. Fucking him all night long. Then Mac. All for nothing. It was hot, but meaningless. Had we been so blinded by the possibility of more thrills for our crazy game that we were heedless to the reality it was a dead end?

I reached for the door and turned the knob. I needed to get out of there.

With one foot out the door, I paused. It was a dead end. Mac hadn't killed Denny. But... none of this really made sense. There were still too many coincidences. And what the fuck was this tattooed killer doing with such a nice pad?

I ducked back into the apartment and closed the door.

Just because he hadn't killed Denny, didn't mean he hadn't killed Zach.

I began by making a loop around the apartment. There were a lot of additional details I had missed initially, when I was both trying to be furtive and also my mind fogged by the sounds of my wife fucking another man. The kitchen seemed almost unused. The fridge was clean, and contained only a few beers, some half and half, and a half-eaten Chipotle burrito. The living room felt equally neutral, though I noted a healthy number of the usual novels, stuff by Dan Brown, John Grisham, and the like. The bedroom could have been in a hotel. Other than the sheets being a mess, with a prominent wet spot, and wrinkles where my wife had held on for dear life while getting her pussy shredded, there was nothing personal. In the bathroom, I finally found some evidence the place was occupied by a normal human, a half-used bottle of 2-in-1 shampoos, a poorly folded bath towel, toothbrush and toothpaste on the counter. He hadn't screwed the cap back on. I wondered if Olivia might be more tolerant of that sort of thing from a guy with a footlong prick.

I returned to the bedroom and began opening drawers. Empty except for, perhaps, a week's worth of work clothes. That made sense; he was recently out of prison... well, sort of out prison. I wouldn't expect a lot of possessions. He said he borrowed the place from a friend, but where was evidence of this friend?

I logged into Airbnb and tried to see if that's what this was. But no dice. It did not come up as a listing. A little more searching found that apartments in this building were renting for about two-thousand dollars a month. Even if they were generous with tip splitting, there was no way he was making more than \$15/hour as a barback. So, the apartment was nearly his gross pay.

Back in the living room, I noted that the furniture was of decent quality. Definitely a step up in price from Ikea. The TV was newish. I sat at the desk. It too seemed largely unused. I opened the drawers. Nothing, nothing, and then... paydirt. In the top left drawer there was a neat pile of bills. Cable, electricity, condo common charges. They all had the address and apartment number of Mac's place. And they were all addressed to the same person: Charles E. Shreve.... Charlie... as in Olivia's boss, Charlie.

I stroked my chin. Literally. I was still new to having facial hair, and it was oddly soothing. Why had Charlie gotten Mac an apartment? What relationship could they possibly have? Charlie, like Olivia, did real estate work, not criminal defense. And anyway, do criminal defense lawyers usually set up their old clients in fancy digs when they got released? Maybe Mac was Charlie's illegitimate son? The ages worked, but nothing else. No, their only connection had to be Olivia. And what in the world connection was that?

I heard keys in the lock. I fumbled for the gun in my backpack, but the door opened before I could get it out. Mac strode into the living room, clearly agitated, but I couldn't tell if he was furious or just puzzled. Olivia ran in behind him.

"Wait," she called out.

"Who's this?" he demanded. Then recognition came over his face. "Fuck, that's your husband. Jesus, I should have known. How did you sneak him in here? Never—"

I took advantage of his befuddlement to pull out Mitch's gun.

“What are you going to do with that?” he demanded.

“I just want everyone to calm down.”

“Calm down? Are you crazy, motherfucker?” he shouted. “I’m a fucking convict. Out on work-release. My fucking parole officer can check up on me anytime. I pee in a fucking cup twice a week and go back to a cell on Friday nights. And the last thing I fucking need is to be mixed up with a couple of psycho Bonnie and Clyde killers.” He rounded on Olivia. “What, you thought that just because I was a criminal I’d be happy to hide you in exchange for pussy?”

She held his gaze calmly. Surprisingly calmly, as a matter of fact. After their wild sex, I expected her to be more emotional. But she seemed able to compartmentalize that. I wasn’t sure quite how that made me feel.

“I’ve been trying to explain,” she said. “But you wouldn’t stop.”

“I can’t be seen with you. I have a life tail hanging over my head. Harboring a fugitive gets me back into prison for a long, long time. You need to get out.”

“We need to talk first,” I said.

Olivia shook her head. “Come on, Dex. Let’s go.”

“No,” I replied.

She looked at me curiously. I nodded toward the stack of bills on the desk. She lowered her hands and gave me a quick nod.

“First, why all the hair on fire stuff?” I asked.

“You... and she,” he said, pointing at each of us in turn, “are celebrities. All over the TV. Wanted in connection with two murders.”

“Shit,” I grumbled.

“Yeah, shit,” he said. “And who knows how many people have already seen me with her?”

“Okay, okay, that’s bad,” I admitted. “Fucking Torres.” I took a deep breath. “Look, we’re being set up. I don’t know who or how, but two men were killed. They both had been involved with Olivia. And now they’re dead.”

“And now I’m involved with her, and you’re holding a gun on me.”

I winced. “Yeah, that doesn’t look good. But just listen. I mean, what do you have to lose?”

He nodded, but his eyes circled the room, and I could see him calculating options. Gun or no gun, I didn't really have any confidence that I could take him if things got physical.

"Just get it over with," he grunted.

I put the gun down. "Just give us a few minutes."

"We thought you were the killer," Olivia said bluntly.

He shook his head. "Jesus, what? After all I did for you."

Her eyes flashed. "Like what Mac? Like when you were selling my ass to your buddies for fifty bucks a pop?"

"I'm sorry about that. I... I was in a fucked up place. And anyway it wasn't like that. I... tried to make it up to you, but—"

"What are you talking about?" she asked.

"Does this have something to do with Charlie?" I asked.

Olivia startled. "What? Where'd that come from."

"This is his place," I replied. "Charlie is Mac's friend who bought him this apartment."

"He didn't buy it for me. He uses it as his little getaway. I'm just borrowing it."

Olivia rolled her eyes. "Oh, what the fucked up fuck?"

Mac chuckled. "Oh, please. If I understand correctly, you've hooked up with at least two other dudes besides me."

"It's four, actually," I said. "Including your boss, Willie."

"Willie?"

"John," Olivia corrected. "It'll be a nice bonding opportunity for you two when it comes up. Anyway, what's with you and Charlie?"

"I guess that's another bonding opportunity. You're what's with me and Charlie."

"I don't get it," I said. Olivia nodded.

"He never told you?" Mac asked.

"Told me what?"

Mac covered his face with his hands. "Okay, okay, this is fucked up. I can't... okay. I'm going to get a beer. Anyone want one?"

I shook my head, as did Olivia. He dashed into the kitchen and retrieved a beer from the fridge. He returned and sat down on the sofa. She sat at the dining room table. He turned toward her.

"Olivia, I went to prison for you."

“What?” she and I exclaimed simultaneously.

“Did you tell him how we met?” he asked.

She blushed and nodded.

“So, here’s something I didn’t know. Even though they’re not supposed to listen in on attorney-client meetings, they have hidden cameras and mics in those rooms. Supposedly it’s for security or something, and they’re supposed to wipe the tapes clean every week, but obviously if they catch something interesting, they copy it. Or at least they did ten years ago. COs pass around compilation tapes of the crazy shit that goes on. Conjugal visits, people shoving contraband up their asses, you can imagine it. We were apparently something of a hit.”

“Oh God,” she gasped.

“One of the COs decided he might be able to get a little more out of this than just cheap thrills.”

She jumped in: “No one ever approached—”

“Yet,” he replied. “He went to Charlie first. You were working for him, right?”

She nodded. “Yes, I had an internship after first year, then a summer associate position after second.”

“Right, so, you were a young student, so he figured maybe your law firm partner boss would have more resources.”

“What did Charlie do?” she asked.

“He paid. And he hired me to deliver the money.”

“How much?” I asked.

“Fifty grand.”

“What happened?” Olivia asked. She was leaning forward.

He sighed. “I was high. Fucked up about you running off to your college boy crush. Feeling really shitty about what I did to you. Taking advantage of you. So I met the guy at a bar. The CO. The one blackmailing you or Charlie or... the whole thing is confusing. I remembered him from jail. Real tool. Trash talker. Liked to provoke people, and if anybody responded, he’d get his club out. So, I was already on edge. According to the deal he made with Charlie, he was supposed to destroy all the copies of the tape. There was no way to know for sure that he would, but Charlie was willing to take that risk.

I asked him anyway if he had destroyed them, and he gave me a cocky smirk. Then he told me he was planning to make some tapes of his own. He kept calling you my girlfriend. Like, *your girlfriend is a freaky slut, or a dirty whore*. He said the money was nice, but he also wanted to get a piece. Then it got worse....”

“Mac, what did he say?” she asked.

“I told him to leave you alone. He told me he was going to visit you. He wasn’t going to take no for an answer. If the threat of the tape getting out wasn’t enough, he said he was going to rape you.”

He let that hang in the air for a moment. Then he continued.

“I shoved him. He punched me. He grabbed a pool cue first, but I was better with mine.”

“But that’s self-defense,” I said.

“Yeah, and who’s going to believe a tatted up con with felony convictions under his belt over a prison guard? Anyway, I could have stopped... I should have stopped before cracking his skull completely open. I was going away in any case. And Charlie said he’d make it worth my while if I kept quiet about you and him being involved.”

“Why wouldn’t Charlie tell you any of this?” I asked Olivia.

She stared at me open-mouthed. “Oh my God. He did. He... tried to... and I completely misunderstood. He....” She massaged her temples. “Remember how I told you he made an inappropriate advance? It... oh God.... It was a misunderstanding. He was all, like, *I know you’re a healthy young woman, and you have sexual needs. But that I should be careful about the men I let into my life. And that whenever I needed anything, I could come to him*. And what I heard him say was that if I had sexual needs, I should go to him. But... that’s not what he meant.”

I was speechless. Mac seemed equally nonplussed.

“And he was afraid to raise it again because of how I reacted. Or maybe, he figured it was better I shouldn’t know. I can’t believe I...” she trailed off and walked to the kitchen and returned a moment later with a beer.

She was still processing it. “I... You don’t know how many times I’ve been in that situation. Older guy, boss, teacher, whatever... and

they groom you. And tell you how smart you are. How special you are. And before you know it, you're sucking dick, and only after do you realize that was all it was all about. And Charlie. The words were just so...."

"It's not your fault," I said. "You can feel bad that you had this negative impression of Charlie, but you didn't know, you couldn't know, and anyway, you've kept it quiet. Mostly."

Mac and Olivia were sitting back, feeling the catharsis of exposing the past. But my mind was still racing. Olivia and Charlie have always had a complicated relationship, as she noted herself. She was an intern, subordinate, and potential professional partner. She was also a young, vulnerable woman who needed his help. A surrogate daughter for an otherwise childless couple. And he was all those things in reverse for her. Boss, colleague, partner. Older mentor. Surrogate father for the one who died when she was in her teens. And there was sex. I didn't know if she'd ever been attracted to him, but he surely was to her. When they met, she was a hot, young blonde who dressed provocatively. Whether he made a pass at her or not, and I was still on the fence about it, he had wanted to fuck her. So I didn't know how any of this cut. At this point, I was confident that Mac and Charlie had been working together. But working together on what exactly?

Mac had to get back to work. And he graciously allowed us to remain in his place for a while. I wasn't sure what a "while" would turn out to be.

Once he left, I found Olivia. She was still wallowing in the revelations about Charlie. I knew at some point I'd need to make those feelings worse by admitting that I'd threatened him with revealing his supposed indiscretions in order to change his plans to start his own firm. But all that was for later.

"Olivia, we need to talk."

"Dex, I can't believe I didn't know about Charlie all these years, and—"

"I know. But look, we need to make some other decisions. We... I need to turn myself in."

She didn't respond immediately. She'd also thought about it. "I don't know. Right now the evidence looks bad."

"It's not going to look better if I stay on the lam. Breaking it open by implicating Mac was our best chance. Now we don't have anything to go on."

She shook her head. "That can't be right. This wasn't random. It is about us somehow, and you said it yourself, the cops are now in building a case mode, not making a list of suspects mode."

"I know. But we got tunnel vision on Mac, and even if we could have figured this out, we're running out of time. They will catch us. We wasted what little freedom of action we had. At this point, I think we need to trust the justice system."

"Do you trust it?"

I shook my head. "No. Honestly not. But, look, we have some money to afford competent counsel and, I hate to say it, but I'm a white man. If a white, male, one-percenter can't get justice, then no one can."

She nodded, and behind her reluctance, I could sense some relief. Maybe she thought I was guilty after all. I couldn't blame her. I remembered the murderous rage that had washed over me when she was in bed with Mac. It was white-hot and anything might have triggered me at that point. It didn't even begin to fade until I was in that closet, jerking off against the far wall. Then murder slipped from my mind, and suicidal thoughts crept in. In that mental state, would I have remembered if I'd killed them? Or would I have ended up roaming the streets, shocked that some madman had killed my wife and her lover?

"Dex? You okay?"

I nodded. "Yeah. Just realizing my freedom is on a clock."

"You're just going to go in?" she asked. Was her tone hopeful? Resigned? Despondent? I should have been able to discern between the three, shouldn't I?

"No. As long as I am running around, we have some leverage. I doubt Torres and Land want to have to answer questions about why

they left me at liberty. We need to negotiate the terms of my surrender to make sure no one else gets fucked in the process. Metaphorically, I mean,” I added. Given the strangeness of our situation, either interpretation was plausible. “I was thinking we should call that PD you worked for.”

“Ellis? He’s not a PD anymore. He’s at Pearson now. I think he does mostly white-collar stuff, now. That’s where the money is, right?”

“Right. But at least he knows you and he knows Mac. That seems like a good head start.”

We called his office on speaker. Luckily he was in. Olivia opened by re-establishing a personal connection, moving on to business.

“Ellis, I’m married now. To Dexter Mullins. Do you know who that is?”

We heard him typing. Then a moment later. “Oh shit. You’re all over the news. Are you safe? Do you know where he is?”

“I’m right here,” I said.

He hesitated. “I need to ask this, Olivia. Are you safe?”

“Yes. Ellis, he’s innocent. But Ellis, it does look bad. Someone set us... him up. It’s complicated.”

Olivia and I took turns filling him in on the story. He tried to remain professional, but the situation was so fucked up that he couldn’t seem to avoid the occasional sigh or grunt. When we explained the Mac part of the story, he sucked in through his teeth. After we were done, there was a long-enough silence that I wondered if he might have stealthily hung up on us.

Finally he spoke. “Okay, no bullshit. This is bad. And by lying to the cops and running, you’ve really locked them in. I guarantee you they *know* you’re guilty right now. And, honestly, I can’t promise that if you turn yourself in, you’ll get bail. They’ll point to your resources and history of flight... so, good chance you’re in jail through trial. We just got rid of capital murder, at least that isn’t hanging over you. But, you need to understand. Once you walk through the door, you might *never* walk out.”

"I know," I said. Olivia's pallor suggested she hadn't quite come to the conclusion yet.

"Look, the only thing I want you to negotiate is a promise not to charge anyone with being an accessory to the crime."

"You know the difference between aiding and abetting and accessory?" He asked. "I might be able to get them to promise to not charge people who have helped you over the last couple of days, but anyone who they can prove had advance knowledge... well... that's another issue."

"That's fine," I replied. "I just don't want to bring down anyone who I roped into this since. And, Ellis, that has to include not violating Mac's parole process."

"I'll try," he said. "But you need to know that they are going to want you in custody, post-haste."

"Friday morning," I replied. "That's the earliest I'll surrender."

"I'll try," he said again. "Um, can I speak to Olivia alone, please?"

"Of course," I replied.

She took the phone off speaker and walked a few yards from me. Her curt answers, yeses and nos, could have concealed any number of admissions. She concluded with, "Okay, I'll make the call."

My wife turned back to me. "He was worried about my safety."

"Are you worried about your safety?" I asked.

"Honestly, Dex, I don't know. I thought we'd find Mac, raving, living in a rat hole, ranting vengefully. But he seems mostly concerned about staying clean, and honestly earlier today, I didn't sense any crazy obsession on his part. I had to seduce him. And if he didn't do it... who did?"

"Maybe me," I said.

She tilted her head slightly. "Yeah, maybe you. But I don't think so. Not sure why. I've not always been the best judge of men."

I forced a smile. "What's that call you need to make?"

"Need to arrange an engagement letter and retainer. I'll take care of that."

I nodded. "We need to make more calls. Kids are in camp, so they won't be hearing anything, but we need to talk to friends and

family and explain what we can. We need to check in with Mitch and Trip, too.”

“I’ll call fam and leave Trip to you. We should talk to Mitch together,” she said.

We retreated to different sides of the apartment.

I could hear Olivia from across the living room repeating the same phrases. *A misunderstanding. They have the wrong man. It’ll be okay.*

I called Trip.

“Hey man,” I said.

“Oh fuck, oh fuck, oh fuck,” he replied in a panic.

“Dude, chill, I’m the one looking at life. I’m negotiating a surrender that will keep you out of trouble.”

“Oh fuck,” he repeated. “Look, I didn’t want this to go down this way, but—”

“You cut me out.”

“I couldn’t help it, man. The board had an emergency meeting when your face appeared on TV.”

I bit back a surge of anger. Our Board of Directors was me, Trip, and three money men. They were important, but without me and Trip, their investments were nothing. If Trip had held his ground, they’d have no choice but to follow his lead.

“Of course,” I said as placidly as I could. “So, what did you decide?”

His pause before responding told me everything. I steeled myself.

“The Board voted to terminate your role in the partnership. They voted to buy out your shares at current valuation.”

“Effective when?”

“Today at 5:00pm.”

I took a deep breath. As of 5:00pm today, our shares were worth less than zero. Liabilities exceeded assets. That would change if we won the bid Friday. But as of today... I was out... and I’d get nothing.

“And?” I asked.

“Dude, what does it matter?”

"Trip. Just tell me."

"They voted to bring in Markson as partner."

"Okay," I said. "Well, good luck. I mean that."

"Dex... I'm fucking sorry... I just... Dude... fucking murder... that's outside my... fuck...."

I laughed. "Yeah, me too buddy, me too."

I hung up before things could get any weirder.

I must have spent some time just staring at the phone because when I looked up, I saw Olivia standing over me, having completed her calls.

"They cut you out," she said.

"They didn't have much choice," I replied.

"Dex, you don't need to pretend with me."

"I'm not. I mean, what were they going to do? I probably fucked them anyway. But cutting ties with me is their only rational approach. Right now, we need to find a way forward that doesn't entangle anyone else."

She nodded. "Let's call Mitch."

We put the phone on speaker, and Olivia dialed. He picked up cautiously. We were calling from an unknown number after all.

"Mitch, it's Olivia."

"You're on the news."

"We know."

"Denise is frantic, she's worried that we'll get connected. She's...."

I put my finger to my lips. I could hear the panic in his voice, and I wanted to let it run.

"She thinks we should have called the cops. That we still should. She... I... you... You didn't use the credit card or... the.... She's worried about any connection."

Olivia seemed ready to jump in. I shook my head.

His monologue continued. "That's why she... I... whatever. Don't use the card. Or the gun. We reported them stolen."

I rolled my eyes. Olivia flushed with anger. I placed a hand on her shoulder to calm her.

I responded. "We understand. When did you report this?"

“Oh, Jesus, Dex, I didn’t—”

“It’s okay. Just, when did you report it?”

He sighed. “Right when you left. Denise insisted.”

Olivia quivered with anger, and I knew it was as much about his effort to shift blame onto his wife as the perfidy itself. I held her gaze and gave her a quick headshake.

“Okay,” I said. “Look, just tell the truth about everything. Don’t fuck around with the cops. You’ll only make things worse. Just tell the truth and everything will be fine.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes,” I replied.

We hung up.

“He betrayed me!” Olivia hissed. “I can’t fucking believe it. I went to him in crisis, and he just...”

I pulled her into a tight hug. “I know. I’m sorry.”

She sobbed in my arms. It was more than just Mitch’s actions, though those were hard enough for her. The man she’d always imagined was there for her, perhaps even more than me, had violated her trust. I knew she’d need to grieve over that, and that would take time. She’s always relied on Mitch as a security blanket, and this had shattered that illusion. I might have been pleased that a persistent competitor for my wife’s trust and affection had disqualified himself, but instead all I could feel was her loss.

We separated and I looked into her red-rimmed, tear-filled eyes. I tried to find words to salve the wound. But there were none. I gave her a soft kiss. And then added a pathetic cliché, “We need to look forward, not back.”

Somehow that resonated. She wiped the tears from her cheeks and nodded. “Forward, not back.”

I gave her some space. She sat by the window staring out over the city as the night slowly fell. I made a few more calls, and then sat at the dining room table with Mac’s last beer pondering the situation.

“So, what now?” she asked.

I jolted. I'd be so lost in thought that I didn't realize she was standing beside me.

"We should probably get some food," I said.

"And some booze," she added.

I pulled a ball cap low over my forehead and went out. I returned twenty minutes later with Chinese takeout and a case of beer. She'd set the table and even found a candle.

"Romantic," I said as I offered her a can of Bud.

She smiled and cracked it open.

We ate in silence for several minutes.

"So, we just wait for Ellis to call back?" she asked.

I shook my head slowly. "No. I mean, we went off in the wrong direction, but we had the right idea. This is about us somehow, which means we know the killer. We just don't know who."

"We don't?" she said. "I think after the board meeting, we know, don't we? It had to be Markson."

I nodded. "Yeah. He's at the top of my list. But honestly, I don't trust my list at this point. I was sure Mac was involved, and honestly, I'm still not sure he wasn't."

"Oh?"

"Let's come back to him. Let's talk about Markson first. I don't like the guy. I doubt he much likes me. He's manipulative and underhanded. He doesn't mind hurting other people to get what he wants. And boxing me out and taking over my shares is a clear motive."

"Right. We probably should have focused on him sooner."

"Maybe. But the problem is, that's all speculation, and it is speculation shaped by personal animosity. We have no evidence that he was involved. I'm not even sure I can tell a story like we could about Mac. What, Markson was stalking me, looking for dirt to use against me and he stumbled into this?"

"Why not?"

"I dunno, just seems weirdly convenient. And it just doesn't feel like Markson, you know?"

"How do you figure?"

“Well, for one, he’s a horndog. If he knew we were playing around, his first instinct would be to bed you, not set up some involved murder plot. And, we know Markson, how could he have been following us?”

“I knew Mac.”

“But you hadn’t seen him in a decade and he had no reason to suspect you might be looking out for him. And anyway, it seems like Mac didn’t do it.”

“Seems?”

“Well, I am trying to keep an open mind, you know. I mean, what if Mac was working with someone?”

“Charlie?”

“Maybe. I... I fucked things up with him. I... was trying to protect you and I went after him pretty aggressively to change his plans.”

“Oh Dex.”

“I’m sorry. It just... anyway, I sort of threatened that I’d go public with his harassment.”

She winced. “Ugh.”

“Yeah.”

“But... on the other hand, now that we know what we know, that actually makes him more likely, doesn’t it? Because as it turns out, it wasn’t just a fifteen year old, he-said, she-said story, which, by the way, would get no traction since I’ve continued to work with him all these years. But instead, it had him tangled up in an extortion plot and a murder. At best, that’s an ugly story to be connected with.”

“You really think Charlie could be involved?” I asked.

She shook her head. “No. It doesn’t feel right. But like you said, we need to keep an open mind.”

“Anyway, back to Markson. There are so many gaps,” I said. “How did he know about Denny and Zach? Did he steal my gun at the party? When did you even invite him?”

“Just a couple of days before. I was feeling wicked.”

“Right, so, it’s just... Markson being involved means a lot of pieces coming together all at once.”

“So what does that leave?”

"I don't know. I've been running it over in my mind. And honestly, the person who seems to best fit this is... Trip."

"Trip?" she repeated.

"It doesn't really make sense," I admitted. "But he knew all the pieces. Denny, Zach, my gun. Heck, he probably even knows the combination to the gun safe. And maybe he got greedy. Trace is pregnant again. He bailed on Inter-Best a couple of months before the acquisition, so maybe he wanted to squeeze me out of this. I dunno."

"He's your best friend."

"I know. So what better cover? But, then again... why did he meet me at the church with money? All he had to do was call the cops then and there, right?"

"Maybe he needed for you to be arrested later?"

"But why? Even today, he needed the cops to go public with my name before he could go to the board to push me out. The sooner I got arrested, the better for him."

She nodded. "So Trip."

"Yeah, Trip." We ate in silence for another few minutes. I got us another round of beers. "Who else knew enough to make this happen?"

Olivia chewed slowly. She took a sip of beer. "Well, Tracey," she said, "but that gets us back to Trip, doesn't it? And... Val? I guess Val knew a lot of it."

"How much did you tell her?"

"She knew about Denny and Zach. I even told her their names, though I doubt I gave enough details for her to track them down. But she had first names and general descriptions. And she was down in the basement during the party."

"Messing around with Denise," I said.

"Right, but that would give her an excuse if you happened to catch her messing with the gun safe."

"Val has always been jealous of me," I noted.

"Of any man I've been with. And the whole thing with Mac sharing me really set her off. If she thought you were doing the same sort of thing.... I don't know. Maybe she might have just snapped?"

“None of that feels right.”

“Val?”

“Val, Trip, Markson, Charlie. I mean, we can tell a story about each, but... I dunno. If you were Torres and Land would you even give a second thought to any of those suspects?” I chuckled. “I mean, I can’t even quite call them that with a straight face.”

“Well, the alternative is that it is someone completely off the radar. Someone we’d never suspect with some sort of deep, dark connection to me or you. A kid you bullied in middle school. A guy who I turned down in college.”

“Oh, I didn’t realize you ever turned anyone down.”

She threw a strand of Lo Mein at me. “Idiot.”

I took her hand and squeezed it.

Mac came home after work. I think he sort of wished that he had come back to an empty apartment, but he didn’t say anything to indicate it. He was grateful for the leftover Chinese and the remaining beers, and he even offered us his bedroom.

Olivia made up the bed, and I thought I caught an amused grin when she realized I’d be sleeping in her wet spot. Well, it was dry by now, but we both knew where it had been.

It had only been a couple of days, but despite that, being in a real bed, with my wife, seemed like a throwback to a lost age. I tried to put it out of mind, but the truth was, there was a good chance that in thirty-six hours, I’d be behind bars, and would never see Olivia or my kids except through plexiglass for the rest of my life.

“What are you thinking?” she asked.

I wasn’t about to share those thoughts. Not because I didn’t think Olivia was having similar concerns, but rather because I didn’t trust myself to say them out-loud without going to pieces. Instead, I decided to pivot.

“Mac is not like I expected him to be.”

“Yeah, he’s changed,” she confirmed. “Prison does that, I guess, and also he’s in his late 30s now, rather than mid-twenties.”

And that changes a person too.”

“Well, he hasn’t changed completely.”

I knew she was blushing. “No, some things stay the same.”

“Would you rather be in bed with him instead of me?”

“No, of course not. I mean, I can always go visit him on the sofa, right?” she teased.

I laughed. “But seriously.... I’ve never seen you like that before. It was intense with Mitch, and pretty wild with Willie, but neither of them affected you like Mac.”

“It’s a plumbing issue, apparently. Most women find cervical pressure to be painful; I find it intensely pleasurable. And most men are not quite long enough to reach the cervix anyway, so it doesn’t matter. But he’s also thick, so he puts pressure on the whole length of my clit, the head, of course, but also inside, the g-spot. He literally pushes all my buttons.”

“You’ve analyzed this pretty thoroughly.”

She chuckled. “Sorry, let me translate to man talk. Big dick feel good.”

I laughed. “Will you continue to see him while I’m locked away?”

“Oh Dex, let’s not talk about that. This will all work out.”

“It would be okay. I mean, not just him. Whoever. There is no reason for you to be alone after I’m—”

She rose up on her elbow. “No. Listen, you are not going away. We’re going to solve this.”

“What if I did do it?”

“What are you saying Dex?”

I went through the red flags. The sleepwalking, the mysterious driving, and finally the murderous rage that I felt when I watched her with Mac. “I don’t know,” I concluded. “Maybe I did it all in, like, some trance or something.”

“You really do read too many of those detective novels.”

“No, but seriously, O, what if—”

“And you don’t remember any of it? And despite being in some strange fugue, you were able to cover your tracks, eliminate blood or

other stains on your clothes, remember to hide your gun after killing Denny, but remember where to find it in time to kill Zach?"

I sighed. "You're probably right. Just... keep an eye on me, okay? Just in case I lose it?"

"Always."

She scooted toward me and we began to kiss. I eased off her t-shirt and kissed her breasts. Her hand slipped into my boxers. She ran her fingernail up the length of my shaft. It was a light touch, and yet always made me hard. She stroked my cock as we kissed. I slipped my hand into her panties and cupped her shaved mound. She moaned softly as I made slow circles with my fingertips, slowly sliding between her folds.

"Oh God," I sighed. "I wish I could make you come like he does."

She kissed me passionately. "You make me come just right."

I rubbed her clit. "I want to see it again."

"You will Dex, one day, I promise." Then she got it. "You mean right now?"

"Mmmm," I sighed as I slipped beneath the covers, trailing kisses down between her breasts and across her belly. I nibbled on her inner thighs and then flicked at her clit with the tip of my tongue.

"Oh oh oh," she moaned.

I licked her deeper. I don't know if I was looking for his taste, but I didn't find it in any case.

"Oh God," she sighed. "You're getting me ready for my lover, aren't you?"

I hummed a "yes" against her clit.

She gasped, and her pussy went from wet to soaked in an instant. "What if he doesn't want to fuck me?"

"He will."

"And after?"

"Then you come back to me, you promise?"

She nodded. "Oh Dex."

"I don't care how many times you do it," I said, "but after, you come back to me."

I peeled off the covers and helped my naked wife to her feet. I held her hand as we walked to the sliding door. I positioned her in the middle, and then slowly pulled the door open, revealing her to Mac. He seemed shocked, and even shook his head a few times, but when Olivia climbed into his lap, his hands went to her breasts and their kiss couldn't hide the passion.

Perhaps it was my impending incarceration, maybe it was the fact that I had unambiguously initiated this encounter, but this time I felt none of the rage and anger that had both marred and heightened our previous adventures. I still felt jealousy at the size of his prick and the hardness of his body, and even more acutely at the way he so fully possessed her, body and soul. Intellectually I knew she was just lost in the moment, in the physical sensations. But there was undeniable love in her eyes as she worshipped his big cock with her lips, her tongue, her hands. The way she writhed against him, caressing his naked body with hers. And then when he was inside her, her abandon was palpable. In those minutes, then hours, her world seemed to become only him: his body, his hands, his lips, his cock, and all the overwhelming sensations that washed over her.

I became invisible, circling them slowly, sometimes close, sometimes far. Maybe they noticed me, maybe Olivia was putting on a bit of a show, but there was no tell, no wink, no reassuring smile. If they were playing a part, they gave no evidence. They never broke the fourth wall. She came again and again, sometimes in thrashing, thunderstorm orgasms, other times with gentle shivers as she kissed his neck and whispered "thank you" into his ear. He came three times. The first, in her mouth, at her request, and she used the sloppy mix of spit and jism to quickly stroked and suck him back to readiness. The second time, he came in her pussy, and I wouldn't have known except for his groans and the copious amount of come that leaked out of her after, which he used as lube to press his thumb into her anus. His third orgasm came as he fucked her like the sweaty, slutty, bitch she was at that moment. On her hands and knees, getting pounded roughly from behind, his thumb in her ass, pulling back on her blonde hair. After, he fell backward into a sitting position, as Olivia collapsed into a dripping, gasping ball on the floor.

I collected her hot, heaving body into my arms and carried her back into the bedroom. I slid the door shut behind us, and climbed onto the bed beside her.

I switched on the lamp on the bedside table and draped my shirt over the top to dim the light. Olivia's head lolled slowly, her hands roaming over her body distractedly, as she slowly seemed to return the present. I kissed her gently, trailing my fingers over her hot, clammy body.

"Oh Dex," she sighed. "Oh Dex."

"Was that good?"

"Oh Dex," she just said again.

I traced the outline of her puffy areolas, then caressed down between her breasts and over her belly. Her abs rippled beneath her smooth skin. Then lower. She moaned softly as I touched her swollen, wet labia. She placed her hand over mine.

"Are you sore?" I asked.

"Mmmm, yes, I can feel my heart beating in my pussy."

I slid down the bed to get a closer look. Her snatch looked like a rare, open-faced, roast beef sandwich, topped with a generous amount of mayo-like jism. It was beautiful. I explored her pussy with my hands. She was so smooth, oddly silky. My finger entered her easily; she was still stretched wide by Mac's thick cock. When I withdrew my digit, another stream of jism flowed out.

"You're so full of his come."

She crunched up and rested on her elbows. "Mmmm, imagine how much more is in there. Deep, deep inside." She ran her hand through my hair. "Are you going to eat me or fuck me?"

I wished I was confident enough to lick her clean, but I couldn't quite bring myself to do it.

"I want to put my dick in your loose, sloppy cunt."

She pulled my face up to hers. "That's the most romantic thing I've ever heard," and it worked as both a deadpan joke and an acknowledgment of how bizarre, and exciting, things were between us.

I chuckled. She kissed me.

"You sure you don't want to taste it first?"

“I’m not ready for that.”

“Then fuck me.”

I entered her. It was hot, wet, and frictionless, which normally might be off-putting, but now served as a constant reminder that she had just fucked another, much bigger, man.

“Are you in yet?” she teased.

“Maybe I should flip you over and put it somewhere tighter.”

“Yeah, maybe you should.”

I churned my dick into that gooey mess, considering the possibility. It was tempting, but more exciting was a more twisted thought.

“No, only your lovers get your ass.”

“Should Mac be the only one? Or should I offer that to all my other men.”

“All of them.”

She sighed and although hard to believe, her pussy seemed to get even hotter and wetter. My dick squished with each thrust, and I felt more jism leaking out of her. She was loose enough that she could easily take a second dick at the same time, assuming it wasn’t as big as Mac’s.

“Have you ever had two men at once?”

“Of course. Many times with Mac. There is nothing quite like getting pounded from behind while slobbering all over his big cock. The reverse doesn’t work as well. He fucks so hard and good that it messes up my cock-sucking technique. Would you like to try that now?”

“You can’t get enough of him.”

She laughed. “Sure I can, but I have a decade to make up for.”

“Are you going to go back to him after I’m done with you?”

Her pussy seemed to flutter. “Yes, I’m going to let him fuck my asshole, just like you want me to. And you’re going to hold my hand and listen to me scream while he does it.”

I groaned and began fucking her faster.

“Oooh, you like that idea, Baby? You want to be right there with me while a man with a horse cock destroys my asshole? You want to

hear me scream and beg for mercy even as I come uncontrollably? Do you want to see his come dripping out of my gaping ass?"

"Oh God."

"That's it Dex, add your come to his. Give me the lube I'm going to use to get my ass ready for him."

I was close. Olivia helped me along. Her hands, that had been gripping my ass, reached down between her legs. She gave my scrotum a squeeze. Then she slid her hand between my butt cheeks. Her fingertip touched my anus. It was wet with the leakage from her cunt. Our eyes locked.

"Have you ever had anything up there?" she asked.

I shook my head.

"The first time, it's like a lightning bolt. It hurts, but it also electrifies."

"Olivia, noooooooooahhhh, fuck!"

She pressed in, probably just an inch or so, but it was enough. I felt my ass spasm against the invading digit. Her grin widened, and we went in deeper. I panted like a dog. My whole body felt tingly. A little deeper.

"Oh God!" There it was. The lightning bolt. I thrust into her almost involuntarily. And then I was coming, hard, as hard as I had ever come. A dozen huge spurts, or at least that's what it felt like.

Olivia was laughing as my hearing returned. I was sprawled across her, gasping, and drenched in sweat.

She chuckled. "That's your prostate, Baby. Probably feels about the same as when Mac pokes at my cervix."

I rolled over onto my back. I stared at Mac's ceiling.

"Why didn't you ever do that to me before?"

"I thought you'd think I was a whore."

"I would have liked it... thinking you were a whore."

"How was I supposed to know that?"

Olivia's hand went to my crotch. She slowly stroked my cock, milking the last few drops from my slimy prick.

"I should probably clean up this mess," she said.

She kissed her way down across my chest. She flicked the head of my penis with her tongue. My head spun, and an insane

thought forced its way into my head.

"I have a mess to clean up too," I replied.

"Want to take a shower?" she asked.

"No," I replied. I wrapped my arms around her sweaty body and rearranged her, onto me, with her mouth at my crotch, and her pussy in my face.

"Dex, are you sure?"

I answered by licking at her sticky snatch. Fuck, it was debauched. It was literally flowing out of her. My come. His come. Her juices. A gooey mess, sticky, salty and musky, but I reveled in it. It was all over my face, and I used my hands to spread her apart even more so I could jam my tongue deeper into her literally manhandled hole.

She sucked me into her mouth to the root. Her lips pulled at my balls as if she wanted to take them into her mouth as well. And she might have been able to had I not gotten hard again so quickly. As I stiffened, she began to bob up and down. Her tongue was a miracle, swirling my shaft, licking at the head like it was ice cream.

I sucked on her clit, harder than I would have ever dared before... before I knew what a dirty slut she could be, before I knew how hard she liked it. She hissed and returned the favor on my prick. I gasped. I wondered what it would be like to be in this position and to have Mac fucking her, his dick inches from my face. I wanted to tell Olivia about it, but from the way she was grinding against me, I suspected she was already thinking something like that. She thrust back against me harder and faster, fucking her pussy against my face. I tried to keep my tongue in place, but I gave up as she just humped me wildly. She was more disciplined though, continuing to work my cock with such maddening skill that it was impossible not to think about all the men on whom she'd practiced. Or maybe that was just me. I was close, so close. She squeezed my balls. I mauled her ass. Her rock hard nipples grazed across my belly. She squealed from around my cock, her body undulating in waves. I came as well and she slurped down every drop.

We lay there for a long moment gasping. Shocked at the intensity we'd drawn from each other. We disentangled and she

curled up beside me. I managed to pull a cover around us. She kissed my neck, my face. She was crying, big wet drops.

“Oh, Dex, oh Dex, I love you so much. So much, Baby, so much.”

I wrapped my arms around her and squeezed her as tight as I could.

“I love you too, O. You have no idea.”

Chapter Sixteen: Tick Tock

I woke up early, despite not having much sleep. We'd earlier admired his view east over the city, but hadn't remembered to make sure the blinds were closed. So shortly after 5:30am, the bedroom was bathed in glorious, red-gold sunlight.

My face was still sticky and my breath stale. I splashed some water on my face and "brushed" my teeth with toothpaste on my finger. When I came back out, Olivia was sitting up in the bed, wrapped in sheets as if in a movie. She cocked her head at me.

"Are we okay?" she asked.

"Why wouldn't we be?"

She laughed, loud and throaty. "Um, because unless last night was a dream... we were up to some kinky shit. And that doesn't always feel as good the next morning."

I sat beside her and kissed her cheek.

"Last night was amazing. I just wish we'd started exploring sooner, rather than...." I couldn't finish the thought.

She placed her hands on my cheeks. "It will work out."

"I know." But I didn't know.

Satisfied that I wasn't about to lose it, she shimmied out of the sheet and walked naked into the bathroom. I heard the shower come on, and I pondered the day ahead. What I wanted to do, what I really wanted to do, was spend the day in Mac's apartment, with Olivia and her lover, exploring whatever remaining secrets lurking in my wife's closet and acting out whatever fantasies still existed unexplored. I wanted a ringside view of his dick in her ass. I wanted to be inside her while another man fucked her. I wanted her to sit on my face while she sucked his cock. For my last day or freedom, I wanted to act out every lurid, crazy, slutwife fantasy I'd ever had.

But I couldn't. We couldn't. It would never have worked. It required too much denial, and we were both too aware of the ticking clock.

Charlie and Mac. I couldn't let the fact that Mac was some sort of perfect Bull for my hotwife fantasies distract me from the fact that

something remained very odd about their relationship. I could see Mac's part in the story, but Charlie's remained a bit hard to grasp fully. Why had he gone so far out of his way, involving himself in what was, after all, a criminal enterprise, to protect Olivia from the consequences of her indiscretions? I couldn't help but wonder if Olivia wasn't maybe, still now, hiding something about their relationship. But why would she?

Markson. I had to be careful here. I'd let myself get distracted by my emotions with Mac. My sentiments toward Markson were almost wholly different, but it would be easy to tunnel-vision on him as we had on Mac. He was clear and ruthless, but not omniscient and omnipresent. How in the world could he have known enough about what Olivia and I were up to in order to frame me? We needed more information from him, and annoyingly, I could only think of one way to maybe get him to talk.

As if honed in on my thoughts, Olivia emerged from the bathroom naked, save for a towel wrapped around her wet hair. I marveled again at the recuperative powers of her body. That's a heads up for men. Your wife's pussy can get torn up by a monster cock the night before, but after a few hours of sleep, and a shower, she'll have no visible blemish on her chastity. Of course, much of that relies on the willful suspension of disbelief. According to legend, Prince Rainier managed to convince himself that Grace Kelly, one of the most notorious man-eaters of the golden age of Hollywood, was a virgin on their wedding night. Her icy blonde beauty let her get away with that. It was the same sort of self-delusion that had kept me from wondering too much about Olivia's past... much to my chagrin.

"What are you thinking?" she asked.

"That if we need to get information from Markson, you might need to make the first move."

She laughed and patted her bare pussy. "Hear that Kitty? That's why Mommy shaved you this morning. A girl's work is never done."

"You seem okay with all of this."

She dug into her Walmart purchases and slipped on a tiny thong. "It's not every day you get to act like a complete slut and have it be for a good cause."

I rolled my eyes. She continued dressing, slipping on a red bodycon dress that only came down to mid-thigh. It was tight enough that it was obvious she was braless. She went back into the bathroom to dry her hair.

Val was also on my list. She'd never made any secret about wanting Olivia back. And it was obvious as well that the idea of Olivia's men sharing her infuriated her. She had played with Denise the night of the party, but I wondered if in the back of her mind, that might have pushed her over the edge. We'd essentially made her complicit in our hotwife game, and maybe.... It didn't really make sense. It played too much into the old, deranged lesbo trope. And yet, with a little help, maybe she could be responsible. Maybe she imagined this whole murderous and tawdry affair would finally convince Olivia that men were not worth it.

"Now what?" Olivia asked when she returned.

"I think you need to have a conversation with Val as well. There are a lot of missing pieces, but what if she really resented being a party to you messing around with Mitch at our party?"

"She didn't seem to mind getting a free run at Denise."

Then it clicked. "And what if Denise wasn't as cool with it as she let on?"

Olivia shook her head. "No that.... Well, wait.... She was definitely not happy to see us when we came down to warn Mitch."

"And she did almost turn us over the cops by reporting the credit card stolen immediately."

"Hmmm. Val and Denise... it still doesn't feel quite right, but yeah, between what Val knew and what I told Mitch at the party, which he probably told his wife, she might have had enough to pull the threads together. Okay, well I guess after I get done pumping Markson for information, I'll need to find some time to feel out Val."

I nodded. "That leaves Trip. I just can't imagine that he's involved... but he's the one person I confided in... maybe too much. I don't know. It...."

Olivia patted me on the shoulder. "It is someone close to us. We need to chase down any leads we can." She paused. "You okay?"

"No."

"Take a shower. You'll feel better. I'll get some coffee and breakfast."

I nodded again and watched as she slipped open the bedroom door and quietly snuck past a still-sleeping Mac toward the front door. Then I rose and went into the bathroom and ran myself a steaming, hot shower. It was a luxury I probably wouldn't have an opportunity to enjoy much in the future.

When I got out of the shower, I found Olivia and Mac sitting at his dining room table having breakfast. He gave me a small nod as he sipped his coffee. Olivia offered me a sugar-glazed cruller that reminded me of how her pussy had looked coated in jism. I waved it off and instead grabbed a half-toasted bagel. It wasn't as good.

"So, were you in touch with Charlie the whole time...." I asked.

"I was in prison?"

"Yeah. Well, off and on. He reached out every once in a while, made sure I had a few bucks in my commissary account."

"That was... uh... nice of him."

Mac eyed me sideways. "It feels like you're driving at something."

"Dex...." Olivia said.

"I'm just trying to make sense of everything that's happened," I said. "Like, did you and Charlie talk about Olivia?"

"Like when?" he asked. "When I was away or when I got out?"

"Either."

Olivia shifted in her chair. For all the fun we'd had with Mac last night, he was still a potentially violent man, who had spent more than half his life locked up. She didn't want me to push him.

"Where is this going?" he asked.

I screwed up my courage. "Look, man, someone has set me up to take the fall for two murders. I don't completely get what's up with you and Charlie now, and," I glanced at my wife, "I don't completely understand what was going on with you, Charlie, and my wife back when...."

"I smashed a guy's skull?"

"Yeah, Mac, when you bashed a guy's skull."

"Dex!" Olivia snapped.

Mac and I locked eyes. He placed his palms on the table. The muscles in his arms rippled. If he rose and lunged at me, there was little I'd be able to do to defend myself. My heart raced, but I forced myself to remain calm and still. His rapid breaths filled the silence.

"I could have called the cops the minute I saw you two on TV," he said.

"Yup."

"And for all I know," he continued, "you could have killed those two dudes. I know you have a gun."

"Yup. And it's in the other room," I noted.

He relaxed. "Look man, it was a long time ago."

"Yeah, and you had a lot of time to think about what happened, so don't give me some story about how you don't remember or were too tweaked out at the time or whatever. Olivia thinks you nickel and dimed her out to some of your buddies—"

"Jesus, Dex!" Olivia hissed.

I ignored her. "But now that I've gotten a bit of a measure of you, that doesn't sound quite right. What else was going on?"

"I told you, man. A prison guard went to Charlie with a tape."

"Yeah, and then what happened."

He sighed and glanced over at my wife. "You sure you want to do this?"

"Mac, what?" she asked.

He seemed puzzled. "You really don't know?"

She shook her head. "Know what?"

A light went on for me. "Olivia, did you and Charlie ever sleep together?"

"No," she said. "I told you, he made... well, I thought he made a pass at me, but.... Jesus, what is going on?"

I turned to Mac. "Dude, she doesn't know. You're not protecting her. Just... what happened."

"You know he's obsessed with you, right?" Mac said.

"I don't know about obsessed, I mean—"

"I made tapes for him," Mac interjected.

Olivia stared at him, open mouthed. "What?" she said finally.

"When he saw the tapes from the jail, he wanted more. He wanted better quality. Close-ups. Sound. He paid me to make those for him. He paid me to get other guys involved."

"You had sex with me for money?"

"No, I had sex with you because you're a hot, kinky slut..." he paused.

"No, that's all right," she said with a slight blush. "That part is probably true."

I took her hand and gave it a squeeze.

"But, I filmed it for money. And I got other guys involved because that's what Charlie wanted to see. He wanted tapes of me having anal with you, and—"

"Okay, we don't need all the details," I said. "And the fight in the bar?"

"Look, it was all fucked up. Charlie wanted more. He kept wondering what would have happened if the guards had walked in on us when I was still in jail. He had this scene in mind, you know. They interrupt us mid-fuck, and then a bunch of them take turns with Olivia. He wanted real guards, and I knew I couldn't control that. Not like just inviting a few buddies to act as unsuspecting porn stars. Charlie was thinking with his dick, you know. Fucking fever shit. I set up a meeting, and it went south. Guy was all mouthy."

He looked at Olivia. "I'm sorry," he said. "I know this is all fucked up."

She forced a rueful laugh. Her eyes were red with tears.

"What happened when you got out?"

"Charlie wanted new tapes. Videos. High def this time."

"You filmed us last night?" she asked.

He shook his head. "No, didn't know you'd be coming. I probably would have."

"But you did follow Olivia, right?"

He nodded. "I couldn't always. I have to work my job. But John's pretty flexible, so...."

"What happened with Denny and Zach?" I asked.

"I don't know."

I sighed. "Mac, did you kill them?"

"He was in jail at least when Denny died," Olivia noted.

"Did Charlie?" I asked.

"I don't know anything about them," Mac said. "Look, he wanted me to spy on Olivia and if I saw an opportunity, maybe make a move. I took a bunch of pictures, but nothing more. I... I don't know what would have happened over the next few weeks. But...."

"But, what?" I said.

"So," Mac began. "I am not sure about this, but... I think he had someone else on the payroll."

"Someone else checking up on Olivia?"

He nodded. "He never came out and said it. But it was like, 'well, if you can't cover the weekends, *she* can.' Something like that. Like I was part of a team."

"She?" I repeated.

He nodded.

I glanced over at Olivia. And we both mouthed the same word at the same time, "Val?"

Before we could continue the conversation, my phone rang. It was Ellis.

"They want you in now," he said.

"Can't do that," I replied.

He sighed. "You're just making things worse for yourself. But that's what I told them. As long as we bring you in by eight o'clock tomorrow morning, they won't make a case against anyone for accessory after the fact, unless there is another criminal act associated with it."

"What does that mean?"

“Well, if part of protecting you involved stealing property or assault or something, they’ll prosecute, but not like if someone just put a roof over your head.”

I thought about Mitch. He’s transferred a weapon to me. That was probably a crime. I tried to think of other possible issues.

“Is Colorado a one party or two-party consent to record conversations.”

“One party,” he answered. “Why, what are you up to?”

“I’ll tell you later.”

“I can’t represent you unless I know what you’re up to.”

“Look, tomorrow is fine. But I need a firmer guarantee on accessory.”

“You’re not getting it, Dex, and what’s more, you’re pushing your luck already. They’re going to stack everything and request no bail. You’re already looking at...” I heard him counting softly. “At least 14 charges.”

“I know. Once I go in, the only way I get out is if things go my way at trial. And even then, with that many charges, the jury will find me guilty on at least some of them.”

“It’s good to have a realistic client for once,” he said. “You’re not going to flee, are you? If you burn me even by a minute, I can’t represent you.”

“I won’t. I’ll be at your office at seven-thirty tomorrow morning.”

I ended the call and looked at my watch. I had almost exactly twenty-four hours of freedom left.

Chapter Seventeen: A Break

We left Mac in the living room and retreated to his bedroom to talk privately.

“How are you doing?” I asked.

“I... I don't know. Has it only been three days? It feels like my whole life is upside down.”

“I know.”

“Charlie.... I spent years thinking he was just the usual older man, who let his dick get the better of him for a moment, but otherwise was a decent, if paternalistic mentor. But I mean, that's par for the course. If you're a woman, it's sort of expected. Even the nicest guy will check out your ass or peek at your tits. It's like, you roll your eyes and move on. And that whole mentor-protege relationship is always a little creepy, but that's life. But this....” She shook her head. “I mean, you know that men who know you professionally will perv on your Instagram bikini posts, or whatever. And that's the price you pay if you want to put that out there, so....”

“It's one thing to have private thoughts,” I said. “As long as you're professional about it, I guess.”

She nodded. “That's the expectation, right? And that's the fucked up thing. He has been professional, mostly. Nothing really out of the ordinary. Except that was all a lie. I'm in shock. Fuck! He paid my boyfriend for videos of me getting tag-teamed and... having anal sex. And I'm not even that upset at Mac. I shouldn't have expected anything better from him, and oddly, knowing that he was making videos for Charlie rather than just selling my ass for a couple of bucks feels... I don't know, better? Jesus, what a fucked-up situation.”

“I'm not any better than Charlie,” I admitted. “I pushed you into all sorts of situations to please my dick. He and I are two sides of the same coin. I'm sorry. I know you won't be able to forgive me, nor should you.”

“Oh, Dex, no. It's completely different. You're my husband. My love. Making your dick happy makes me happy. And I've never felt

closer to anyone or more connected than we've been the last few weeks and last night. You saw me at my dirtiest, rawest; you saw the crazy animal inside me, and you liked what you saw. You saw me at my very worst, in thrall to my passions, giving myself to another man, and instead of pushing me away, you held me close."

I smiled through my tears. "I love you, Olivia. I love everything about you. I love your smarts and kindness. And I love the way you curse and fuck. I love how you are with our kids. And I love your passions. I... I just wished we'd discovered all of this sooner, instead of at the last minute."

"No, it's not the last minute. It is the first minutes of the rest of our lives." Her eyes shone a little maniacally. "You can't give up. You're going to beat this. We're going to beat this."

I nodded though I couldn't muster up the same confidence she seemed to have.

"What now?" I said.

"Well, you are right about one thing. Time is short. We need to confront people directly and hope to shake something loose. See, as desperate as we may be right now, that means our enemies are vulnerable because if we're worried that failure is on the immediate horizon, they're over-confident imagining success. And we need to use that against them."

"So Val or Charlie?"

"Charlie. He's behind this."

"I still have trouble believing that," I replied.

"Even after what Mac told us? I mean, it all sort of fits, doesn't it? Starting a new firm would keep me under his control. It explains why Charlie gave Mac this apartment to use. And the combined fear of losing me and your threats made him decide to lash out against you."

I nodded. "But murder?"

"He literally paid money to get tapes of me getting fucked up the ass so he could jerk off. He's got a fucking screw loose."

"So Mac says... he might just be covering something else up. We need to confirm Mac's story before anything else, right? So maybe we have Mac call him and say that he hooked up with you."

"Won't he want proof?" she asked.

"Well, that should be easy enough to acquire."

She smirked and strode back out into the living room.

"All right, Stud, looks like you're about to earn your keep," she said to Mac.

He responded with an incredulous eye-roll. "Look, I just want to get out of this situation, you know? Like, live a normal life."

"You will, Baby. But first, you're going to make a nice little video for Charlie. And make it good... but not too good. We want him wanting more."

She grabbed his phone from the desk and handed it to him. She led him over to the sofa and knelt down between his legs.

"Okay, show time," she said.

He began filming. She unzipped his pants. She fished out his big prick.

"Oh God," she sighed. "You have no idea how much I missed this cock."

She fondled his heavy member and licked him up and down before taking the bulbous head into her mouth.

"Mmmmm, so tasty," she cooed.

She slurped him noisily, smacking her lips, and letting out delighted little mewls. He stiffened quickly, and she took advantage to stroke his hard shaft as she suckled his balls.

He glanced up at me. I gave him a thumbs up and mouthed, "Put on a show."

He nodded.

"You like that big dick, don't you?" he said. He wove his fingers into her hair possessively.

"Mmmm, yeah," she replied.

She kissed him tenderly up the bottom of the shaft and then took his cockhead back in her mouth.

"That's it, Slut, take it," he said.

He pressed down on her head forcing another inch or two into her mouth, until she gagged messily on his tool. He released her just long enough to catch her breath before choking her again with his

meat. When he let her up again, she gasped, and a thick stream of spit connected her lips to his cock.

“You can do better than that, can’t you Slut?”

He gripped his huge prick and slapped her back and forth across the face with it, a wet salami splatting her cheeks. She took it submissively, her tongue reaching out to get a lick in as he abused her.

“You want it back in your mouth, don’t you?”

“Mmmm, yeah,” she enthused.

“You’re going to do better this time, right?”

She nodded rapidly. “Yes, yes, please let me suck it again.”

He gave her one more hard slap across the cheek, and then jammed his cock back her mouth. She struggled with it, maybe getting another inch or so past her stretched lips, as slobber dripped down to her chin. Red-faced she gagged on his tool. He finally released her as she turned scarlet.

“Gonna need to try another hole.”

She gazed up at him from between his legs and licked her lips. He stood and barked at her, “Get up on the table.” He followed my wife with the phone’s camera as she obeyed his orders. He approached and she instinctively spread her legs and hiked up her dress. He focused in tight on her shaved snatch.

“You ready, Baby?” he asked.

She responded by spreading her lips, exposing the juicy pink within. Without hesitation she thrust two fingers inside herself. She withdrew then and held them out to the camera for inspection.

“I’m so wet,” she sighed.

“Got some wet ass pussy? Need a mop and bucket?”

She giggled. “Please fuck me.”

He moved in closer. She seized his cock and began rubbing it between her slick, puffy lips, moaning like a whore as she did.

“Please,” she begged.

He thrust in. She let out a high-pitched squeak and began to shimmy from side to side. He buried himself inside her in one, continuous, confident stroke. As he hit bottom, her ass rose off the table and she shuddered. He pulled out and slapped his heavy prick

against her clit. She reached down and urgently stuffed him back inside her. He thrust in hard. She gasped and fell back against the table, her knees rising in the air. His deep strokes had the same effect as last night, waves of pleasure rolling over her. She gasped and moaned. Her head swung side to side. She pulled her dress off her shoulders and exposed her breasts, and as he fucked her, she played with her nipples until they stood up, long and hard.

“Where do you want my nut?” he asked.

“I want to taste it,” she growled.

He pulled out and she slid off the table, onto her knees before him. She stroked his slimy prick with both hands, mouth open wide, tongue out. His first spurt shot deep into her mouth, and the next several pooled on her tongue. She milked every last drop, ending up with a mouthful of his creamy jism. Then with a loud gulp she swallowed it all, and opened her mouth to prove it.

He ended the video.

“Shit, you two ought to make porn for real,” I said.

Olivia laughed. Mac shook his head. She rose from her knees and went to the bathroom to freshen up.

“Okay, what now?” he asked.

“Now you call Charlie,” I said.

He picked up his phone but hesitated before dialing. He looked at me. “What do you get out of this, man?”

I knew what he was asking.

“It’s still new. So who knows how it will wear? But I just love seeing her so wild and free. I honestly had no idea she had that in her. And you have no idea how exciting it is when someone you’ve been with over a decade surprises you like that. You get in a rut, and you don’t even know that’s where you are.”

He shook his head again. I couldn’t blame him. I’d have felt the same way if I were him.

“Mac? I’m going away. For a long fucking time. Maybe forever. I know that. Am I... gonna make it?”

“Yeah. Look, most of the trouble people get into inside. It’s horseshit. Guys are bored. They have nothing better to do than beef. Most of ‘em, they don’t even know anything other than beefs. It’s all

they've ever done. Man, that was me. Back when I was a kid. Fucking stupid. Didn't think there was anything out there. Olivia changed that for me. I fucked it all up. And honestly, she's lucky I did. Because she deserves better than me." He sighed. "Well, she'd have figured that out anyway. But that's what I realized in prison. I mean, what more can you want, right? A girl who has your back. Keeps you sane. Grounded. Gives you something to live for. Anyway, if you do go in... you just... do your time. Give the idiots space. You'll find some other guys to hang with. The ones who've figured it out."

I nodded. "Mac... will you keep an eye on Olivia?"

"No way," she interrupted. "No more of that surrender talk. Dex, we have this thing figured out. Just need to reel him in."

"Mac calling Charlie just confirms that Charlie is a fucking creep," I replied. "Doesn't even come close to tying him to murder."

"Maybe. Though I'm guessing this might be enough to convince Torres and Land to continue the investigation."

"I don't know," I replied. "You heard Ellis. They're locking in and pissed."

Mac nodded. "Cops aren't looking to solve crimes. They're looking to clear cases. And right now, they've got a strong case. Why risk fucking it up?"

"I think we can still crack it," she replied.

"Look, even if we get Charlie on tape acknowledging he asked Mac to track you down and make more tapes, how do we get him to confess murder? He's a perv, not an idiot. Even if we blackmail him, admitting he's a horny shit is still going to be less painful than going down for murder."

"We don't blackmail him. Don't push when we can pull. Didn't either of you ever take Judo?"

We both stared at her blankly.

"Just call Charlie," she said.

Mac sighed but pulled out his phone. He put it on speaker and dialed the number. We began recording the conversation on our own phones.

"Mac?" Charlie answered. He sounded anxious.

"Yeah, man. I have good news."

"Did you see the news?" Charlie asked.

"Yeah, look, I don't know nothing about that. All I know is that Olivia turned up here, looking for me."

"Shit, how'd she find you?"

Mac laughed. "I guess I should have found a job in a different bar. But anyway, she was looking for a place to lie low."

"Is her husband with her?"

Mac looked up and we both shook our heads quickly.

"Naw, man. Look—"

"Where is he?"

"I dunno."

Olivia grabbed a sheet of paper from the desk and scribbled a quick note. Mac nodded as he read it.

"She's scared of him. Doesn't know what to believe. She wanted a place to hide until the cops caught up with him."

"But what about—"

Another quick note.

"Charlie, I have a tape," Mac interrupted.

Silence.

"Well, not a tape. A video. That phone you gave me takes some amazing video."

Olivia rolled her fingers. *Reel him in.*

"You can count the hairs on her snatch," Mac said. "Well, you could if she wasn't completely shaved."

"Did you...."

Mac chuckled, getting into the role. "Did I fuck her? Yeah. And nutted right in her hot, little mouth."

"Send it to me," he croaked.

"More." Olivia mouthed at him.

"I might need a little more spending money," Mac said.

"Okay, okay, whatever. Just send it to me." Then as an afterthought, he added, "Where is she?"

"In my shower, Dude. I'm gonna go join her. Make some more videos."

"Yes... yes... Send me what you have. I'll pay. I'll pay for more."

Mac chuckled. "Yeah, you will."

"Send it to me," Charlie gasped.

"Big file. Might take a little time."

Charlie groaned.

Mac laughed and hung up.

"What now?" he asked.

"You send him the video," Olivia replied.

But first we watched to make sure nothing gave away my presence. It was indeed, as Mac had promised, impressively crisp. You could almost smell the salt and musk of his come on her tongue.

"So, now I go to Charlie?" I asked.

"No, I go see Charlie," she replied.

"And do what?"

"Give him what he wants... but only if he tells the truth."

I figured she had something like that in mind. If we were lucky, the old fuck would keel over at the possibility... after he spilled his guts.

"What do I do while you're gone?" I asked.

"You need to find Val."

"And do what?"

"Keep an eye on her. Either I get a confession out of Charlie, or he stays mum, in which case he'll call Val with a warning. That'll be as good as a confession."

"Well, not quite," I said.

"Close enough. Or at least, it's the best I can think of. Do you have a better solution?"

I pondered for a few moments, but I didn't have any better options.

"Where do I find Val?"

"At work, of course."

"Right... of course."

Olivia smiled at me. "Wish me luck."

"Good luck."

"You too."

She gave me a kiss on the cheek and shot Mac a quick wink. Then she flounced out of the apartment.

“Um, can I borrow some of your clothes?” I asked. “This outfit,” I gestured at my khakis and polo shirt, “will stand out a little around where Val works.”

“What does she do?”

“She owns one of those CrossFit gyms out among the warehouses out in Commerce City. Muscly dude and dudette hammering huge tires with sledgehammers.”

“Sounds like my kind of place.”

I’d thought about that. But I still had questions about him and Charlie, and decided to keep him at a distance.

“Yeah, but you have to work.”

“We could trade,” he said.

I chuckled. “The only thing more out of place than me skulking around warehouses and auto shops would be me trying to haul a keg up the stairs at the bar.”

“All right. Well, let’s see what we can do in terms of a disguise.”

His clothes were a little baggy on me, but that was okay. In grey cargo pants, a lightweight blue-grey plaid shirt, a camo bandana and wrap-around Oakley knock-offs, I looked passably blue-collar, and not very much like my usual “business casual” self. He gave me a pack of cigarettes to further the disguise. I put my regular clothes into the backpack with Mitch’s gun. I shook his hand as we parted. For good or ill, I was pretty sure I’d never see him again.

Olivia had called ahead and confirmed that Charlie had left their office after Mac’s call. It was possible he’d gone home, but since Ellie didn’t work, that seemed unlikely. Instead, she guessed he might have gone to the new office space he’d leased. He’d have a little privacy there. So as I made my way out to Commerce City, she headed up toward Five Points.

We tethered ourselves by phone again, so I could listen in to her activities. I had my earbuds in, and my phone muted. I’d text her if I wanted to communicate with her. We both used public transport,

and I listened in as Olivia got chatted up on several occasions. She was dressed more to go out clubbing than work, and at least one of the guys opened with a joke about a walk of shame, which, actually, given the video she had shot with Mac that morning was not that far off the mark. She shooed away the attention, and happily no one pushed too hard.

I had farther to go than she did, so I was still on a bus, my second, when she arrived at their new office building.

"I'm going to check for his car in the garage," she announced.

I listened as her heels clicked down the concrete ramp into the underground garage, and then as her steps echoed in the parking area itself.

"Yup. There's his car," she announced.

<Dex>: So far, so good. Be careful. He's dangerous.

"Probably not to me," she answered.

I hoped she was right. This was the second time we'd had her approach a possible murderer alone, each time counting on the assumption that they were going to be more interested in fucking her than killing her. I was worried though. Just like it had taken me some time to work past the jealous rages that overcame me when I first began to share Olivia, I wasn't sure how Charlie would actually react to seeing Olivia fucking Mac again. He was deranged and deserved no sympathy, but in a demented sense, he too was in love with her. I tried to put that thought out of my mind.

She started walking again. The echoes abruptly ended, and I assumed she'd entered an elevator. Sure enough, a muted chime sounded as it went up floors. Seven, by my count, which, if the parking was -1 would put her on the 6th floor. I didn't hear much after that. There would be carpeting on the office floors, so no more footsteps.

She took a deep breath. "Okay, there's the office. Jesus, he already has our names on the door. Shreve and Mullins. Let me know when you get to Val's. I'll hide in the ladies until then"

I was almost there.

<Dex>: Getting off bus now.

I hopped out at the next stop. In a couple of minutes I was walking past the gym, which was really just an old warehouse with a parking lot out front. There were a couple of dudes working out outside, and as I walked past, I saw Val working with a client, throwing medicine balls against a wall.

<Dex>: I see her.

“Okay, I’m going in.” She exited the bathroom and took another deep breath. I heard a latch click. “It’s not locked.” She stepped inside and I heard the door close heavily behind her.

I had a panicky urge to stop her, call her back, but I knew it was too late. She wouldn’t be reading texts anymore. I lingered in the general area of Val’s box, but didn’t stay too close. Charlie wouldn’t be calling until after Olivia left. So, I found a quiet nook beside an out-of-use loading dock. I lit up a cig and pretended to be on a smoke break.

“There he is,” she said. “In his office. Door’s open. I think he’s... yeah... he’s watching something on his phone.”

I pictured Charlie sitting at his desk, in a big leather chair, hunched over as he stared at the screen, tugging at his pathetic little dick. I began recording their interaction.

“Erm Charlie?”

He let out a squeak. “Jesus, Olivia, you scared me.” But he recovered quickly. “So you finally decided to check out your new office... I mean, if you accept my offer.”

“What were you watching?”

“I... um... nothing. Just checking email.... Wait... that’s the same....”

“Dress? Well, yes, we just made that video this morning.”

I heard his chair squeak as he leaned back. “Oh God, Olivia, I’m so sorry. He wasn’t.... Fuck.... This wasn’t supposed to happen this way.” He began to put things together. “Where’s Dex?” he sounded nervous.

“Dex is turning himself in.”

“So he did it,” Charlie said. I’d have liked to have seen his face and body language. I couldn’t tell if his statement was a conclusion, a question, or a bluff.

"I don't know. He says he didn't. The evidence suggests he did. It is one of the many mysteries I am trying to understand. Like, this one. Why didn't you tell me you were in love with me?"

His chair squeaked again, and I imagined him standing up. Was he still hard? Did he have a big wet spot on his pants?

"Because I knew you wouldn't be interested in a married man, twenty-five years your senior."

"But what if I am interested in a handsome, successful older man, who has done so much for me over the years. Maybe it's time we were honest with each other instead of wasting more time and hurting more people...."

"You're just shaken up over what's happening with Dex."

"I am," she admitted. "But it's also a wakeup call. You know what Dex and I have been going through."

"I... I don't know what you're talking about."

"Oh Charlie," she sighed. Her voice softened, and I knew it meant she was moving closer to him. "No more lies. Please, no more lies. You've had Mac... and others... following me for a long time."

"No. Not that long. Just since... since that dinner. When I told you about this place, and you got so upset. I was worried that I'd lose you. And at the same time, Mac got his work-release, and... it all.... I went a little crazy."

I gasped. She was so close. He was about to admit everything. I imagined her standing next to him now, maybe gently stroking his forearm, looking into his eyes.

"Who else was following me?"

"Some guy I know. A PI. Well, not formally. Guy I know from a matter I worked a while back. He's like in economic intelligence or something. What does it matter?" He sounded a little exasperated.

A guy. Fuck, now we'd have to go back to Mac and revisit the woman he claimed was following us.

"It's okay. I'm glad you did," Olivia replied in a soothing tone. "Otherwise we wouldn't be having this talk, this chance to make everything right."

"What are you saying, Oli?" He asked, his voice quivering as he used a nickname he probably never normally used. He was close to

a breaking point, but I wasn't sure if he'd break in a confession or by shutting down altogether.

"Dex and I have been in a rut. It's bad, Charlie. We still..." she sobbed. It was a great touch. I could almost sense him softening. "We still have something, and we have kids, but it isn't enough. We fight. We hurt each other. We've been trying to rekindle something, but it's just out of reach. And sometimes... he gets so angry. And I'm scared."

"Oh, I didn't realize."

"You thought it was all just a game? Me with other men?"

"Yes."

"But you've saved me... again."

"I... what?"

I cringed. It was such a fine line, trying to get him to admit to a crime in the hopes it would unlock her love. She had to set the bait, but he had to take the first bite. She realized the same thing and took a different tack.

"You saved me back with Mac. I was crazy, stupid. And you risked your reputation to protect mine."

He sighed. "I wish it was like that, but—"

"I know," she interrupted. "I know your motives were not wholly pure. And that's... okay. What Dex and I tried recently. Well, you should know that I can be open-minded about that sort of thing. We all have needs, desires, kinks. And it's hard because in many cases, we're not supposed to have them. I'm not supposed to be attracted to tattooed bad boys. Dex isn't supposed to be maddened, both in a good and bad way, by the idea of me cheating. You're not supposed to be sexually attracted to a young, powerless subordinate. And you and I are not supposed to act on a deep attraction and connection we feel because we're married. But life is complicated. Often we can't quite control ourselves, even if we hurt other people in the process. And while we can try to avoid that... we need, ultimately, to do what makes us happy. Because that's the only thing that really counts, isn't it?"

"I... I guess."

"I can forgive anything." She let it hang in the air for a long time. "Anything. As long as we're honest. Mac told me a lot. But I need to hear the rest from you."

"I'm sorry, Olivia. I'm sorry about everything I did with you and Mac. I guess he told you about the tapes?"

"Yes."

"And... the...." he trailed off.

"The special requests?"

"Yes," he mumbled.

"Did I seem to enjoy myself?"

"You did."

"I *did*," she emphasized. "And I would never have had the courage to do those things on my own. But I'd always fantasized about being with more than one man at a time... about having anal sex. If it wasn't for you, I'd have never had those amazing experiences. Even if you were being selfish at the time, it met my needs too. It is like you and I are connected, deeply. You sometimes seem to know what I want... what I need... more than I do."

"I do?" he asked.

She kissed him. From the sound, it seemed like a peck on the cheek, but I couldn't be sure. "Yes, and even these past few weeks, I think you've known what I want and need better than I do. Like this place. Of course, I'll be your partner. I was just shocked when you asked, and it came from left field. And to be honest, I was afraid that if it was just you and me, working together, late, building something, that we might not be able to stop ourselves... and that we might hurt others... but now, we've crossed that bridge, and we need forget about the past and look to the future."

"Olivia, I'm not sure what you're proposing, but..."

"That we can be together. You and me. Like you've always wanted."

"Olivia... Sweetie... I... don't want that."

"It's okay. No more lies. Let's just tell the truth about everything and work with that."

"Olivia... I already have everything I want."

"Not everything."

I wondered what she was doing to tempt him. Was she leaning forward in a cleavage-baring pose? Had she subtly hiked up the hem of her dress to expose her creamy thighs? Was she touching his chest, gazing into his eyes?

"But I do. I make love to you almost every night. I've memorized those tapes. Every inch of you. Every sound. Every reaction. I enter something like a trance, and when I am inside Ellie, I'm really inside you. When she moans, I hear your voice. When she touches me, I feel your hands. Her mouth becomes yours. She doesn't know, of course. All she knows is that her husband of thirty-five years has the hots for her as if we were newlyweds. My tapes are all old and worn. I wanted newer ones, digital that wouldn't degrade. I wanted to add to my collection of sights and sounds. But I could never be with you. It would never be the same. I could never make you come like someone like Mac does."

"But you could."

He laughed. "Oh Olivia, it just wouldn't be the same. I'm so sorry about the pain I've put you through. But I could never be the man I'd want to be for you. Now when I fantasize about you, I see you like I want you... wild, free, fierce. I can't replace that with disappointment, frustration, resentment. I'm sorry. So sorry."

There was a moment of silence that dragged on until I wondered if I'd lost connection.

Finally, Olivia said, "What the fuck? He just... left."

I unmuted my phone. "Think he figured out what you were up to?"

"He must have. Okay, keep an eye on Val."

"He said it was a guy."

"I know," she snapped. "But who knows what was true and what was lies. Jesus. I thought we had him. I thought he was about to confess."

"I know. I did too."

"Fuck, fuck, fuck."

"I have eyes on Val. She's with a client, so she may not have her phone with her. But I'll keep watch to see if she spooks."

"What should I do now?" she asked.

"I don't know.... Wait. What was that he said about the private investigator?"

"Something about him not being a real PI, but rather, what, in economic intelligence?"

"Right, right... you know who else refers to himself that way? Markson."

"So, Charlie is involved with both Mac and Markson? Fuck, this is convoluted. Feels like we're chasing shadows. But it does make sense in a strange way. It helps explain why Markson would know some of the things he'd need to know if he's our real target."

"Yes, but it also feels really convenient. Like something desperate people would invent."

"I'll call Charlie and get him to confirm it one way or the other."

I waited as she tried his cell.

"Fuck, he's not picking up. I'll have to wait until he arrives somewhere where he can't dodge me. I'll head towards our current office and hope he's heading back there. Anything with Val?"

"No, now, she's showing a client how to flip a tire."

"Let's say he does finger Markson, what do I do then? I don't know I have any real leverage to make him talk. You want me to see if I can search his place or something?"

"I don't know. We're running out of time, and it seems like everything we think seems solid turns into smoke. And this doesn't feel solid at all. We're grasping at straws."

She chuckled. "Shadows, smoke, and straws. That'll be the title of the miniseries they make about this case."

"A podcast more likely."

"Well, he should be at our office. They're probably crunching on last-minute RFIs if the bid is still alive. Think you could talk your way into his apartment? I think he has a concierge at his building."

"I'll see what I can do."

I texted her the address. He lived nearby, in Five Points.

"Okay, convenient location. Let me know if anything happens with Val."

"I will."

I ended the call and checked my watch. It was nearly 11:00am.
I now had less than twenty-one hours of freedom left.

Chapter Eighteen: Dead Ends

As Olivia walked over to Markson's apartment building, I continued to observe Val and her female client. The woman looked to be mid-thirties, fit, though not as muscular as Val. She was average height and had a cute ponytail of light brown hair poking through the back of her ball cap. After the tire flips, Val had her do some sled pulls. And then finally, brought her back inside for some post-workout stretches.

There is something undeniably erotic about a trainer helping a client stretch her muscles. Lots of grabbing and touching, particularly the hamstring stretches that had Val's client on her back, and her leg pressed back to her chest. I suspected Val often seduced her female clients, and indeed, I felt pretty confident that Val would have this one folded over naked in relatively short order.

That thought brought me back to the night of the party. All the answers had to be found in those few hours from the time Denny texted me, asking to meet up with Olivia again, to his murder in the early morning hours. And our party was right, smack in the middle of that. Everyone was there: Charlie, Val, Markson.... Something had happened to trigger the murders. The question remained about whether that something was related to those things I'd been focused on, Val seducing Denise and Mitch hooking up with Olivia, or whether it involved things I hadn't observed. Did Charlie meet Markson? Who else was involved?

Val and her client disappeared further back into the gym. I was worried she'd escape via a back door, so I decided to risk it and get closer. A couple of the other patrons gave me a quick nod, but didn't pay me much mind. Inside, there were two big guys working at a squat rack to the encouragement of a metal tune. Motorhead maybe? My heart spiked as I realized there was a back door, and also that Val wasn't in sight.

Her office door was open, and the lights were out, so not there. That left the locker rooms. At this point, I'd already jeopardized whatever element of stealth I had. By now, Charlie had to have called if Val was the mystery woman, and with the woman client's

session over, Val would have probably checked her phone. So I didn't have time to wait. I had to know if Val was already in flight.

I glanced back at the meatheads and the 350 pound load on the squat rack. CrossFit folks are protective of one another, and if they saw me sneaking into the women's locker room to find Val, they'd probably beat the crap out of me. Yet another risk I'd have to take. I waited until one of them shouldered the bar, with the other spotting, to dart into the women's locker room. As befits a CrossFit box, it was spartan, and small, with green lockers that looked like they might have been recycled from a now-defunct high school. Beyond the lockers was a small area with three sinks, mirrors, and a battered hairdryer, and past that were the showers. I crept closer and peered into the shower area via one of the mirrors. I could see above the shower curtains that only one shower head was running. So either they were showering together, or Val had already split.

The curtain across the shower stall was not completely closed. Or at least it fluttered tantalizing as movement inside and the actions of the heated air set it in motion. I took another step. The sounds of the water on tile echoed, drowning out the few muffled sounds that came from within the stall. I peeked behind me. I had no escape if anyone came in after me. Another step, and I heard a sigh, and then a slight gust of wind gave me a peek inside.

Sure enough, both women were inside, kissing passionately, each with a hand between the other's legs as they ground against one another sensuously. The client broke the kiss and sucked one of Val's long nipples into her mouth. Val growled and spun the woman around, engulfing her with both arms and working her pussy with both hands. The other woman braced her forearms against the tile wall and thrust her bubble butt into Val crotch as they gyrated together.

Olivia's voice in my earbuds broke the spell, and I realized I'd crossed over from surveillance to Peeping Tom mode. I retraced my steps, and when the opportunity arose, I made my escape, back through the gym, across the parking lot with tires and ropes, back to my spot across the street. I couldn't cover both the front and the back, but I already knew what I had come to find out. Val might be

sexually voracious, but even she wouldn't be fucking a client if she'd just received a message from Charlie warning her that her participation in a murder plot was potentially about to be exposed.

"Dex, are you there?"

<Dex>: Yeah, sorry. He doesn't seem to have tipped Val off. She's enjoying herself with a client at the moment.

"Jesus, can't anyone keep it in their pants?"

I didn't answer.

"Okay, I'm at his building. 11C is his apartment, right?"

I texted her a thumbs-up.

She took a deep breath and from the sudden quieting of the street noise, I knew she'd gone inside. I heard footsteps on the marble flooring. Then she cleared her throat.

"Oh, hello, can I help you?" came a deep voice that sounded like an African-American man.

"I hope so," Olivia trilled, her own voice rising an octave into baby talk land. I imagined her batting her eyelashes. "So, like, I totally hooked up with this dude in this building last night. Trevor something. In like 11C?"

"Yesssss?" he responded skeptically.

"It was... awful," she said with a giggle. "Like, coyote date awful. Like, I don't mind a little PE, you know, the first time. But you know, after I've gotten you off twice, you should be able to last a little. Instead, this guy goes right from PE to ED."

"Ma'am... I'm not sure why you're telling me this."

"Well, after three disappointments and then me slurping on his limp noodle for half an hour, he went to the bathroom, and I just left. But, as you can see, I left my bra behind."

I imagined her thrusting out her chest, her hard little nips clearly visible through her tight dress.

"Like, my favorite bra. And I really, really don't want to see this guy again."

"I'm sorry, I—"

"I know you have his key." I imagined my batting eyelashes, more twisting and turning to show off her body. "And I would be soooo grateful, if you'd just let me in so I can find my bra."

He chuckled. "I can't do that."

"Well, of course you *can*. Just like you can probably last longer than Trev baby when I'm slurping your schlong."

"You're gonna suck my dick, just so you can recover your bra without running into a lame fuck?"

"Well, maybe more than suck. I could definitely use a little relief after last night."

"Baby, you're crazy."

"Ayup. And you know what they say about crazy bitches, right?"

He didn't answer right away. But then I heard him pick up a phone and say, "Yo, Jimmy, come up and cover the desk for a few."

"So you'll take me up?"

"I'm probably going to lose my job over this."

"Don't worry, it'll be worth it."

I couldn't get a clear sense of what they did once they got in his apartment. Unlike Willie, he wasn't narrating. I know she sucked his cock noisily, then at some point, they fucked. I heard them moaning, flesh slapping flesh. Olivia executed her best porn star impression. Lots of "ohh yeah, fuck my tight little pussy" talk in an unnaturally high pitched voice. And in the end, she requested his load in her mouth, and he seemed happy to oblige.

"Okay, Baby, get the bra and let's get out of here."

"You go ahead. It'll take me a while to find it." Her voice had returned to her usual pitch.

"I can't leave you in here alone."

"Yeah, well, you shouldn't have brought me here at all. So, let's not make a scene. You got your rocks off, and I promise, I won't trash the place."

"Look—"

"Oh Sweetie," she interrupted. "Don't fight it."

He hesitated. Then finally said, "You have twenty minutes."

"Of course. Now, it is time for you...." The front door opened. "To leave." And then slammed shut.

"Okay, I'm in."

I unmuted my phone. "That's what he said."

"Ha ha. So what am I looking for?"

“Gun would be nice. But honestly, I don’t know. Anything that can shed light on what the fuck we’re up against.”

“Okay. I hope he doesn’t come home for lunch.”

“I doubt it. Today should be a busy day for them at work.”

“I’ll let you know if I find anything. What are you doing now?”

I peeked again at Val’s compound. A group class was about to start, and Val was leading it. She was either the coolest cucumber in the world, or she wasn’t involved with Charlie.

“I need to make amends.”

“Huh?” she said.

“Don’t worry about it.”

I muted myself again and began walking south. I peeled off the do-rag and tossed the cigarettes. I went into a grocery store bathroom and changed into my normal clothes, putting Mac’s clothes in the backpack. I ran my finger over the cold metal of Mitch’s gun, and for just a second I imagined pulling it out and blowing my brains out.

Instead, I found a cab by the Northfield Stapleton shops, and headed for Aurora.

“Ms. Muriel Jennings?” I asked when a middle-aged woman answered the door. She was pleasant enough looking, a bit frumpy, and like her now-deceased husband a bit soft around the middle. Her short hair was salt and pepper and curly. Her eyes red-rimmed and glazed.

“Do I know you?”

“I’d like to talk about your husband.”

“Are you a reporter?”

“I’m not. I... just need to explain some things.”

“Wait... you’re... I’ve seen you on the news.” Her eyes widened fearfully.

“I’m here to explain and apologize. And if you want to call the cops... I won’t make a fuss. Can I come in?”

She hesitated and then wordlessly took a step back and let me into their tidy home. She gestured for me to sit down on their beige sofa, but she remained standing. I didn't blame her.

"I didn't kill your husband," I said. "But I'm responsible in a sense. He got caught up in a game my wife and I were playing, and—"

"Which one is your wife? The blonde showing off her asshole, or the brunette with the big tits?"

"Excuse me?"

"He was texting... or sexting, I guess," she said with a snort. "With two women. That I know of. Those were the two on his phone, but he probably had more." She shook her head. "Who knew I was married to such a stud, huh?"

I tried to process all of this, but it was hard. There was another woman texting Denny?

"Do you still have the phone?" I asked.

"Cops took it," she said with a wave.

"How long has he... was he... texting with other women?"

"How should I know? He probably cleaned up after himself for the most part, but just was...." As angry as she was, she still teared up at what had happened to him. "Just my luck to find it, I guess. Probably should have been checking his phone all along. I always knew the passcode. Men are dogs."

"You didn't check before because you trusted him."

"Yup. Stupid me."

I shook my head. "No... please, just let me explain."

She tilted her head and gave me a skeptical scowl.

"My wife, she's the blonde, and I had this game where we'd talk about her being with another man."

She rolled her eyes.

"I know. It sounds weird, but it was just a fantasy. I don't know. It spiced things up. Jealousy gets the blood pumping, and she found it exciting to flirt with strange men... I mean, men who were strangers. And we happened to be at El Pecado, and talking about our game, and Olivia... that's my wife... asked if she should pick up someone and.... Well, it was just a fantasy, you know. But she

decided to spice it up. And she took those pictures and sent them to me, and I sent them to your husband. But that was it. They never met up. They never... he never cheated on you."

Muriel shook her head slowly. "Mister, I don't even know.... I saw the texts. He was going out to meet her that night. The night he was.... He snuck out of the house. And next thing I know, the cops are coming by telling me he's... and asking me if I can unlock his phone."

"He was going to meet Olivia?"

"She's the blonde?"

"Yes."

"Well, I don't rightly know. I didn't have much time with the phone. Cops took it as evidence. There were different text threads. I just glanced at them before turning it over."

"But there was a second woman texting him?"

"Or at least pictures of a different whore... woman... whatever. Look, Mister, if you have something to say, say it."

"Right. Right. I don't know all the details. All I know... all I can reassure you about is that he didn't meet up with the blonde."

She snorted again. "Aw, you're even more naive than I was."

I held up my hand. "Maybe. You're right. Maybe I don't know. But I do know... or I thought I knew... that your husband was an innocent victim. He got caught up in a plot by people trying to hurt me and my wife. And it happened because we, randomly, decided to flirt with him in a bar, and some bad people saw it and took advantage." She wasn't buying it. I decided to cut my losses. "I should go."

"If it wasn't you, maybe it was the other husband. The one whose wife was fucking Den... my husband. Why aren't the cops looking for him?"

"I don't know."

She waved toward the door. "Whatever. You've said your piece. Now... please leave."

I nodded and walked to the door. Just before exiting, I said it once more, "I'm sorry. If I had anything to do with this, I'm sorry."

"Yup. We're all sorry."

She shut the door in my face.

Chapter Nineteen: Caught

I drifted slowly back toward downtown. I stopped checking to see if I was being followed. At this point, it didn't matter anyway. Every avenue we'd pursued had been a dead end. The trip down to Colorado Springs was pointless. Mac didn't seem connected with the murders. Neither did Charlie. I checked my watch. Olivia had been searching Markson's apartment for nearly an hour and had reported nothing back. Val probably wasn't the mystery woman. And now, the mystery had another twist. Another woman sexting with Denny, and maybe even setting him up for the murder.

I called Olivia.

"Did you find anything?" I asked.

"Not yet. Went through his closets and drawers. Nothing interesting. Now I'm working my way through his desk. Bunch of divorce documents. Some bills. Looks like he's only been living here a few months."

"Must have been when his wife kicked him out. Anyway, anything of real interest will be on a computer or something."

"He has a monitor and mouse on his desk, but no laptop. Probably has it with him."

"You should get out of there."

"I will. Soon. What have you been up to."

"I went to see Denny's widow. To apologize."

"Oh God, Dex, are you crazy? What if she called the police?"

"Yeah, what if? Anyway, get this. Turns out that Denny had other irons in the fire."

"Huh."

"He was apparently seeing other women as well. His wife didn't have much time to look at his phone after unlocking it for the cops, but she said there was another conversation from a different woman."

"Weird. Wonder why the cops didn't pursue that?"

"They probably did. Which is why they didn't arrest me right away. But then when Zach was found and we'd disappeared. Well,

not hard to see how we'd end up on the news."

"Oh my God. Do you think this could all be a stupid coincidence, and that if we'd just held tight, nothing would have happened?"

"I don't know. But at this point... I don't know."

She chuckled. "This is crazy.... Oh fuck. Someone just came in. Putting the phone down."

I heard the sound of her phone clacking down on a hard surface, and a second later a rustling sound as she covered it with a stack of papers. I muted my end to avoid giving away that I was listening in. I put in my earbuds and hastened my pace. I heard footsteps. Loud ones. Those of a man. I was hoping it was the concierge coming back to try to get Olivia to leave, but no such luck.

"Well, well, well, Olivia. I've always wanted to get you back to my place, but this isn't exactly what I had in mind."

"Oh Trevor, I'm a wanted woman, don't you watch the news? You can't expect me to just sit in your lobby waiting for you to return."

I gasped. Fuck, Markson had walked in on her.

"You could have called," he said.

"But where is the fun in that?"

"So this is a social visit?"

"Of course."

He chuckled. I wondered if he was really buying this line of horseshit. If he was then he was even a bigger horndog than I realized. "I guess I shoulda expected it. I know how you girlies can't help dishing when you get some really good dick for once."

"Is that what you have for me?"

"I guess you're going to find out."

I found a cab in front of a Marriott and gave Markson's address. We pulled into the traffic flow.

"How about you slip off the dress, Babydoll?" he said.

"Oh, what's the rush?"

"I'm a busy man. Work, work, work, especially with your husband going all loco on us. Just came back to grab some files, but you know, there's always time to bust a nut in another man's wife. Maybe knock up another one."

"I can wait around."

"Oh, you'll definitely want to after I give it to you good. But why delay the fun?"

"It builds anticipation," she offered.

"Well, Baby," he said, his voice dropping an octave, "I think you and I have been building anticipation for years, haven't we?"

She gasped softly, and I realized he had just touched her.

"Now, give me a peek at that hot, little bod... unless you're here for some other reason?"

He was speaking calmly, but his voice oozed menace. I wished I could jam my foot down on the accelerator and make my driver go faster, because as frantic as I was getting, he seemed wholly relaxed and untroubled. He probably had a couple of hits of pot before starting his shift. Half of fucking Denver was wake and baking nowadays.

"What other reason could I have?" she asked, trying to draw him into a longer conversation.

"Exactly," he replied. And from her surprised squeak, I knew he was either trying to pull her dress down past her boobs or up past her crotch.

"That's not very gentlemanly of you."

"Well, I ain't a gentleman, and you ain't a lady. And those are some nice titties. I bet these nips get rock hard, don't they?"

"When they're handled right," she said with forced joviality.

I pictured her trying to fend him off, as he slowly backed her into a corner.

"I like it when sluts play hard to get. It means they're trying to get a guy riled up. Looking for a little rough stuff. Is that it, Olivia? Dexter's too nice for you. Well, I'm just what you're looking for."

"I think I should go."

"I think I shouldn't let you. After all, you went to all the trouble of fucking Tom at the front desk to get in here. I'd hate to leave you disappointed."

He forced a kiss on her. I could hear her struggle to break free. I unmuted my phone and yelled into it. "Leave her alone!"

My cabbie jerked around to stare at me. I listened intently at the phone, trying to determine if anyone had heard. But neither he nor she said anything, and I had to conclude that just as I had muted the call, she had probably turned down the volume when she heard the door opening.

“Trevor, Baby, you don’t understand. I was just here to give you a little taste, not the whole meal. What’s the fun in that?”

He chuckled. “Well, if you don’t know, then you really are in need of a good fucking.”

Olivia shrieked over the sound of rending fabric.

“No Boundaries? Shit, Dexter is a fucking loser if he has you shopping at Walmart.”

If he could read the label, then he’d torn off her dress. She was breathing heavily, trying to figure a way out of this situation. The fact that she didn’t just give him what he wanted spoke to her sense that this was a different situation than with the concierge or Willie. There she’d been in command of the situation, using her sexuality to get what she wanted. But with Markson, she sensed dark intentions behind his actions. She was in his trap, not him in hers.

She tried to turn things around. “Maybe I just had the sense that an animal like you couldn’t be trusted with anything nicer.”

“Now you’re getting the picture. Let’s get these off too.... Very nice, I always like a shaved cooch.”

“You’re a real alpha, aren’t you, Baby?” She asked in a husky voice. “How does it feel to first take a man’s work and then his woman?”

He laughed. “Well, honestly, the work just fell into my lap, and I haven’t had his woman yet.”

“Aaaah,” she gasped.

“Fuck, you are nice and tight. Didn’t think that would be possible with you being such a whore.”

“It did more than just fall into your lap, though, didn’t it?” she persisted.

“Well, I did have to have drinks with boring-ass Trip, but that worked out pretty well for me too.”

"Please Baby," she cooed. "Tell me the whole story. You have no idea how hot it makes me when I hear about alpha men dominating Dex. It's why I do what I do."

"I think you do what you do because you like getting fucked. So... let's fuck."

I tried to assess how far we were from his apartment. At least another ten minutes. I gripped the gun in my backpack. It would be better to get a confession from Markson, but he seemed to know what Olivia was up to and was deflecting her efforts.

"If we're going to fuck, then why am I the only one who's naked?"

He laughed coldly. "All in due time, Baby. There are some things I like too. Have you ever been tied up?"

"Oh, we don't need all that nonsense, do we?"

"I think we do."

"Maybe I should leave."

"No. I don't think so." I heard a drawer open and shut. "See, nothing to worry about. Just this nice, thick, cotton rope."

"Trevor, no."

"Shhh. You wind it around and around from the wrists to the forearms. Nice even pressure. No bruises, no marks. And now your legs. Ankles up to calves. Oops, yeah, steady there. Probably best to get you onto the bed."

The bedsprings squeaked as he dropped her onto his mattress.

"Now we just attach you to some handy bindings attached to the bed frame... a lot of amateurs think tying someone to a headboard is better... but actually a metal bed frame is more secure."

"What are you going to do to me?"

"I'm going to fuck you, Baby. Just like you want. But first... just one more little thing. As beautiful as is a tied up woman, there is one cherry on the top... or maybe rather, in the mouth."

"No, Trevor, no! N-mmmmmhhh!"

"A nice bright, red ball-gag."

I could hear Olivia struggling and her muted shouts. We were only a couple of minutes away, and I fought off the irrational urge to

get out and run the rest of the distance, which would take longer, even though it might give me a sense of actually doing something.

“Hey, Dexter, you there?”

I jolted at the volume. I had turned up my earbuds to listen in on what was going on in Markson’s apartment, but he had spoken right into the phone. I unmuted.

“You better not hurt her, you bastard.”

He laughed. “Just get your ass over here. I know how much you like to watch.” He hung up.

We pulled up to the building. I threw a couple of twenties at the driver and jumped out.

I entered the lobby, all sleek and modern, dark marble floors, and a curved metal desk. A TV screen played building announcements. An older African-American man sat beneath the monitor with a grin on his face. Probably the man Olivia had sucked and fucked to get into Markson’s apartment. I debated whether to just walk by him or try to BS him, but I didn’t need to.

“Dexter?” he asked.

I nodded.

“Go on up.... And give the little lady my best wishes.” He winked.

I choked back my embarrassment and got into the elevator.

Markson was built more powerfully than me. I didn’t want to have to confront him hand to hand. So when the elevator dinged his floor and the doors opened, I pulled out Mitch’s gun, and held it to my chest covered by the backpack. I hurried to his door and rang the doorbell. And then I cooled my heels, feeling absurd and impotent. My wife was naked and bound in a killer’s apartment, and I was waiting for him to deign to open the door.

He did. With a smirk on his face. It didn’t dissipate when I pointed the gun at his chest and pushed my way in. That should have been a warning, but in the heat of the moment, I missed it. I rushed past him and toward the sound of Olivia yelling into the ball gag. I stepped into his bedroom, and I realized my mistake.

“Drop the gun,” Tracey said.

She was holding what I recognized as my Sig Sauer against the back of Olivia's head. Tracey's green surgical gloves somehow making the scene even more ominous.

"You won't," I said.

"What choice did I have? When two armed killers forced their way into the apartment?"

I hesitated and then lowered the weapon as Markson entered the room behind me and took it out of my hand.

Olivia dropped her head against the bed. She'd been trying to warn me. And I had totally missed it.

Chapter Twenty: The Contest

I was also kicking myself for having never really had Tracey on my radar. She was the other woman in Charlie's spy rotation. She was the brunette with the big tits on Denny's phone. And even just a few minutes ago, Markson himself had basically outed her with his line about "girlies dishing when they get good dick." More pieces came together. Via Trip, she'd be the source for a lot of the things that Markson had to know to make the setup work. And, of course, this was his MO. Seduce a woman and use her to get what he wanted. I just would never have thought Tracey would be vulnerable to his blandishments.

I scanned the room looking for options. The bedroom was large, with a king-sized bed on which my wife was bound. High windows let in copious amounts of sunlight. He had a leather reading chair with ottoman in one corner. A large closet with folding mirrored doors lined another wall. I could see his bathroom through a doorway in which he'd hung a chin-up bar. He had uncluttered bedside tables and a dresser on which he had displayed a collection of watches.

"So what should we do with them?" Markson crowed.

Tracey smirked as she replied, "Well it doesn't seem fair that wifey is naked and tied up and hubby isn't."

Her malice contrasted oddly with her attire. In blue mom shorts and a bright yellow, short-sleeved blouse, she looked like the sort of woman who might be bragging about the secret recipe she used to make the potato salad at the church social.

"Good point." Markson poked me in the ribs with Mitch's gun. "You heard the lady, Dex. Go ahead and strip."

"No."

He laughed. "You're wanted for murder. You forced your way into my apartment with a gun. You really don't think self-defense will hold up?"

"You're going to kill me anyway."

“Oh no no no. Not unless you make me. Having you alive is much more fun. Now strip.”

I glanced at Olivia. She gave me a small nod. If we were going to get out of this alive, we needed to play for time. Just one moment after another. Like the old adage. Even the longest journey begins with a single step. My first step was getting naked.

I began to undress as Tracey and Markson grinned at each other. I kicked off my shoes and then unbuttoned my shirt. Tracey laid on the bed beside Olivia, running the barrel of my gun over her naked body.

“I wonder what Trip would think of you now,” Tracey said to my wife. “Little Miss Fucking Perfect. *Olivia is happy with just two kids. Olivia’s job means that Dex can take bigger risks.* Little Miss skinny and blonde. Oh, so easy to pull one over on the boys when you look like you.”

I paused as I listened to Tracey spill her resentments. Markson jabbed the gun in my lower back. “Keep going, Dexy,” he taunted. “And, by the way, love the dye job. You look like an albino with a wig.”

I ignored him as I pulled down my pants. I hesitated now, hoping that would be enough, but he disabused me of that hope by wedging the barrel of the gun down into the waistband of my boxers. I slid them off.

Tracey chuckled. “Oh, Sweetie,” she trilled in Olivia’s ear. “I can see why you’re such a slut if that’s all you have at home.”

I blushed, while trying to maintain a ounce of composure. It was difficult, standing there naked, with my equally naked wife bound to the bed. Markson disappeared for a moment and returned with a slender, cushion-less, metal armchair, the kind you might have around a patio table,

“Get comfy, Dex,” he said as he forced me down onto the cold, hard seat. Then to Tracey, “Hey Baby, toss me the ropes from the drawer.”

I opened my mouth to protest, but I knew begging would do no good, and I preferred to maintain as much of my dignity intact as possible. He forced my arms through the armrests and down behind

my back and tied them together, like with Olivia, starting at my wrists and winding the thick ropes up toward my forearms. I tried to flex my forearms to create a little give, but he knew what he was doing, and when I tested the bonds, I couldn't generate any movement. He proceeded to bind my ankles to the chair's legs. These too he tied fast. Then he dragged the chair backward toward the bathroom doorway. He wrapped a cord around my neck.

"No, Trevor, don't," I pleaded.

He laughed. "Don't worry, Dex. I'm not gonna kill you. Like I said, you're more useful to me alive." Still, he tied the other end of the cord to a chin-up bar above my head, and pulled it taut. "You probably shouldn't move around too much," he said with a chuckle. "And definitely don't fall asleep."

I understood his point. Given the narrowness of the chair, any struggles would tip me over, and if I tipped over, I'd hang myself.

"What are you going to do n...aaah."

He quieted me by forcing a red ball gag into my mouth as well and securing it firmly behind my neck.

With us both immobilized, Tracey and Markson relaxed. They put their guns down, and she removed her gloves. Tracey approached Markson. He wrapped his arms around her. "Damn, you're a bad bitch," he said.

"You know it."

"What are we going to do with them now?" he asked.

She chuckled. "Did that little whore really tell Tom you were a two-pump chump?"

He laughed. "Yeah, right before she guzzled his come."

"Maybe," Tracey began, "you should prove her wrong." She slipped out of his grasp and pulled up the ottoman and sat down on it beside me. She ran a fingernail along my flaccid member. "Plus, Dex here is going away for a long time, and he deserves one last opportunity to see his wife get fucked."

I struggled against my bindings to no avail. Olivia, who'd been tied up longer, didn't bother. She knew she was securely fettered. Markson climbed onto the bed. He turned her onto her side so she was facing me, and then he settled in behind her. He draped an arm

across her torso and began fondling her. She tried to squirm from his touch, but she had nowhere to go.

He nuzzled into her neck. "You're going to like this, Baby," he rumbled softly as he pinched her nipple until it stiffened. She shook her head. His other hand began fondling her ass.

"Do you like this part, Dex?" Tracey asked me. "The foreplay? Or do you just like the actual fucking? Or maybe the climax? Where do you have them come? On her face? In her mouth? Inside her pussy? I bet that's what you like. You probably dream about men coming inside your wife. Do you ever fantasize about them knocking her up?"

While she did that, she continued to lightly tease my prick with her fingernail. Slowly dragging it across the bottom of my shaft. Markson's hand drifted lower, palming my wife's shaved pussy. He made firm, little circles at the top of her slit.

"This one's getting hard," Tracey taunted. "How about her?"

"She's breathing hard, that's for sure."

Tracey rose and opened up his bedside drawer. She tossed an egg vibrator onto the bed. "Here, use this on her."

Markson grinned as he palmed the sex toy. He turned it on and its insect-like buzzing filled the room. He placed it atop Olivia's clit, making her jolt. She shrank from him, but he was persistent, keeping that oscillating contrivance pressed firmly against her most sensitive spot.

"Look at the way she's thrusting her ass against him. She wants it," Tracey breathed in my ear. She spit in her palm and began rubbing it against the head of my cock. She laughed. "A bit of a mushroom top and a little skinny, but not bad. Trev, show him yours."

Markson rose up on his knees. Olivia rolled partially over on her stomach to recover and protect her clit from his attention. He peeled off his shirt first. He was thickly built. A broad chest, muscular shoulders, and powerful arms. He reached down and massaged Olivia's ass with a firm grip, dipping his hand between her cheeks. With the other hand, he first removed his belt, folding it over, and ran it over her naked body. He gave her a sharp spank with the thick leather. She yelped into her gag and tried to roll back, but he easily

kept her face down on the bed. Then he unzipped his pants and yanked them down. His cock was darker than the rest of him, almost like that of a black man. He wasn't as massive as Mac, but still large and thick, probably about the same as Mitch. He stroked himself a few times to maximize his girth.

Tracey stared at his prick admiringly. "He's got a nice cock, doesn't he? I bet you like it when her lovers are big. When they really make her scream."

I glanced in her direction. She was increasingly flush, and she'd opened the top couple of buttons of her blouse, displaying a vast expanse of cleavage. When she noticed me looking, she popped open another and lifted her boobs toward me.

"You've always liked my big titties, haven't you Dex? Too bad Olivia keeps you locked up. Only she's allowed to play in your little game, right? Though, honestly, I'm not sure I completely understand your rules. Are there any? Or does she just get as much dick as she wants whenever she wants?"

Olivia whined into her mask. I thought it was in response to Tracey, but when I looked over at her, Markson had dropped back onto the bed beside her and was aggressively pulling her butt cheeks apart and pressing the pad of his thumb into her ass. She managed to roll onto her back, and he switched back to playing with her pussy, holding the egg against her clit and slipping his spit-lubed fingers between her folds. He was pressed up against her, sliding his cock against her thigh.

"Baby," Tracey said to Markson, "you gonna go front door or back door?"

He chuckled. "This is juicing up pretty good, but I think that ass is hella tight."

Tracey closed her fist around my shaft. She didn't pump up and down, but instead pulsed her grip slowly.

"What do you think, Dex? Should he fuck her pussy or her ass? Shake for pussy or nod for ass."

I tried to keep my head still, but she grabbed a handful of my hair and forced my head up and down.

“Cucky says ass,” Markson crowed. “What do you think about that, Babydoll?”

He slowly withdrew the two thick fingers he had in her pussy, and easily rolled her back over onto her belly.

“Toss me the lube,” he said.

Tracey went back into the bedside drawer, and squeezed a health dollop into her palm before tossing the tube to Markson. Her familiarity with his bedroom setup raised all sorts of questions about when their relationship began. But my mind couldn’t pursue that train of thought for long. At the same time that she gripped my cock in her slick palm, Markson squirted a gob of lube on Olivia’s anus and pressed his thumb into her ass. She squirmed, but between the ropes and his hand on her lower back, she couldn’t escape.

I looked at Tracey imploringly. I couldn’t understand how Markson had turned her so thoroughly. We’d been friends for years. Tracey and Olivia were confidants about children and marriage. But now, Tracey was complicit... not just complicit, but an active participant in orchestrating a sexual assault on my wife, her friend.

She smirked at my lack of comprehension. “Don’t worry. You’re going to have multiple life sentences to work it all out.”

I grunted into the gag.

She chuckled. “Okay, Dexy, now we’re going to play a game, inspired by Olivia if you will. Trevor is going to fuck Olivia up the ass.” I struggled against the ropes binding me. “Take it easy,” she said, “he has her nice and lubed up.” And indeed, he had two fingers plunging into her butthole with audible squishes. “And I’m going to jerk your cock as he does it. And we’re going to see who comes first.”

I shook my head, and she mockingly nodded back at me. “I’ll even give you the advantage of not starting until he’s inside of her.”

Markson straddled my wife and began rubbing his thick, greased-up cock between her butt cheeks. He pressed the head of his cock against her anus. She tensed momentarily, arching her back and trying to rise off the bed. But with most of his weight on her legs and his hand on her lower back, she was completely immobilized. She surrendered, dropping down on the mattress and closing her

eyes. I shook my head again, but my attention was immediately drawn back across the room by Olivia grunting into her gag. The head of his prick disappeared into her buttock. He dropped forward onto his arms, parallel above her prone body and slowly buried his fat cock into her rectum. Her body shuddered as he filled her. Once he was inside, he turned and grinned at me.

"Nice and fucking tight," he taunted.

"You wouldn't know about that, would you Dex? I bet she never lets you do that to her."

I tried to remain impassive, but they both seemed to know and shared a laugh. Still chuckling, Tracey grabbed my cock. Both it and her hand were still coated in lube. She nodded at Markson, and he began sodomizing my wife in earnest with long, slow, deep strokes that left him balls deep in her ass. As he did, Tracey matched his pace with firm tugs at my pecker.

I wished that my anger and revulsion would translate into a flaccid prick, but it didn't. I was hard and very sensitive. I could have come right away if I'd wanted, but I didn't. I tried to hold back.

Markson fucked Olivia's ass harder. With each deep stroke, she emitted a stifled groan. It shouldn't have been arousing, but it was. To my shame and horror, it was. I leaked precum. Tracey pumped my cock harder and faster. I moaned involuntarily.

"Look at your husband, Slut," Markson growled at Olivia. And when she didn't, he grabbed a handful of her hair and turned her face to me. We locked eyes.

He fucked her even faster. His groin slapped her ass. His cock blurred into her anus. Her muffled grunts quickened. So did mine. I clenched every muscle to resist what was becoming inevitable. She gave me a quick nod. It was okay. She understood. Another deep thrust, his balls nestled against her cheeks as he ground into her. Her eyes rolled into her head. I came violently, my first spurt arcing above my eyes, and then another and another, hot on my chest, and then my belly.

Tracey laughed. But I wasn't embarrassed this time. I was just angry.

I thought my climax would clear the way for his. But he wasn't done yet. Instead, he rolled them over so that they were side-by-side, him spooning her, his cock still deep in her ass. He grabbed the vibrating egg and turned it on. He was going to do to her what Tracey had done to me. He slowed down, sliding into her with measured strokes, almost tender, and at the same time placed the egg lightly on her clit. Olivia wriggled to and fro, away from the vibrator, but impaling herself deeper on his cock, away from his prick but then increasing the pressure on her clit. Trying to escape the more potent stimulus, she writhed back and forth. He was patient, obviously enjoying the sensation of my wife squirming against him.

Caught between his dick and the egg, Olivia rocked faster and faster. Quick desperate breaths through her nose. Her nipples were rock hard. Her body glistened with sweat. And then suddenly she tensed and spasmed violently several times as Tracey chuckled.

Now, finally it was Markson's turn. He rolled her back onto her belly and began pounding into her mercilessly. He grunted with the exertion. Olivia squealed into her gag. Thankfully, he didn't last much longer. He rose up on extended arms and let out a triumphant growl as he pumped his jism into my wife's ass.

He eased himself out and pushed past me into the bathroom, deliberately trailing his slimy prick against my shoulder as he did. As he freshened up, Tracey stood between me and Olivia.

"A cuck and a whore. Well, I know you two enjoyed this, so, don't worry, we'll be back to play some more. And we might even bring back some friends." She caressed Olivia's forehead with mock tenderness. "I haven't seen you two do this yet, but I'm thinking a nice, all-night gangbang would be the proper sendoff for cuck." She turned toward me. "Maybe we'll even have you suck a few cocks yourself. It's probably a skill you're going to need where you're going."

Markson came out of the bathroom, this time clocking my head with his elbow. He sat down on the bed beside Olivia and dressed. He clapped her firmly on the ass.

"Don't worry, Dex, I will take *good* care of her while you're away."

Tracey gathered up our clothes, and hand in hand, they exited the bedroom, and a moment later, I heard them leave the apartment altogether.

I looked at Olivia. She was again struggling against her ropes, to no avail. I didn't know how long Tracey and Markson would be gone. I only knew that we had damn well be out of there before they returned.

Chapter Twenty-One: Escape

With my legs tied securely to the legs of the metal chair, my arms bound behind my back and through the armrests, and a rope taut around my neck and tied to a chin-up bar, I couldn't see many options to get free. The big danger was that in struggling around the bindings, I could easily lose my balance, topple over, and hang myself.

One option was to bounce up and down. It would make a racket below. If I didn't fall over, I might be able to get someone to call for assistance. I couldn't see how we would escape that without police involvement. Though maybe that was the best option. The sights of Olivia and I tied up, and her leaking semen from her ass, would certainly raise questions. But it would also confirm the narrative of us as extreme sexual deviants. I didn't like putting my life in anyone else's hands. Not quite yet.

Freeing my arms was not an option. I glanced up at the rope, wrapped around the chin-up bar. It was attached to the doorframe. I could see a couple of flathead screws securing a mounting bracket, but the bar frame itself seemed to be just resting against the top of the door frame. If I could lever far enough back, I might be able to yank those screws out from the wood. I scooted myself backward, but even raising my chin to gain a little slack in the rope, I couldn't move far enough back. I was still almost directly beneath the header, and my weight would still be pulling almost straight down against the door frame rather than at an angle away from it. I scooted forward again to relieve the pressure on my throat.

I examined my ankles. The rope was wound around my ankles and lower calves. I tried flexing my calves to see if I could cause the rope to pool, but the rope was thick, and the coils themselves kept them in place. The footpads of the chair were relatively narrow, though with just a slight flare to provide a little extra stability. If I could extend my legs enough, I might be able to begin slipping the rope past the chair's feet, and that extra slack should allow me to

free one leg at a time. Then I could stand, and maybe get the leverage necessary to tear the bar from the door frame.

The problem was that to extend my legs, I needed to get them off the floor, and to do that, I needed to tilt the chair backward and support my weight with my nape of my neck. I scooted as far forward as possible.

Olivia was staring at me anxiously as if she'd realized what I was planning. She gave me a small head shake, warning me against it. But I had to try.

I rocked backward as gently as possible, but the tipping point arrived suddenly. I had no way to stabilize myself other than my core as I fell backward and the rope bit into the back of my neck. As it did, the front of the loop moved up along my throat, tight against the base of my chin. I had a moment of panic as the pressure increased, but I realized I could still get breaths in.

I calmed myself and tried to extend my right leg, rolling slightly to my left. Shifting my body destabilized me and I began to twist. But I could also feel the chair's foot sliding up against my heel toward my Achilles. I elongated my body as much as I could. The chair rose onto just one leg, teetering precariously. The metal armrests dug painfully into my arms, the noose tightened around my neck. I kicked out my foot to try to free it. My heel cleared the chair's leg, and the rope loosened, but at the same time, my chair's balance shifted unexpectedly. I spun over, face down, the rope around my throat tightened on my throat suddenly. I couldn't breathe. I heard Olivia thrashing on the bed, screaming into the gag. I struggled violently to free my leg. It remained stuck, the ropes loosened, but still clinging to the chair leg. The chair banged against the floor. The pressure on my chest grew. My vision dimmed. There was a rushing sound in my ears. Another kick, and my leg was free, but I was nearly blacked out, feeling disoriented, like a diver in deep water, not quite sure which way was up. I tried to plant my foot, ended up kicking my toes into the floor excruciatingly. The jolt of pain gave me the energy to try again. I managed to get my foot flat on the floor, and now I had to do a one-legged squat, with my arms tied behind me, a heavy metal chair draped over me, and no oxygen left. I pressed upward

unsteadily. It was just enough to relieve the pressure on my throat. I could breathe. I slowed down, tried to restrain my panic. Then I slowly rose until I was standing, one-legged, but no longer in danger of immediately strangling myself.

I was drenched in sweat, and it took me a long time to recover my breath through my nose. I was far from free, however. I peered again at the bracket holding the chin-up bar in place. It was a small piece of metal. I couldn't tell how thick, and the screws seemed relatively flimsy. It was just designed to keep the bar's frame in place. I decided a sudden violent effort would be most effective. It would either tear out the screws or bend the metal or splinter the wood. It would also put me off balance again, it was likely I'd again be in danger of hanging myself. I decided to risk it. I centered myself beneath the header, and launched myself backward in the bathroom.

The wood cracked, but not enough. The frame shifted, but held firm. And then sickeningly, slowly, my body rolled over again, and the pressure on my throat returned. I didn't have it in me to swing back into place and do another one-legged squat. Instead, I desperately kicked out with my free foot against the door jamb. The wood dug into the flesh on the bottom of my foot. I heard the wood crack again, and then suddenly it gave way. I fell hard onto the tile floor face first, the chair and the chin-up bar and frame landing on me as well. I tasted blood in my mouth, and I ached all over, but I was free of the threat of death by hanging.

Freeing myself the rest of the way was easier, but still a sweaty, messy, bloody struggle. I got my second leg free. Then, hunched over with the chair still attached to me and dragging the detritus of the bar, I hobbled back into the bedroom. I tried to untie Olivia, but my hands couldn't reach her ropes with the chair in the way. I glanced at the mirrored, closet door, and decided that was my chance. I swung the chair and shattered the mirror. Shards of razor-sharp glass spread over the floor. I tried to maneuver between them, with only partial success, adding bloody feet to my challenges, but I was still able to back up against a piece of mirror still in its frame. Carefully, using the exposed edge, and with only a few cuts on my

arms, I managed to cut through the rope. The chair clattered to the ground. I was free.

I removed my ball gag and went quickly to Olivia. I freed her as fast as I could. She wrapped her arms around me.

“Oh, God, Dex, are you okay?”

I was bleeding profusely. From my nose and mouth. My feet. My arms. I could feel the ligatures on my neck throbbing.

“I’m fine. We need to get you to the hospital.”

“Me?”

“He... raped you. We need to get you to a—”

“No. Dex. I’m okay. It was humiliating. But he didn’t hurt me. Just my pride.”

“Olivia, I’m sorry. I... didn’t protect you. I... oh God....” With the fear of death momentarily lifted, the embarrassment of everything that had happened felt overwhelming. I’d watched a man anally rape my wife, and I had climaxed during it.

She caressed my face and tried to reassure me. “Oh, Dex, you freed us. You’re my hero.”

I shook my head. “I’m not. I’m not even a real—”

She pulled me into a kiss. “Yes you are,” she said urgently. “You are.”

We locked eyes. She held my gaze and then slowly nodded. She smiled. “Now I’m not saying we won’t both need therapy after this... or at least a stiff drink.”

“Or five.”

“Or five,” she agreed. “But first, we still have work to do. And before that, we need to clean up those wounds. You look like an accident victim.”

None of my cuts were particularly deep. Olivia fished a couple of shards of glass out of my foot, and I bloodied all of Markson’s linens.

Markson and Tracey had stolen our clothes and everything else we owned. So we had no money, no phones, and no gun. I rifled through his closet and put on a pair of his pants, cinching a belt tight, and a shirt. I looked like a man who’d lost 50 pounds but hadn’t updated his wardrobe. I fit into his shoes by wearing three pairs of

socks. Olivia had a hard time. She had to make do with a cotton sweater that she stretched into what could almost pass for a minidress once she cut off the arms, and she carved a pair of gym slides into makeshift sandals. We slipped out of his apartment looking mismatched and suspicious, but at least we were alive, and free.

We took the stairs down to the parking level, and then walked up the ramp to the street. I didn't want to risk going through the lobby and running into Tom, who had already proved to be Markson's man.

We moved rapidly in the direction of Coors Field and away from his apartment. The sky was beginning to darken as the sun set behind the mountains.

"What do we do now?" she asked.

"We need help."

"Mac?"

"Could be. Or maybe Val? Now that we've cleared her. Charlie isn't in any position to say no to anything we ask."

"I'm not sure what we'd ask," she said.

"I know. I... I have no idea what to do now. Maybe the cops?"

"Why did they let us go?"

"The cops?"

"No, Tracey and Trevor."

"They didn't exactly let us go," I said. I had the cuts and bruises to prove it.

"If they had wanted to make sure we couldn't escape, they could have stayed to keep an eye on us. Or... killed us. They've already killed two people."

I stopped walking as it hit me. "They couldn't stay because they had to do something else. And they couldn't kill us because they needed us alive for some reason." The more I thought about it, the more the pieces came together. "Markson had to go to finish working on the bid. That's his play in all of this. But Tracey...."

"What is she getting out of this?" Olivia asked.

“You don’t think it’s just sex? Maybe he pushed her buttons.”

“Like Mac pushes mine?”

I blushed. “And Mitch,” I said.

“And you,” she added kindly. “Maybe. But she’s not a kid, likely to get carried away like that. And anyway, if she just wanted to fuck Trevor on the side, then there was no need to get into the murder business.”

“What if she was worried Trip was going to find out? And... oh God, the prenup.”

“What?”

I slapped my forehead. “Trip and Tracey have been having troubles. He doesn’t want another kid. And she’s got to be worried that if we get a big score, he’ll ditch her. He jokes about it all the time. Him and a passel of twenty-somethings on a yacht. But it isn’t all a joke. Problem for her is that they have a prenup that cuts her out of any business he starts. He sold it to her as being about reassuring investors, but the point is... if they divorce, she gets close to zippy.”

“But if he’s dead... she gets it all via his will.” Olivia gasped. “She’s going to kill him. That’s why she had to leave too.”

“And that’s why she needed me alive. I had to be breathing when Trip was killed in order to frame me.”

I began walking quickly toward downtown.

“Where are we going?” Olivia asked.

“To our car. Assuming it hasn’t been towed, it should still be in the convention parking lot, and I hid the keys nearby. We need to warn Trip.”

Olivia hurried after me as darkness descended on the streets.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Heroism

We hurried the mile and half to the convention center. I was cut, bruised, and exhausted, but what felt more disconcerting was that my pockets were empty. I couldn't remember the last time I'd been out in public without anything, no keys, no ID, no phone, no wallet. It was as if my old identity had been stolen from me. I was a wraith.

Olivia kept up with me in her makeshift footwear and sweater masquerading as a dress.

We entered the garage and took the steps down the lower level where we'd parked. It seemed like an eternity ago, but it was just a few days. Our car hadn't even begun to pick up any significant coating of dust. I found the keys where I'd left them, in the well of a support beam. We got into the car and started it up.

As I approached the exit ramp, with its automated payment machine, I realized I couldn't pay. Olivia hopped out and lifted the barrier part way manually, and I scraped the car beneath the partially raised gate, hoping the resultant scratch along the roof didn't draw too much attention. I drove cautiously, avoiding tolls, toward Trip's home.

He lived in a tightly packed development by Stonegate. Row after row of nearly identical three and four-bedroom houses. His was partway down a cul de sac, and I drove past his home first to check it out. It was mostly dark, though I did see one light coming from the back of the house, maybe from the kitchen.

"Did you see anything?" I asked.

Olivia shook her head. "He usually parks in the driveway, right?"

"Yeah, usually no room in their garage with the kids' bikes and such."

I turned around at the end of the street and then drove back toward his house, stopping maybe a hundred yards short. I parked at the curb and turned off the lights.

"Think we should go look around?" Olivia asked.

"I'd rather have a little more sense of what might be awaiting us inside," I replied. As I said it, I spotted his car. "There he is."

Confounding expectations, as he approached, he remotely opened the garage door and drove in.

"Fuck," I grumbled. "I'd have liked to catch him outside. Well, let's go."

We got out of the car and approached his house.

"What are we going to tell him?" Olivia asked.

"I don't know. The truth. We'll see—"

BAM. BAM. BAM.

Three gunshots rang out from inside Trip's home, the muzzle flashes lighting up their living room window.

"Oh, fuck!" I exclaimed breaking into a run.

"Dex, wait!" Olivia shouted behind me. "I think there was someone else in the car!"

It didn't register. I reached the front door and drove into it, shoulder low. My shoulder exploded in pain, but the frame splintered, and I sprawled into their foyer. My left arm hung limp and waves of nausea rolled over me. I shook my head to clear it.

To the right, in the living room, I saw Trip, on his back, three circles of red blooming on his chest. I rushed over to him. His eyes were closed and his breaths shallow. One the floor beside him was my Sig Sauer.

"So nice to see you again," Tracey chimed from the kitchen.

I grabbed the gun and wheeled to face her.

She smirked. And I realized the depth of my miscalculation. I had just turned a solid but circumstantial case against me into an iron-clad conviction. I had placed myself at a murder scene, with handprints on my own gun, the murder weapon.

I stared at her for several long moments, as Trip gurgled what were surely his last breaths. She laughed. I had lost, but I was going to take her with me. I raised the gun and aimed it, dead center on her chest. I pulled the trigger. It clicked on the empty chamber. I pulled the trigger again. Her expression darkened.

I stood and dropped the gun. That's when she raised hers. I recognized it as Trip's Kimber, with its long barrel. I dove to my left

back into the foyer, just as a gunshot rang out, shattering the window behind me.

There was a moment of hesitation, confusion. Trip moaned piteously. Where was Olivia?

Then from the next room, Tracey bellowed, "What are you waiting for? Get him, you idiot!"

Heavy footsteps rushed toward me. I debated momentarily between ducking into Trip's den and taking the stairs to the second floor. I chose the latter and bolted up the stairs. Someone was behind me, not Olivia, not Tracey, a man. As I hit the landing, I glanced back. Markson. With a gun of his own.

I dashed into Trip and Tracey's bedroom. He was right behind me.

From downstairs, I heard Olivia shriek, "What did you do to him?"

Tracey yelled back, "Get away from him, you whore."

I tried to warn my wife. "She has a g—"

Markson plowed into me, sending me sprawling, face down, at the foot of the bed. It felt like a red-hot poker was driving into my shoulder. My vision blurred. Bile in my mouth. He stood above me.

I swept my leg beneath him. Caught by surprise, he lurched into their dresser. The gun flew from his hand beneath their bed. I snaked toward it and reached out. My fingertips grazed the grip. He grabbed my legs and yanked me backward. He dropped onto me, driving his knee into my back. I heard a crack and a flash of agony fired through the right side of my body. His hand grabbed the back of my head and he slammed my face into the carpeting.

"I... fucked... your... wife... in... the... ass," he taunted as he smashed my head into the floor.

Sirens sounded in the distance. It made him pause for just a moment. I bucked upward, and he fell forward on top of me. I drove my right forearm into the ground and rolled us over, so that I was on top of him. But he was on his back and I was facing the ceiling. He wrapped his strong arm around my throat. I struggled to breathe.

"Now you die, asshole," he growled.

I slammed my head backward. It made a satisfying crunch, and a gush of wet heat splashed on my neck. He roared in pain, and released his grip. I rolled away from him and into a crouch.

He stood quickly as well, blood flowing from his nose. But I was worse off. My left arm hung limp. I gasped a deep breath and my side exploded. Broken ribs. I tasted blood in my mouth. He wiped his face and took a step toward me.

With the last remnants of my strength, I launched myself forward. I drove my right shoulder into his gut. He punched at my back as I pushed him backward, picking up speed. There was a crash. Wood splitting, glass shattering. A cool rush of air and the sirens suddenly louder. And then his weight was gone. I looked up and realized I'd driven him through their French Doors, onto their small balcony, and over the railing.

He looked up at me, dazed, from his landing spot on their lush lawn.

The sirens stopped suddenly, and red and blue light swirled through their house.

"Police, police, police! Put down your weapons." I heard heavy footsteps entering.

"He killed my husband. He's still here!" Tracey shrieked.

"Where is he?" one of the cops asked.

"He must be upstairs."

Markson rolled to his knees. He smirked at me over his shoulder and then disappeared over a low fence into a neighbor's backyard. The smirk brought me back to the present. Nothing that had happened up here changed any of the facts of the case. I was still screwed.

I retreated back into the bedroom. I scanned the room desperately. Bed. Nightstands. A large armoire. Dressers. Pictures of the family. A southwest-inspired print over their bed. I considered trying to make an escape through the window, following Markson, until I heard more sirens and tires squealing in the street in front of the house. In my sorry state, I wouldn't get far. I pressed my back into a corner. There was nowhere to go. I had two options left. Surrender and go to jail for the rest of my life... or suicide by cop.

I weighed it. Really weighed it. I didn't want to die. There was still this modicum of hope that something might give. But it was unlikely. I imagined the forthcoming tribulations. Endless judicial proceedings, prison, the effect it would have on my family. At least if I were dead, Olivia might be able to move on. And as painful as it was to contemplate my kids one day calling another man "Dad," it was even worse to imagine them coming to see me behind bars for decades to come. I took a step forward. It would be fast. I merely needed to rush toward the front door, as if I were trying to escape, and in a sense... I would be. I took a deep breath.

"Oh, God, Trip! Oh God, oh God! What did she do to you?" It was Olivia.

"I didn't do anything, you crazy bitch," Tracey snarled. "It was your husband."

"Oh God, oh God, oh God," Olivia wailed. "Where is the ambulance?"

"It'll be here soon," came the reply. I recognized detective Torres.

"She has a gun," Olivia said.

"I was trying to defend myself," Tracey said. "Here." I heard a loud thump as she tossed her weapon onto the floor.

I raised my right arm above my head, my left still dangled uselessly. "I'm coming out," I bellowed. "I think I broke my shoulder." I tried to take a breath. "And ribs."

"Slowly," came a voice from the bottom of the stairs.

I approached a uniformed cop, with his weapon drawn. I turned to face the wall and he cuffed me. I yelped in pain. He led me into the living room. Olivia was crouched over Trip, her hands wet with his blood as she pressed down on his wounds. Torres scanned from me to Tracey to Olivia.

Olivia raised her head and spit toward Tracey. "You killed him because he liked fucking me better than you."

Tracey seemed confused, but she quickly recovered and shouted back, "That's why *your husband* killed him."

She looked up at Torres, "Dex likes me to have sex with other men." Her story seemed to gain additional credibility by the fact that

her “dress” had ridden up, exposing her bare ass. “We swung with them, and Tracey got jealous because Trip obviously enjoyed being with me more than her.”

“That’s bullshit,” Tracey snarled.

The ambulance arrived. Paramedics rushed in and began working to stabilize Trip. Olivia stood, tears running down her cheek. She held out her bloody hands.

“You did this because your man likes my ass better than yours. Because he’d rather come in my pussy than get you pregnant.”

Tracey let out a barking laugh. “You think anyone really wants your skanky holes? You’re worse than a gutter whore. How many men have you fucked today alone?”

“I don’t know, how many?” Olivia replied.

Tracey snorted. “So many that you lost track of the fact that my Trip is the one man you haven’t fucked.”

“But I have. Many times. And every time, he tells me how much better I am than you.”

“Bullshit,” she repeated.

“I fucked him the night of our July 4th party.”

“No you didn’t. You were fucking that old boyfriend of yours.”

“I meant later.”

Tracey hesitated. Olivia pressed forward.

“You went out late that night, remember?”

“No I didn’t.”

“You did. And Trip invited me over. And he fucked me in your bed.” My wife turned toward me. “Isn’t that right, Dex?”

I nodded. “It was fucking hot. Trip always says you’re the best lay he’s ever had.”

“And we fucked again Tuesday,” Olivia said. “You were out again, remember?”

“Bullshit.”

“We can ask Mac. He was following me that night, wasn’t he? You and Markson covered weekends, but he had weekdays.”

I saw a flash of panic on Tracey’s face as it occurred to her we might have a firm alibi for the nights of at least one of the killings.

That along with Olivia's taunts about screwing Trip seemed to have her on the verge of unraveling.

"Who's Mac?" Torres asked.

Olivia ignored him, continuing to focus on Tracey. "Must have been hard knowing you were going to lose Trip, especially with that prenup you signed. And, of course, it wouldn't have helped when he found out that baby in your belly is Markson's."

"Who's Markson?" Torres grumbled.

Tracey clenched her fists, her entire body vibrating with anger. I remembered Markson's boast about "knocking up another one." So it wasn't just the sex that tied her to him.

There was just enough truth in what Olivia was saying that Tracey couldn't be sure what we knew and what we could prove. Olivia had woven in things we'd learned from Mac and Charlie along with some guesses to throw Tracey off balance. Like us, Tracey wasn't a hardened criminal. She was flying by the seat of her pants. She made a split-second decision, and it was one that probably saved my life. She suddenly began sobbing. "I didn't have any choice. Trevor was blackmailing me. Trip and I were fighting. Trevor took advantage. He seduced me. And then forced me to do his bidding. I... I never meant to hurt anyone."

I breathed a small sigh of relief. I glanced over at Torres. He raised an eyebrow at me, and with a nod of his head ordered the police officer to lead me away to the squad car. I didn't know how things would turn out, but now that Olivia had managed to bluff Tracey into turning on Markson, I felt a little optimistic that their plot would unravel. The physical evidence against me was still strong, but at least now Torres would have to conduct an alternative investigation. Everything would come out. Much of that would be embarrassing, but at least it might not end with me in prison for the rest of my life.

Chapter Twenty-Three: Resolution

Olivia and I walked hand-in-hand down the hospital corridor and into the patient room. My wounds had healed, although I still had a sling on my left arm as a result of the dislocation and rotator cuff surgery. Trip was white as a sheet, had lost at least twenty pounds, and was still wired up to sensors and fed by IVs, but he was alive. This was the first time we were allowed in to see him. Prior to that, it had only been his parents and kids in. By the time he regained consciousness, Tracey was no longer at liberty to make social calls.

We sat down beside him, and he stirred.

"Dex? Olivia?"

We nodded. Olivia squeezed his hand.

"I owe you two," he said.

"If it wasn't for us, none of this might have happened in the first place," I said.

He shook his head. "No, if you hadn't called 911 and hadn't kept pressure on my wounds...." He shuddered slightly. "I almost bled out."

"Well, Olivia did both those things," I replied. While I was fighting upstairs, Olivia had dashed into Trip's study and called the authorities.

"But you rushed into the house right after the gunshots."

I shrugged. "You'd have done the same for me."

"I'm not sure I would have. For Olivia maybe, but you?" He chuckled and then winced in pain.

"Take it easy, man. Save the jokes for later."

He shook his head slightly. "I never saw her shoot me. I just came in from the garage, Markson behind me, and then everything is a blur."

"I wish we'd stopped you before going in," I said.

"And I wish.... I'm sorry," he said. "I told Tracey all sorts of things. She used it against you."

"I was dishing, too," Olivia admitted. "It just never occurred to me that it was anything more than fun stories."

We remained silent for a few moments. I don't think any of us had fully processed everything that had happened with Tracey.

"We didn't get the contract," Trip sighed.

I chuckled. "You can hardly blame them. One partner in intensive care, another in police custody, and a third on the lam."

"Did Markson really get away?"

I nodded. "So far. But they'll get him." I tried to sound confident, but I wasn't so sure. Tracey had self-incriminated herself badly, and while she was trying to shift blame onto Markson, it was her tits that had lured Denny out the night of his murder. In a way, Markson just complicated the case.

"Well, you were right. He is an asshole."

Trip groaned softly as a flash of pain struck him. I patted his forearm. "Get some rest buddy. Get better. I have some ideas for a new company."

"We have some ideas," Olivia corrected. She had decided to quit the law, at least for a while. That whole part of her life was too intertwined with Charlie, and she needed some space.

He gave me a thin smile. "I'll be there."

We stepped outside. It was mid October, and there was a nip in the air. Soon we'd be able to pack up the kids and hit the slopes. But for tonight, we were on our own. The kids were at Grandma's, and for the first time in three months, we had a date night.

"So what should we do tonight?" I asked.

"I was thinking we might go home and... snuggle."

I had spent six weeks in jail as they built the case against Tracey. And since then, the kids had been tremendously, if understandably, clingy, which meant the only sex in three months had been of the solo, shower variety.

"Just us?" I asked.

She gave me a wicked smile. "Well, I'm not wearing any panties, so if you want to find a nice bar, with high stools, maybe we can have a little fun."

I shivered excitedly. That was the thing. Even though we'd nearly been burned, I could think of nothing sexier, after three months of celibacy, than to break the streak with some nice, juicy, sloppy seconds.

"Sounds like a plan."

Epilogue

I awkwardly cradled a bottle of wine as Olivia rang the doorbell. Denise and Mitch opened the door together.

"I'm sorry," we all said at the same time. It wasn't scripted, it was just that we all had regrets about what had happened. We'd brought danger to their door. They'd tried to protect themselves and their family.

We shared a laugh and sheepish smiles. They invited us in.

I was going to lose again. Denise wasn't even trying very hard. But she was beautifully naked, with her dark hair, dark eyes, and luscious body. Just one fingertip sliding up and down my shaft. A few feet away, Mitch was passionately fucking my wife.

Olivia was face down, ass up, on their bed. He would give her three or four hard strokes, and then it was her turn, and she thrust back against him, impaling herself on his cock. And with every stroke, Olivia mewled softly, passionately. She looked over at me and smiled. Then he thrust in, and her eyes rolled back.

I came.

Denise laughed. "Looks like it is dinner at the Y, for you again."

With my cock still dripping, she led me over to the bed. She laid down and spread her legs, and then guided my head into place. I lapped away at her juicy cunt, clean shaven just like Olivia's still was, while just inches away another man fucked my wife. Olivia moaned sensuously.

Denise leaned over and pulled Olivia into an embrace. They kissed sloppily, Mitch's hard thrusts jostling my wife back and forth. Denise reached down and began tweaking Olivia's hard nipples.

"You like my husband's big dick, don't you?" Denise cooed.

"God yes," Olivia enthused. "He stretches me out and made me come so hard."

I looked up from Denise's tasty pussy and saw that Olivia was looking at me. Her words were for me.

"I want him to come inside me," she continued. "Is that okay?"

Both Denise and I answered "yes" at the same time.

Olivia grinned. She reached down between her legs and cradled his heavy balls. "Oh God, Mitch, please fill me up with your come. Make it overflow from my pussy."

Mitch grabbed my wife's hips and began pounding into her mercilessly. Olivia's screams of passion were muffled by Denise's mouth and tongue kissing her roughly. He came with a grunt, spurting inside my wife over and over.

As he pulled out and backed off the bed, I was drawn as if by compulsion to his place behind Olivia. Her cunt gaped open, pink and wet. I licked deep into her battered gash, luxuriating in the multitude of tastes and emotions that washed over me. Excitement, humiliation, love, anger, and more than anything, lust.

My tongue flicked over her clit, and I sucked on her labia. Denise curled over and began sucking me off. Her hot mouth and swirling tongue on my sensitive prick had me almost breathless. Mitch spooned his wife. His hands mauled her big tits. She reached back and stroked her husband's cock. Although he wasn't hard yet, he was still big enough to slip inside Denise's aroused, wet cunt. She moaned as she swallowed me deep.

I licked Olivia enthusiastically, from her clit, through the juicy channel of her pussy, then to her ass. She hissed excitedly as I tongued her ass both from the sensation and what it implied.

Only two men had ever had anal sex with her. Mac and Markson. The first had been many years before, the latter under circumstances I wouldn't want to relive. I wanted to replace that anal memory with a better one.

"Oh God," Olivia gasped. "He's getting my ass ready for you Mitch."

Denise chuckled, "Hear that Baby? Are you excited about fucking that slut's tight, little ass? Is that why your cock just swelled up in my pussy."

He moaned enthusiastically and began to fuck his wife harder, as she continued to suck my dick, and I continued to eat Olivia's ass. Olivia and Mitch were staring at each other, eye-fucking really. I straightened up and took my cock from Denise's mouth and put it into my wife's loose, well-fucked cunt. She moaned and ground against me.

Mitch pulled his wife's body close to his and began fucking her hard from behind. I matched his pace and the girls held hands and moaned in tandem. Their cries of passion built on each other, louder, high. Using the mix of come and excitement dripping out of Olivia's pussy, I lubed up my thumb and pressed it into my wife's ass. She was so tight that it was hard to imagine a cock fitting in there, but I knew she and Mitch would make it work. My thumb was the final straw. Olivia gasped and came, squeezing Denise's hand. Denise shuddered in orgasm as well. And seeing the two women come, set off Mitch too.

Victory! I thought to myself.

But things continued to move on. Mitch withdrew from his wife, and Olivia disentangled from me. We switched partners. I plunged deep into Denise's now-messy hole. I'd don't know if it is the other man's come that makes it so hot, or just the feel and excitement of a freshly fucked pussy, but everyone should try sloppy seconds at least once in their lives, though it can be addictive.

Mitch and Olivia began making out. He brought out some lube and squeezed some out on Olivia's anus. He then passed the lube to his wife, who did the same to me. I knew what was coming, but even though I relaxed, I couldn't really be prepared. Mitch's finger entered my wife's ass as Denise's entered mine. Olivia gasped excitedly. I came with stars in my eyes.

We were just getting started. It was a good reunion.

We don't see Mac anymore. He decided to cut us off. Said he needed some distance from "the bad influences in his life." I couldn't really blame him, though I missed seeing what he did to Olivia.

Happily, we've found some other playmates. But that's another story.

And Markson? He's still at large. One day, a few months later, I got an email from him. It was carefully anonymized, and the cops weren't able to glean anything from the missive. The message was simple and chilling. "Tell Olivia... I'm coming for her."

He can try. But I'll be waiting for him.

Afterword by Ben Boswell

Yes, this is set in the present. And no, there is no Covid-19. I felt like we all needed a break from that.

This is the closest thing I've written to a "real novel" since *Whatever It Takes*, which I published five years ago. As with WIT, my hope is that the sex serves the plot effectively, but obviously if you plan on writing in this genre, at some points the plot has to be flexible enough to allow the sex to occur. (The characters also need to be flexible, both morally and physically.) I hope I struck a decent balance.

This was a lot of fun to write, and something of a challenge. Balancing the murder mystery with the genre-defining journey of sexual discovery was one challenge. Pacing another was another. There were a lot of moving parts.

I had basically three sets of inspiration as I wrote. The first is obviously old-fashioned murder mysteries. Seeing *Knives Out* last year, which is a delightful, modern, version of the genre, was one motivation. I wasn't quite sure how to approach that sort of project. I am completely self-taught as a fiction writer. I decided to set a rule for myself that I wouldn't actually know who had set up Olivia and Dex until nearly the very end. I knew I'd have to rule out suspects over time, but I tried to keep as many in play as possible as long as possible. Ideally you spent some time working through the different possibilities. Was it Charlie? Mac? Dex, himself, in some sort of fugue state? Someone else? Hopefully, the revelation of Tracey and Markson as the bad guys didn't seem too forced. I tried to leave enough breadcrumbs for several options to be plausible, and then added a few more about Tracey once I decided she was the villain. I hope that the pieces came together well enough in the end. Presumably, I'll hear about it in the reviews if it did (or didn't).

My second inspiration is Italian *giallo* movies. If you haven't seen them, they are bloody, trashy, sexy messes, and shockingly fun. Mario Bava, Dario Argento, Lucio Fulci, and others made some wonderful movies in the genre. Many of them operate under the guise of being thrillers or police procedurals, but honestly, it is most about the style. Sexy women, morally compromised men, lurid settings, and sudden shocking violence. Check them out if you haven't.

My last inspiration was that cycle of early 1990s erotic thrillers. The Era of the Two Shannons (Tweed and Whirry). Whirry was more of the bad girl in the mix, and her cool, calculated sexuality was a bit of an inspiration for Olivia (personality-wise. Think of her in *Body of Influence* (1993) or *Lady in Waiting* (1994). And if you haven't seen any of her movies, well, you have to check out one of the greatest hotwife/voyeur movies ever, *Animal Instincts* (1992). I'll still occasionally queue that one up.

I like the idea of doing more mashups of this sort. I have a couple of projects quite well advanced, so I'll be publishing on a more regular basis in the future. At least I hope so. I'm optimistic. The challenge, to be honest, is that writing this sort of book is more difficult than cranking out 10-20k word shorts, and unfortunately, given the market, I don't feel I can charge a genuinely commensurate price. I can put a 20k short on the market at \$2.99 and no one complains, but if I tried to sell this book, nearly 95k words, for \$10.99, few would buy it. I could serialize it... but I'm not going to because that doesn't feel right. But in any case, if you did like this book, I hope you'll consider buying some of my other works. You may get a little less bang for the buck from some of my shorter novellas, but they're pretty darn good on the whole, and some are better than that. Also, it helps subsidize me in writing longer works.

I'd like to thank all the readers who have emailed me over the past year encouraging me to get back to writing. It was a challenge. I was

dealing with a lot of work stress and other issues, and the support and encouragement helped a lot. I also want to thank Kenny Wright for his comments on a draft of this book, and Robert C and Burt L for their keen eyes in catching my numerous typos and grammatical errors. And thank you also to all the readers who volunteered to review ARCs. If you're interested in being on the list for future works, or if you just want periodic updates from me, or if you want to talk about any of my books, please don't hesitate to email me at ben.boswell.author@gmail.com. I haven't said it in a while, but, honestly, hearing from readers is one of the great joys of writing!

I hope you managed to remain healthy these past several months. And I hope to be able to count you among my readers in the years to come. Best wishes.

Ben Boswell, October 2020